

The Economist & *the artist*

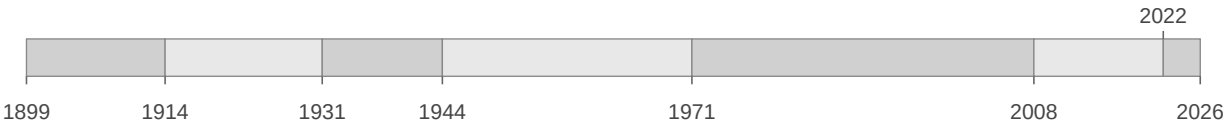
A 200-Year History

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The Monetary Regimes & Foreword



1899–1914	The Sterling Rail
1914–1931	Suspension & Gold-Exchange
1931–1944	Monetary Disorder
1944–1971	Bretton Woods
1971–2008	The Petrodollar Era
2008–2022	Money Without Limit
2022–2026	The Sanctions Era

Foreword

A word on what the book is not. It is not a prophecy. It is not a conspiracy theory: banks, agencies, and governments coordinate, and the chapters describe where and how, but coordination is not proof of one hidden hand running the world. The book is in no way complete. Whole regions and decades go thin; its firmest claims rest on a handful of cases; it names its own failures rather than bury them.

One rule governs every page. There is no protagonist. No nation is the hero, none the villain. The currents run through every party named, and they lift and drown by no logic of desert; even the world-historical figure serves a current rather than authors it. To read in search of a side to root for is to mistake the loudest point of a current for its source.

Expect the temperature to rise. The early chapters concern orders whose believers are all dead, and the reader will weigh them coolly. Somewhere past the middle the events stop being history and become memory, and then the present, and the same cold instruments turn on arrangements the reader still lives inside and may still believe in. The heat that rises then is itself evidence. People defend an order with feeling only while they still believe it; once belief fades, its story stirs no one. The reader is not an exception.

Prerequisites

The chapters return to a few names and terms.

- Kant: the mind never reaches the thing in itself, only the world its categories assemble.
- Hegel: every ruling idea produces the contradiction that undoes it.
- Marx: that engine runs on ownership and interest.
- Freud: the self is split.
- Bernays: the split can be worked on for pay; he called it the engineering of consent.
- Shannon: information is the reduction of uncertainty, stated mathematically.
- Wiener: bodies, markets, furnaces, and states steer toward targets by feedback; he named the study of this cybernetics.
- Foucault: modern truth is produced inside institutions that count, classify, and discipline.
- Friston: the brain is a prediction engine, corrected against data and acted into the world.
- Hayek: the mind sorts raw sensation into a model of the world before conscious thought reaches it.
- McLuhan: each medium reshapes perception more than the message it carries.
- Jaynes: the sense of an inner self is a product of history, and it has changed across the ages.
- A gold standard promises convertibility into a fixed weight of gold.
- Fiat money is backed by the shared decision to treat it as worth something.
- Inflation is money that outruns goods; deflation is the reverse.
- A central bank issues currency, steers credit, and in a panic lends when no one else will.
- Bretton Woods is the post-1944 dollar order.
- The petrodollar is the post-1970s circuit that recycled oil revenue into dollars and Treasuries.
- Quantitative easing is central-bank money creation through bond purchases.
- Financialization is the long shift, strongest after 1971, by which claims on production come to dominate production itself.
- Eschatology means last things: any conviction, sacred or secular, that history climbs toward a final settlement the believer is chosen to deliver, hasten, or witness. The book treats millenarian movements, Marxism, Christian Zionism, religious Zionism, the apocalyptic strand in Iran, and AI salvation or doom as material forces: things budgets follow, weapons answer to, and markets capitalize.

The Long Nineteenth Century

In a wet field south of Brussels, on the eighteenth of June 1815, a question that had hung over Europe for twenty-two years was settled in nine hours of slaughter. While the Imperial Guard broke against the British squares at Waterloo, a Rothschild agent watched the line bend and did not bend with it, and rode for the Channel coast with the result in his head. The house of Rothschild, already laced across the Continent by couriers and carrier pigeons, knew the outcome before the Cabinet in London did. Whether Nathan Rothschild actually traded on the news a full day ahead of the market is unprovable, and stands as legend. The tale would not die because it named what the new century was about to confirm: the decisive knowledge would no longer be where the armies stood but what their positions were worth, and it moved faster than kings and answered to no crown. The visible sovereignty of Europe had been decided at Waterloo by cannon. An invisible sovereignty made of information and credit had already overtaken it. The crowned heads signed the treaties. The men who knew the price of the treaties before anyone else owned the outcome, and preferred not to be seen owning it.

The quarrel deserves a portrait, because it is the founding comedy of the modern world. On one side stood Napoleon Bonaparte, a Corsican gunner who had ridden a revolution to a throne, rewritten the laws of France between campaigns, crowned himself with his own hands, and made more of Europe answer to one will than anyone since the Caesars. He thought in armies, dined off the map, treated whole nations as flanks. On the other side stood a damp island of shopkeepers, a nation that could not have fielded one soldier for every five of his. The island had three weapons: a navy that owned every sea he could not march across, a treasury that could borrow against tomorrow on a scale no emperor's word could match, and the patience of a creditor. The first he understood and resented. The second he never truly grasped, and it killed him slowly. His grand stroke, the Continental System decreed at Berlin in 1806, was an attempt at murder by paperwork: every port from Lisbon to Riga closed to British goods, the shopkeepers to be starved of their customers¹ It leaked from the first week, his own officers smuggling English boots and cloth, and enforcing it dragged him into Spain and then to Moscow, the two wounds that bled the Grande Armée white. Reduced to its terms, the duel was this: the man who could take any field, against the island that could pay for every field. Twenty-two years settled which resource runs out first.

Waterloo was an ending, and to read it as one is to read the twenty-two years backward. The war that closed in that field had run since 1803 and had nearly broken every power that fought it except the one that had financed the others to fight. Napoleon had inherited the armies of the Revolution and the hunger of a continent reorganized by it, and for a decade he won battles that should not have been winnable, against coalitions that re-formed each time he shattered them

1. The Berlin Decree, November 21, 1806, extended by the Milan Decree of December 1807; J. Holland Rose, "England's Commercial Struggle with Napoleon," in *Lectures on the History of the Nineteenth Century*, ed. F. A. Kirkpatrick (Cambridge, 1902).

because one government on an island would not stop paying for the next. At Austerlitz in December of 1805 he destroyed the combined armies of Austria and Russia in an afternoon, drawing his enemy onto weakened ground he had abandoned on purpose, then folding the center shut. It was the cleanest victory of his life, and it made the rest of Europe his clientele. The land was his to dispose of. The sea remained someone else's. Two months earlier, off Cape Trafalgar in October of 1805, Nelson had taken the Royal Navy into the combined fleets of France and Spain in two columns driven straight through the enemy line, and destroyed sea power for a hundred years at the cost of his own life, shot through the spine on his own quarterdeck and dead before the firing stopped. After Trafalgar no rival would contest the ocean Britain commanded. The war settled into a contest between a land empire that could not reach the sea and a maritime one that could not occupy the land, fought through a third medium that belonged to neither: money.

Unable to invade the island, Napoleon tried to bankrupt it. The Continental System was a blockade run in reverse, meant to starve the British economy of the markets that fed its credit, and it failed in the way such schemes fail, by costing the enforcer more than the target. Smuggling ate it from beneath, the Continent wanted the goods, and the effort to seal the whole coastline drew Napoleon into Spain to close the last gap and into Russia to punish the Tsar for reopening his ports. The Spanish ulcer bled for six years, a guerrilla war no battlefield victory could end. The Russian campaign of 1812 destroyed the largest army Europe had assembled, more than half a million men marched into a country that put its own capital to the torch rather than feed them, and left them to walk back through a winter that killed by the tens of thousands a day. By the time the survivors recrossed the Niemen the Grande Armée had ceased to exist. The coalition that formed against the wreck met him at Leipzig in October 1813, six hundred thousand men, the largest battle Europe would see before 1914, and broke his empire east of the Rhine. The hundred days that ended at Waterloo were an aftershock.

Through all of it Britain spent. It could field only a small army and built its strategy on that knowledge, paying other nations to supply the men it could not. The subsidies the Treasury shipped to Austria, Russia, Prussia, Portugal, Sweden, and the lesser German states ran to nearly fifty million pounds across the wars, gold sovereigns stamped with Saint George riding down the dragon, and French observers, contemptuous of an enemy who fought with coin instead of corpses, named the payments the golden cavalry of Saint George² The contempt missed the point.

The cavalry won.

The cavalry had a stable, and the stable had been built a century earlier in a single legislative season. The mechanism was published in 1693 in a pamphlet by William Paterson, a Scottish merchant who had spent the previous decade between London and the Caribbean and had assembled around himself a circle of Whig financiers willing to underwrite his proposal. A Brief

2. On the subsidies, J. M. Sherwig, *Guineas and Gunpowder: British Foreign Aid in the Wars with France, 1793–1815* (Harvard, 1969).

Account of the Intended Bank of England set out a scheme by which a syndicate of subscribers would lend the crown one million two hundred thousand pounds at eight per cent, the loan to be paid not by extraction of metal from the present but by the assignment of future tax revenue, and would be incorporated as a joint-stock company empowered to issue its own notes against the loan. The Tonnage Act of April 1694, which raised duties on shipping and beer to service the interest, gave Parliament's pledge to the bondholders. By July the subscription had closed in twelve days, the Bank was chartered, and the war against Louis XIV was financed by a paper claim on taxes not yet collected. The corporation that emerged was, in form, a private company whose business was the administration of the public debt and the issue of notes against it; in function, the central instrument by which the English state borrowed at rates no Continental rival could match. The arrangement put the credit of the propertied nation behind the obligations of the crown and made the obligations of the crown the asset on which the private money supply was built.

The political fight that produced the Bank had been running since 1660 and had been fought, at the level of theory, as a quarrel about what value was. The Stuart kings had inherited the older monarchical doctrine that the worth of a coin was the metal in it and that the king's revenue could not exceed what his realm could be made to surrender; James II's preferred instrument for raising sums above that limit had been the chartered monopoly, the East India Company being its model, in which the crown sold to a syndicate the exclusive right to a trade in exchange for a present payment. The doctrine treated value as scarce, finite, and prior to the act of issuing money. The Whigs who came in with William of Orange in 1688 had reached the opposite conclusion, by way of the Amsterdam merchants who had financed William's invasion and the Huguenot bankers who came across with him: that credit issued against an institutional pledge would be honored as long as the pledge was institutional, that the pledge could be made institutional only by binding the crown to a parliament whose taxes secured it, and that the supply of money so constructed had no fixed upper limit but only an upper limit set by what the propertied classes would believe. The Glorious Revolution settled the constitutional surface of the quarrel; the Bank of England settled the monetary substance of it. The Stuart doctrine of scarce value was retired, and the Whig doctrine of paper credit, expansible at the discretion of a parliament whose interests were the lenders', was installed in its place. From 1694 forward, the operating theory of value in England was a theory of credit, and the operating theory of credit was that belief in the pledge was the underwriting and the metal in the vault a ceremonial backing.

In May of 1695 the Licensing Act, which since the Restoration had required every printed work to pass through a royal censor before it could be sold, lapsed. The vote not to renew it was procedural, taken on grounds of administrative cost and the inconvenience of the censor's office; the substantive effect was that the press of England came out from under prior restraint for the first

time, and a literate market in opinion was permitted to assemble itself. Within the same fifteen years the cabinet government formed under William and then Anne settled into the practice by which ministers, not the monarch, ran the executive of the state, and a coffeehouse trade in news and rumor grew up in the streets immediately around the Royal Exchange. Jonathan's, Garraway's, and Lloyd's stood within three minutes' walk of each other and of the Bank itself, and the same merchants who subscribed to the loan met in the same rooms to read the same papers and trade the same shares; the public sphere that Habermas, two and a half centuries on, would describe as the bourgeois discursive infrastructure of the modern state assembled itself at the address of the Bank and on its trading hours. Paper credit, paper press, paper conversation, paper persona: the same Whig ascendancy that had arranged for credit to substitute for coin arranged also for opinion to substitute for command, for printed argument to substitute for royal proclamation, and for the inner life of a person to be read off pages rather than confessed to a priest.

Inside that order, the novel and the diary and the published letter arose as the technologies by which a literate population learned to assemble a self out of the day's words. The form was new. The medieval and Renaissance traditions had produced romance and confession and the tract; what they had not produced was the sustained first-person interior narrative of an ordinary person making and remaking himself through commercial trial. Daniel Defoe, who had begun as a hosier and gone bankrupt twice before becoming the most prolific pamphleteer of the new order, set down in his 1697 *Essay upon Projects* the term that would name the substance of the new economy: he wrote of air-money, of the credit projected forward against a future return that did not yet exist, and observed that the new financial instruments depended on a public willing to treat a written promise as a present fact. Twenty-two years later, in *Robinson Crusoe*, he wrote the founding fiction of the new self, an English bourgeois cast onto an island who keeps an account of his days, his stores, his debts to providence and his credits against it, and who reconstructs civilization from his own diary. Samuel Richardson would, in *Pamela* in 1740 and *Clarissa* in 1748, take the same technique inward and produce the first sustained novels of consciousness in English, both of them epistolary, both of them constructed entirely out of the letters by which the protagonist persuades herself and her correspondents that her interior is the thing it should be. The diary, the letter, the novel: three forms by which an unbeliever in the priest's confession could compose himself from the materials of his own writing, run on the same press and offered to the same public that owned the shares of the Bank.

The first stress test of the new system came in 1720, twenty-six years after the charter. The South Sea Company, chartered in 1711 to assume a portion of the public debt in exchange for a monopoly on trade with Spanish America that the company never managed to conduct, proposed in early 1720 to assume the rest of the national debt by an exchange of its own shares for outstanding annuities. The conversion was a financial engineering operation of the kind the Bank

had pioneered and the Company now imitated at speculative scale: shares were offered to the public at a price the directors guaranteed they could resell at a profit, the proceeds funded the assumption of the debt, and the bondholders who took shares were promised dividends out of the trade the company did not have. Through the spring and summer the share price ran from one hundred and twenty-eight in January to nine hundred and fifty in July; in September it collapsed, taking with it the savings of much of the political nation, three peers and the Postmaster General, and the reputations of several cabinet ministers who had taken bribes in shares. The crisis was contained by Robert Walpole, who entered the Treasury as the only major politician untouched by the scandal and arranged a triage of debts and prosecutions that preserved the Bank and the public credit while letting the South Sea Company subside into a residual administrative vehicle. The lesson the political class took, and would teach itself again every fifty or sixty years for the next three centuries, was that the new monetary order could survive its own speculative excesses if the central institution of credit could be defended, that the price of defending the central institution was the sacrifice of peripheral schemes and the prosecution of a manageable number of villains, and that the public's faith in the underlying instrument was the only thing the system could not afford to lose. The Bubble Act of June 1720, passed at the height of the mania, made the chartering of new joint-stock companies harder for the next century; the underlying credit doctrine it had been meant to discipline survived intact and went on expanding.

The modern monetary order and the modern self were issued by the same press in the same years and would run together for the next three hundred. The same printing trade produced the Bank's notes, the South Sea Company's prospectuses, the censored-no-longer pamphlets, and the novels in which the literate Englishman learned to read his own interior as a sequence of pages. The same Whig ascendancy that had defeated the Stuart theory of scarce value had defeated the Tudor theory of pre-censored speech, and the same coffeehouses in which the share prices were traded served as the venues in which the day's printed opinion was read aloud and disputed. What had been installed in the fifteen years between 1694 and 1709 was not a single institution but an interlocking apparatus: a credit instrument whose value depended on belief, a press whose products produced and disciplined that belief, a parliamentary executive whose accountability ran to the lenders rather than to the throne, and a literate public trained by the new novel and the new diary to compose itself out of the same paper. Every later episode this volume covers will be a stress, a transformation, or a stage in the failure of that apparatus. The eighteenth century would extend it to empire and the nineteenth would make it the unspoken constitution of the planet. The twentieth would learn, by 1971, that the institutional pledge could be replaced by the institutional capacity to print, and that the credit-and-belief system could in principle be run without even the ceremonial vault. The twenty-first would test what happens when the underlying belief frays. The prologue to all of it was a single legislative season at the close of the seventeenth century, in which

paper credit, the censorship-free press, and the novel of bourgeois interior life were instituted together, by the same political coalition, on the same street, in the same year.

A power that rents the armies of a continent and outlasts every ally it pays is a state whose true weapon is its credit, and Britain's endured through twenty-two years of war for a reason that is the hinge of the century that followed. In 1797, with gold draining from its vaults to pay the allies and a French landing party briefly ashore in Wales, the Bank of England stopped redeeming its notes for gold³ The suspension was meant to last weeks and lasted twenty-four years, renewed by Parliament every year until 1821; through all of it the British state financed the longest war in its history on paper money that could not be exchanged for metal on demand. The pound floated. The war was paid for by an income tax William Pitt introduced as a temporary measure and by borrowing on a scale no enemy could match. The credit survived not because the gold was there but because lenders believed the gold would be there again when the war was won. It was. In 1821 Britain resumed payment in gold at the old prewar parity, announcing that the pound had passed through a generation of war and come out worth what it had been before. The announcement was the foundation of everything that followed. The empire of credit was born in a suspension and consecrated in a resumption, and its first lesson was this: the promise mattered more than the metal, and a nation that could make the world believe its word could borrow the world into its service.

The power that emerged as the arbiter of the world ruled by money first and arms second. Britain had financed the coalitions and paid the Continental armies whose men died in the greatest numbers, and it would spend the next century ruling less by garrison than by guarantee, by the assurance that a pound sterling was gold, that contracts would be honored, that the seas were open and the City of London would clear the world's debts. An order of that kind prefers to look like nature, and for most of the long century the British arrangement felt less like a regime than like the climate itself: the source of its reach and the trap folded inside the gift. You can pick a fight with a regime; you cannot pick one with the weather. A power that has persuaded the world it is climatic has won the only contest that matters, the one over what counts as the given. To make a human contrivance appear as a fact of nature is the oldest and most profitable work a ruling order does, and Britain did it better than any power before, because the work ran through the books rather than the bayonet.

Beneath the order of promises ran an older order of ideas, because this was the century in which Germany taught the world that reality is made of mind. Kant had performed the turn before Waterloo. No mind reaches the thing in itself, he argued; a mind has only the phenomenon, the world its own categories assemble. This applies many times over for the vast collective objects no single sense ever touches, the nation, the market, the god, the future, real in the one way that

3. The Bank Restriction Act, 1797; convertibility resumed under the Resumption Act of 1819 and was complete by 1821.

4. On the dialectic and the world-historical individual: G. W. F. Hegel, *Lectures on the Philosophy of History*, trans. John Sibree (London: George Bell & Sons, 1837); on the secularization of Christian eschatology in Hegel's reading, Karl Löwith, *Meaning in History* (Chicago, 1949), chs. 3–4. On the older millenarian inheritance the dialectic kept and rebranded: Norman Cohn, *The Pursuit of the Millennium: Revolutionary Millenarians and Mystical Anarchists of the Middle Ages* (London: Secker & Warburg, 1957).

counts and fictional in the way that never stops mattering. Hegel built an engine on that floor. History advances by contradiction: every ruling idea, by the act of ruling, calls its opposite into being, and the collision resolves in a synthesis that governs in turn until its own antithesis arrives. He named the motion the dialectic and the thing that moves through it Geist, mind and spirit at once; the treaties and prices a conventional history sets down are the surface, and the deeper current is made of ideas. Hegel allowed for the world-historical individual, the Napoleon through whom an age forces its idea into the world, and insisted that such a figure is the current's instrument and never its author. There is no hero power and no villain cabal whose fortunes the centuries secretly track, only impersonal currents that lift and drown by no logic of desert. The men who knew Waterloo first were instruments of the new order of credit, not its inventors. A river's loudest stretch is not its source⁴

The British peace was not, despite the navy, a thing of arms. Trafalgar had bought a command of the sea no rival would contest for a hundred years, but the army was small and Britain fought no great-power land war in Europe between Waterloo and 1914. The real machinery ran beneath the diplomacy. It was the City, which came out of the wars as the world's creditor and built an empire of finance that needed no garrisons of occupation. The gold standard, formalized at the 1821 resumption, was its constitution, and the mechanism is worth setting down because the whole arrangement of power in the century rode on it. To put a currency on gold was to promise that the state would exchange its paper for a fixed weight of metal on demand, and that pledge governed everything else. A country losing gold, because it bought more abroad than it sold, would find its money tightening and its prices and wages forced down until its goods grew cheap enough to draw the gold back; a country gaining gold loosened. The discipline was automatic and merciless, and administered from one room. The Bank of England maintained the thinnest gold reserve of any great financial center and learned it did not need a deep one, because by raising or lowering a single interest rate it could pull gold toward London or push it away across the whole world at will. A rise drew metal from every other capital to earn the higher return, and the other central banks had to follow or watch their own reserves drain toward Threadneedle Street. So the planet's credit was conducted by a handful of men adjusting one number, and the adjustment fell as boom or slump on people who had never heard of them. Money was the supreme case of Kant's point, a shared image so total it organizes a civilization, the metaphysics of the lecture halls made into a thing one could spend, steered by a power that preferred to be invisible and largely succeeded⁵

If money was the era's master fiction, the institution that tended it was the age's church. A civilization that had begun to lose its God moved its habits of belief onto the one object that still commanded universal faith. Carroll Quigley, a Georgetown historian with no taste for the marginal, read the coordinated central banking of the modern age as exactly that, a system of financial control in private hands, governed by the central banks acting in concert through

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5. On the categorial limit of human cognition: Immanuel Kant, *Critique of Pure Reason*, trans. Norman Kemp Smith (London: Macmillan, 1929 [1781]), B xvi–xxvii (the "Copernican turn") and A 369–380 on the limits of speculative reason. On the nation as one such category that organizes a population without ever being touched directly, Benedict Anderson, *Imagined Communities: Reflections on the Origin and Spread of Nationalism* (London: Verso, 1983).
 6. On central-bank cooperation as priesthood: Carroll Quigley, *Tragedy and Hope: A History of the World in Our Time* (New York: Macmillan, 1966), pp. 324–328 on the Bank for International Settlements; for a corrective view, Liaquat Ahamed, *Lords of Finance*

agreements reached in private meetings, its apex a small bank at Basel owned by the central banks themselves⁶ The central bank is a priesthood because its authority rests on a belief it must continuously sustain: that money is real, that the paper and the entry in the ledger stand for something and will be honored. No army enforces that belief and no law can manufacture it. It lives only so long as the faithful go on professing it, and the bank's true office is to keep them at it. The gold standard was the high altar of this church, the visible token that made the invisible faith feel grounded in something eternal, a metal that did not rust or multiply, dug from the earth at great cost and locked in vaults the worshippers would never see. The promise that paper could be exchanged for gold on demand worked the way a relic works: not because anyone meant to redeem it but because its mere existence underwrote the belief that the whole edifice was backed by substance and not by consensus alone. The mechanism beneath the theology is humble enough to state in a sentence. A bank keeps far less gold than the value of the paper issued against it, just as a church keeps far fewer relics than the prayers said over them, and the system functions only because the holders of the claims do not all present them at once. The priesthood's central labor is to ensure they never do, to keep the run from starting, to sustain the confidence that lets a thin reserve stand behind a vast pyramid of money. Bound by that shared creed, the central banks of the West cooperated above the heads of their nominal sovereigns, lending to one another in crises and adjusting their rates in a rough concert no parliament had authorized and few electorates understood, a transnational communion of bankers who answered first to the faith they kept. The church needed no central planner once every priest had been trained to the same liturgy. The deepest power of the arrangement was that it presented a human contrivance, the value of money, as a fact of nature on the order of gravity, so that to question it felt not like dissent but like madness, the same protection the older church had enjoyed when it ruled.

That this empire of credit was British and not French or Spanish overturns the usual assumption that strength comes from concentrated power. England's crown had never managed to centralize, and the English solution to that weakness made Parliament, not the king, the guarantor of the public debt. A loan was backed by the whole propertied nation rather than by one man's caprice. Here is the deeper mechanism the dreadnoughts hid. A bank does not lend the coins in its vault; it creates a deposit by writing the loan, and the new balance is spent, redeposited, and lent again, so that a small base of reserves supports a far larger pyramid of money and debt. The British state did the same trick at the scale of a nation. Parliament pledged the taxes of the realm against the bonds it sold, the Bank of England stood behind them, and the same securities served as the safe asset on which the whole credit pyramid was built, money conjured against the collateral of the public debt. Because the pledge was institutional, not the promise of a single mortal monarch who might die or default or be overthrown, lenders trusted it, and trust let Britain borrow vaster sums at lower rates than any rival could. A nation that borrows cheaply outbuilds and outlasts

rivals who must wring their wars from current taxes. Public credit, not coal and not the fleet, was the deepest foundation of the empire of money. The men who managed it understood, better than the men who commanded the ships, where the power actually lay, and grasped that a debt owed to them by the whole world was a leash more durable than any colony.

The arrangement looks, in retrospect, like *laissez-faire*, and was preferred by its beneficiaries to look that way, but it was a managed apparatus from the beginning, and the management was a continuous tradition that ran without serious interruption from the Elizabethan court to the postwar Atlantic. Whig historiography has treated the British nineteenth century as the age of free trade, the spontaneous order of contracts and markets emerging from the retreat of the state; the same century read against the institutional traffic discloses a different object, a single technical project of population management that begins under Elizabeth and ends, three hundred and fifty years later, at the Macy Conferences in New York. The figures who conducted it are not usually grouped together by the standard histories because they sit in different disciplinary boxes: a statesman, a philosopher, a pamphleteer, a panopticon-architect, a mathematician of inference, a designer of factories, a Fabian economist. Lined up in sequence they describe one continuous engineering tradition whose object was the management of a population by the calibration of its appetites, its information environment, and its productive arrangements. Francis Bacon, who was Lord Chancellor under James I and the lieutenant of Robert Cecil's intelligence apparatus, set down in his posthumous *New Atlantis* of 1627 a fable of an island whose government was organized around a research institute called Salomon's House, an assembly of scholars whose business was the production of useful knowledge for the state. The fable was read for two centuries as a utopian conceit; it was, more exactly, the first written prototype of the think-tank, an account of what a state would look like that organized its intelligence-gathering and its applied science under a single coordinated institution. The lantern of the kingdom, Bacon called Salomon's House. The Royal Society, founded in 1660 under the new Stuart settlement, was conceived in conscious imitation of it.

Defoe extended the project across the financial revolution that the previous section described. He was, in addition to being the novelist that the political economists would lift *Crusoe* from, a paid intelligence agent for both Tory and Whig ministries, a projector of currency reform proposals, a designer of joint-stock schemes, and the author of the *Essay upon Projects* which proposed in 1697 a national pension fund, a road tax, a system of insurance for widows, an academy for the cultivation of the English language, and the regularization of bankruptcy law. He understood, before anyone else seems to have set it down, that the new credit instruments could be paired with the new statistical reasoning to give the state an instrument of governance more flexible than the older ones of conscription and taxation. A population could be enumerated, its productive capacities estimated, its consumption taxed, its credit extended or contracted, and the

resulting flows tracked by a small clerical apparatus in London; the projector was the figure who proposed each scheme and the pamphlet was the medium through which the proposals were circulated for political reception. The 1690s of the Bank also produced the political arithmetic of William Petty and Gregory King, the first English attempts to count national income, to estimate the population by parishes, and to compute the productive output of the realm as a single quantity. From there the line runs directly to Jeremy Bentham, who in 1791 published *Panopticon*, or the *Inspection House*, a treatise on the architectural arrangement of buildings such that a single inspector at the centre could see all of the inhabitants without being seen by them. Bentham proposed the design first for prisons, then for poorhouses, factories, schools, and asylums; he wrote, in a letter to his brother, that the principle was applicable to any institution whose object was to bring about the maximum of conformity at the minimum of supervision. The *Panopticon* was the architectural implementation of the same logic Bacon had set down for the institute and Defoe had set down for the state, the management of a population by the calibrated distribution of visibility and access.

Bentham's deeper proposal was the calculus of pains and pleasures, the doctrine that human action was the resultant of two opposed magnitudes which could in principle be quantified, and that the proper object of legislation was to arrange the laws and institutions of a society so as to produce the greatest sum of pleasure across the population to be governed. Utility was the function that legislation existed to maximize, and the state was the central instrument by which the calibration was performed. The doctrine and the architecture were a single project. The *Panopticon* was the building inside which the calculus was administered; the pleasures and pains the inmates felt were the variables; the inspector's adjustments were the controller's interventions. The system anticipates by a century and a half the formal description of a feedback loop with a setpoint, an input, an output, and a control unit. Charles Babbage, who attended Bentham's funeral in 1832 and was present when Bentham's preserved corpse was set up in University College London where it sits to this day, that year published *On the Economy of Machinery and Manufactures*, an analysis of the new factory production written in the language of the calculus of operations. Babbage observed that the productivity of a factory could be raised by the division of labor into the smallest possible operations, each performed by a worker chosen and trained for that operation alone, and that the same principle applied to mental as to manual work; the calculating engines he was then building were intended as the mechanical embodiment of that division. Babbage's *Economy of Machinery* sat in Darwin's library, was annotated by him through the late 1830s, and the language of the division of labor as the principle of competitive efficiency was transposed directly into the theory of speciation. The differential survival of slightly different forms, each better fitted to a slightly different niche, is Babbage's factory transposed onto the biological scale, the species as the operation and the niche as the workstation. Marx, with characteristic directness, observed that

Darwin appears to derive the British class system from nature, the manufactures being projected onto the kingdom of organisms and returned to society as natural law. The same Victorian decade produced both the doctrine of natural selection and the second edition of the *Philosophy of Manufactures*. They were the same doctrine in two languages.

The line runs forward through W. S. Jevons, whose 1869 logic piano the chapter has already met and will meet again. Jevons had been an undergraduate at Bentham's University College London, had worked as an assayer at the Sydney mint, and had returned to England to take up the chair in political economy at Manchester. His *Theory of Political Economy* of 1871, in which the Crusoe figure became the textbook setup for marginal utility, was preceded by his *Principles of Science* of 1874, in which the logic piano was set out as a mechanical demonstration of Boolean syllogistic. The same hand that had reduced economic agency to a calibration of pleasure against labor had built, in wood and brass, the apparatus that demonstrated formal inference as a sequence of physical states. Sixty-eight years later, in his 1937 master's thesis at MIT, Claude Shannon would prove that Boolean algebra mapped onto the relay circuits of electrical engineering, and the digital computer would follow within a decade; Jevons's logic piano, then demoted to a museum case in Oxford, was the direct ancestor. The same Jevons who taught the undergraduate to think of himself as Robinson Crusoe optimizing his utility had built the Victorian sketch of the digital machine. The two projects were the same project; one specified the calculation, the other built the instrument that performed it. The economic agent imagined by political economy and the logical agent embodied by the relay circuit are the two halves of one apparatus, and the marginalist undergraduate and the digital computer arrived together at the same office at MIT seventy years later because they had been built in the same Victorian study by the same Manchester chemist.

The institutional pivot came in the 1880s. The Fabian Society, founded in London in 1884, took its name from the Roman general who had refused pitched battle and worn his enemy down by delay, and announced itself as a society of socialists who had concluded that revolution was the wrong method for the British case. Beatrice Webb, the daughter of a railway magnate who had spent her late twenties as an investigator of London poverty under Charles Booth, and her husband Sidney Webb, a clerk in the Colonial Office with a first-class degree in law, set out the strategy in a series of pamphlets and tracts that ran from 1889 through the 1890s: the Society would not seek to overthrow the liberal institutions but to colonize them, to staff the new civil service positions, to write the new bureaucratic regulations, to teach the new economics and the new sociology at a new university the Society would establish for the purpose, and to permeate the existing political parties with people educated in the doctrine. The London School of Economics and Political Science was founded by the Webbs in 1895 with funds drawn from a small bequest to the Society, took its first students that autumn, and was designed from the start as the training college of the new administrative class. The shift was decisive. The utilitarianism of Bentham, which had been a

revolutionary doctrine in 1791 directed against the inherited institutions of the Anglican state, became under the Fabian construction the operating doctrine of the institutions themselves, the trained expertise by which the welfare state of the next century would be staffed and run. Utility was no longer a critique of the order; it was the order's calibration manual. The same century that produced the Panopticon as a critique of the unreformed poorhouse produced the LSE as the institution that would design the reformed one. Managerial cybernetics, the doctrine that the state is a control system whose business is the optimization of an objective function over a population, dates in substance from this pivot, and the figure of the trained expert who administers the function dates from the LSE's first cohort.

The pleasure-and-pain feedback loop Bentham had specified ran forward through the same century by way of the Russian physiologist Ivan Pavlov, who in the 1890s discovered that the salivary response of his laboratory dogs could be conditioned to arbitrary stimuli, and through the American behaviorists who took up Pavlov's results after 1913 and developed under B. F. Skinner the operant conditioning schedules that became the standard apparatus of the American twentieth-century behavior laboratory. The principle was Bentham's: an organism whose action was governed by the calibration of pain and pleasure could be trained, by the systematic application of the two, into any pattern of behavior the operator chose. The lever the rat pressed and the food pellet that fell were the inspector's adjustment and the inmate's response, mapped from the prison architecture to the experimental cage. The same principle was extended by Norbert Wiener and the Macy Conferences after 1946 into the formal mathematical theory of negative-feedback control, the framework that would be called cybernetics and that would be presented as a postwar American invention emerging from wartime work on anti-aircraft fire-control. The genealogy is otherwise. The control theory Wiener formalized in 1948 was the mathematical expression of an engineering tradition that had begun under Elizabeth with Bacon's intelligence apparatus, had been formalized under William and Mary by the Whig credit and the Whig press, had been written into architecture by Bentham in 1791, into the factory by Ure in 1835, into the species by Darwin in 1859, into the logic machine by Jevons in 1869, into the welfare state by the Webbs in the 1890s, and into the behavior laboratory by Pavlov and Skinner across the same decades. Wiener's 1948 book completed a project that had been running for two hundred and fifty years. What the postwar Americans presented as a wartime invention emerging from radar-driven fire-control work was, viewed at a longer scale, the British imperial control apparatus translated into the mathematics it had always presupposed and migrated to the institutional setting of the American research university. The Victorian institutions that the rest of this chapter will treat, the gold standard and the central bank and the cotton mill and the museum, were not the *laissez-faire* arrangement the Whig histories presented them as; they were the operating instruments of a continuous engineering tradition whose business was the calibration of

populations and whose textbooks were the same textbooks the next century would put on the syllabus at the LSE and at MIT.

No one rendered the empire's image of itself more exactly than Joseph Mallord William Turner, and he did it while living, in his late years, in a riverside cottage in Chelsea under the assumed name of Admiral Booth, hiding from the dealers and the press and from his own celebrity. The housekeeper of an earlier mistress, Sophia Booth, kept the place; he gave his real name to almost no one in the neighborhood; he died there in December 1851 of cholera with his secret intact, and the surviving daughters by his earlier housekeeper learned of his death from a newspaper. The man who had been Britain's most decorated painter died on a borrowed pillow with the curtain pulled. The arc of the work runs the same way the order runs. He had begun as a topographer of cathedrals and ruins, a young man hired by engravers to paint solid things in clear light, and across a half-century the solidity dissolved. The legend that he had himself lashed to the mast of a steamboat off Harwich in 1842 to study a snowstorm from inside it is unverifiable; the canvas is the evidence, paint applied as if the air itself were moving substance. In *The Fighting Temeraire*, exhibited at the Royal Academy in 1839, a gunship that had fought at Trafalgar is towed to the breaker's yard by a small black steam tug, the old wooden world of sail going pale and ghostly behind the squat dark engine that has replaced it, the whole scene swimming in a sunset that seems less painted than exhaled. In *Rain, Steam and Speed*, hung in 1844, a Great Western locomotive crosses Brunel's new viaduct out of a downpour so total that the bridge, the river, the train, and the air through which it moves are no longer separable. He worked the canvases up to the last minute on the Royal Academy's Varnishing Days, scumbling color onto barely-finished surfaces in front of his rivals, who watched him assemble his pictures in public the way a magician finishes a trick. The formal fact across the late work is the loss of fixed outline. Turner was painting at the moment the British order felt most natural to itself, when its power seemed not imposed but climatic, and his canvases give that feeling its truest form: a world in which the hard edges of things melt into an atmosphere that has no boundary. What they contain is the empire's vision of its own dominion as atmosphere, vast and answerable to nothing outside it. What presses against the canvas is that atmosphere is the one substance a person cannot grip. The loss of outline that makes the pictures sublime is also the loss of the firm shape by which a thing endures, and a power that has become atmosphere can thin out and pass. Turner painted how the order felt from within at its height, hiding from his own century in a cottage by the river, and the feeling, set down honestly, delivered the warning the statistics could not supply. He left his canvases to the nation and his money to a charity for impoverished British artists. The bequest sat tied up in court for twenty-six years before it produced a single shilling for an indigent painter.

The same self-image stood up once in iron and glass. For the Great Exhibition of 1851 Joseph Paxton built, in Hyde Park and in under a year, a structure of cast iron and nearly three hundred

thousand identical panes of glass, a transparent shed eighteen hundred and fifty-one feet long, its length chosen to match the year, and inside it the empire arranged the produce of the whole earth as though the earth were a single warehouse it managed. The iron frame nearly vanished behind the light, so that one stood inside an enclosure that did not seem to enclose, under a roof that read as sky. The press named it the Crystal Palace, and it was Turner's dissolving outline made habitable, a structure whose genius was to present itself as nothing built at all, only light and commerce and air. The whole produce of the earth was on display; the labor that made it was nowhere in the room, the exhibition's deepest statement and its most useful one. To gather the world's goods and erase its workers in the same glass hall is the consumer fantasy in its first pure form, wealth shown as if it fell from the sky onto the deserving, and the men who profited from the labor were the men who paid for the hall.

The doctrine that arranged that erasure had been worked out across the previous century in a sequence of textbooks and novels, and the first of the textbooks was a novel. Defoe's *Robinson Crusoe*, published in April 1719, was read on its appearance as an adventure of shipwreck and survival; what it became, in the hands of the political economists, was the founding pedagogical fiction of the new discipline. The man on the island who keeps an account of his stores, calibrates his labor against his needs, allocates his hours among the production of bread and the rearing of goats and the building of his palisade, and arrives by methodical accumulation at a one-man commonwealth, was the abstracted figure on whose hypothesized choices the science of economics would, for the next three centuries, be founded. The teaching trick was to begin from the island because the island stripped away the inconvenient fact of other people. A society in which production occurs through divisions of labor settled by hereditary class, ownership rules backed by armed force, and credit arrangements running back to the Bank of England, is hard to describe without naming any of those things. A man alone on an island with a Bible, a chest of tools rescued from the wreck, and a Friday who arrives later as a free assistant, is easy to describe, and the description can be exported back to the metropolitan factory as though the factory were the island writ large. W. S. Jevons, whose logic piano the chapter has already met, formalized the move in his 1871 *Theory of Political Economy*, taking *Crusoe* as the textbook setup for marginal utility: the lone agent maximizing satisfaction across hours of labor and quantities of fruit, indifferent between curves the modern undergraduate is still made to draw. A century and a half later the *Robinson Crusoe Economy* remains the canonical opening of the introductory microeconomics syllabus, the figure of the bourgeois individual presented as the natural unit of economic life rather than as the historically specific creature the Whig press had produced in the 1690s.

Marx, in the first chapter of *Capital*, took the trope apart. He observed that the *Crusoe* of Defoe's novel arrives on his island equipped with a watch, a Bible, an inkpot, the habits of

double-entry bookkeeping, and the disposition to treat his own labor time as a quantity to be measured and allocated, and that none of these are properties of a human being as such. They are the properties of a particular eighteenth-century English Protestant merchant whose interior has been organized by the institutions the previous section described. Robinson on his island is not human nature; he is the bourgeois reproducing himself in solitude, his interior already shaped by the press, the chapel, and the counting-house he has been shipwrecked away from. The mistake the new political economy made, on Marx's reading, was to take the result of three centuries of specific institutional formation and present it as the natural starting point of all economic analysis, as though the categories the institutions had produced were the timeless categories of the human as such. Bourgeois economics, he wrote, in its preferred mode of starting from the isolated individual and building outward to society, projects the present back through the ages and finds in every prehistoric hunter and gatherer a Crusoe already keeping accounts. The fiction had become the discipline. The discipline could not see that it had begun in a fiction. The pedagogical figure on which the science of the market rested had been written by a journalist who had also coined the term air-money for what the market traded.

In the same generation that the textbooks were being written, the factory that the textbooks abstracted was being assembled, and the man who assembled its image in prose was a Glasgow chemist named Andrew Ure. In the autumn of 1818 Ure had performed a public demonstration in the Glasgow infirmary on the body of an executed murderer, a collier called Matthew Clydesdale, hanging at the end of which the body had been delivered, still warm, for galvanic experiments. Before an audience of medical students and the curious, Ure attached the poles of a Voltaic battery to the spinal column and the phrenic nerve, and the corpse on the table inflated its chest, jerked its limbs, and contorted its face into expressions the witnesses recorded as fury, derision, and despair. The reports of the demonstration ran in the Glasgow papers through the autumn of 1818 and were read in London the following spring, when Mary Shelley was preparing for press the novel she had drafted in 1816 at Lake Geneva. Whether Shelley took the specific scene from Ure or from one of the several galvanic demonstrators of the previous decade is unprovable; the figure of the man assembled out of parts and animated by a current of will was, by 1818, in the air, and Ure's was the most theatrical version of it. *Frankenstein* appeared in three volumes in January of that year. Seventeen years later, in 1835, Ure published the book by which he would be remembered, *The Philosophy of Manufactures*, a defense of the new factory system intended to refute the early reformers and to set out the principles of industrial organization for the men who were building the mills. The factory, Ure wrote, is a vast automaton composed of many self-regulated mechanical and intellectual organs acting in uninterrupted concert toward the production of a common product, all of them being subordinate to a moving force that animates the whole. The mechanical organs were the looms and the steam engines; the intellectual organs were the operatives at the

looms; the moving force was the proprietor, and the whole was a single creature whose limbs were the workers and whose will was capital.

Marx noticed. In the volume that he was finishing in the British Museum reading-room, the volume the chapter will reach in a few pages, Ure is quoted at length and with an unusual relish, named the Pindar of the factory, called the classical expression of the spirit of the factory in which the contradictions of the capitalist brain blurt themselves out with a naïveté that no opponent of the system could have improved on. Capital, Marx wrote, is dead labor that, vampire-like, lives only by sucking living labor and lives the more the more labor it sucks. The metaphor was not loose; it was the precise structural figure of the new factory as Ure had described it, an artificial body animated by a force that did not belong to its limbs and that grew, the more it consumed of them, the more it required to be fed. The same animation that Ure praised as the principle of industry, Marx diagnosed as the principle of the vampire and of the creature in Shelley's novel: an assemblage of human parts, brought together by belief and stitched at the joints by contract, given motion by an external charge, and turning at last on its makers because the makers had not understood what they had built. The factory was not metaphorically Frankenstein's creature; it was literally what Shelley had described, an artificial body assembled from human parts and animated by a force it did not own, growing in strength as it grew in self-consciousness, and approaching the moment at which it would reach for the throat of its constructor. Where the novel had pictured the catastrophe in the figure of a single man pursued through the Arctic by his own creation, the political economy described it as the standing condition of industrial society, the makers pursued through history by the artificial body they had built and could not now disown.

What the two registers, the textbook and the factory, had in common was the construction of an artificial creature out of human parts and the subsequent presentation of the creature as nature. Robinson Crusoe was the human individual stripped to his bourgeois inheritance and presented as the natural unit of economic analysis. Ure's automaton was the assembled factory presented as the natural form of industrial production. In both cases a historically specific arrangement, made by a particular class in a particular generation under particular legal and credit institutions, was raised to the status of a fact about the universe and used as the starting point for a science. The doctrine that arranged the Crystal Palace was the same one that had arranged the Lancashire mill, and the same one that the political economists would soon arrange into the lectures they gave at the new University College London and at Edinburgh, lectures the next generation of administrators would take with them out to India and to the Cape. The Frankenstein figure that the romantic novel had given the order was the figure of its own self-misrecognition: a creature built by the bourgeoisie out of the bodies of the workers, animated by the credit the Whigs had invented, told by its makers that it was a fact of nature, and growing every decade larger and less containable than its makers had foreseen. The factory and the textbook were two sides of one project. The first manufactured

the product, the second manufactured the doctrine that the product was inevitable. Where one stood, the other followed. The Hand in Coketown was the worker as Ure had described him, the intellectual organ of the great automaton, his identity reduced to the function he performed, and the chronicler the next paragraph introduces was the man who walked into the factory to see what the textbook had refused to show.

That labor had a chronicler, and one man made its erasure his life's subject because his own had been pasted onto a bottle. When Charles Dickens was twelve his father, a Navy Pay Office clerk who could not stop spending more than he earned, was sent to the Marshalsea debtors' prison south of the river, and the boy was put to work at Warren's Blacking warehouse near Charing Cross pasting labels on pots of shoe-blackening for six shillings a week. He spent four months on the labels. He told no one but his closest friend John Forster what he had been, and he told even Forster only late; his own wife and children never knew. The wound stayed open for fifty years and produced the books. In *Hard Times*, serialized in 1854 after he had gone north to watch a strike in the cotton mills at Preston, he invented Coketown, identical brick streets, a black canal, a river that ran purple with dye, where the working people were called Hands as though they were detachable from the bodies they belonged to and were only units of labor. The novel's villain is not a man but a doctrine: the political economy that could see a population as a column of figures and could not see a person at all, the same calculus that let the City clear the planet's trade without touching the lives it consumed. The official order's fantasy was that wealth was the climate, ambient and innocent. Dickens forced into view that the sky fell as soot on particular streets and named lungs, and that someone had to live underneath the glow so that someone else could call it climate. Harold Bloom, who argued that the canon coheres by the power to disturb rather than by virtue or moral instruction, kept Dickens near its center for this reason: the caricatures are larger than life and therefore more real than realism, and Coketown is more permanent than the Lancashire it was drawn from. The Hand is a figure no statistic could have produced and no column of numbers can dislodge. He spent the last decade of his life on public readings, performing his own scenes from a stage in evening dress, and the one he kept to the last was the murder of Nancy from *Oliver Twist*, performed at such pitch that his doctors recorded his pulse running past a hundred and twenty afterward. He gave the murder forty-three times. On the ninth of June 1865 he had survived the Staplehurst rail crash with the actress Ellen Ternan, who was not his wife, climbed back twice into the wreckage to retrieve the manuscript of *Our Mutual Friend*, and tended the wounded for hours. He died on the ninth of June 1870, exactly five years to the day after the crash, his daughter Mary recording that he had been at supper before the stroke and had said, suddenly, "On the ground." The thing the order needed no one to see, Dickens made unforgettable, and he performed his own scenes until the performance killed him.

The order had teeth when the occasion called for them, and where it bared them shows what the empire of guarantee actually was beneath the talk of free trade. The Opium Wars of 1839 and 1856 are the purest distillation of finance and force in the century. Britain ran a chronic deficit with China, hungry for tea and silk, and closed the gap by selling Indian opium into the Chinese market against Chinese law. When the Qing moved to stop the trade, the Royal Navy arrived to insist that markets stay open and debts be paid. Free trade was the doctrine when it served the creditor; the gunboat took over when it did not. The two were never in tension. Both answered to the same balance of payments. Empire here was an accounting operation conducted by warship, run to make a national drug-pushing scheme profitable and to keep silver flowing toward London. It worked cleanly and cheaply, the look of a rising power whose capability runs so far ahead of resistance that violence files itself under administration. The columns at Omdurman in 1898, where Kitchener's Maxim guns killed eleven thousand for a few dozen of his own, belong to the same arithmetic. But the men dying against the machine guns were the army of a sacred end-times movement, followers of a Sudanese who had declared himself the Mahdi and whose vision of the last days had destroyed Gordon at Khartoum and ruled the Sudan for thirteen years. Apocalyptic belief is a material force, not an ornament, a script that sends men marching into certain death by promising the contest is cosmically final and the dead are not lost but vindicated. It is among the most powerful instruments ever found for converting human energy into action against all rational calculation, and the orders that learn to wield it outrun those that merely pay wages. Britain had capability at Omdurman; the Mahdists had resolve; in a rising hegemon's asymmetric war, capability crushes resolve. A later day, on other frontiers, would bring a declining hegemon against the same will with capability alone, and teach that capability alone is never enough.

The decade that produced the war produced, in four other rooms, the intellectual instruments by which the rest of the century would read what the war had been. In London, in a reading-room of the British Museum where he kept a steady seat, Karl Marx finished the first volume of *Das Kapital* in 1867.⁷ His diagnostic was already on Hegel's floor, history advanced by contradiction, but he had inverted the dialectic and placed it in the ownership of the means of production. Ideas, on his account, are not the prime movers a Hegelian seminar took them for; they are the rationalization of material interests, and the ruling ideas of any age are the ideas of its ruling class. The Civil War he had read in real time, writing on it for the *New York Daily Tribune* across the conflict, was the working example of the doctrine: a regional ruling class had built its account of itself, its civilization, its honor, its way of life, on a property arrangement, and when the arrangement was threatened the account turned to gunfire. In a country house in Kent, Charles Darwin had published *On the Origin of Species* in 1859, after two decades of suppressing the manuscript from the religious horror he expected it to provoke. His mechanism was survival and the differential reproduction of small variations; the formal claim was that complexity in living

systems requires no designer, only time, pressure, and selection. The reading of the species as the product of competitive adaptation under scarcity would, before the century was out, be misappropriated as a social doctrine and dropped onto the empire as license. The Darwin who mattered was the one whose mechanism let the rest of biology stop reaching for design. And in a laboratory in Heidelberg, Hermann von Helmholtz had been demonstrating across the 1850s and 1860s that perception is not the passive reception of an external world but an active inference: the eye and the ear take in fragmentary signals, and the brain constructs the world from them by applying expectations the perceiver does not consciously possess. His *Handbuch der physiologischen Optik* appeared in three volumes between 1856 and 1867. Kant's old limit, set down a generation earlier, now had an experimental physiology. The mind that mediates the world had been opened in the laboratory. And in a workshop in Manchester, the economist William Stanley Jevons built in 1869 a wooden device he called the logic piano, a keyboard machine that solved Boolean syllogisms mechanically by levers and pulleys, the first apparatus to perform formal inference as a sequence of physical states. Sixty-eight years later, in his 1937 master's thesis at MIT, Claude Shannon would prove that Boolean algebra mapped onto electrical relay circuits, and the Jevons piano, demoted by then to a museum case in Oxford, turned out to have been the Victorian sketch of every digital computer that followed.

While Britain ruled, Britain built the powers that would bury it. This is the deepest movement of the century. British money built the American railways and the German chemical works and the infrastructure of Meiji Japan; British free trade opened a market to the rising powers while they sheltered their own industries behind tariffs Britain on principle declined to match. The fastest industrial growth occurred not in Britain but on its peripheries, and relative decline is the hardest thing for a hegemon to feel, because in absolute terms Britain kept growing richer the whole time. The City lent to the borderlands at interest and counted the coupon as proof of strength, while the borrowers turned the loans into steel mills that would out-produce the lender within a generation. The creditor's mistake is always to read the flow of interest as strength and miss that the real power is the thing built with the principal, and the City made it on a planetary scale. Germany is the great case, where steel and ideas run together. Bismarck's wars ended with the German Empire proclaimed in the Hall of Mirrors at Versailles in 1871, the new power's birth staged in the palace of the defeated. What was born was a continental industrial state with the best chemists, the best general staff, a steel output that would pass Britain's by the century's end, and the modern research university besides. Out of the same German nineteenth century came the antithesis to its own confidence. Schopenhauer had turned Kant's veiled reality into a blind striving will beneath all appearance, and Richard Wagner heard him and built, across the decades it took to compose the Ring, an art designed to submerge the listener in exactly that will. Wagner's formal invention was the melody that refuses to resolve, the chord suspended so the ear is never released, the orchestra

grown so continuous that the audience is meant not to watch a drama but to drown in a sound that has swallowed the stage.

Across the Atlantic the same energizing of the periphery ran through the bloodiest war of the century, and at the bottom of it stood the ownership of human beings. Slavery was the central cause of the American Civil War, materially and morally both, not an occasion the deeper story merely passed through. An entire regional ruling class had built its wealth, its politics, and its sense of itself on the ownership of four million people, and it went to war to keep and extend that possession, saying so in its own declarations of secession before later memory taught it to say otherwise. South Carolina, Mississippi, Georgia, and Texas each set down in writing, in the winter the Confederacy formed, that they were leaving the Union to protect the institution of slavery against a North that meant in the end to abolish it. Centralization and industrial finance are the war's frame; the ownership of people is its cause. Two visions of the continent had contended since the founding, Jefferson's decentralized agrarian republic against Hamilton's strong central state, and the slave economy was the material engine that made the pastoral ideal a vision of bondage and the contest irrepressible. The South was not a backwater fighting modernity. It was the richest agricultural region in the world, its cotton the single largest export of the United States, the raw material the mills of Lancashire and New England both depended on, and the human beings who picked it were the most valuable form of property in the country, worth more in aggregate than all the railroads and factories of the North combined. A class that keeps that much of its wealth in the bodies of others does not negotiate it away. It fights.

The war ran four years and killed three-quarters of a million men, the deadliest in American history, and it took them in a new way: this was the first great war of the industrial age, and the weapons had outrun the tactics of the generals. Rifled muskets that could hit a man at four hundred yards were still met with massed frontal assaults bred for the smoothbore. The result was the slaughter of Antietam in a single September day in 1862, the bloodiest day the country has ever had, and the three days at Gettysburg the next July, where Lee threw the flower of his army across an open mile of Pennsylvania field into the center of the Union line and lost a third of it in an hour. The South won the early battles on the skill of its officers and the resolve of men defending their own ground, and it could not win the war, because the war had become a contest of production. The North could make more of everything, more rifles, more rail, more men, more money, and would go on making it longer than the South could bear to lose its men. When Lincoln found a general willing to spend that advantage without flinching, the war turned into something the previous wars of the century had not seen: a deliberate campaign against the enemy's capacity to continue. Grant ground Lee's army down through the Wilderness while Sherman marched through Georgia and the Carolinas, tearing up the rail and razing the plantations and feeding his army off the land it crossed, war waged against the economy and the will of a whole society rather than

against its army alone. It ended at Appomattox in the spring of 1865 with Lee's surrender and, days later, with the murder of the president who had won it, in a theater, by an actor who believed to the end he had struck a blow for the South.

What the war abolished was the ownership of people, and what it built in the same stroke was the continental state, because to fight it the federal government had to construct that apparatus in the language of money. The Legal Tender Act of 1862 created the greenback, a federal paper currency declared lawful payment for debts and backed by nothing but the government's word, the first time the United States issued a fiat money and compelled its acceptance. It floated against gold for the rest of the war as the pound had floated against gold through the Napoleonic suspension, worth what the public's confidence in eventual victory made it worth. The National Banking Acts of 1863 and 1864 then built a uniform federal currency out of the wreckage of the thousands of state-chartered banknotes that had circulated before, by a device that set the pattern for the century to come⁸ A bank that wanted a national charter had to buy federal war bonds and lodge them with the Treasury; against that collateral it was licensed to issue its own notes. The banks thus financed the war by buying the debt and were paid interest on the very debt that backed the money they printed, so that the government's debt and the banks' profit were welded into one instrument. Who benefited beyond the four million freed is plain. The industrial and financial North gained, its banks now owning the national debt as the asset on which the new currency stood, so that the destruction of the planter aristocracy and the enrichment of the Northern creditor class were the same act of construction, accomplished by the same printing press. A monetary instrument was forged to destroy a property regime in human beings, to bind a continent under a single state, and to seat a creditor class at the center of it, and all three were accomplished at the cost of three-quarters of a million dead. The continental power that emerged would by 1900 out-produce Britain in steel, its rise fed by British capital and nearly invisible to a British establishment that still counted strength in dreadnoughts. On the world's far rim Japan drew China's opposite conclusion, importing after 1868 the railways and the constitution and the conscript army and the central bank so as never to be opened by another nation's guns. In 1905 it would defeat Russia, the schooled frontier becoming a teacher in its turn.

What the war freed, the peace refinanced. Appomattox released four million people into an economy in which they owned almost nothing, surrounded by the men who had owned them, and for a decade the republic experimented with protecting the experiment: federal troops in the South, Black men in statehouses and in Congress, a Freedmen's Bureau, three amendments written into the Constitution. The experiment ended by arithmetic. The election of 1876 came out disputed, and the bargain that resolved it gave the Republicans the presidency and gave the South the removal of the troops. The price of one office was the abandonment of four million citizens. Both sides understood the trade and made it. What replaced bondage was not freedom but a ledger. A family

8. The National Currency Act of 1863 and the National Bank Act of 1864.

9. The Compromise of 1877. On the crop-lien system, Roger Ransom and Richard Sutch, *One Kind of Freedom* (1977); Plessy v. Ferguson, 163 U.S. 537 (1896).

farmed land it did not own, borrowed seed and tools and food against a crop not yet grown, bought at the only store that would extend the account at interest that ran to half the loan, and settled at the gin against the landlord's books, which the landlord kept. The crop lien was emancipation converted into debt at the moment of settlement, renewed each January, enforceable each fall. A man who tried to leave with a balance outstanding could be arrested for it, and the convict lease stood ready to rent him back to the fields he had fled. By 1896 the Supreme Court had blessed the arrangement's social face, separate and equal, and the order had completed at home the discovery it was making abroad: a population can be re-bound with paper after the chains are made illegal, and the paper binds tighter than iron because it does not advertise its work. The century ahead would put the discovery to general use⁹

Read at distance, the order of 1900 stood at a deceptive zenith. Dynamism still looked high, the City clearing the planet's commerce, the navy supreme, the gold standard global, the colonial wars won, yet the pressures that end orders had climbed. Financialization was the order's defining trait and its hidden weakness: an empire that lives by lending and clearing rather than by making concentrates its risk, and a system so concentrated does not fail at its edges but at its center, suddenly, when several pressures arrive at once. The same evidence raises the reading's blind spot up to the light, because the order did not collapse on schedule. It adapted. The lender of last resort Bagehot codified after the panics of 1825, 1866, and 1890 was a guarantee credibly rebuilt rather than abandoned, the discovery that in a true run the Bank must lend freely, against good collateral, at a punitive rate, and so stop the panic by promising to do the one thing a panicked depositor fears no one will do¹⁰ A reading of this kind sees slow rot well and is blind to that reflexive repair. It does not read the rescue that keeps arriving in time, nor the thing Turner had already painted: the dissolution of a solid order into an atmosphere that feels boundless and is the most contingent of all.

The century closed with one more dissolution of outline, this time chosen as method rather than reached as a late style. In 1872, in the harbor of his native Le Havre, Claude Monet painted the sun rising through industrial haze over the masts and cranes of a working port, the water a few orange strokes, the boats half-erased in mist, the whole scene set down so loosely that nothing in it retained a firm edge. When he showed it in Paris in the spring of 1874 a hostile critic named Louis Leroy seized on its title, *Impression, Sunrise*, and used the word as an insult, complaining that wallpaper in its unfinished state was more finished than this seascape. The painters took the insult for a name and kept it. What Leroy could not forgive was the formal claim the picture made: that the truth of the modern world was not its objects but the perception of them, not the harbor but the impression it left on one retina at a single hour. This is the Kantian floor surfacing in oil paint at the very end of the century the lecture halls had opened. The Impressionists abandoned the firm outline of things on principle, as Turner had lost it by temperament, and conceded openly what the

10. Walter Bagehot, *Lombard Street: A Description of the Money Market* (1873). On the longer succession of liquidity crises, Charles P. Kindleberger, *Manias, Panics, and Crashes: A History of Financial Crises* (New York: Basic Books, 1978).

gold standard depended on no one saying, that the world a person inhabits is a version and not the thing itself, real in the way a banknote is real, and dissolving the moment the agreement does.

The same conceded ground was being walked in the seminar and the consulting room. In a furnished room in Turin on the third of January 1889, Friedrich Nietzsche threw his arms around the neck of a cab horse being beaten in the Piazza Carlo Alberto and collapsed sobbing into the street. His landlord lifted him upstairs and he never wrote a coherent sentence again. The decade he lost his mind across had produced *Beyond Good and Evil*, *On the Genealogy of Morals*, and the four parts of *Thus Spoke Zarathustra*, and the central claim across all of them was that the Christian moral order had quietly died and the West had not yet noticed that the bottom had fallen out. He named the condition nihilism, and he meant it not as a creed but as a diagnosis. The values inherited from Christendom no longer rested on anything; what would replace them was a question the next century was going to have to answer in blood, because the question of what underwrites the worth of anything cannot be left unanswered indefinitely by a civilization that wants to keep functioning. He was probably right. He died of pneumonia in Weimar in 1900 without recovering his speech, his mother and sister having spent the last decade nursing him into a small industry of edited posthumous volumes that would do as much to misdirect his thought as to preserve it. In a private practice in Vienna, in the same years, the physician Sigmund Freud was assembling the case histories that became *Studies on Hysteria* in 1895 and *The Interpretation of Dreams* in 1899. His claim was that the rational mind a Kantian seminar took for granted is in fact split, sitting on a sub-basement of motive and desire it does not see and cannot fully govern, and that what a person says about why he did what he did is mostly a story he tells himself after the fact, fitted over a current of wish and fear he never glimpses. Freud cared about therapy and the courts of Vienna; his nephew would, a generation later, take the same insight to commerce and make of it the engineering of consent. The two together, Nietzsche announcing that the inherited values had stopped binding and Freud naming the layer beneath them where motive actually lived, opened the century to come. What followed in oil paint, in concert hall, and at last in the trenches, ran out of the gap they had named.

One painter took that conceded ground and pushed it past method into a place the order had no use for: a madhouse. He had cut off the lower part of his own left ear in Arles on the night of December 23, 1888, wrapped it in newspaper, walked to a brothel he frequented and delivered it to a young maid named Rachel, telling her to keep the object carefully. The exact wound and the woman's name were established only a hundred and twenty-eight years later when a researcher read the local police register against a French farmer's letter; the standard story had had the recipient wrong for a century. Five months on, in May of 1889, Vincent van Gogh committed himself voluntarily to the asylum of Saint-Paul-de-Mausole outside Saint-Rémy, paid for by his brother Theo, an art dealer in Paris who had supported him financially for a decade. From the

barred east window of his cell, working in daylight from a vision he had preserved out of the night, he painted *The Starry Night* in the middle of June. The sky is in violent motion, the stars swollen into spinning bodies of light, a current of paint rolling across the dark in thick coiled strokes; beneath it the village sleeps in straight horizontal lines with a church spire reaching up into a sky that pays it no attention. A cypress, the tree the south of France plants in its graveyards, twists up the left edge like a column of dark erupting from the earth toward the turning heavens. The formal fact is that the sky is alive and the town is inert; the energy of the picture is all in the firmament, and the human settlement is a row of quiet rectangles with no force of its own. The Impressionists had said reality is the impression it leaves on a single retina; van Gogh took the claim to the place it had always been heading and painted the mark one overcharged consciousness left on the world, the night seen not as it is but as it presses on a man whose nerves can no longer keep it out. The fantasy of the rational nineteenth century was that the universe was a mechanism a clear eye could measure and a column of figures could capture. The thing his sky forces up, which that century could not admit, is that perception is not a window but a pressure, that the measuring eye is itself an organ under strain, and that the cosmos felt from inside a breaking mind is not a clockwork but a turning weight the church spire cannot reach and the figures cannot capture. He sold one painting in his life, *The Red Vineyard*, to a Belgian named Anna Boch for four hundred francs in February 1890, the only documented sale on the books; he wrote nearly nine hundred letters to Theo over a decade, almost all surviving, the most complete record of a working consciousness any painter has left. He shot himself in a wheat field outside Auvers-sur-Oise in late July 1890 and walked back to his lodging to die two days later in his brother's arms; recent forensics suggest the bullet's angle and powder pattern are inconsistent with self-infliction, and the death may have been an accident inflicted by local boys he had been drinking with, a possibility he took to the grave without naming them. Theo died six months later, broken by the loss. The order that had no place for either would within a generation pay more for a single canvas than the brothers' joint accounts had ever contained, the market discovering, as it always does too late, that what it could not price was the thing worth keeping.

Belief itself was draining out of the institutions that had sustained it, and in Barcelona one man set out to give the departure a shape in stone that would not finish in his lifetime, his children's, or theirs. In 1882 work began on a temple meant as an act of expiation, the *Sagrada Família*, paid for not by a crown or a state but by the donations of the faithful, raised in conscious answer to a Spain the Church felt slipping away into commerce and revolution. The first architect drew a conventional Gothic revival church and resigned within a year over the cost of materials. The job went to a thirty-year-old named Antoni Gaudí, who had been the son of a coppersmith and was, at the time he took the commission, an unknown with a single completed building behind him. He gave the next forty-three years to it. He modeled his columns by hanging weighted chains

from the ceiling and tracing the inverted catenary curves they made, the geometry borrowed not from the cathedral tradition but from the forms of bone and shell and the hanging chain, a structure that looks grown rather than cut. He grew more religious year on year, ate less, dressed worse, and by his late sixties walked the city in clothes that were taken for a beggar's. On the seventh of June 1926 he was struck by a tram on his way to evening prayer at Sant Felip Neri, was refused a cab by three drivers who took him for a vagrant, was conveyed unidentified to the pauper's wing of the Hospital de la Santa Creu, and died there three days later. The funeral was the largest Barcelona had given anyone in living memory. A century later to the day, on the tenth of June 2026, a pope would bless the central spire above the nave, the tallest church on earth, and the construction beneath the cross would still not be finished. In 1936 an anarchist crowd had burned the crypt and smashed the plaster models of his interior; his successors gathered the fragments and went on building, hands that had never seen Gaudí raising stone from drawings pieced out of rubble. What the building preserves is the old conviction that belief can be poured into permanent matter and made to outlast those who believed, that an age which had lost its god could build itself a stone large enough to mark the loss. The thing its endlessness will not say is the suspicion the century would not say either: the faith was draining faster than the towers could climb, and what was being raised was not a shelter for a living belief but a beautiful and unfinished marker of where one had been, sustained at last by people who came to see it not as a church but as a wonder. The epilogue will return to it.

One earlier maker shows what an age can cost the person who bears it, and the document is a single sheet he wrote in the spa village of Heiligenstadt in October 1802 and left, folded and unsent, in the bottom of a desk for the next twenty-five years. Ludwig van Beethoven was thirty-one. He had begun to go deaf in his middle twenties and had tried, in the last summer that his physician could think of nothing to try, the mineral baths at Heiligenstadt. The page is addressed to his brothers Carl and Johann, asks their forgiveness, and describes in plain prose the night he had decided not to take his own life because the work he could feel inside him had not yet been written. He went back to Vienna and across the next three years made the *Eroica*, the Fifth, and the violin sonatas the conservatory still uses to break a student's playing apart. The Testament was found in the drawer the week of the funeral in 1827, the most consequential suicide note never sent, and Bloom's law about how the strong arrive is the only frame that fits it: the maker enters the canon by forcing his precursor to yield, and Beethoven did it to Mozart and to Haydn at once, by taking the form they had taught him to revere and stretching the symphony past the point at which its container could contain its argument. He inscribed the Third Symphony to Napoleon, the world-historical figure who seemed to embody the age's promise, and ordered the dedication copied onto the title. When the news arrived that the consul had crowned himself emperor, Beethoven took a pen to the score and tore the name out so hard the nib went through the paper.

The page with that gash sits today at the Beethoven-Haus in Bonn, the first plain document of the principle the rest of these works confirm: the man who seems to embody the current is its instrument, and the moment he mistakes himself for its author the work withdraws the name. The deafness ran its course. By 1818 his visitors brought small notebooks in which they wrote to him because he could no longer hear them, and what they wrote, sometimes Goethe and sometimes the price of beef, sits today as the strangest correspondence in musical history, a half-conversation with the silence around it cut out. At the premiere of the Ninth Symphony on the seventh of May 1824 he stood before an orchestra he could not hear and beat the air while Michael Umlauf actually conducted, and when the finale ended the contralto Caroline Unger reached up and turned him by the shoulders to face the audience he had not heard applauding. The chorus he had forced into the symphony where none had ever been sings on Schiller's words of all men made brothers, and the willed wholeness of that finale is the German idea made audible, mind imposing a reconciliation the world had not produced. The thing under the public joy, which the music will not name, is the silence the deaf man worked inside. He died three years later, fifty-six, of cirrhosis or lead leaching from his cheap Hungarian wine, the autopsy still disputed; the procession that followed his coffin through Vienna drew twenty thousand mourners, more than the city had turned out for any emperor, and one of the torchbearers walking beside the box was Franz Schubert, who would be buried beside him within the year.

What survived was none of the order these works were made inside. The empire of credit that had looked like the climate itself would, within two decades, walk into a war that ended its primacy, and within three would surrender the gold standard it had treated as a law of nature. The German metaphysics of will would find its armies and its catastrophe. The continental state the greenback helped construct would inherit the world the City lost. One man inside the century had said so. Jacob Burckhardt, who taught history at Basel, wrote to a friend in 1889 of "the terribles simplificateurs who are going to descend upon poor old Europe," and the simplifiers came on schedule¹¹ Two years before Burckhardt, in his 1887 introduction to a pamphlet by Sigismund Borkheim, Friedrich Engels had set down the most exact European forecast of the century to come: a world war of "eight to ten million soldiers" at each other's throats, "the depredations of the Thirty Years War compressed into four," with "the crowns rolling into the gutters by the dozens" and no one to pick them up. He named the toll, the duration, and the dynastic outcome twenty-seven years before Sarajevo, and was read in his own lifetime as a journalist who had let a polemic outrun the evidence. The works outlasted all of it. Turner's late canvases still dissolve the solid into light, and read now not as the empire's confidence but as the truest portrait of what any order at its height looks like from inside, boundless and already beginning to thin. Dickens's Coketown still stands as the soot beneath the glow, the Hand more permanent than the mill. The Eroica still bears its torn and scratched-out name, the discovery that no individual authors his

11. Jacob Burckhardt to Friedrich von Preen, July 24, 1889. On the older diagnostic tradition Burckhardt's anxieties belong to: Ibn Khaldun, *The Muqaddimah: An Introduction to History*, trans. Franz Rosenthal (Princeton, 1958 [1377]), book III, on the cycle by which a civilization passes from desert solidarity to settled luxury and dissolution; John Bagot Glubb, *The Fate of Empires and Search for Survival* (Edinburgh: Blackwood, 1976), for the modern restatement.

moment, set down as a document a person can go to Vienna and see. Monet's harbor still hangs as the moment a painter admitted the world is a rendering and made the admission beautiful. Van Gogh's sky still turns above the sleeping town, the cosmos as it feels to a consciousness too open to keep it out. Gaudí's towers climbed for more than a century, paid for by strangers, a faith outlived by its own monument. Each took the load of an order built on promises and credit and translated it into a form that did not collapse when the pledges did. The order is gone. The forms outlasted the credit-built empire that made them, and they are now the only honest accounting of a century the bookkeepers preferred not to leave.

The same century that produced the Bank of England and the transparent Crystal Palace also laid the quiet foundations of the offshore financial-centre. Before the term existed, the architecture of the money-laundering empire was being prototyped in the City of London's legal protections of secrecy and the peripheral island jurisdictions where British capital could move beyond the reach of parliamentary scrutiny or domestic tax. The empire of free trade was public; the empire of protected capital was deliberately not. Beneath the public narrative of parliaments and monarchs, the era formalized how power works in the modern state, consolidating into three indispensable pillars. The first was finance, the sovereign credit that could out-buy any army. The second was the shifting priesthood of belief - what began as religion was steadily replaced by the authoritative claims of organized science and applied statistics. The third was intelligence, the quiet apparatus of surveillance, correspondence interception, and information asymmetry that ensured the center always knew what the periphery was doing before the periphery did.

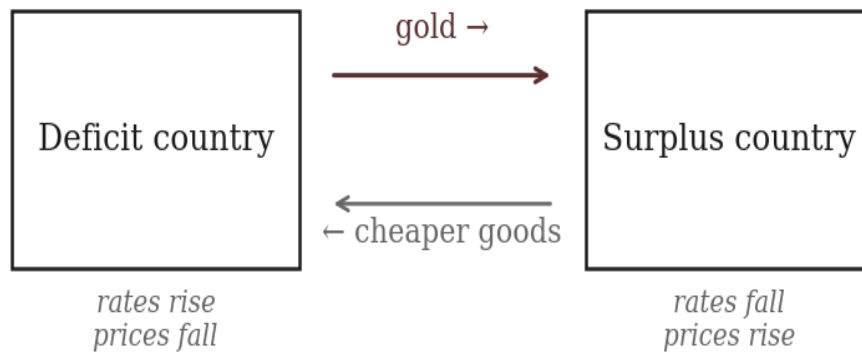
1900 – 1909

A man sits naked on a rock with his chin sunk against the back of one hand, and his whole body is at work though he does not move. Auguste Rodin, son of a clerk in the Paris prefecture and rejected three times in succession by the École des Beaux-Arts as a young man, had modeled the figure two decades earlier as a small thing meant to crown the lintel of a portal called *The Gates of Hell*, a state commission for a museum that was never built; he kept the gates in his studio for the rest of his life and altered them on and off for forty years, the most famous unfinished object in late-nineteenth-century sculpture. The brooding ornament above it was, then, no larger than a man's head. Across the 1880s and 1890s it stayed that size, an attendant detail in a larger architecture. Then, in the early years of the new century, the studio enlarged it. Henri Lebossé, the workshop's master enlarger, ran the original through the Collas pantograph that scaled a clay figure up by mechanical proportion, and the brooding ornament became a monument, six feet of bronze that no longer answered to any door. The first large cast was shown at the Salon of 1904, freestanding, with nothing above it to contemplate and nothing below it to judge. A public subscription was raised to set the figure before the Panthéon in Paris, the secular temple of the nation's great men, where it was unveiled in April 1906. By then the title had changed. The poet had become the thinker, and what the name now claimed was no longer one man over a particular hell but thought itself, generalized, turned in on its own body. Everything in how the figure is modeled resists the serenity the museum label would later impose. The muscles are tensed as if for labor; the toes grip; the back is rounded under a load that has no external source. This is not the repose of a mind that has solved something. It is a body straining under the weight of a mind that has turned away from the world and found, where the object of contemplation used to be, only itself. Rodin did not set out to make a portrait of the age. He scaled up an ornament and discovered a monument, and it said, in its bowed mass, what the confident surface of the decade could not afford to say aloud: that thought at the edge of the modern had begun to fold back on its own ground and was no longer certain there was a world out there to think about. He kept, all through the years he was modeling it, a parallel private affair with his student Camille Claudel, a sculptor of his own gift whose mental collapse he watched at a distance and did not stop; her family had her committed in 1913 and she lived another thirty years in the asylum without producing a single further work. He married his lifelong companion Rose Beuret in the unheated villa at Meudon two weeks before his own death in November 1917, in the third winter of the war. She died sixteen days later.

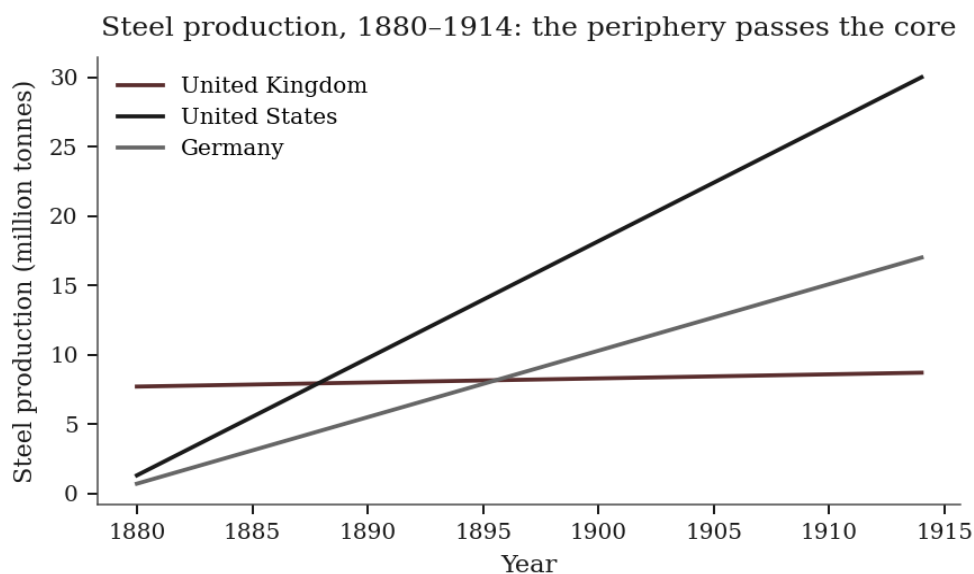
The surface of the decade said the opposite, and said it with conviction. The Edwardian years opened on the British monetary order at a pitch of self-assurance that has rarely been equaled. The City of London cleared the planet's commerce, sterling settled the world's accounts, and the gold

1. John Herman Randall Jr., *The Making of the Modern Mind* (1926), pp. 259–260.

standard was the discipline every serious nation submitted to as if it were a law of nature. The standard worked by a single promise made physical. The Bank of England would hand over a fixed weight of gold for every pound presented to it, and because each major money offered the same kind of pledge, every exchange rate was settled in advance by the metal behind it. A pound bought so many marks or francs or dollars because each was a claim on a definite quantity of the same substance. The discipline was severe and self-acting. A country that imported more than it sold paid the difference in gold, and as the gold drained out its banks were forced to raise interest rates, which cooled wages and prices until its goods were cheap enough to sell again and the metal flowed back. Ministers had nothing to decide; the metal moved and the books reacted. Governments submitted because the alternative, a currency that promised nothing, was considered no money at all. By the middle of the decade a large share of world trade was financed through London, much of it on paper that never touched a British dock. A merchant in Buenos Aires shipping hides to Hamburg would settle not in pesos or marks but with a bill of exchange drawn on a London house, a written promise to pay sterling in ninety days that banks across the world would accept as good as gold and discount for cash on the strength of the City's name. The cargoes of continents moved on the credit of Lombard Street, and the City earned a small toll on each promise it stood behind, the income of a place that had made its currency the universal solvent of trade. British capital, vast and patient, had built the railways of Argentina, the docks of the Yangtze, and the mines of the Rand. The surplus of the first industrial nation flowed outward as foreign investment at a scale, well over a third of national wealth invested abroad, that no creditor empire had attempted before. This was the high noon of the first great age of global integration, and the men who lived inside it experienced it as permanence. A clerk in London could eat New Zealand lamb and Indian tea, settle the account in gold-backed pounds, and feel the whole arrangement as fixed as the orbit of the earth. The orbit was the right figure. Here was the eighteenth century's clockwork cosmos still running, the universe a later historian would call "one huge, related, and uniform machine," with gold for its gravity¹ The era ruled by promise. A pound was redeemable in gold on demand, the empire's order was redeemable in gunboats, and the alliances were redeemable in armies; nobody had yet asked the system to honor all of these at once, and as long as nobody did, the arrangement looked permanent.



The discipline as its believers drew it: the price-specie flow, by which movements of gold were to correct every imbalance without a hand on the wheel. Schematic.



Steel production, 1880–1914: the periphery passes the core. Source: Mitchell, International Historical Statistics.

The strength was increasingly financial rather than productive, and that distinction was the quiet fracture beneath the marble. What the City did supremely well, to lend and insure and broker and settle, was precisely what flourishes once a country has begun to manufacture fewer of its own goods. British steel output, which had once led the world, had been passed by the United States in the 1880s and by Germany in this same decade. In the new industries that would define the coming age, chemicals and electricals and optics and dyes, Germany was simply better, its technical

schools and corporate laboratories generating the patents while Britain lived on coupons clipped from earlier triumphs. A nation that lives on the productive labor of others is a creditor, and such a nation is rich, but rich in a brittle way, because its wealth is a claim on a system rather than a thing owned in its own hands, and claims can be repudiated, defaulted, or rendered worthless by a war nobody can pay for. The Edwardian rentier did not feel fragile. He looked at his portfolio of foreign bonds and felt more secure than any saver in history. That confidence was itself the symptom, the complacency of an order that had substituted the management of money for real power and had not yet been required to tell the two apart. Read at the decade's hinge, the order shows the face of a deceptive zenith. Dynamism still live, the economy expanding and the society broadly open, yet financialization climbing and the load-bearing diversity of the productive base already thinning, a power that looks strongest in the season before it must be defended.

That defense was already under way at sea, where the energized frontier was doing what such frontiers do. Germany had been called into being as a great power inside the European order, fed by capital and technology and the discipline of the gold standard, and now, grown to full strength within it, it turned to challenge the core, and the instrument it chose was a navy. Alfred von Tirpitz and Wilhelm II, whose admiration for the Royal Navy was inseparable from his resentment of it, set out through successive Naval Laws to build a High Seas Fleet that could never defeat Britain but could threaten her enough to force a negotiation, a fleet conceived as a calculated threat written in steel. Britain answered in 1906 with HMS Dreadnought, a battleship so superior in speed and all-big-gun armament that it rendered every existing capital ship, including Britain's own, obsolete at a stroke. The First Sea Lord, John Fisher, had meant the leap to preserve British supremacy. What it did was reset the race to zero and invite Germany to compete on even terms in a new class where Britain's century of accumulated advantage suddenly counted for little. The dreadnought count became the public obsession of the decade, the crowd chanting that it wanted eight and would not wait when the Liberal government hesitated over the program in 1909. That chant did not rise on its own. The Navy League, the armoring firms with contracts to win, and a press that sold copies on invasion scares manufactured the panic that bent the government's hand, the same technique that would shortly be named and refined into a profession: fear produced to order, demand for armaments engineered the way demand for any product is engineered, the public taught to want what the men who would build the ships and bank the contracts needed it to want. Each side read the other's construction as proof of aggressive intent, and each was partly right, and behind both stood the interests that profited when the public believed it and worked to keep that belief alive. A hegemon that must strain and tax and frighten its own electorate to stay ahead of a younger rival in the very technology it pioneered is no longer simply dominant. It is defending a position, and the act of defense advertises that the ground can be contested.

Germany was the rising periphery Britain feared, but it was not the only one the European order had energized, and the quieter of the two would prove the more decisive. Across the Atlantic the United States had been built on British capital and the British market, its railways floated on the London exchange, its industrialization underwritten by the patient money of the City, and it had now grown past its tutor without anyone in London registering the moment as a turn. By mid-decade American steel output was roughly double Britain's. The largest economy on earth was no longer the one that printed the world's money. What rose with it was not merely a new power inside the old order but a new kind of arrangement, and this is the part a count of steel tonnage misses. The European nations the Americans were overtaking were civilizations in the old sense, thick with inherited rank and place and an idea of the good life that money alone did not settle, each man born into a station he could rarely leave. America offered something the older world had no name for and no use for: a society that replaced civilization with a fair, winnable game, the rules the same for everyone, the prize money, and the only question how much a man could make. The arrangement was deliberately atomized, each player on his own account, the old webs of clan and guild and parish dissolved into the single relation of buyer and seller; deliberately uniform, a continent of interchangeable towns and replaceable men who could pick up and move a thousand miles and find the same stores and the same coin, because mobility was the whole promise and roots were friction; and deliberately mediocre, a game open to all rewarding what the most can do rather than what the few can do best, leveling the heights to widen the field. That it leveled was its genius and its menace at once. A society of atomized equals with no station above the market and no authority the game itself does not confer is an order peculiarly defenseless against the man, or the mood, that promises to organize the lonely crowd. The very flatness that made it fair made it prone to the sudden tyranny of whoever could speak to the mass as one. This was not a better England. It was the replacement of civilization with commerce raised to a way of life, and the older empire, counting its dreadnoughts and its foreign coupons, mistook the upstart for a cruder version of itself rather than the successor form it actually was.

Where Germany's challenge was loud and naval and resented, America's was almost invisible to its creditor, taking the unthreatening form of repayment to the British investors who had financed its rise, and thereby quietly converting from debtor into peer. The financial crisis of 1907, remembered as the Panic, broke out not in London but in New York, ran through the trust companies that operated at the edge of the regulated banking system, and was halted only when J. Pierpont Morgan summoned the city's bankers to his library and kept them there until they pooled their reserves. A private man performed the function a central bank performs, and the country had watched its money supply rest for a few decisive days on the nerve and the balance sheet of one financier in one room. That demonstration was not lost on the men in the room. The same concentration of private power that had stopped the Panic now wanted an institution to relieve it of

the burden when the next crisis came, and required it built on terms the financiers themselves would set. So in November 1910 a delegation of them, the most powerful banker on the Senate side and the agents of the houses of Morgan, Rockefeller, and Kuhn Loeb, boarded Senator Nelson Aldrich's private rail car one at a time at a New Jersey terminal, addressed one another by first names only so the porters could not identify them, and rode in seclusion to a club on Jekyll Island off the Georgia coast, a resort owned by the very interests they represented, where for a week they drafted the plan that would become, after much revision, the Federal Reserve. They told the press a duck-hunting story and kept the meeting denied for more than two decades. What the secrecy protected was not the citizen from a danger but the design from the public. A plan drawn by the largest banks to organize the nation's currency in their own image would never survive daylight in the populist climate of the age, so it was written in the dark and floated later under a reform banner, its authorship concealed, its substance pushed through by men who understood that the appearance of public control was the price of private control. This is the era's central fact about money, and it does not require a single secret author behind the century to be legible. The same houses that had financed the railroads and would finance the coming war set out to capture the issue of the currency itself, and they largely succeeded, building a public-seeming instrument around a private core. The world's financial weather would now be made in New York, by men who preferred not to be seen making it, while the older empire, counting dreadnoughts, scarcely noticed that the margin was overtaking the core not with a fleet but with a balance sheet.

If the naval race embodied the energized frontier, it was the war between Russia and Japan that delivered the decade's most concentrated shock, and it supplied every part of the pattern at once. The conditions that built toward it were the same ones massing everywhere, a modernizing late-arriving power pressing on a complacent established one over the spoils of a third, in this case the dying Qing sphere in Manchuria and Korea. Russia had pushed its single-track Trans-Siberian Railway eastward to the warm-water naval base it had wrung from China at Port Arthur, and it had occupied Manchuria during the Boxer troubles and declined to leave. Japan, having beaten China a decade before and then been forced by Russia, France, and Germany to disgorge the very Liaodong Peninsula that Russia then took for itself, regarded the Russian advance toward Korea as a knife laid against its throat. When negotiation over spheres failed, Japan struck first and declared war after, sending its torpedo boats against the Russian squadron at anchor in Port Arthur on the night of the eighth of February 1904 before any declaration reached St. Petersburg, a surprise blow against a fleet in harbor that prefigured the century's manner of beginning wars. Japan had been reforged within a single generation, its old warrior class converted by deliberate state policy into an industrial and military elite, and the instrument that had remade it was the same one reshaping the European populations and would shortly march them at each other: the mass compulsory school. The model was Prussian. Prussia had built the first centralized state-run system of

compulsory schooling not to enlighten its children but to manufacture them, to produce out of a scattered peasantry a stock of obedient, literate, drillable citizens who would pay their taxes, work the machines, and above all stand in the line of battle when the state required it, and who would do these things because the classroom had trained the reflex of obedience to an unseen authority before the boy was old enough to question it. The school took the child from the family that loved him and seated him in rows under a stranger who graded him, taught him to answer the bell, to wait for permission, to receive a single official version of the world and return it on command, and in doing so it implanted the nation-state itself in the place where older loyalties to village and faith and kin had been, so that the abstraction printed on the map became the thing a man would die for. American reformers crossed to Prussia and came home converted; Horace Mann toured the system in 1843 and built Massachusetts on its image, and the design spread across the new continent as the engine that would make uniform citizens out of immigrant multitudes. Japan, modernizing under the same pressure and with fewer scruples about admitting the purpose, adopted the machine wholesale, and what stepped off its conscript trains in Manchuria was its first great product: a peasant army that read its orders and believed in its emperor and spent itself for an idea of the nation that the school had put there. The insecurity the school manufactured along with the obedience, the lifelong sense that one's worth waited on an examiner's mark, was the binding agent, a population taught to crave the approval of authority and therefore primed to surrender to it. The generation seated in those rows across the 1880s and 1890s, in Tokyo and Berlin and Manchester and Massachusetts alike, was the cohort that would march in 1914, and it could be marched because it had first been schooled. The empire it now faced was vast, populous, European, and reckoned, in the unspoken grammar of the age, a real great power against an upstart that was not white and therefore not expected to win. The expectation was wrong, and the error reverberated for the rest of the century.

The war was fought along the rim of the Yellow Sea and across the Manchurian plain, and it ran on the weapons that would define the next one. The Japanese army that landed in Korea and on the Liaodong Peninsula pressed inland and then turned to reduce Port Arthur, the fortress harbor where the main Russian Pacific squadron lay bottled behind minefields and shore guns. The siege ran from the summer of 1904 into the first days of 1905, a preview of the Western Front a decade early. Japanese infantry charged entrenched positions strung with barbed wire and swept by machine guns and quick-firing artillery, took the high ground called 203 Meter Hill at a cost of tens of thousands of dead, and used it at last to drop plunging fire onto the trapped fleet until the ships were wrecked at their moorings. The fortress surrendered at the start of January 1905 with the Russian Pacific squadron destroyed where it sat. Then came Mukden. Across three weeks in late February and early March, more than half a million men fought along a front many miles wide, the largest land battle the world had yet seen, and when General Kuropatkin pulled his army

north to avoid encirclement he left the field and roughly ninety thousand Russian casualties behind him. Japan occupied Manchuria, but it had spent itself to the edge of bankruptcy doing so, its war financed in large part by loans floated in London and New York, and it could not have fought another year.

The sea settled what the land had left open. With its Pacific squadron gone, Russia had ordered its Baltic Fleet to the other side of the world, and the force under Admiral Rozhdestvensky steamed some eighteen thousand nautical miles over more than seven months, around Africa because Britain denied it the Suez route, coaling at sea, its crews worn down and its hulls fouled, to reach a theatre where the war was already lost. It met Tōgō Heihachirō in the strait between Korea and Japan on the twenty-seventh and twenty-eighth of May 1905. Tōgō crossed the Russian line of advance so that his guns could fire down the length of the enemy column while few of theirs could answer, directed by wireless telegraphy in the first naval battle radio helped decide, and in a day and a night he annihilated the fleet that had sailed around the planet to be sunk. Of the heavy ships the Russians brought into action almost none survived. Battleships went down with most of their crews, others struck their colors or were driven into neutral ports, and a bare three vessels reached Vladivostok. The Japanese lost three torpedo boats. A European great power had been beaten by a non-European one in the open field and on the open sea, and the colonized world heard it like a bell. From Calcutta to Cairo to Constantinople, men who had been told that European supremacy was a fact of nature now possessed the counter-evidence in their hands.

Japan had won and could not press the advantage; Russia, having lost, was nonetheless too large to be made to pay. Both turned to Theodore Roosevelt. He mediated the settlement signed at Portsmouth, New Hampshire, in September 1905.² Japan received its sphere in Korea, the Russian lease on the Liaodong Peninsula and Port Arthur, the South Manchuria Railway, and the southern half of Sakhalin. It did not receive an indemnity, the war costs Tokyo had counted on to repay its loans. The terms read as a Japanese victory, and the Japanese public, told nothing of how near its own treasury had come to empty, rioted in the streets of Tokyo at being denied the spoils it thought it had earned. The mechanism that decided the war recurs through the century. Japan did not out-resource Russia. In steel and population and money the Tsar's empire dwarfed the islands, and a balance-sheet comparison would have forecast a Russian victory. What Japan possessed was a different quantity of resolve. For Tokyo the war was a question of national existence, whether a modernizing Asian state would secure a sphere of its own or be partitioned as China was being carved, and a nation fighting for that stake spends itself to exhaustion. For St. Petersburg it was a colonial adventure at the far end of a single-track railway, prosecuted by ministers who had partly wanted it as a distraction from troubles at home and who never persuaded their people that Manchuria was worth dying for. The optionally committed lost to the existentially engaged, as they tend to, and the margin of victory had almost nothing to do with the balance of capability. A

schooled Asian borderland had broken a European empire, and much of what came after, the anticolonial currents that rose against the racial-imperial order and the long demonstration that resolve beats size, runs downstream of an afternoon in the Tsushima Strait.

Russia did not absorb the defeat. The loss shook it the way that overextended and aging powers are destabilized by losses a confident power would have shrugged off. The humiliation released the long-laid grievance, and in 1905 the Romanov order cracked for the first time. On a January Sunday, troops fired on a peaceful procession of workers bearing icons and a petition to the Tsar at the Winter Palace, killing many and converting the residual faith of the common people in their Little Father into something colder. Through the year strikes spread, a battleship mutinied, a general strike in autumn paralyzed the country, and the first soviets, councils of workers' deputies, assembled in St. Petersburg as the embryo of an authority the autocracy had not authorized. Nicholas II was forced to concede a manifesto, a parliament, the appearance of constitutional life, which he conceded without believing in and spent the following years clawing back, dissolving assemblies that displeased him, narrowing the franchise, governing through his minister Pyotr Stolypin with a mixture of land reform and the gallows so frequent that the hangman's noose acquired the minister's name. An institution was aging before its time, an autocracy that could no longer rule in the old open way and would not learn to rule in a new constitutional one, hardening into something more repressive than what it replaced. One of the revolution's participants would later call 1905 the dress rehearsal. The empire that survived it came through as a wounded thing, its prestige spent, its peripheral defeat converted into internal rot rather than strength.

What had assembled in those workers' councils was not only a new organ of power but a new faith. The men in the soviets believed they stood at a hinge of history that had been foretold. Marx had taken Hegel's vision, in which spirit comes to know itself through contradiction across history, and turned it on its feet, and what he made was a secular end-time. The dialectic now ran through the ownership of the means of production, capital generated the proletariat that would bury it as surely as a chemical reaction yields its product, and the kingdom at the close was no longer heaven but the classless world after the last expropriation. This was eschatology with the god removed and the certainty kept, and it was the engine. A man who believes the shape of history guarantees his victory spends himself with a recklessness no merely interested man can match, the same surplus of resolve that had propelled Japan past Russia in the field, now turned inward against the autocracy. The vision worked as a material force because men believed it, a collective object in the exact Kantian sense, a thing no one could touch and yet real enough to reorganize what men were willing to die for. The Romanov state read 1905 as a problem of order to be managed with land reform and the gallows. It was facing something its instruments could not measure, a creed that had absorbed the modern claim that reality is made rather than found and concluded that the

existing arrangement of property was therefore not eternal but a thing that could be unmade by those who saw through it. The empire that put down the revolution had not put down the belief, and the belief was patient.

The secular end-time the soviets advanced was not, however, the only eschatology in the Russian air, and beneath it ran an older and stranger one that the Marxists thought they had buried and had in fact only inverted. A quarter-century before the soviets assembled, Fyodor Dostoevsky had given that older faith its sharpest modern voice. In the great novels of his last years and in the Pushkin address he delivered in Moscow in June 1880, months before his death, he laid out a vision of Russia that took the entire liberal West for a spiritual ruin. The Europe of reason and commerce and the rights of the isolated individual had, in his reading, cut man off from God and from his brothers and left him alone with his appetites, a civilization that had bought comfort at the price of the soul and was rotting from within behind its confident facade. Against that ruin he set the Russian people as the bearer of the true Christ, the one nation that had kept faith whole, charged with a mission to reconcile and to redeem a Europe that did not yet know it was dying. This was the Third-Rome conviction in modern dress, the old monastic claim that Moscow had inherited from fallen Rome and from Constantinople after it the charge to keep the true church and would be the last, the certainty that Russia was not a backward margin of Europe but its appointed successor and judge, destined to outlast the liberal order that condescended to it. The conviction was not folklore. It was a working fact about how the Russian state and a great part of its educated class understood their place in history, an eschatology with the kingdom set in this world and the Russian nation cast as its instrument. The men in the soviets were Dostoevsky's enemies and read him as a reactionary, yet the shape of what they believed was his own turned inside out, the same conviction that Russia stood at the hinge of universal history and would show the rotten West its future, with the Orthodox redeemer swapped for the proletariat and the kingdom of God for the classless world. The Romanov state that fell, the Bolshevik one that rose on its ruins, and the regime that would much later gather the same self-image again all drew on the one deep well, the belief that Russia was a thing apart and a destiny to come, the Third Rome that would still be standing when the West had spent itself. The diplomatic archive reads the period as a contest of interests over Manchuria and the Balkans. Underneath the interests lay this conviction, dormant in the season of defeat and revolt, and it would be reanimated whenever the Russian state again needed a reason larger than survival.

What knit these separate shocks into a single danger was that Europe's flexible diplomacy had hardened into two opposed and rigid blocs, a monoculture of alliance in which every member was exposed to one shared failure. The Anglo-Japanese Alliance of 1902 broke Britain's long isolation. The Entente Cordiale of 1904 settled the colonial quarrels of Britain and France and bound the two old rivals together. The Anglo-Russian Convention of 1907, partitioning Persia and composing the

rivalry in Central Asia, completed the Triple Entente and ranged Britain, France, and Russia against the Triple Alliance of Germany, Austria-Hungary, and Italy. Each agreement was presented as defensive, prudent, a reasonable insurance against a feared neighbor, and each served interests more particular than the prudence advertised. The Entente bound Britain's command of the sea to France's army and to French capital's exposure on the Russian loans that floated St. Petersburg's debt through the Paris bourse; the men who arranged the partitions of Persia and Morocco were dividing markets and protectorates as much as composing quarrels. Together the agreements assembled a machine in which a dispute between any two members could mechanically engage all six, in which the existentially anxious, Austria fearing Slav nationalism and Germany dreading encirclement, were chained to the merely interested, and in which the safety valves that had vented earlier crises were welded shut. The First Moroccan Crisis of 1905, when the Kaiser landed at Tangier to test the new Anglo-French friendship, did not break the system; the Algeiras Conference of 1906 contained it. The crises that followed loaded the system further. In October 1908 Austria-Hungary annexed Bosnia and Herzegovina outright, humiliating a Serbia that claimed the Slavs there and a Russia that had backed Serbia and then, still weak from its Pacific defeat, was forced to swallow the loss; St. Petersburg resolved never to back down again. In 1911 Germany sent the gunboat Panther to Agadir to contest the French move into Morocco, and the crisis it provoked pushed Britain and France into still tighter military conversation and left Berlin convinced that the Entente was an iron ring drawing closed around it. None of these blew up into general war, and each contained passage subtracted from the margin that kept the next one contained. The survival of every crisis in isolation was the trap, for a system that absorbs each blow one at a time persuades its makers that it is stable until several arrive together and it discovers it has no slack left to give. No single person designed the trap, yet it was built by identifiable hands acting on legible interests: financiers who needed Russian solvency, strategists who wanted the Channel secured, dynasts who required an enemy to bind their restive subjects to the throne. It raised the cost of one miscalculation toward the catastrophic, and its builders could not see it because each repair had worked. The continent did not stumble into the machine. It was constructed, link by interested link, by men who profited from each link and would not own the assembled whole.

Beneath the diplomacy ran a change in what reality was taken to be, and the bowed bronze before the Panthéon was its first monument. At the moment the gold order looked most solid, the picture of a fixed, findable, objective world was coming apart in the places thoughtful men went looking for bedrock. A patent clerk in Bern showed in 1905 that space and time themselves bend with the observer, that simultaneity is relative, that there is no absolute frame; a Viennese physician had opened, five years before, a sub-basement beneath the rational self where the real motives lived, unseen and unfree. Physics and the mind, the two last refuges of the solid, both

reported that the solidity had been ours all along. This was Kant's old verdict returning with teeth, the finding that no mind reaches the thing in itself but only the version its own categories make of it, so that the great shared objects, the nation and the market and the god and the money and the future, exist as collective fictions and are real in the one way that counts. Rodin's figure is that verdict cast in metal. The thinker has no Gates of Hell beneath him anymore, no scene to judge, no object to contemplate; the studio removed the door when it scaled him up. He sits on bare rock and broods on nothing external, and the strain in the modeled muscle belongs to a consciousness discovering that the world it took for granted is a construction of its own faculties and that the bedrock under thought is thought. The Victorian certainty that the world was simply there to be measured was dissolving into a modernist suspicion that it was, at bottom, projected and imagined, and a culture that has begun to doubt that its reality is real is a civilization preparing, without knowing it, to be told a new story about what is.

The doubt reached the picture plane itself, and it entered through a canvas almost no one was allowed to see. In his Montmartre studio at the Bateau-Lavoir, a wooden tenement on the Place Ravignan whose name came from its likeness to the laundry boats on the Seine, across the spring and summer of 1907 Pablo Picasso, twenty-five years old and broke, worked and reworked a large painting of five women in a brothel, scraping and repainting it through more than four hundred preparatory sketches catalogued later by his dealer's archive. His lover Fernande Olivier ground his pigments. His pet dog Frika slept under the stove. In March of that year his friend G ry Pieret had stolen two ancient Iberian heads from the Louvre and sold them to him for fifty francs apiece; the heads sat in a cupboard while Picasso worked, and four years later, when the Mona Lisa was taken from the same museum and Pieret confessed publicly to the earlier theft, Picasso and Apollinaire would walk to the Pont des Arts at night with a suitcase that contained, they later said, the very heads, planning to drop them in the Seine, and would lose their nerve and turn back, returning the carvings anonymously through a newspaper a few days on. The carvings sit in the canvas. The two faces on the right side of *Les Femmes d'Alger* are not painted in the European manner at all. They are the Iberian heads with planes copied also from the African masks Picasso had seen, weeks earlier, in the cramped colonial gallery of the Trocad ro ethnographic museum, an encounter he would later say was the most violent of his artistic life, the moment he understood what carvings were for. When he finally showed the finished thing to his closest circle the reaction was something between alarm and revulsion. Matisse is reported to have taken it for a provocation; Braque said that looking at it was like drinking petrol. Picasso rolled the canvas up and kept it in the studio. It would not be shown publicly until 1916 and would not be widely reproduced until later still, its enormous influence running for years as a private transmission among the few painters and dealers who had stood in the room. What they had seen was the unified perspectival subject coming apart on the wall. Since the Renaissance, European

painting had organized space around one eye at a single instant, a window through which one observer beheld a coherent scene, and the entire apparatus of monocular perspective was a pictorial form of the belief that there is one world, seen from one vantage, the same for everyone who looks. Picasso broke the window. The five figures are rendered from incompatible angles at once, a nose in profile inside a face seen frontally, a body twisted so that front and back appear together, the deep space of the room flattened and shattered into faceted planes that refuse to resolve into a single volume. The presence of the colonial mask inside the Parisian brothel scene tore the membrane between the metropole's image of itself and what it had defined itself against. The Australian sociologist Tony Bennett would later read the whole apparatus that had produced the Trocadéro display and the Crystal Palace before it as a single nineteenth-century invention, the exhibitionary complex, in which museums and world's fairs trained the European visitor to see his own civilization as the climax of a sequence whose other terms were on view as evidence; his *Birth of the Museum*, published in 1995, names the device the carvings ambushed Picasso with at twenty-five.

What the painting registered, before any treaty or any market could name it, was the end of the single point of view. The one observer dissolved into many incompatible ones. The coherent scene became a thing the eye assembled out of fragments that did not add up; the perspectival subject that had organized European seeing for four centuries was broken on the canvas a full decade before it shattered in the trenches. What the painting forced into form was the suspicion the patent clerk and the physician were both posting from their separate rooms: that there is no view from nowhere, and that the confidence of an order which believed there was had been built on a perspective it could no longer defend. Picasso did not deduce the coming century. He was a young man competing with Matisse for the lead in Paris and metabolizing the carvings he had seen in the ethnographic museum at the Trocadéro, and he hid the result because it frightened the people he most wanted to impress. What he made nevertheless registered the fact the gold order's surface denied: that the unified subject on which the whole edifice of guarantee depended was already coming apart.

The Trocadéro gallery that ambushed Picasso did not stand alone, and it was not a place a young painter wandered into by accident. It was one node in a continental apparatus that had been built across the preceding half-century to organize how the populations of the great powers experienced the world they did not see directly, and the gallery and the painting and the Larkin Building all sit downstream of the same invention. The Crystal Palace, raised in Hyde Park in 1851 to house the Great Exhibition of the Works of Industry of All Nations, was the first instance and gave the form its theatrical scale. Six million visitors passed through its iron-and-glass nave across five months, more than a third of the population of Britain, to look at fourteen thousand exhibitors and a hundred thousand objects arranged so that the products of the industrial north sat

alongside the raw materials of the colonial periphery and the curiosities of the non-European world, and the visitor who walked the length of the building learned without instruction what the order he lived inside took itself to be. The arrangement said that there was a stock of things in the world, that the British nation knew how to assemble them, and that the visitor was the audience for whom the assembly had been performed. The form spread. The 1867 Paris Exposition added an oval ground plan that placed France at the center and the contributing nations at its radii. The 1876 Philadelphia Centennial gave the United States its first turn at the apparatus and used it to admit the republic to the company of industrial powers. The 1889 Paris Exposition built the Eiffel Tower as a permanent advertisement for the form, and the World's Columbian Exposition at Chicago in 1893 raised the White City on the shore of Lake Michigan, a temporary plaster metropolis of neoclassical pavilions whose Court of Honor proposed the City Beautiful style as the architectural language a republic should use to render itself monumental. Twenty-seven million visited that one, in a country of sixty-five million, in a season. The 1900 Paris Exposition Universelle drew fifty million across seven months and was the largest gathering of human beings to that point in history. The 1904 St. Louis Louisiana Purchase Exposition staged an Anthropology Department under the direction of W. J. McGee whose Philippine Reservation housed twelve hundred Igorot, Negrito, and Moro tribespeople in built reconstructions of their villages, fed and exhibited as living evidence that the new American colonial possessions were inhabited by peoples the order could classify, schedule, and improve. The 1915 San Francisco Panama-Pacific International Exposition celebrated the opening of the canal and rebuilt a city seven years after the earthquake. The 1939 New York World's Fair on the marshes of Flushing Meadows would close the great age of the form with the Perisphere and the Trylon.

The point is not that the fairs were spectacular, which everyone said at the time, but that they were instruments, which almost no one then said and which the literature on the apparatus has named only across the past forty years. Tony Bennett's argument in *The Birth of the Museum* reads the fairs and the universal museums as a single nineteenth-century invention he calls the exhibitionary complex, and locates the invention in the same generation as Jeremy Bentham's panopticon. The two devices perform inverse operations of the same disciplinary kind. The panopticon arranges the few to surveil the many, places the inmate in a cell under a watchtower whose interior he cannot see, and induces in him the constant possibility of observation so that he polices himself in the absence of any guard. The exhibitionary complex arranges the many to look at the few, places the citizen-visitor in a gallery before a display, and induces in him the conviction that he stands as the audience for whom a presented world has been assembled, the spectator of an order whose totality he can survey at a glance because the apparatus has done the assembling for him. The panopticon disciplines through the felt asymmetry of the gaze. The exhibitionary complex disciplines through the felt completeness of the view. Both manufacture a subject whose

interior conduct conforms to an authority the building has internalized for him. The Larkin Administration Building, which the chapter has already named, takes the panopticon indoors and adapts it to a civilian wage labor whose virtue-words ran on the brick piers in place of the prison's regulations. The Trocadéro that ambushed Picasso, and the colonial pavilions at every fair in the sequence above, take the exhibitionary complex to the metropole and adapt it to a citizenship whose grasp of what the empire was could not be derived from any single colonial encounter and had to be staged for it.

Inside the staging the two ends of the operation become legible together. The mass-displayable colonial body and the mass-purchasable mass-produced object came out of one industrial line. The fairs put both on view in the same building, often in adjacent halls, and the visitor's eye moved between them without registering that the trade pavilion and the human-zoo enclosure were exhibits of the same apparatus working on different materials. The Igorot village at St. Louis sat across the grounds from the Palace of Manufactures. The Senegalese village at the 1889 Paris Exposition stood within a short walk of the Galerie des Machines. The colonial subject and the consumer good appeared as variant outputs of the productive order the fair existed to celebrate, the one a labor input the empire had brought under classification and the other a finished commodity the empire had brought under manufacture, and the visitor learned to see them as members of the same series. The Trocadéro's ethnographic collection sat at the western end of the same axis that ran through the Champ de Mars, and the masks the curators had brought back from Dahomey and the Congo were displayed without the ceremonial context that would have made them anything other than objects. Picasso met them in the case as carvings stripped to form, and the violence of the encounter, which he would describe to André Malraux thirty years later as the moment he understood what painting was for, lay precisely in the apparatus that had stripped them: he was meeting the African mask as the exhibitionary complex had prepared it for him, an object the institutional architecture had already cut loose from the world that made it.

The 1939 World's Fair stands as the closing instance of the form and supplies the figure that makes the operation visible at its limit. The Trylon and the Perisphere, the two abstract geometric structures that served as the fair's central theme, were a seven-hundred-foot triangular spire and an adjacent two-hundred-foot sphere, both faced in white gypsum board, connected by what was then the longest escalator in the world. Visitors rode up the escalator into the Perisphere, stood on a slowly revolving balcony around the equator of its interior, and looked down on a built-to-scale model of a planned city called Democracy, designed by Henry Dreyfuss to demonstrate the urban form of the next century. They saw a centralized commercial core surrounded by satellite residential and industrial townships, a rationalized regional plan presented as the working future of American democratic life, while a recorded narration explained the order they were observing. The figure is exact. A democracy had been built in miniature inside a sphere, and the visitor looked

down on it from a moving platform as if from outside history. The fair had reached the limit case of the form: the public was no longer brought to look at the world the order presented to it but at a model of the polity the order proposed to be, the citizenry as audience of its own constructed future, the rendering of the public as spectator complete in the figure of a working democracy a man could survey from above and walk away from afterward. Twenty-six months later the United States entered the war, and the fairgrounds were sold off for scrap. The form did not return at the same scale. What replaced it, the broadcast news program and the consumer dream-apparatus the chapter has already named at the storefront and the Châtelet, did the same work inside the household, and did it without requiring the citizen to take a train to Flushing.

The gold order needed an apparatus of this kind to recruit a public consonant with its operation, and what the exhibitionary complex supplied sits as a long structural fact under the modernist break Picasso put on the wall. The gold-standard arrangement required, at the level it ran, a citizen who experienced himself as the audience of a presented world rather than as the agent of his own conditions, a subject whose grasp of the international division of labor came from the trade hall and whose grasp of the imperial periphery came from the human-zoo enclosure and whose grasp of progress came from the recorded narration in the rotating sphere. The exhibitionary complex manufactured that subject across the decades the gold standard ran, and the same generation it produced was the one Picasso painted and Bennett would later anatomize. What the canvas registered in 1907, the dissolution of the unified observer into incompatible angles, was the early symptom of an apparatus that had begun to lose its grip on its own subject, the moment at which the audience the fairs had been assembling discovered that it could no longer see the world they were showing as a single coherent scene. The fairs would run for another thirty years on the strength of the apparatus's accumulated authority. The painting had already named what was leaving it.

The same pressure reached its limit in sound. Gustav Mahler, the son of a Bohemian distiller and the conductor of the Vienna Court Opera until administrative conflict and the antisemitism of the city's press drove him from the post in 1907, was straining the inherited tonal order toward a point past which it could not be sustained. He composed in a small wooden hut built for him on the shore of Lake Wörthersee in southern Carinthia, reachable only by a plank over a stream, and the household was instructed to bring his morning coffee in silence because any noise broke his concentration. The works of his last years push the apparatus of the late-Romantic orchestra to a scale and a chromatic density that test where music stops being able to resolve. The Eighth Symphony, composed in one concentrated stretch in the summer of 1906 and not heard in public until the Munich premiere of the twelfth of September 1910, threw a thousand performers at a Latin hymn to the creating spirit welded to the closing scene of Goethe's Faust, an attempt to make the whole tonal cosmos cohere through sheer mass and sheer affirmation. He conducted that

premiere himself and was kept on the podium for half an hour by applause. Two months earlier, in July, he had opened a letter from the young Bauhaus architect Walter Gropius mistakenly addressed to Direktor Mahler, asking Alma to leave him; Mahler had taken the letter in his hand, walked into her room with it, and asked her to choose. She did not leave him. Three weeks after the discovery he travelled to the Dutch town of Leiden to consult Sigmund Freud, who had agreed to see him on his summer holiday; the two men walked the city for four hours and Freud later wrote that he believed he had achieved a partial cure of an Oedipal fixation in a single afternoon, the only such single-session analysis the Viennese physician ever recorded. The works that followed, written as his heart was diagnosed as failing and his eldest daughter Maria, called Putzi, died of scarlet fever at four, turned the other way and let the doubt speak. In them the harmonic language stretches toward the threshold where the home key, the tonal center that bound European music together as monocular perspective unified European painting, loses its gravitational grip and a chord no longer knows for certain where it must resolve. A tonal system is a guarantee, a promise that every departure will come home to its center, and Mahler's late scores are the sound of that pledge straining at the limit of what it can underwrite. He died of bacterial endocarditis in Vienna on the eighteenth of May 1911, fifty years old, with the Tenth Symphony unfinished on his desk. He did not theorize the dissolution of tonality that younger Viennese composers, foremost among them his protégé Schönberg, would shortly complete. He lived inside the tonal order, loved it, and pressed it until the cracks showed, and they are audible, the same fracture the painter put on the wall and the diplomats welded over, surfacing in the one art that cannot lie about whether a thing resolves.

While the unified subject came apart in the studio and the concert hall, a new apparatus was assembling the mass one, and it ran on the smallest coin. Edwin Porter's *The Great Train Robbery* of 1903 showed that a film could tell a realistic story and close with an outlaw firing his pistol straight at the audience, and its success across the next two years filled the storefront theatres that took their name from the nickel charged at the door. By 1907 about a million people a day in the United States were passing into nickelodeons to watch pre-packaged programs of short films, a manufactured dream supplied in identical copies to a mass audience for the price of the smallest coin in circulation³ The crowd that could no longer be reached as a public of readers could now be addressed as an audience of viewers, all of them shown the same images at the same time. In Paris the same impulse took an aristocratic form when Serge Diaghilev brought his company of Russian dancers, painters, and composers to the Théâtre du Châtelet for the season that opened in May 1909, the first of the seasons known as the Ballets Russes. The apparatus there was not the cheap reel but the total spectacle, choreography and orchestra and painted scenery fused into a single sensory event engineered to seize a metropolitan audience whole, and it did, becoming the obsession of fashionable Europe almost overnight. At the storefront and at the Châtelet the same

3. On the nickelodeon and the assembly of a mass viewing audience: Neil Postman, *Amusing Ourselves to Death: Public Discourse in the Age of Show Business* (New York: Viking, 1985), chs. 5–7, traces the long passage from print culture to the image-as-discourse; for the period figures, Eileen Bowser, *The Transformation of Cinema, 1907–1915* (Scribner, 1990), reports roughly two million admissions per day in the United States by 1908.

machinery was under construction: the technology for the management of collective attention that the century would refine without limit.

The same machinery walked into the workplace, and the building that admitted it was finished in Buffalo, New York, in 1906. Frank Lloyd Wright's Larkin Administration Building, commissioned by a mail-order soap company, set its eighteen hundred clerks at metal desks arrayed across the floor of a five-story central atrium open to a skylight, the first wholly open-plan office in the United States. The supervisors looked down from galleries above. No clerk could close a door because there were no doors to close, and no clerk could turn his face from the sightline of a superior without turning it into the sightline of another. Wright had built, without ever using the term, the architectural form Jeremy Bentham had proposed a hundred and twenty years earlier for the management of prisoners: the panopticon, in which the inmate cannot tell at any moment whether his keeper has him in view and so conducts himself as if the view is always present. Around the central court, inscribed on the brick piers in foot-high block letters, ran the words by which the clerk was meant to absorb the surveillance into his own conscience: generosity, altruism, sacrifice, integrity, loyalty, fidelity, imagination, judgment, initiative, intelligence, enthusiasm, control, cooperation, economy, industry. The virtues that an older order had asked of a Christian were now asked of a wage employee at a soap company, set in masonry so that the office could perform the cathedral's work without a priest, the inscribed pier in place of the altar and the supervisor's gallery in place of the apse. The Larkin Building was demolished in 1950 for a truck depot. The arrangement it pioneered moved into the corporate towers of the second half of the century and eventually onto the Bloomberg trading floor, where six rows of identical screens face inward toward a central platform and the panopticon, drained of its virtue-words and rebuilt in liquid-crystal, performs the same daily transfer of attention from the worker's own life to the watcher's accounting.

What survived is not the order these works were made inside, which began coming apart almost on schedule. The gold standard that felt eternal would be suspended for the war that began five years past this decade's close, and the rule by guarantee that organized the whole arrangement would be the first thing the war broke, every promise called at once across a continent that had quietly arranged for them all to fall due together. The empire that counted its dreadnoughts would win that war and lose its solvency in the victory, ceding the world's financial weather to the New York it had financed. The autocracy that cracked in 1905 would shatter in 1917. The racial-imperial certainty that Tsushima had wounded would bleed out across the rest of the century. The works outlasted all of it. Rodin's figure still sits before the Panthéon and in the gardens of the museum that bears his name, bowed under a load with no external source, the most exact thing anyone made about thought turning in on its own ground at the threshold of the modern. Picasso's five women still break the window every viewer brings to them, and the canvas

that frightened its first audience into silence became the hinge on which the history of modern art is hung, the place where the lone point of view came apart on canvas before it came apart in fact. Mahler's late symphonies still press the tonal order to the edge of what it can sustain and let the listener hear a guarantee straining at its limit. The reel and the staged spectacle still run, refined past anything their first makers could have pictured, the mass dream-apparatus assembled at the storefront and the Châtelet. Each was made by one mind under the load of an order that believed in its own permanence, and each kept the doubt the surface declined to admit. The order is gone. The studio knew before the chancery did: the unified subject, the single frame, and the world-as-given on which the whole edifice of guarantee rested had already come apart in Picasso's studio and in Mahler's concert hall, years before the diplomats and the markets were made to know it.

As the American century gathered momentum, it presented itself not as a continuation of European civilization but as a radical break from it. To its European critics, America was an anti-civilisation: an atomised, uniform landscape where the complexities of culture and history had been flattened into a winnable money-game. It was a society engineered for commercial scale, structurally prone to the tyranny of the majority and the homogenization of the human spirit. The same era perfected the art of seeing like a state. The bureaucratic drive to categorize, enumerate, and standardize populations meant that the legibility of the citizen became the primary goal of administration. In the pursuit of rational management, this legibility systematically destroyed the organic diversity of local communities, replacing the idiosyncratic and unmeasurable with the standardized and taxable.

1910 – 1919

In the cellar of a tavern called the Meierei on the Spiegelgasse in Zurich, six doors down from the rooms in which Lenin sat through his last year of exile reading Hegel and waiting, a thirty-year-old German poet named Hugo Ball opened a cabaret on the fifth of February, 1916, and began to unmake European art from the inside. Ball had been raised in a strict Catholic household in the Palatinate and had spent two years as a young man in seminary studying for the priesthood before walking out and becoming a stage director; he would die of stomach cancer eleven years later, in 1927, returned at the end to the Church and writing a book on the seven Byzantine saints whom he believed had preserved the true faith through the early dark. The arc is the whole movement compressed into one body. He called the place the Cabaret Voltaire, after the apostle of reason; the name was the joke and the program at once. Reason had produced the war then grinding a generation into the mud a few hundred miles to the north and west, and Ball had concluded that a civilization able to marshal science and industry and philosophy and faith alike toward the mechanical slaughter of its own young had forfeited the right to be taken at its own valuation. By late July he had read out a manifesto for a movement he and his companions called Dada, a word selected by sticking a knife into a French-German dictionary at random and reading what the blade rested on, a child's first sound, a hobbyhorse, a noise. On the twenty-third of June he climbed onto the cabaret stage inside a cardboard tube designed by the Romanian painter Marcel Janco that pinned his arms to his sides and reached past his head into a cone with a wizard's hat; the cabaret hands had to lift him on and off the stage because he could not walk freely inside it. He chanted syllables stripped of meaning like a liturgy in a language no one spoke, "gadji beri bimba" and "zimzim urullala," and the audience listened in silence and then, he wrote in his diary that night, the sweat ran down his face and he had to be lifted off the stage. The formal choice stated the argument his generation could not yet phrase. This anti-art was not incompetence dressed up as rebellion. It was a deliberate refusal of coherence by people who had decided that the coherence was itself the lie, that if the inherited forms of sense had delivered Verdun then meaning itself was suspect, and the honest response was the controlled production of nonsense. Lenin, who lived a minute's walk away, never came to the cabaret. He thought it was bourgeois.

What the Dadaists were answering had been, only a few years earlier, the most confident order the modern world had built. The City of London cleared the planet's payments, capital moved across borders as freely as it ever has, before or since, and a German bank and a British one were tied to each other by ledgers as tightly as either was bound to its own government. The gold standard was less an economic policy than a metaphysics, a shared agreement that value had an anchor outside human will, that a pound or a mark or a franc stood for a fixed weight of metal and therefore for something real and unarguable. Men of standing had argued, with evidence, that this

density of mutual obligation had made great-power war obsolete, and Norman Angell's book to that effect sold widely in 1910. The argument was not foolish, only confident in the wrong direction: it read the system's intricacy as strength when the complexity was the fragility itself, and assumed that a web of obligation would restrain its members when in fact it meant no strand could be cut without dragging down the whole. Beneath the confidence ran a correct intuition that the order was weightless, that the visible architecture of credit and empire rested on belief alone and could be reorganized by men who did not announce themselves.

That intuition found its strangest expression in a story the era began to tell itself about a ship. On the night of the fourteenth of April, 1912, the Titanic struck ice in the North Atlantic and went down in a little under three hours, and among the roughly fifteen hundred dead were three of the wealthiest men in America: John Jacob Astor, Benjamin Guggenheim, and Isidor Straus. The ship belonged, through a chain of ownership, to J. P. Morgan, whose International Mercantile Marine had absorbed the White Star Line a decade earlier, and Morgan had booked passage on the maiden voyage and then cancelled at the last moment, kept abroad, his biographers later said, by business in Paris and the matter of his art collection. Eighteen months after the three financiers drowned, the

Federal Reserve Act became law. Out of these facts a reading assembled itself and has refused, across more than a century, to die: that the catastrophe cleared three powerful men from the path of a central bank shortly before the bank was chartered, and that Morgan's empty cabin was the tell.

Two facts must be set against the story. No hand steers a ship onto a chosen iceberg on a particular night, nor arranges that three named passengers go down with it rather than into the boats, which is nearly where all three came. And the three men were not a unified anti-Fed bloc: Isidor Straus had spoken publicly in October 1911 for a national reserve association, urging his peers to act at once against future panics, while Astor and Guggenheim left no recorded position at all. On the night of the sinking and on the politics of its dead, the popular story overreaches.

Everything else the story gropes toward is true, and the era was right to feel it. The Titanic sinking was not the mechanism; it was the screen onto which a public already half-aware of the real thing projected a picture it could grasp. The real thing was that a concentrated financial order had, in private, already begun to redesign the monetary spine of the country, and had concealed its own presence while it worked. The prior chapter set down what happened at the Jekyll Island club in 1910: the rail-car ruse, the first-names rule, the nine days of drafting, the burial of the meeting itself for two decades. What the prior chapter did not say is that the same buried truth was what the Titanic legend was reaching for. The legend names the wrong instrument and the right hand. A night, a set of bodies, a clean line of cause, laid over a reorganization of the country's money that had been drafted in the dark a year before the ship was launched¹ The architecture of value had

1. Frank A. Vanderlip with Boyden Sparkes, *From Farm Boy to Financier* (New York: Appleton-Century, 1935), ch. 23.

slipped out from under anything a citizen could see, vote on, or name, and a society that senses this without being permitted to see it will manufacture the missing evidence out of whatever wreckage the year provides.

That the financiers did not get the whole of what they drafted is part of the victory, not a check on it. The Aldrich Plan from Jekyll Island would have vested governing control in the bankers outright. It drew enough public suspicion to be beaten on the floor, and the Glass-Owen compromise of 1913 placed nominal oversight in a Board appointed by the President and confirmed by the Senate² The visible crown was withheld; the working function was not. A system designed in secret by the men it would most enrich passed into law dressed as an instrument of public accountability, with the regional reserve banks owned by the very members they were said to supervise. The order learned the lesson here and kept it for the rest of the century: the surest way to keep power over money is to arrange for that power to look shared.

The war began with a teenager in a doorway. On the twenty-eighth of June 1914, in Sarajevo, the Habsburg heir Archduke Franz Ferdinand was riding through the city in an open car with his wife Sophie when the driver took a wrong turn down a narrow street and stopped to reverse. A nineteen-year-old Bosnian Serb named Gavrilo Princip, who had been part of a six-man assassination team scattered along the route earlier that morning and had given up after his comrades failed and stopped for a sandwich at Schiller's delicatessen, looked up to find the car halted in front of him. He stepped onto the running board and fired twice at point-blank range; the Archduke was hit in the throat, Sophie in the abdomen; both were dead within an hour. Princip was sixteen days short of the age at which Austria-Hungary could legally execute him, was instead sentenced to twenty years, and died of tuberculosis in Theresienstadt prison in April 1918, weighing eighty pounds, six months before the empire that had imprisoned him. The shot was the spark; the dry tinder around it was the alliance system of the prior chapter, a continent prewired so that one detonation propagated everywhere. The Austrian ultimatum, the Russian mobilization, the German declaration on Russia, the German declaration on France, the German march into Belgium that brought Britain in: within five weeks of a wrong turn in a small Balkan city the great powers had walked through a sequence none of them had quite chosen and from which none of them could quite step back. The monetary order that intuition feared was, in any case, about to be dissolved by the war, not by any ship. When the continental armies mobilized in the summer of 1914, the gold standard that had seemed the bedrock of the world lasted a matter of days. Britain suspended convertibility in August through the Currency and Bank Notes Act. The banks had grasped that a run was coming because the war would be paid for in fresh money the Treasury did not have in coin: a state that prints what it must spend has no metal to exchange at the window, and any holder of paper who understands this presents the paper first. Within hours of the declaration the queues began. By the second day of August the Bank of England had suspended payment in gold and the

2. Federal Reserve Act, December 23, 1913.

3. Currency and Bank Notes Act, August 6, 1914.

other belligerents followed³ The anchor supposed to lie outside human will turned out to be the first thing that will be discarded when survival required it. How a state pays for a war it cannot tax for is the whole of what the gold standard had concealed. Under the metal rule a government could only spend what it taxed or what it borrowed from savings that already existed; the discipline lay in its scarcity. Cut loose from the metal, a government discovers it can manufacture purchasing power out of nothing but its own promise. The treasury issues a bond, a paper claim on future taxes; the central bank, or the commercial banks it stands behind, buys that bond and credits the treasury's account with new money it conjures in the very act, balances that did not exist the instant before. The state then spends this money into the economy, on shells and uniforms and the wages of men who make them. Nothing of substance was saved first. The claim came into being and the state spent it, and the gap between the new money chasing goods and the supply there was to buy is made up by a quiet rise in every price, which is to say by a tax on everyone owning the old money, levied without a vote. War, in short, is paid for out of belief: out of the population's willingness to lend its savings against a promise of repayment, and out of its readiness to keep accepting money the state prints faster than the metal behind it can grow. Britain raised some three and a quarter billion pounds in war loans; the United States, once it entered, sold over twenty billion dollars in Liberty Bonds, financed roughly a third by taxation and two-thirds by borrowing. The bond drives were the first mass campaigns to convert private feeling into public finance, the poster and the rally and the celebrity tour enlisting ordinary citizens as creditors of a war whose direction they did not set, and they rehearsed on a national scale the technique a later decade would turn into a science: the management of a mass mind toward an end its managers had already chosen. The inflation that followed quietly consumed much of what the lenders had lent, so that the saver financed the war twice, once in the bond he bought and again in the value the new money drained from the old. The metal anchor was gone; in its place stood the unbacked promise of the state and the readiness of its people to keep believing in it, which is the condition every currency has lived under since. The United States alone did not abandon gold outright, a high-pressure profile that adapted where the others broke, and it ended the war owning the obligations of victors and vanquished alike.

The war this finance paid for began as the thing the chancelleries had all rehearsed and turned almost at once into something none of them had imagined. The plans were all of movement. Germany's, drafted years before by a general staff that knew it would one day fight France and

Russia at the same time, called for a vast wheeling sweep of the right wing through neutral Belgium and down into northern France, the whole German army pivoting on its own left flank like a door swinging shut on Paris, the campaign to be won in six weeks before Russia could fully mobilize in the east. France's plan was the mirror image and the opposite temperament, an immediate headlong offensive eastward into Alsace and Lorraine to recover the provinces lost in

1871, the doctrine of attack pressed to the edge of mysticism, the infantry sent forward in blue coats and red trousers against an enemy dug in with modern rifles and quick-firing guns. Both plans assumed the war would be short because every plan a general staff could finance did. A long war was one no treasury believed it could pay for, and so no army prepared for the fight that actually came. In the first weeks the French offensive in the east was cut to pieces, twenty-seven thousand French soldiers killed on a single day in August, the bloodiest day in the history of French arms, the red trousers a target the machine gun could not miss. In the west the German wheel swung in on schedule and then, within sight of its object, faltered. The right wing, exhausted by its own speed and stretched past the reach of its supply, swung inside Paris instead of around it and exposed a flank, and on the Marne in early September the French and a small British force struck into the gap, Paris taxicabs requisitioned to rush reserves to the line, and stopped the wheel a few days' march short of the capital. The plan that was to win the war in six weeks had failed, and nothing was left for either side but to find the other's open flank.

There was no open flank. Through the autumn each army tried to swing past the northern end of the other's line and each found the enemy already there, the two of them sidestepping toward the sea in what the soldiers called the race to the sea until there was no more ground to reach around, the line meeting the Channel coast in Flanders. By the end of 1914 a continuous front of trenches ran from the North Sea to the Swiss frontier, four hundred miles of earthwork that could not be turned because it had no end, and the war of movement was over for three and a half years. What replaced it was a condition the doctrines had no name for. To attack was to climb out of a trench and walk across open ground churned to mud against barbed wire and machine guns laid to sweep fixed lines, the defender always faster to reinforce a threatened point by rail than the attacker could exploit a breach on foot, so that every offensive bled to a halt a few miles past its start and the front barely moved for years while the dead piled into the millions. The machinery favored the defense absolutely and the generals went on ordering the attack regardless, because the alternative was to admit there was no way through and no way home, and the soldiers went over the top because the penalty for refusal was a firing squad and because the men beside them were going. This is the machine for converting young men into corpses at a fixed rate, the only variables left being how many each nation possessed and how long its people would keep feeding them in.

In 1916 the machine reached its full and deliberate horror at two places whose names became shorthand for the century's idea of futility. At Verdun the German command set out not to break through but to bleed France white, to choose a fortress city the French would feel bound to defend to the last man and then to kill them there in industrial quantities by feeding the battle just enough to keep it alive. The French resisted, as intended, and the two armies between them lost something near three quarters of a million men over ten months for a few square miles of cratered ground that ended roughly where it began. On the Somme the British army, most of it volunteers who had

enlisted together in the first patriotic surge and trained for two years, attacked on the first of July after a week of bombardment meant to cut the wire and destroy the German guns. The bombardment did neither, the shells too often failing to explode or falling short, and the infantry climbed out and walked forward in waves at a steady pace as ordered, and the German machine gunners came up out of their deep dugouts and cut them down. Nearly twenty thousand British soldiers died that morning, the worst day the British army has ever had, and the battle ground on for another four months and gained a few miles at a cost of more than a million casualties on all sides. Into this the new instruments of the industrial age were poured one after another, each promising the breakthrough and each absorbed by the deadlock: poison gas, first chlorine and then the mustard agent that blistered the lungs and the skin and did not always kill but maimed for life; the flamethrower; the heavy howitzer that buried men alive in their own trenches; the aircraft, used first to spot for the guns and then to fight each other for the right to spot; and at last, on the Somme in 1916, the tank, the armored answer to the machine gun, too few and too unreliable that year to matter. None of it broke the line. It only raised the toll. The men lived in the ground among their own dead and the rats and the standing water, shelled at the enemy's pleasure, told by the staff far to the rear that one more push would do it, and the gap between what they were told and what they endured widened past anything the official language could close. The eastern front moved more than the western, vast distances changing hands across Poland and Galicia, but it killed as freely, and behind it the Russian state began to come apart under the strain of feeding an army it could neither equip nor supply. What that machine did to the minds of the men inside it is the part the artworks register, and they preserve it better than any casualty table.

A British subaltern named Wilfred Owen, twenty-four, a former lay assistant to a country vicar who had lost his faith and a former English tutor in Bordeaux who had not yet found his voice, was invalided in May 1917 to the Craiglockhart War Hospital outside Edinburgh with shell shock; he had been blown into the air twice in succession near Savy Wood and then trapped for days in a railway embankment with the dismembered body of a fellow officer. In August Siegfried Sassoon arrived at the same hospital, sent there in lieu of court-martial after publishing in *The Times* the protest letter known as *A Soldier's Declaration*, refusing to continue what he called a war of aggression and conquest. Owen, who had read Sassoon's *Counter-Attack* and considered him already the war's poet, knocked on his door with a stack of Sassoon's books and asked him to sign them. The two men met every afternoon for seven weeks. In the first week of October Owen sat in a ward and drafted a poem against the line of Horace every educated Englishman of his class had been raised to revere: *dulce et decorum est pro patria mori*, that it is sweet and fitting to die for one's country. He wrote it in the iambic pentameter that had borne the whole tradition of English heroic verse, and then fouled it on purpose at the moment of the gas attack, the line guttering, choking, drowning stumbling so that the reader cannot get a clean foot beneath it, the meter gassed

along with the man. He had watched a soldier die inside a mask that failed, and he set the death down with a clinical exactness the patriotic verse of the period could not absorb, the white eyes writhing, the blood gargling from the froth-corrupted lungs, and then turned on whoever would still recite the old line to children hungry for some desperate glory. He called it the old Lie, and the capital letter is the whole indictment; the classical form is summoned precisely so that it can be desecrated from within. The drafts in the British Library show Sassoon's pencil revising in the margins. The encounter is the clearest case the decade offers of what Bloom called the agon of a strong poet with his precursors. He went back to the front in August 1918, was awarded the Military Cross in October for an assault on a German position at the Beaurevoir-Fonsomme Line, and was killed on the fourth of November, 1918, exactly one week before the Armistice, leading his platoon across the Sambre-Oise Canal at Ors and trying to set duckboards under enemy fire that hit him in the chest. He was twenty-five. The telegram reached his mother Susan in Shrewsbury on the eleventh as the bells rang in the town for the peace, the two messages crossing on the same threshold; she lived another twenty-two years and edited his collected poems. Only five of his poems had been published in his life. *Dulce et Decorum Est* appeared two years after his death, rescued out of the wreckage by Sassoon, and it registered what the recruiting posters and the bond drives could not: that the official account of the war, the noble sacrifice, the fitting death, had come apart from the felt one, and the gap between them was now unbridgeable.

The same break ran through a printmaker and sculptor in Berlin, and through her it acquired a face and a measure of guilt. Käthe Kollwitz, forty-seven in the summer of 1914 and married to a doctor named Karl who ran a free clinic for the city's poor, had a younger son, Peter, who wished to volunteer for the German army at eighteen in the patriotic surge of August. His father was reluctant; it was Käthe who supported the boy and helped persuade Karl to sign the consent. She wrote in her diary on the night of the signing that the noble youth feels the call of the German Volk. Peter was killed in Flanders on the twenty-second of October, near Esen east of Diksmuide, ten weeks after he marched out. The telegram came on the thirtieth. She wrote, simply, "Your son has fallen." The line about the noble youth she would bear on her conscience for the rest of her life. What gives the work she made of that wound its authority is that her grief was inseparable from her own part in his death; she had believed the sacrificial idealism of 1914, and the long labor of the memorial was the work by which she came to disbelieve it. She conceived it almost at once and could not finish it for almost two decades, discarding one draft after another, until she set the granite at last in the German military cemetery at Vladslo in Belgium, near where Peter lies, in the summer of 1932: a pair of figures, a mother and a father, kneeling apart, the man with his arms folded hard across his chest keeping himself together, the woman bowed under her own grief, the two separated by a gap of stone the composition refuses to close. She modeled both on herself and Karl. The parents do not embrace, do not console each other, do not resolve their grief into

anything shareable. The official culture wanted the dead son redeemed by the nation he died for; Kollwitz gave it two parents on their knees and an uncrossable silence between them, and refused the redemption. The regime that prepared the next war understood the threat in the refusal: in 1933 she was forced off the Prussian Academy and her work removed from exhibition, because a monument that will not glorify the first war is intolerable to men readying the second. Her grandson Peter, named for the uncle he never knew, was killed on the Eastern Front in 1942. Her studio was destroyed by Allied bombing in November 1943; a lifetime of plates and drawings burned in the strike. She died on the twenty-second of April 1945, near Dresden, eight days before Hitler's suicide, of natural causes at seventy-seven. The granite at Vadslo still kneels.

Between the trench and the memorial lay a form almost no one counted as art and that recorded the war more completely than either: the letter home. Millions of soldiers wrote to families they would not see again, and the letters perform a constant double labor, telling enough to keep faith with the truth and concealing enough to spare the reader, so that the censorship runs not only through the official redactions but through the writer's own hand. In their gaps and their forced cheer and their unguarded sentences sits the same fracture Owen built into his poem and Kollwitz cut into her stone, the impossibility of fitting what was happening into the language available to describe it. The available language had its professors. In 1916, in Harvard's Noble Lectures, the dean of Chicago's divinity school was still reading history as "the substitution of moral for physical control," and the letters home arrived, by the millions, as the refutation no lecture hall would hear⁴

Somewhere in the same German lines, shuttling messages between regimental headquarters and the forward trenches, was a failed painter who would make of the war an aesthetic and a creed. Adolf Hitler had come to Vienna in 1907 at eighteen meaning to be an artist, and the city had refused him. He sat the entrance examination for the Academy of Fine Arts in October of that year, paid the registration fee of ten kronen, submitted samples that the panel of examiners marked, in the surviving register, "Sample drawing unsatisfactory. Few heads." He was rejected. Two months later his mother Klara died of breast cancer in the small town of Linz; he had been the dutiful son in the last months and would keep her photograph in his pocket for the rest of his life. He sat the examination again in 1908 and was not admitted to it. The double rejection by the institution that certified who was and was not an artist sank into him as a permanent wound. He moved into a homeless men's dormitory called the Männerheim in the working-class district of Brigittenau and spent the next five years in it, sleeping in a curtained cubicle and painting small watercolours of Vienna's landmarks, the Karlskirche and the Hofburg and the parliament and the opera, copied from postcards and sold by his roommate Reinhold Hanisch to tourists and frame-makers, competent renderings of facades empty of people. The two dealers who handled most of the watercolours, who paid him decently and steered the work to other shops, were both Jews: Samuel

4. Shailer Mathews, *The Spiritual Interpretation of History* (Harvard, 1916), pp. 67–68.

Morgenstern, a glazier on the Liechtensteinstrasse who kept ledgers of the purchases for decades, and Jakob Altenberg, a frame-maker. After Anschluss in 1938 Hitler had agents recover and destroy the work he could find of theirs. Morgenstern's ledger survived. The pattern of the talent the academy had named persisted in the work: the human figure was beyond him; the monumental building was not. A sensibility forms in that gap. The man who could draw the colonnade but not the face came to imagine politics as a building under construction, with the people as material to be massed and arranged, the nation as an edifice raised on a cleared site, and any obstacle to the composition as a thing to be erased rather than a person to be persuaded.

When the war came he found in it a place to belong and a purpose the studio had denied him. He enlisted with the Bavarians, reached the front in October 1914 in time for the slaughter of the volunteer regiments around Ypres, and served the rest of the war as a dispatch runner, conveying orders along the few kilometres between headquarters and the line, exposed to the bombardment that killed so many of his fellow runners, decorated with the Iron Cross Second Class in 1914 and, rarely for a man of his rank, the Iron Cross First Class in 1918, the latter on the recommendation of a Jewish officer of his regiment. He was gassed in the closing weeks and was in hospital, his sight damaged, when the news came that Germany had surrendered. To a man who had found in the trenches the only frame his life had ever known, the surrender could not be a defeat suffered honestly in the field. It had to be a betrayal worked from behind, the front stabbed in the back by the financiers and revolutionaries and Jews of the rear, the same rear whose academy had once turned him away. By 1918 it was all there in embryo in a corporal nobody had heard of: the politics aestheticized, the masses arranged like material, the rage at an invisible enemy who had cheated him of a victory he had earned with his body, and the decade that produced him handed him forward to the next.

That fracture, the gap between an idea and the experience that no longer fits it, is what no distant reading can see. Read at the war's hinge in 1917, the European order shows a face such a reading handles well: the old dynastic empires of the Romanovs and Habsburgs and Hohenzollerns and Ottomans read low on dynamism and high on the pressures that precede collapse, their authority resting on coercion more than consent, their error-correcting reflexes long atrophied, and all four were gone within two years. The borderland pressure reads correctly too, the United States entering the war a net debtor and leaving it the creditor of every other belligerent, the financial center of gravity sliding west while the guns still fired, the same shape the Dutch financiers had shown who funded the British rise that eclipsed them, hegemony in migration rather than extinction. What the reading cannot see is the thing Owen and Kollwitz saw, the moment when an idea that had organized a civilization simply stops being believed. The nineteenth century had insisted, on Hegel's authority above all, that history was the rational self-unfolding of spirit, each clash of opposites resolving upward into a higher synthesis. Four years of thesis and antithesis

ground against each other along four hundred miles of wire and produced no synthesis but corpses. The dialectic, stripped of its promised ending, stood revealed as a machine that could grind forever without arriving anywhere, the nihilism Nietzsche had forecast, on schedule and in field-grey, and no account of pressures has a place for the death of a belief that commands no army and guards no border and yet, once gone, leaves everything it had supported standing on nothing. It cannot date the war's beginning either: the shot at Sarajevo arrived at an alliance system already loaded to breaking, the timetables and treaty webs wired so that one detonation propagated everywhere, and the men who believed they gripped the levers were gripped by them instead, the Tsar told in the last days of July that a partial mobilization was mechanically impossible. No single capital authored the catastrophe; the currents of obligation and fear ran through every chancellery at once, which is why the search for the one guilty hand has never ended and never will.

The art that mattered most in the decade was the art that registered the dissolution before the war began. In Paris on the twenty-ninth of May 1913, more than a year before Sarajevo, Stravinsky's *Rite of Spring* had its premiere at the Théâtre des Champs-Élysées. The hammered chord of the *Augurs of Spring* lands in displaced accents the body cannot anticipate or march to. Rhythm, the oldest reassurance a listener has, arrives wrong. The music drives toward a rite in which a chosen girl dances herself to death to renew the soil. The score brought to the surface what Edwardian rationalism worked to keep buried, a pre-rational appetite for blood sacrifice that civilization had not abolished but only scheduled, and that the same continent would discharge within fourteen months along four hundred miles of wire. The premiere later became famous as a riot. The word attached only in reviews written more than a decade after, inflating an evening of catcalls and furious argument into something it never was. The score perceived the appetite a full year before the order ran on it.

The same season delivered the same refusal across the Atlantic. The Armory Show opened in New York in 1913 and gave America its first sustained look at European modernism, and the work that drew the crowds and the mockery was Marcel Duchamp's *Nude Descending a Staircase*, a figure dissolved into overlapping planes, motion fractured into simultaneous instants, the human body broken into a sequence of machine-like states. The newspapers called it an explosion in a shingle factory and the former president compared it unfavorably to a rug in his bathroom, and nearly ninety thousand people came to be scandalized. What scandalized them was what Stravinsky's audience heard: the unified image, the coherent body, the single confident point of view coming apart into fragments that would not be reassembled, a year before the order itself followed.

The same recognition had a clown in the same season, and a body, and a name. In February of 1914, on the Keystone lot in Edendale, a twenty-four-year-old English music-hall comedian

named Charles Spencer Chaplin was told to put on a costume for a one-reel comedy and walked into the property room and assembled, from the racks, the figure the next century would recognize at a glance: the tight coat, the loose trousers, the toothbrush mustache, the bamboo cane, the bowler. The picture was *Kid Auto Races at Venice*, six minutes long, his second film, and the character he played in it had no name yet. By the end of the year he had made thirty-five short pictures for Keystone and was the most famous performer alive in the new medium. The figure was the body inside the machine. He played a small man perpetually entangled with rotating doors, conveyor belts, swinging gates, kicking police, and revolving stages, his survival a matter of comic timing against mechanical force; the early Tramp pictures are the Edwardian assembly line read as slapstick, and the joke is the same joke the trenches would shortly play in earnest. The body and the machine are not made for each other, and the body will be broken on the machine unless it learns the rhythm. The Tramp would acquire pathos in the longer films Chaplin made in his own studio after he broke from Keystone, and by 1936 the same joke would be played at feature length under the title *Modern Times*. The figure was already there in 1914, the year the order he was satirizing marched into the worst version of itself.

By 1917 the war had reached its irreversible year, and it turned on two hinges, both toward the future and away from the old order. Britain and France had run through their reserves and were borrowing from New York to keep their larders supplied, the Allied blockade slowly strangling Germany while Allied resolve had to be furnished without pause, and the only inexhaustible supplier was American industry and American credit, with J. P. Morgan and Company as the broker binding American prosperity to Allied victory. The house that had drafted the country's central bank in secret three years before now underwrote one side of a world war, and stood to lose its loans if that side lost; who profited from American entry is not a question the documents leave obscure. In the east, the Romanov order that had ruled for three centuries collapsed in a matter of days, and the Bolsheviks seized power in Petrograd, Lenin sent home from his Zurich exile in a sealed train the German command was glad to provide, because a Russia in revolution was a Russia out of the war. The word glad understates the design. The German foreign ministry approved a grant of five million marks for propaganda inside Russia in the spring of 1917, and the channel for much of it was Alexander Parvus, a revolutionary turned war profiteer who had persuaded Berlin that the surest way to break the eastern front was to finance the men who wanted to overthrow the state that controlled it. The minister Richard von Kühlmann set the calculation down in plain words to army headquarters: Russia was the weakest link in the enemy chain, and a steady flow of funds under various labels had let the Bolsheviks build up their press and their agitation to a pitch the Provisional Government could not match. How much of that money reached Lenin's own hands the documents do not say, because Parvus refused to sign for what he passed on, and how much the party itself knew of the source is not established; the intention

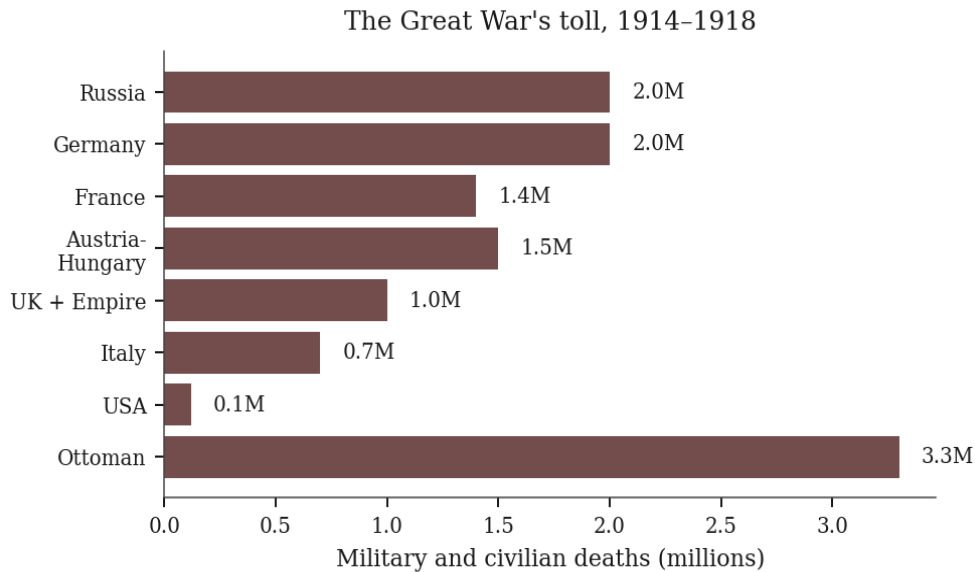
behind the transfer is. An imperial power at war deliberately financed the most extreme faction in a rival's politics, not because it shared the faction's doctrine but because the creed was a solvent, and it would dissolve an enemy from within at a cost far below the price of another offensive. The revolutionary extreme is rarely as spontaneous as its own myth requires, and it serves, knowingly or not, interests that stand well outside it.

The pattern runs wider than one train and one grant, and it runs in a direction the standard account finds awkward. The Bolshevik program declared open war on capital, yet the existence of an absolutist, terror-wielding faction on the far left was, across the decades to come, of considerable use to the propertied themselves. A maximal revolution that promised to abolish property, dissolve the nation, and shoot the bourgeoisie outright was useful to the men it threatened. The alarmed middle would accept a reactionary strongman or a hard police as the price of protection against the thing on the train. The workers' movement split down the center, setting the revolutionary against the reformist and the communist against the social democrat, a quarrel so bitter that the two halves would later refuse to combine even against a common enemy bent on destroying them both. By association the milder demands could be tarred with the brush of the Petrograd cellar: any call for a pension, a union, a shorter day, an end to a colonial occupation could be dismissed as the first step toward it. The extreme, in other words, was the most effective argument the propertied order ever had against the moderate. An order that grasped this had every reason to tolerate the menace, to let it run, on occasion to feed it, rather than to stamp it out. This needs no planning cabinet where industrialists and revolutionaries shake hands across a table. It is a current: a standing interest that a thousand separate hands served without conferring, the German general staff funding Lenin to wreck a front, a later financier preferring a red scarecrow to a labour movement that might actually win, a newspaper proprietor finding the red menace better copy and better politics than the reasonable grievance it buried. Where the engineered extreme leaves off and the merely exploited one begins is not always recoverable. A movement that styled itself the gravedigger of capitalism was, in its absolutist form, one of capitalism's most reliable instruments, and the men who profited from the fright it produced were under no obligation to understand that they were doing it.

What came aboard that train, whatever paid its fare, was a party that read history as a script already written toward a foreordained end, a secular end-time served by a disciplined revolutionary vanguard prepared to use unlimited violence in the name of an ultimate good. Men do not march into the machine guns for an adjusted balance of interests; they do it for a vision of the end of days, and Bolshevism supplied one with the authority of science. Eschatology was not the decoration on the politics of the century to come; it was the engine, the thing that converted ordinary fear and grievance into the willingness to kill and die at scale. That same engine was what made the faction so serviceable to its enemies: a movement convinced it possessed the key to

5. On the financial transfer that accompanied American entry into the war: Adam Tooze, *The Deluge: The Great War, America and the Remaking of the Global Order, 1916–1931* (New York: Viking, 2014), chs. 2–4. On the House of Morgan as Allied purchasing agent, Ron Chernow, *The House of Morgan* (Atlantic Monthly Press, 1990), part II.

history would not compromise, would not merge with the reformists, would not settle for the larger slice, and so could be counted on to keep the workers' house divided against itself. In the west, Germany gambled that unrestricted submarine warfare could starve Britain before American strength could be brought to bear, and that bet, compounded by the clumsy Zimmermann offer of a Mexican alliance, drew the United States into the war. The decisive American contribution was at first financial rather than military. How that transfer happened is the part the moral framing usually skips. Britain entered August 1914 as the world's banker; by Christmas 1916 it was running through its gold reserves to pay for American shells, beef, and steel. The House of Morgan, designated sole purchasing agent for both Britain and France in early 1915, placed orders worth roughly three billion dollars across the war and floated a series of Anglo-French loans on the New York market, the first of them in October 1915 for five hundred million dollars, the largest foreign loan in American history to that date. American banks and American savers bought those bonds; American factories filled the orders; American ports loaded the ships. Every transaction shifted the same accounting entry: a credit on the United States ledger, a debit on the British. By 1917 the British Treasury was warning that without American entry the supply line would break inside three weeks; the German submarine campaign and the Zimmermann telegram supplied the political cover for the entry that the financial position already required. The United States ended 1914 owing the world about three and a half billion dollars; it ended 1919 owed by the world about ten billion⁵ The rising creditor had committed its industry and its credit to one side, and in doing so had quietly inherited the future the European powers were spending themselves to death to determine. By the summer of 1918 American troops were arriving in France at a quarter of a million a month, fresh divisions against armies four years exhausted, and the final German offensive of the spring, the drive to win before the Americans could weigh in, broke against a line that no longer broke. The German army was not overrun. It was worn through, its home front starving under the blockade, its allies collapsing one by one, until its own command told its government the war could not be won and an armistice was signed in a railway carriage in the forest of Compiègne on the eleventh of November, 1918.



The Great War's toll, 1914–1918: military and civilian deaths by belligerent. Source: standard historical estimates.

When the guns fell silent that morning, four empires that had stood at the war's beginning were simply gone, and the settlement the victors imposed at Versailles in 1919 turned its grievances into a debt and extended them forward. Germany was assigned sole guilt and a bill of reparations so large it could be neither paid nor forgiven, a debt that became a standing humiliation drawing compound interest, signed in the same Hall of Mirrors where the German empire had been proclaimed in triumph half a century before. John Maynard Keynes walked out of the negotiations and wrote that a settlement which treated a defeated great power as a sum to be collected rather than a neighbor to be lived with had mistaken accountancy for statesmanship, and he proved right⁶ Engels's 1887 prophecy of eight to ten million dead, of the Thirty Years War compressed into four, of crowns rolled into the gutters by the dozens, had been in print for twenty-eight years when the war it described began, and the men who signed at Versailles had been raised on shelves of books in which that prophecy sat, marked or unmarked, and had filed it away as the polemic of a German exile and proceeded as their fathers had. New borders carved a belt of small, raw, mutually suspicious states out of the wreckage of the fallen empires, each a grievance with a flag, none strong enough to defend the ground Germany and Russia would both, in time, want back. The American president had arrived with an eschatology of his own, self-determination and a League and a war to end war, and then the American Senate refused to ratify the treaty he had authored, the new creditor declining the political crown that came with the financial one. An influenza the war's movements of men spread across the world killed more people than the war itself had. The elite that came home from the trenches came home dissociated, taught by the slaughter that the pieties of their fathers were lies, drawn to the absolute where their elders had trusted the center. A traumatized generation does not build cautiously; it reaches for

6. John Maynard Keynes, *The Economic Consequences of the Peace* (London: Macmillan, 1919). Keynes resigned from the British delegation on June 7, 1919, and the book appeared in December.

extremity, and the extremities were already forming, one of them in a hospital in Pomerania where a blinded corporal lay listening to the news of the surrender and deciding it was a crime.

What survived the decade was not the order these works were made inside, which came apart on something close to schedule. The gold anchor, the dynasties, and the belief that history bent toward reason all disappeared inside four years; Britain, the banker of the world in 1914, emerged a debtor to its former colony while the United States owned everyone's obligations and declined, for the moment, to rule. The works outlasted all of it. Owen's poem still springs its trap on every reader who comes to it for consolation, and after it English heroic verse could never again speak its old heroism quite straight. Kollwitz's two parents still kneel apart with the uncrossable stone between them, and the grammar she invented, grief that refuses glory, became one of the dominant idioms of the century's war memory, set against every official monument that tried to redeem the dead into the nation. Ball's nonsense syllables still stand as the most honest thing a European could have said in 1916, the discovery that anti-art can be the only truthful art when reason itself has been compromised passing into every avant-garde that followed. Stravinsky's displaced pulse and Duchamp's fractured body still register how a confident order had begun to break apart a year before it did so in fact. Each was the work of one mind under the load of an order whose money had lost its anchor, whose empires had lost their legitimacy, and whose shared faith had stopped being shared; each preserved the strain in a shape that did not come apart when everything around it did. The order is gone. These are the forms that arrived early, and they hand forward, into the decade coming, a doubled price level loosening toward the open collapse of the money-symbol at Weimar, a grievance loaded into the reparations machine, a traumatized generation reaching for absolutes, and a modernist refusal, matured here in broken pentameter and cardboard liturgy, about to flower into the waste lands of the years ahead.

In the shadows of the Great War and the Bolshevik triumph, a more cynical utility was discovered. Communism, rather than being the genuine negation of capitalism, functioned increasingly as its weapon. By funding and tolerating engineered extremes, the architects of the financial order could split the working class, discredit moderate socialism, and ensure that any structural challenge to capital was tainted by association with violent, authoritarian radicalism.

1920 – 1929

In the late autumn of 1921 a clerk at Lloyds Bank in London applied for three months of paid leave, and the staff card in the Colonial and Foreign Department, where he had been processing prewar German debts since 1917 for a salary that had reached six hundred pounds a year, recorded the reason as a nervous breakdown. Thomas Stearns Eliot was thirty-three. He had been raised in St. Louis in a New England Unitarian household whose habits of denial were the unstated subject of half his early poetry; he had married Vivienne Haigh-Wood in a registry office in 1915 on something close to a dare, ten weeks after meeting her, and the marriage had been disastrous on the day it began. She had inflammations he could not name; he had migraines and tachycardia; they shared an apartment whose narrow Bayswater rooms reduced each of them to the other's most intolerable witness. Bertrand Russell, who had befriended them both, had taken Vivienne to bed and so introduced a third sliding axis into the wreckage. By the autumn the marriage that had drained him as thoroughly as the ledgers had was coming apart alongside his nerves. He convalesced first at Margate, sitting in a glass-roofed seafront shelter on the Nayland Rock promenade with sheets of paper and his portable typewriter, and travelled on to Lausanne to be treated by a Swiss specialist in disorders of the will named Dr. Roger Vittoz, whose technique was the discipline of fixing a single image steady in the mind for as long as possible. In a hotel room above the lake he assembled out of a heap of drafts, quotations, and three years' worth of false starts the nineteen-page typescript he brought back to Paris in January. He handed the manuscript to Ezra Pound at Pound's studio on the rue Notre-Dame-des-Champs. Pound was four months older than Eliot and had made his name as the impresario of his own generation; he wrote on the margins in pencil and red ink. He cut the poem almost in half, struck whole passages, including an opening tour of Boston nightlife titled "He Do the Police in Different Voices" that Eliot had thought the spine of the thing, supplied the title, and gave the manuscript the shape that made it the founding document of a century's poetry. Eliot dedicated it to Pound, in Italian, the better maker. Boni and Liveright paid one hundred and fifty dollars in advance. The Waste Land appeared in The Criterion that October and the next month, with the notes that Eliot added under pressure from his American publisher, as a book. Its readers took the fragmentation for a difficulty to be decoded, an obscurity laid over a hidden coherence. It was the reverse. The fragmentation was the meaning. Eliot had set down a heap of broken images because the order that once bound them together had stopped cohering, and a mind under load could no longer pretend otherwise. The poem does not describe the collapse of a shared world. It performs that collapse in its own joints, jumping between voices and languages and centuries with no connective tissue, because the binding had perished and the honest account of its loss was a surface that would not cohere. Vivienne was committed in 1938 to an asylum in Northumberland by her brother, with Eliot's

silent consent, and died there nine years later without having seen her husband again.

The poem is also a séance, a deliberate raising of the dead. Bloom's account of poetic influence proposes that a major poet does not inherit a tradition so much as wrestle a precursor he cannot escape, misreading the dead to clear a space for his own voice, and the resulting work bears the marks of that struggle on its surface. *The Waste Land* is built almost entirely out of borrowed lines, Dante and Shakespeare and Webster and the Grail romances and the Upanishads stitched into a single tissue of quotation, and what he borrows is not homage. It is the agon made visible. Eliot drags Spenser and Augustine and the rest into his own ruined present so that they sound suddenly thin, period voices that can no longer convince, and the contrast between their old confidence and his fractured frame is the argument. The thing Eliot's own theory could not quite say, that he preached an impersonal tradition while making a poem soaked in private breakdown, surfaces in the poem's nerves. Bloom saw the cost of Eliot's program and spent a career resisting it, refusing the banishment of the Romantic poets that Eliot's criticism demanded and laboring to lift Wallace Stevens above him in the century's order. The quarrel matters here because it is the same contest the poem stages, a living mind forcing the dead to yield ground.

What had perished was a confidence that the symbolic could be trusted to mean what it said, and nowhere was that trust stripped barer in the same years than in the place where the symbol of all symbols, the unit in which every other value is reckoned, came apart on the street. In a Berlin autumn two years after Eliot's, a woman wheeled a barrow of banknotes toward a bakery, and by the time she reached the counter the loaf cost more than the load had been worth when she set out. The mark that traded at four to the dollar before the war stood at more than four trillion to the dollar by November of 1923. The Reichsbank ran dozens of paper mills and nearly two thousand presses and could not feed the demand for notes, because the paper it printed was the thing it destroyed. Prices doubled in days; wages were paid at noon so a worker could spend them before the afternoon halved their worth; thieves stole the baskets and dumped the cash. What annihilated itself in Germany was not chiefly savings, though a lifetime of bourgeois thrift evaporated in months. It was the promise folded inside money, the assurance that a number printed on paper would mean tomorrow what it meant today. The wheelbarrow exposed the oldest premise the modern era kept relearning, the one the German philosophers had set down a hundred years before. No mind touches the thing itself; it reaches only the version its own categories assemble. A banknote is worth something solely because everyone consents to imagine that it is, the most concrete object in a modern life and a piece of pure agreement, the master fiction on which the whole material order balances. When the consent drained away, the solidity went with it, and the most solid thing a German owned proved to have been an act of collective imagination all along, revocable in a season.

The collapse fell on the German middle class, and the question of who survived it answers itself once the gainers and losers are sorted. A hyperinflation is a transfer, and its direction is fixed by the structure of debt¹ Marks owed disappeared; marks saved disappeared with them. The industrialists and the great estates and the speculators who had borrowed to acquire real assets emerged from 1923 owning factories and land free of the loans that had bought them. The pensioner, the rentier, the salaried professional, the owner of war bonds sold to him as a patriotic duty, was wiped to nothing. Hugo Stinnes assembled one of the largest industrial empires in Europe in those years precisely by borrowing depreciating marks to buy hard things, and he was not alone in seeing what the printing presses made possible. The Reichsbank under Rudolf Havenstein went on issuing notes long after the consequence was plain, and a state that owed reparations in a currency it controlled had its own reasons to let the unit die, since every mark it destroyed was a mark of foreign debt it would not have to honor in real value. To call the destruction simply a policy error is to miss what it accomplished and who arranged to profit from it: the liquidation of a creditor class and the enrichment of the debtors, who happened to be the owners of German heavy industry, the same men with the access and the credit to borrow at scale while the currency fell. The barrow of worthless paper was the visible face of a redistribution executed under cover of catastrophe, and the people it ruined would remember, a decade on, that their savings had been taken while the great firms grew greater. The lesson the ruined drew was not that money is fragile but that the fragility had a beneficiary, and a politics built on that grievance was waiting to collect.



*Marks per United States dollar, 1914–1923, log scale: the destruction of a currency in nine years, the last of them vertical.
Source: Reichsbank exchange quotations.*

1. On the 1922–1923 inflation: Costantino Bresciani-Turroni, *The Economics of Inflation* (1937); Adam Ferguson, *When Money Dies* (1975).

That premise is the floor the rest of the decade stands on, and Eliot's heap of broken images and the Berlin barrow are two readings of one event. The image and the banknote are both promissory notes drawn on a collective belief, and in the years after the war both defaulted at once. Yet the era did not register the default as catastrophe so much as metabolize it into form, and the works that performed that conversion are what survived the order that produced them. In a flat in Paris the same year the mark died and *The Waste Land* appeared, on the second of February 1922, his fortieth birthday, an Irishman published through the small American-run bookshop Shakespeare and Company on the rue de l'Odéon a novel that performed the opposite operation on the same broken material. James Joyce had spent the previous seven years writing the book longhand on the backs of envelopes and the margins of newspapers, his eyesight failing on him from glaucoma that would require him to undergo eleven surgical procedures across the decade. Sylvia Beach, the daughter of a Presbyterian minister from Princeton who had opened the shop in 1919, had agreed to publish the book at her own expense after every other publisher in the English-speaking world refused on obscenity grounds, and printed it in Dijon at the press of a typesetter who spoke no English and set the manuscript by following the shape of the letters. She paid Joyce sixty-six percent of the net profit and went broke. He had relocated the Homeric epic into one ordinary day in Dublin, the sixteenth of June 1904, the day on which he had first walked out with the chambermaid Nora Barnacle who would be his lifelong partner. He dissolved the heroic into the interior monologue of a man named Leopold Bloom. Bloom is the antithesis of every classical protagonist, an unremarkable middle-aged Jew who eats a kidney, attends a funeral, visits a newspaper office, and goes home to a wife he knows is unfaithful. He is also, by trade, an advertising canvasser, a man who solicits commissions from shopkeepers and arranges where their notices will sit in the Dublin papers. Joyce gave the new century's epic interior to a person whose living was made by composing the small persuasions that move goods. The exterior world, the city of plot and incident, has thinned to a backdrop, and the whole density of the book has migrated inward, into the unbroken murmur of a single consciousness as it is worked on, hour by hour, by appetite, grief, memory, and the slogans of the marketplace it half-resists and half-recites. The fantasy the official culture still told, that a man is a sovereign rational citizen who governs his own attention, dissolves in Bloom's head into a self that is largely a current of received images, a mind colonized by the very persuasions it is paid to manufacture.

Joyce's wrestle with his own precursor was as deliberate as Eliot's, and his choice of Homer settled it. The same critic who tracked the poets' struggle with the dead argued that the strongest writers seize a giant of the canon and bend it to a purpose its author never imagined, and Joyce's seizure of the *Odyssey* is the boldest instance the century offers. He did not honor Homer; he overwrote him, mapping the wanderings of a Greek king onto the errands of a Dublin ad man so completely that the epic frame becomes a cage the modern content strains against. Where Eliot

summoned the dead to mourn a lost coherence, Joyce raised Homer to prove that the heroic had nowhere left to live except inside the head of one ordinary man, that the only odyssey now possible was the circuit of a single consciousness through a single unremarkable day. A self made of borrowed slogans is given the largest inheritance in literature, and the gap between the estate and the inheritor is the truth the book delivers.

While Joyce mapped the interior of an advertising man, a younger relative of the philosopher whose account of the unconscious underwrote the whole inward turn was building the industry to engineer that territory from the outside. Edward Bernays was Sigmund Freud's nephew twice over, his mother Anna Freud's sister and his father Ely Bernays the brother of Freud's wife Martha; the double bond was a Viennese knot the family kept by correspondence after Edward's parents emigrated to New York in 1892, where his father became a successful grain merchant. Edward had absorbed his uncle's central claim, that beneath the reasoning subject runs a deeper machinery of irrational desire the citizen does not see and cannot fully govern. He had begun in the 1910s as a press agent for the dancer Nijinsky and the tenor Caruso. The Great War made his discipline. In 1917 the Wilson administration set up the Committee on Public Information under George Creel to sell American entry to a country that had voted against it; Bernays joined as a young propagandist, drafted releases that turned a draft war into a crusade for democracy, and watched a population persuaded of a thing it had opposed within a single year. After the Armistice he wrote that the same techniques used to sell a war could sell a soap. Bernays took the claim and turned it into an instrument. Where Freud meant to bring the buried material to light so a patient might be freed of it, Bernays reached for the same stratum in order to move it, to manage the mass mind by addressing the appetites underneath its stated reasons. He laid the method out in *Crystallizing Public Opinion* in 1923 and again, more frankly, in *Propaganda* in 1928, writing without apology that the conscious and intelligent manipulation of the organized habits and opinions of the masses was an invisible government which was the true ruling power of the country, and that those who pulled the wires controlled the public mind⁸ This was not a critic's accusation. It was the practitioner's own boast, set down in plain print by the man who did the work. His most exact demonstration came on Easter Sunday, the thirty-first of March 1929, when the American Tobacco Company hired him to break the taboo against women smoking in public and so open half the population as a market. He consulted the psychoanalyst Abraham Brill, his uncle's American translator, who told him the cigarette read in the unconscious as a torch of masculine power. Bernays paid ten fashionable young women to march in the Easter parade down Fifth Avenue lighting Lucky Strikes at an arranged signal, briefed the wire services in advance, planted photographers in the crowd, and christened the cigarettes torches of freedom. The newspapers reported it as a spontaneous feminist gesture, which is what he had built it to look like. Women's smoking rates climbed for the rest of the decade. He had attached a manufactured desire to a

8. Edward Bernays, *Crystallizing Public Opinion* (New York: Boni and Liveright, 1923); Bernays, *Propaganda* (New York: Horace Liveright, 1928). The Easter Sunday "Torches of Freedom" event of March 31, 1929: Larry Tye, *The Father of Spin* (Crown, 1998), ch. 2; Bernays, *Biography of an Idea* (Simon and Schuster, 1965), ch. 38. On the consumer counterpart, Roland Marchand, *Advertising the American Dream* (California, 1985).

genuine longing for emancipation and sold the first as a fulfilment of the second, on commission, for a corporation that wanted the sales. Desire itself had become the engine of demand, and the advertisement was now applied ideology, a hardened picture of who a person should want to be, projected back at her until she mistook it for her own want. Bernays would live to a hundred and three and would give the practice its lasting name in 1947, when he called it the engineering of consent, and the name is honest. What was engineered was not a product but the want for it, and the engineer was paid by whoever profited from that want.

A correction is owed to the reader before the chapter moves on, because the popular histories of this material, most influentially Adam Curtis's *Century of the Self*, compress an entire profession into the single showman and so misdescribe what was built. Bernays did not theorize the system he sold. Walter Lippmann did. In *Public Opinion* of 1922 Lippmann set down the diagnosis that a modern democracy is too large and its citizens too occupied for ordinary voters to govern from any direct knowledge of the affairs they vote on, so that what they govern from is a set of pictures in their heads assembled by the press and the schools and the propaganda offices, and in *The Phantom Public* of 1925 he drew the conclusion the diagnosis required: that the manufacture of consent was both inevitable and, properly handled, the necessary condition of democratic government in a mass society. The measurement apparatus that made the technique a profession came later and from two other men. Elmo Roper launched the first commercial public-opinion poll in 1933 for *Fortune*, refining a sampling method that could deliver a usable verdict on national sentiment from a few thousand interviews. George Gallup, whose academic statistics work through the late 1920s on advertising readership supplied the theoretical floor, opened the American Institute of Public Opinion in 1935 and within a year was correctly forecasting the Roosevelt landslide that *Literary Digest's* much larger but unweighted poll had spectacularly missed. Lippmann supplied the theory of why consent had to be manufactured, Roper and Gallup built the instrument by which the manufactured product could be checked, and Bernays staged the demonstrations that sold the service to the corporation. Read together they form the polling-and-persuasion industrial complex of the interwar years, and to attribute the whole apparatus to the one practitioner who left the most quotable boasts is to miss the institutional fact: the system worked because a theorist of consent, two measurement firms, and a publicist were available in the same decade to the men with the money to buy all four.

The decade's two faces converge. Joyce went inside the advertising canvasser and found a self made partly of slogans; Bernays built the firm that manufactured them and aimed them at exactly that self, on retainer to the men who needed the public to buy. The interior the novelist mapped and the technician engineered were one and the same, and the century to come would be organized around the management of it. A profession set out to govern the public mind in the interest of those who paid it, said so in print, and largely succeeded. The technique was real, the intent was

published openly, and the beneficiaries were named in the invoices. Bernays and the men who hired him built the apparatus by which a few could shape what millions desired, and they understood it as power and called it that. No private board sat in a single room directing every appetite of a civilization, and the currents Bernays harnessed ran through him as much as he ran them. The genius of the method was that it required no central committee, only a profession that had discovered how the irrational mind could be reached and a market that paid handsomely to reach it. The want was engineered, and the men who did it left the proof in their own ledgers and manifestos.

The monetary ground beneath both was the Dawes Plan, which took effect in September of 1924.² It did not resolve the absurdity at the centre of the postwar settlement. It financed the absurdity and called that loan a recovery. The plan was drawn up by a committee chaired by Charles Dawes, a Chicago banker, and shaped throughout by the houses of American finance that stood to place the bonds, J. P. Morgan and Company foremost among them, which underwrote the initial German loan and took its fee. American banks, much of the money raised through bond issues sold to American investors on Wall Street, lent dollars to Germany. Germany paid reparations to France, Britain, and Belgium. The Allies repaid their war debts to the United States. The dollars, having closed the circuit, were lent out again. Money travelled in a loop in which each leg existed only to service the next, and at no station did the loop touch the production of anything that could have rendered the debts real. The arrangement was profitable at every turn for the institutions that built it. The American banks took their underwriting commissions on each new German bond, the bondholders collected interest, and Morgan sat in the middle of the cycle, recycling the flow for a fee. The capital that fed the loop was a single recycled crop of American loans planted across the whole field of European finance, and like any monoculture it was magnificently productive and helpless against a shock that struck several of its parts together. The men who built the circuit were not fools blind to the weakness. They were bankers who priced the fragility into their fees and collected on every leg while the dollars moved, and the recovery the politicians announced was, for the houses that arranged it, a stream of commissions disguised as statesmanship. Treasuries and central banks and the great private houses coordinated the loop in the open, each pursuing the gain the arrangement offered, and the brittleness was the cost the public would absorb for the profit the architects banked in advance. There was no secret cabinet behind the Dawes Plan; there was something more durable, an order in which the people who designed the circuit profited from its motion and stood clear of its collapse, so that the incentive to keep the dollars moving belonged to those least exposed when they stopped. The loop endured until something broke it. Dollars moved while Americans lent, and Americans lent while the return at home did not suddenly look better; every link in the chain assumed the permanence of every other, and none was permanent.

Sterling rejoined gold in the spring of 1925, and the manner of the return shows what the restoration decade actually worshipped. Winston Churchill, Chancellor of the Exchequer and unsure of the question by his own admission, took the pound back to convertibility at the prewar figure of four dollars and eighty-six cents, not because the arithmetic supported it but because the parity was the empire's dignity expressed as a number, and the City's word, once given at that figure, was treated as the collateral of civilization. Keynes answered within weeks in a pamphlet titled *The Economic Consequences of Mr. Churchill*, and his argument was simple: at the old parity the pound was overvalued by roughly a tenth, which made every British export dearer by the same fraction, which meant the difference would be clawed out of wages, beginning with coal³ It was. The mine owners posted wage cuts and longer hours, the miners answered with the slogan not a penny off the pay, not a minute on the day, and in May of 1926 the Trades Union Congress called the only general strike in British history. For nine days close to two million workers stood out, buses driven by undergraduates, troops conveying food from the docks, and then the congress folded and the miners starved alone into the winter. The restored pound had been defended, and the defense had been paid for by the people with the least say in the parity. The mechanism then exported itself. To defend sterling at a figure the market doubted, the Bank of England needed money to stay cheaper in New York than in London, and in July of 1927 the central bankers of Britain, Germany, and France crossed the Atlantic to a Long Island estate and persuaded the Federal Reserve to cut⁴ The cut was made for sterling's sake, and its largest effect was at home: cheaper call money in the exact season the American boom was learning to run on it. The defense of a dead parity in London helped inflate the bubble in New York, which is the gold-exchange standard in one sentence, a web of IOUs dressed as discipline, every member defending a number, the pressures pooling where this chapter ends.

The same years produced the American boom that made the capital so abundant, and that boom ran on a newer device: ordinary people's borrowed money, leveraged into ownership of goods they could not yet afford. More than half the cars left the showroom on installment credit, and radios and refrigerators followed, consumption outrunning income the way the mark had run ahead of the bakery, except that here the gap felt like prosperity. It was filled not with paper currency but with the borrower's own future, pledged in advance and spent in the present. Banks did not lend out money already gathered in their vaults so much as create it whenever they lent, since a bank keeps only a fraction of its deposits in reserve and writes the rest into existence as fresh credit; each loan becomes a new deposit somewhere else, which becomes the base for further loans, so the supply of claims on wealth swells with every signature while the underlying goods grow only as fast as factories can make them. The claim on wealth had begun to circulate as if it were the thing itself, and to multiply faster than the substance it claimed. By the end of the decade the same appetite stacked the New York market on borrowed money in the form of the broker's

3. Gold Standard Act, April 28, 1925; J. M. Keynes, *The Economic Consequences of Mr. Churchill* (1925).

4. The July 1927 meetings of Norman, Schacht, Rist, and Strong; Liaquat Ahamed, *Lords of Finance* (2009), ch. 17.

9. On the leverage mechanics of the 1929 boom and the call-money market: Charles P. Kindleberger, *Manias, Panics, and Crashes: A History of Financial Crises* (Basic Books, 1978), chs. 5–6; Galbraith, *The Great Crash 1929* (1955), ch. 3 on the trust pyramids.

loan, the margin account in which a buyer of stock put down a tenth of the price and the broker, with funds raised in turn from the banks, supplied the other nine. The arithmetic of that leverage is the whole story of what came next. A man who owns a share outright loses ten percent when it falls ten percent; a man who owns it on a tenth down forfeits everything, because the fall has erased the slice that was his and the broker, to protect the nine parts that were lent, sells the stock out from under him to recover the loan. A small decline does not dent such a tower; it dissolves the base, and the forced sales push the price down further, which wipes out the next tier of borrowers, whose liquidations drive it down again⁹ The men who arranged the credit, the brokers who extended the margin and the investment trusts pyramided one atop another so that a dollar of real saving controlled ten dollars of paper claims, took their cut at every level of the pyramid, so that the boom enriched its engineers most of all in the months before the mechanism reversed and took the public's money down with it.

No work of the decade caught the moral interior of that boom more precisely than the short novel an American expatriate published in April of 1925, and its formal choices make it an X-ray of the order Bernays was perfecting. F. Scott Fitzgerald gave *The Great Gatsby* a narrator, Nick Carraway, who is not the protagonist but the witness, a bond salesman new to New York in the summer the credit ran hottest, and the choice of trade is not incidental. The man who tells the story of the dream sells paper claims on other people's future earnings for a living. At the center stands Jay Gatsby, born James Gatz, a man who has manufactured a self out of catalogue images and rumor and the proceeds of bootlegging, and who throws open his mansion to crowds who do not know him in order to draw back the woman he has fashioned the whole performance to win. Gatsby is Bernays's subject rendered as tragedy, a consciousness that has swallowed the advertisement whole and become it, a self that is wholly a projected picture aimed at a single buyer. The formal stroke that makes the book endure is that Fitzgerald keeps Gatsby at a distance, seen always through Nick, glimpsed across water and lawn, so that the man is never quite present and is instead a picture the narrator constructs. Daisy's voice, Nick says, is full of money, and the line states the book's whole economy: the object of longing is not a person but the sound of capital, the dream of belonging to the class that the new credit seemed briefly to open to anyone with nerve. What the green light conceals is that the dream was always a financial fiction priced for a few, that the boom promising the self could be remade by purchase was built on borrowed funds pledged against a future that would not arrive, and that the old money in its houses across the bay would close ranks and let the striver drown. Fitzgerald sold poorly in 1925; the country was inside the fantasy and had no wish to read its own obituary. The book outlived the boom because it had already buried it.

Gatsby's parties had a soundtrack, and it had walked north. Between the war's labor hunger and the decade's end, more than a million Black Southerners left the cotton belt for the cities of the

5. On the Great Migration, Isabel Wilkerson, *The Warmth of Other Suns* (2010); census estimates put the 1910–1930 outflow near 1.6 million; the Johnson-Reed Act, May 26, 1924; William J. Collins, "When the Tide Turned," *Journal of Economic History* 57 (1997); A. Philip Randolph, *The Messenger*, August 1923.

6. Louis Armstrong and His Hot Five, "West End Blues," Okeh 8597, recorded June 28, 1928.

North, the Chicago Defender printed the train times, the boll weevil and the lien made the case, a Pittsburgh wage made the decision, and after the Johnson-Reed Act of 1924 closed the Atlantic door, the mills that had staffed themselves from steerage sent their recruiters south, in the largest internal migration the republic had yet seen, conducted without a leader, an act of mass refusal disguised as a job search⁵ They were leaving the lien the prior chapter met at the gin. Harlem became the capital of the refusal, and what it produced first was sound. In a Chicago studio in June of 1928, Louis Armstrong, the grandson of slaves, raised in a New Orleans waifs' home, opened West End Blues with a twelve-second unaccompanied cadenza that musicians have been measuring themselves against for a century, a single horn announcing, without a word, that the formal mastery of the age lived wherever it chose to live⁶ The order's reply was the Cotton Club. On Lenox Avenue, a gangster's nightclub dressed its stage as a plantation, hired Duke Ellington's orchestra, the finest working band in America, writing three-minute masterpieces on a deadline, and barred Black customers at the door of a club in Harlem itself. The arrangement says what the decade could not: the order wanted the energy and not the people, the sound piped out on radio wires into white living rooms whose owners would never sit beside the men who made it. Ellington took the terms and used them, as the makers in this book keep doing; the so-called jungle numbers the management ordered up came back as compositions of such intelligence that the insult dissolved inside them, the commission outlived by the work. Read as evidence, the music preserves what no white account of the decade admits: a people converting four centuries of pressure into the only asset that could not be repossessed, a form. And the form was bought, broadcast, imitated, and laundered, there is a straight wire from the Cotton Club's radio feed to the sound the fifties will sell back to its suburbs, while the people who made it rode north into cities whose maps, within a decade, would be inked red around exactly the blocks they could afford. The migration had escaped the lien. The lien was learning to travel.

Where the American boom told its happy story, two German painters who had survived the trenches insisted on showing the figures the boom wanted unseen. The movement a Mannheim curator named New Objectivity in 1925 set itself against the romantic inwardness of the Expressionists and looked instead with a cold, exact, almost clinical eye at the surfaces the prosperity preferred to skip. George Grosz drew the profiteer and the corrupt official with a venom that was nearly diagrammatic, the fat banker and the bloated general rendered as types caught in the act, and his target was never abstract. It was the specific class that the inflation had enriched, the speculator gorging while the veteran begged. Otto Dix, himself a soldier who had served at the front and never stopped returning to its wounds, painted the maimed man the new affluence stepped around on the pavement, the cripple with a mechanical jaw or a face rebuilt by surgeons or no legs at all, set down beside the well-fed citizens who looked away. The verists called their method a pitiless precision, and the pitilessness was the point. The official fantasy of the stabilized

republic was a society that had put the war behind it and could now consume in peace. What the painters forced back into view was the body the war had broken and the wealth the inflation had stolen, the human cost the recovery was built on a refusal to see. Dix and Grosz did to the comfortable surface of Weimar what Eliot did to the coherent poem, refusing to let the broken thing be smoothed over, keeping the fracture open as the only honest witness of what had happened.

The shock the decade was metabolizing was not only economic, and the deepest reading of it took the form of a man arraigned before a court that will not state his crime. Franz Kafka died of tuberculosis in 1924 and asked his friend Max Brod to burn the unpublished manuscripts; Brod refused, edited what survived, and released it across the years that followed, so that *The Trial* reached print in 1925, assembled posthumously from chapters the author had left unordered and written a decade earlier. Josef K. is arrested one morning by officials who never name the charge, tried by a tribunal whose location and law he can never establish, and finally executed without learning what he was accused of. The novel is usually read as prophecy of the totalitarian state, and it became that. But its formal core is more exact and more disturbing than prophecy. The Law in Kafka is not absent; it is everywhere, pressing on every corridor and every clerk, and yet it can never be brought into view, never quoted, never confronted. It works precisely as a bureaucratic order functions, as a system whose authority is total and whose ground is unavailable, demanding obedience while withholding the rule that would make compliance intelligible. K.'s guilt is the modern subject's own before an apparatus that cannot be known and cannot be appealed, a machinery that makes a person feel he has transgressed without ever specifying the transgression. What erupts through the smooth procedural surface is that the order rests on nothing a person can interrogate, that behind the unending offices and stamped papers there is no graspable law at all, only the demand itself, and the men who staff the offices serve a power none of them could name.

The recognition that collective feeling can be produced rather than merely expressed became, in the Soviet Union, a deliberate technique of the state. Sergei Eisenstein finished *Battleship Potemkin* in 1925 on a commission to mark the twentieth anniversary of the 1905 revolution, made to order for a regime that understood cinema as the most powerful instrument it had for the construction of a public, and its Odessa Steps sequence remains the textbook case of the cut as manufacture. No single shot in that sequence contains the meaning. A line of soldiers descends; a mother falls; a pram rolls; a woman's face shatters behind her glasses; and the feeling of the massacre is generated in the splice between the shots, in collisions the camera never recorded and the eye assembles only because the edit forces it. Eisenstein theorized this openly as the production of an emotion the spectator experiences as spontaneous. Where Bernays engineered consent for a cigarette by attaching it to an unconscious wish, Eisenstein manufactured collective grief and revolutionary resolve by joining shot to shot, and both understood, in their separate

hemispheres, that mass feeling was now something a technician could build to order for whoever commissioned it. The form admits what the politics of the film conceals. A picture made to celebrate the spontaneous uprising of a people is in fact the most controlled artifact imaginable, every frame placed to produce a response, so that what the revolutionary image disavows is the manufacture inside it, the technician's hand on the very spontaneity it depicts, and the state's hand on the technician.

Beneath all of this an inheritance soured. The German idealism that had opened the modern era with the claim that mind and category come before the world a person perceives did not vanish under the Weimar humiliation; it curdled. Schopenhauer had already turned Kant's sober limit into a metaphysics of will, recasting the world as blind striving rather than reason; Nietzsche then drove that will from mere persistence into the will to power, the drive of a self to expand and impose itself; meanwhile Marx had inverted Hegel's dialectic into a secular eschatology, a promised end of conflict reached through the collision of material forces. A nation broken by defeat and robbed by its own currency reached back into this inheritance for an idea on which to rebuild, and what it found, ready to be misread, was the doctrine that reality is finally made of will and may be remade by an act of self-assertion through force. The claim that the mind constructs its world, sober in the seminar, became under humiliation a creed of self-deification. And the men who had directed the 1918 surrender, the officer caste that emerged from defeat with its prestige bruised but its position intact, fostered the legend that the army had been undone not on the field but by betrayal at home, a stab in the back, and watched the chaos as a trough before a return rather than as an end. The legend served them: it shifted the blame for the defeat from the generals who lost the war to the civilians and the minorities who signed the peace, and it kept alive the prestige on which their restoration depended. Europe, congratulating itself on the Dawes loans and the handshakes at Locarno, saw a nation laid low and missed the same people gathering themselves around a manufactured grievance.

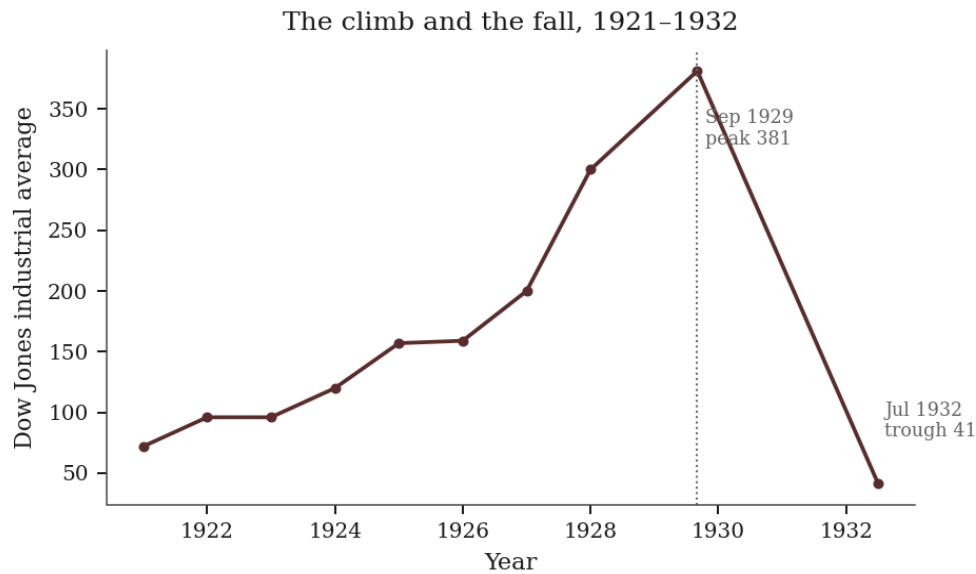
Measured at its hinge near the end of 1929, the American order still possessed live dynamism, an expanding economy and a society that made things on an enormous scale, and the boom looked like health at its apparent maximum. The pressure beneath it was climbing all the same.

Financialization showed in the installment note and the call-money market, the claim on wealth circulating as the thing itself. The whole European recovery rested on the single recycled crop of American credit, strongest in appearance just before the moment it shattered. A surplus of ambitious men showed less in America than across the wrecked centre of Europe, where the universities turned out more credentialed and aspiring young men than the hollowed establishment could seat, a counter-elite the existing order could neither employ nor silence. It was a deceptive zenith, a power that looked robust while its load-bearing diversity had already thinned to a single

rail. Productive strength was the wrong measure of what was failing. The brittleness lay in belief itself, in the moment a society's account of its own solidity stops convincing the people inside it, and no count of factories or harvests could register the speed of it, because what gave way was not output but agreement. The mark's collapse was that moment made literal. Dix's ruined veteran and Eliot's broken images registered the loss of confidence years before the market would confirm it, seeing what the ledgers were built unable to see.

The schedule arrived in the autumn. On the third of September 1929 the Dow Jones industrial average closed at 381, having tripled in five years, and a forecaster named Roger Babson told a business conference two days later that a crash was coming and was laughed at by the wire services that quoted him. Through September and October the market sagged, rallied, and sank again, the way a crowd loses conviction, not all at once but in waves of individually reasonable departures. On Thursday the twenty-fourth of October the waves became a run. Nearly thirteen million shares traded, a new high by millions; the ticker fell hours behind, so that men sold blind into a price they could no longer see; and at midday the heads of the great banks met at the House of Morgan and sent the exchange's vice president onto the floor to bid above the market for U.S. Steel, the 1907 playbook run from memory. The bid steadied the market for two sessions. On Tuesday the twenty-ninth, sixteen and a half million shares went over the side, the pools and the bankers stood away, and the margin arithmetic this chapter set down earlier ran in reverse at industrial speed: the ten-percent man was erased by a ten-percent fall, his broker sold him out automatically into a falling market, and every forced sale manufactured the next margin call⁷ By the middle of November the average had given up nearly half its September peak. The country was told, and largely believed, that the storm had passed; the President pronounced the economy fundamentally sound; and a long rally into the spring of 1930 made the optimists briefly right. Then the credit machine the next chapter will take apart began to run backward in earnest, and the market followed it down for two more years, to a close of 41 in July of 1932, eighty-nine cents of every September dollar gone. The crash did not cause the depression any more than the courier caused Waterloo. It was the moment the belief failed in public, the hour at which a decade of claims circulating as wealth was asked, all at once, what it was a claim on.

7. October 24 and 29, 1929; Dow peak 381.17 (September 3, 1929), trough 41.22 (July 8, 1932). John Kenneth Galbraith, *The Great Crash 1929* (1955).



The Dow Jones industrial average, 1921–1932: the climb, the break of autumn 1929, and the long fall to 41. Source: Dow Jones daily closes.

What survived is not the order these works were made inside, which came apart roughly on schedule. The Dawes loop broke when American capital was drawn home by the rising market, starving Germany of the credit the whole reconstruction depended on, and the men who had taken their commissions on the way up were already clear of the wreckage. The tower of borrowed money in New York dissolved its own base in the autumn after the decade closed. The stabilized republic the painters indicted did not outlast the slump that followed, and the curdled will the officer caste was husbanding found its terrible instrument in the decade after that. The works outlasted all of it. The Waste Land performs the collapse of a shared world in its own fractured joints. Ulysses, still in print and still widely unfinished by its purchasers, mapped a self made partly of the slogans aimed at it, the first full chart of that interior. Across the bay from his green light, Gatsby has not stopped being the purest portrait of a self manufactured to be bought, or the credit boom's purest sales pitch for the country that could not afford it. Kafka's court tries a man before a law he cannot read, and the apparatus has only grown more literal. And the techniques the decade invented for the management of the mass mind, the engineered desire and the manufactured feeling, did not collapse with the monetary order that produced them. They were the durable thing. The tower of recycled belief gave way in a season, as the mark had given way, and the consumer order that ran on Bernays's methods and Joyce's colonized interior outlived the whole arrangement, and runs still.

The roaring surface of the 1920s disguised a structural decay that history had warned of: easy money destroys nations. The artificial expansion of credit decoupled wealth from production,

incentivizing speculation over substance and quietly rotting the economic foundations of the republic. Parallel to the financial bubble was a psychological one. The cult of the self, catalyzed by the popularization of Freud and Jung, turned the citizen inward. This 'modernism ruined everything' ethos atomized society, promoting a narcissistic preoccupation with personal neurosis that effectively disabled collective political action. The public was too busy analyzing its dreams to notice who was stealing its waking world.

1930 – 1939

On the night of the twenty-eighth of March 1935, at the Ufa-Palast am Zoo in Berlin, an audience watched one woman's record of a crowd of seven hundred thousand and saw, with no apparent strain, a nation become a single body. Leni Riefenstahl had begun her working life as an Expressionist dancer in the Weimar revues, had moved into the cinema as the lead in the mountain films of Arnold Fanck, had directed her first film at thirty in 1932, and had a year later attended a Berlin rally at the Sportpalast that she said reversed her sense of what cinema was for. She wrote to Hitler asking for an audience and was given one in May 1933, the regime then four months old. He commissioned her, over the objections of Goebbels, who detested her, to film the party congresses; the budget for the Nuremberg picture had no ceiling. She had been given resources no documentary maker had ever commanded for such a subject: thirty-six cameras, a crew of one hundred and seventy, pits dug beside the parade routes, tracks laid up the flagpoles, an elevator built into one of them so a lens could climb alongside the banners. She shot the sixth Nazi Party Congress at Nuremberg in September 1934 and then spent five months in the cutting room with two assistants reducing sixty-one hours of exposed film to one hundred and four minutes, and that room is where the picture was actually made. She slept on a cot beside the cutting bench. What she assembled was not a report of an event. It was the construction of a perception the event by itself did not contain. The opening sequence has the leader's aircraft descend through cloud toward the medieval roofs of Nuremberg, the shadow of the plane crossing the marching columns below like an annunciation, and from that first image the film's grammar is fixed. The individual face exists only as it dissolves into the mass; the mass has being only as it turns toward the one man on the rostrum; and the camera, ever in motion, always rising, supplies the unifying consciousness the crowd itself cannot possess. No single person standing in that square could have seen what the film shows. It manufactures a viewpoint no human occupied, the vantage of the collective as a thing with a will, and then offers it back to the viewer as something witnessed rather than something built. Riefenstahl insisted to the end of a long life that she had made a work of art and not of politics; she lived to a hundred and one, was tried after the war and classified a fellow-traveler rather than a Nazi, took up still photography of the Nuba people in Sudan in her sixties, learned scuba diving in her seventies, and was filming under the Indian Ocean past the age of ninety. The denial extended to her last interviews. The work she had made denies the denial in every frame.

This is the decade in which one mode of being human reached its purest expression on film: the mode in which independent judgment is not defeated but surrendered, handed over with relief to a movement that promises to think and to feel on the individual's behalf. Riefenstahl insisted to the end of a long life that she had made a work of art and not of politics, that she cared about composition and rhythm and the play of light on stone and skin, and the protest is the exact form

the ideology took. They did not know it, but they were doing it. The film offers release from the burden of being a separate mind in an unmanageable world, the longing that one might cease to weigh evidence against experience and simply belong, and the formal means by which Riefenstahl produces that dream are the rising crane, the rhythmic cut from the one to the many and back, the elimination of any face that registers doubt. The buried truth is that the unity is a fabrication of the editing bench, that the single collective body the film presents never existed outside the splices she made, and that what looks like a people finding its soul is a technology assembling an image of a soul and selling it to the people as their own. *Triumph of the Will* is the engineering of consent raised to the scale of a state. What Edward Bernays had built in New York as a commercial technique, the deliberate manufacture of mass desire through the staged image, the regime in Berlin took up as statecraft, and Joseph Goebbels, who admired American advertising and studied its methods, ran a ministry that did with a nation's belief what an agency does with a brand. The film is the purest surviving specimen of that method: applied ideology, the period's official picture of who a German should want to be, sold through the camera with the same machinery a soap is sold. The metaphysical inheritance the century had been dragging behind it surfaces here in its most dangerous inversion. Kant had drawn a line no mind could cross, the line between the thing as it is and the version the mind's own categories make of it, and from that sober limit the German line had run through Hegel's history, in which spirit works itself out through the dialectic, and curdled, by way of Schopenhauer and Nietzsche, into a creed in which a sufficiently total will need answer to nothing outside itself. The movement Riefenstahl filmed took that creed and made it a method of government. Reality became raw material for an act of imagination performed at the scale of a state, and the facts that refused the vision were not evidence to be heeded but enemies to be abolished.

The man on the rostrum had begun as a painter, and the failure had marked him. The earlier chapter laid out the rejection: twice at the Academy of Fine Arts in Vienna, the second time not even admitted to the examination, the Männerheim dormitory, the watercolours of facades emptied of people sold through Samuel Morgenstern's frame shop on the Liechtensteinstrasse. The rejection festered into a theory of culture in which his own thwarted taste became the measure of a civilization's health: the modern art he could not make recast as degeneracy and the buildings he admired elevated as the true expression of a race. He never stopped thinking of himself as an artist; he simply changed his medium to the state. The rally was composed the way a painter composes, columns of men arranged into geometry, banners hung for their color and rhythm, and the architect Albert Speer, whom he had met at twenty-eight in 1933 and elevated by 1937 to General Building Inspector for the Reich Capital, gave the composition its grandest form. At the Nuremberg congresses Speer ringed the night assembly on the Zeppelinfeld with one hundred and fifty-two anti-aircraft searchlights pointed straight up, the bulk of the Luftwaffe's strategic reserve loaned at

1. Albert Speer, *Inside the Third Reich*, trans. Richard and Clara Winston (New York: Macmillan, 1970), pp. 58–60, on the "cathedral of light" at Nuremberg; Neville Henderson, *Failure of a Mission* (Putnam, 1940), p. 73.

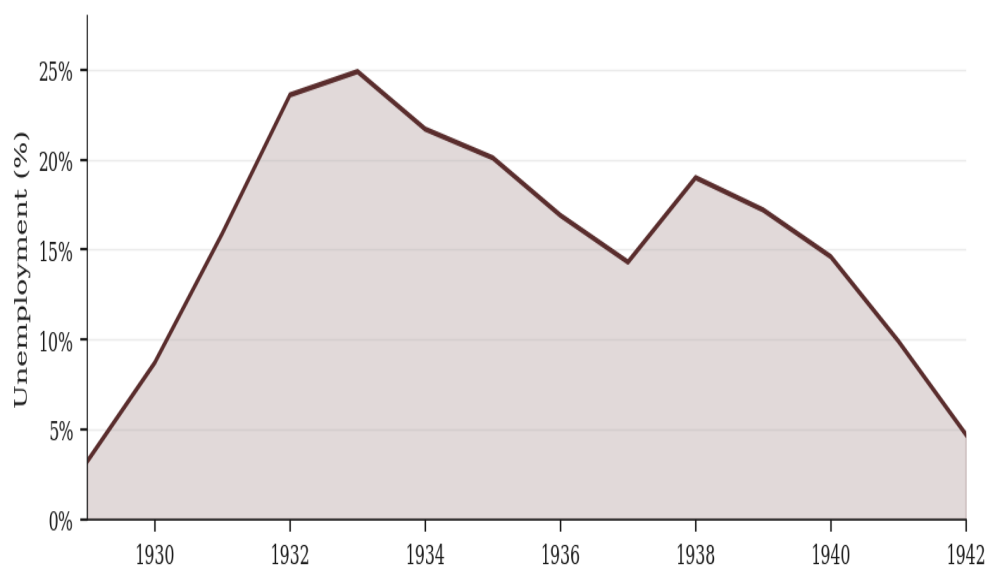
Göring's complaint, their beams meeting eight kilometers overhead in what the British ambassador Neville Henderson called from the visiting box a cathedral of ice¹ Speer designed in ruins, drawing his buildings as they would look as romantic wreckage a thousand years on; he sketched the proposed Volkshalle for the rebuilt Berlin under the name Germania as a domed structure sixteen times the volume of St. Peter's, large enough to generate its own indoor weather. Walter Benjamin, a German Jewish critic watching from exile in Paris, named the thing in an essay finished in 1935. The logical end of a politics that makes itself beautiful, he wrote, is war, because only war can give a mass movement a goal grand enough to match the spectacle while leaving the property relations beneath it untouched. The regime gives the people a chance not to change their condition but to express it, to find in the columns and the searchlights an aesthetic gratification that costs the rulers nothing. Mankind, contemplating its own destruction as a spectacle, had become an object of its own pleasure. Benjamin took his own life on the Spanish border in September 1940 trying to escape the army the rallies had built. The rejected painter had enlarged his art until a continent was the frame, and the people inside the picture were composed, like the figures left out of his Vienna watercolours, into a surface with no inner life the composition was required to honor.

The conditions that made such a surrender attractive were not metaphysical. They were monetary, and they had begun with the destruction of money's most basic promise. The prosperity of the prior decade had rested on a web of credit so tightly bound that what made it strong against any one tremor made it lethal against several at once: margin debt on shares bought with borrowed money, brokers' loans financed by corporations and by capital that flowed in from abroad, the whole edifice resting on the assumption that the assumption would survive. When the New York market broke in the autumn of 1929 the break did not, by itself, make the catastrophe. A market can fall and a country absorb it; the panic of 1907 had been violent and the republic recovered. What turned a financial shock into a decade-long ruin was a machine working in reverse, and it has to be understood first, because almost everything else in the decade is downstream of it. Most of what a modern economy uses for money is not coin or government paper but bank deposits, and those balances are created by lending. A bank keeps only a fraction of its deposits in reserve and lends the rest. The borrower spends the loan. The proceeds land in another bank as a fresh deposit, against which the cycle runs again. Money, in this arrangement, is debt in motion, conjured into being when a loan is written and destroyed when it is repaid or struck off. The arrangement multiplies purchasing power in good times and runs backward with the same force in bad ones.

When a bank fails, the deposits on its books do not merely change hands; they vanish, because the money was never metal in a vault but a promise the failed bank can no longer keep. Some nine thousand American banks failed in waves through 1930 and 1931 and into 1933, depositors who had trusted that their savings sat behind oak counters discovering that the funds had been lent out into the same collapsing world, and each failure quietly extinguished a portion of the money

supply itself. The stock of money in the United States shrank by roughly a third. This is the engine beneath the misery, and it fed on itself. Debt that had been serviceable at one level of prices became crushing as they fell, and they fell because everyone sold at once to service debt and because the money that bought things was disappearing. Deflation, quiet and merciless, raised the real weight of every loan even as it lowered the income that serviced them, so that the more a man worked to escape his obligations the deeper he sank into them, and the harder banks called in loans to save themselves the faster they destroyed the deposits that were their patrons' wealth. Then trade: the Smoot-Hawley tariff of 1930 invited the retaliation it received, and the web of global commerce contracted by roughly two-thirds in dollar terms within three years, every nation reaching for the same defensive wall and so multiplying the harm it fled. By 1933 a quarter of American workers had no work, the figure worse in Germany, and that is a number no order can absorb without forfeiting the loyalty of those who suffer it.

What the slump did to economics as a discipline was its first great test, and the decade is where the central monetary argument of the whole century was first fought to the ground. The men who ran the treasuries of the West had inherited a creed about depressions, and it told them to do nothing. Andrew Mellon, secretary of the Treasury under Hoover, gave it the bluntest statement, advising the President, as Hoover later recorded it, to liquidate labor, liquidate stocks, liquidate the farmers, liquidate real estate, to purge the rottenness out of the system so that values would be readjusted and enterprising people would pick up the wreck from less competent people. The slump was a moral event, a needed correction, and the only sin was to interrupt it. The creed had a constituency. A deflation that wipes out debtors and small holders leaves untouched the man who already sits on cash and gold, and indeed makes him richer, since every dollar he keeps commands more as prices fall. The call to let the slump run its course was, whatever its authors believed, a program under which the creditor inherits the wreck of the debtor. The Austrian economists gave the creed its intellectual armor. Ludwig von Mises and the younger Friedrich Hayek, the latter newly installed at the London School of Economics and drawing audiences away from Cambridge, taught that the downturn was the unavoidable hangover from a credit expansion the central bank should never have permitted, that the cheap money of the boom had pushed capital into projects that should never have been built, and that these errors had to be wrung out of the system before any recovery could be sound. Reflation would only paper over the misallocation and seed the next collapse.



U.S. unemployment, 1929–1942: the slump that produced the cinema of the rural poor and the New Deal art programs.

Source: Bureau of Labor Statistics; Lebergott (1957) for pre-1948.

It was a doctrine of austere internal consistency and catastrophic real consequence, the cure being the disease run to its end, and it commanded the levers of power while the banks failed and the unemployed multiplied. John Maynard Keynes set himself against it. He had argued since the slump began that the liquidationist counsel was suicidal, and in 1936 he published *The General Theory of Employment, Interest and Money*, which named the mechanism the orthodox could not see² Its claim broke the spell. An economy, Keynes showed, has no automatic tendency to return to full employment; it can settle into a stable rest with a quarter of its workers idle and remain there for years. The reason is a circuit the orthodox had assumed away. What one man spends is what another man earns, so when households and firms grow frightened and lay out less in order to save, they cut one another's incomes in turn, and out of the shrunken pay comes less to spend again, the contraction feeding on itself the way the bank failures fed on themselves. The saving that the orthodox trusted to flow automatically into new investment instead vanishes into idle hoards, because no one will build a factory whose product no one can buy, and so the very thrift that is prudent for one household is ruinous for all of them at once. A rate of interest pushed near zero does not break the trap, because in a deep enough fright people will hoard money at any price rather than risk it. The remedy could not be patience, since the circuit had no floor. It had to be demand, and if the private kind had collapsed the state was the one actor large enough to supply what was missing, borrowing the idle savings and spending them into the gap until household incomes recovered enough to sustain themselves. The two readings of the catastrophe could not be reconciled, and the quarrel between them runs through the rest of the century, reopening at Bretton Woods, at the stagflation of the seventies, at the rescues of 2008. Hayek answered with a defense

2. John Maynard Keynes, *The General Theory of Employment, Interest and Money* (London: Macmillan, 1936). For Mellon's "liquidate" counsel, Herbert Hoover, *Memoirs: The Great Depression, 1929–1941* (Macmillan, 1952), p. 30. For the Austrian rebuttal, Friedrich A. Hayek, *Prices and Production* (Routledge, 1931); Ludwig von Mises, *The Theory of Money and Credit* (1912; English ed. 1934).

of the price mechanism and, after the war, with *The Road to Serfdom*, the warning that a state which takes command of demand ends by commanding everything; Keynes had replied in advance that in the long run we are all dead, that an economy which waits for the self-correction leaves the living to starve in the meantime. Neither man was a hero in this account. Both were currents the period ran through, and the decade decided the first round between them not by the elegance of either argument but by the brute fact that the orders which left the slump to liquidate itself bred the regimes that nearly ended the world.

Beneath all of it, locking the international economy in a posture it could no longer sustain, was gold. The gold standard had been the disciplining faith of the prewar world, the invisible arbiter to which currencies bowed, and the statesmen of the prior decade had labored to rebuild it as one rebuilds a cathedral after a disaster, believing that the restoration of the form would restore the substance³ The form, as it happened, was a corpse.

The standard worked by a cruel automatism: a country losing gold, because it imported more than it sold or because foreigners were pulling their balances out, was required by the rules to raise interest rates and contract its money until wages and prices fell far enough to make its goods cheap and stem the outflow. In a boom that discipline was tolerable. In a depression it meant deliberately deepening the slump, raising the price of credit when the economy was strangling for want of it, choking output and employment at home to keep a fixed quantity of metal from leaving the vaults. One by one the governments learned that this was a sacrifice no electorate would forgive and no economy survive. Britain, the standard's historic guarantor, went off gold in September 1931; the Bank of England, defender of the pound for a century, simply could no longer defend it, and the act the City had regarded as unthinkable turned out, once done, to be survivable and even a relief. Country after country followed. The United States cut the dollar's tie in 1933 and then fixed gold at a higher price under the Gold Reserve Act of January 1934, devaluing the currency by official decree and voiding the gold clauses in private contracts⁴ The discovery was everywhere the same. The rule that everyone had treated as a law of nature had been a promise, and promises can be broken when keeping them costs more than breaking them. A guarantee that cannot be paid for is none at all, and when the most fundamental pledge an order makes, the convertibility of its money into metal, is abandoned in a season of panic, the abandonment teaches a lesson that travels far beyond the foreign-exchange desks. It teaches that the floor under collective belief can drop away, and that the men who maintained it will let it drop the moment it costs them too much. What replaced the single rail was not a successor order but a set of walls, managed currencies and exchange controls and currency blocs, and in Germany a system of bilateral clearing that turned trade itself into a leash on weaker partners. Money had been revealed as belief, and belief, with the gold pool gone, was now nationalized.

3. Barry Eichengreen, *Golden Fetters: The Gold Standard and the Great Depression, 1919–1939* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1992); Liaquat Ahamed, *Lords of Finance* (2009).

4. Executive Order 6102 (April 1933) and the Gold Reserve Act (January 1934); Eric Rauchway, *The Money Makers: How Roosevelt and Keynes Ended the Depression, Defeated Fascism, and Secured a Prosperous Peace* (Basic Books, 2015).

Charlie Chaplin had been watching what the same machinery did to the body, and on the fifth of February 1936 he answered it with *Modern Times*. He was the most famous performer alive and one of the last holdouts against synchronized sound, and the picture is in part a refusal: the Tramp does not speak, because Chaplin understood that a voice would individuate the figure and destroy his function as a body that anything could happen to. The film opens on a literal herd of sheep dissolving by cut into a crowd of workers pouring up from a subway, the equation made without a word, and then puts its little man on a factory line where the work is one convulsive gesture repeated until the gesture invades his nervous system and he goes on twitching with it after the belt has stopped. The most exact thing in the film is the apparatus of total management that surrounds the line: a screen on which the boss appears to bark orders into rooms where the worker thought himself unobserved, an automatic feeding machine wheeled in so that the lunch break itself can be abolished and the man kept at his station while a contraption shovels soup into him and a corncob spins against his teeth. Where Riefenstahl composes the collective body as redemption, Chaplin shows the body fed through the system as degradation, and the two are the same act read from opposite sides. What the comedy makes legible is the era's official promise that rationalized production would lift everyone into abundance. What the body keeps disclosing is that the rationalized process has no use for the person inside the worker, that it would feed him through itself like stock through a lathe if it could, and that the abundance it produces sits behind glass while the man who made it is marched off to jail for picking up a fallen red flag. The deepest formal stroke is the easiest to miss: nine years into the era of sound, Chaplin keeps his man essentially wordless, so the body and not the voice states the argument, and the comic persistence of those entrained movements after the line stops is the counter-myth in a single gesture, the irreducible empirical self the apparatus cannot fully entrain.

Against the manufactured collective body of the Nuremberg film, the decade produced its most complete refusal in a single mural-sized canvas, and the thing was made under conditions of commission and deadline. In January 1937 the government of the Spanish Republic, fighting a civil war it was slowly losing, asked Pablo Picasso for a large work for its pavilion at the international exposition opening in Paris that summer. The Republic understood the fair as a stage on which to assert its legitimacy before the watching democracies, and it knew that Picasso's name was itself a kind of currency. He took the commission and then, for months, had no real subject and no wish to make a political picture; he worked without urgency on sketches of an artist and a model in a studio, his perennial theme, nothing in them answerable to the war. What gave him the subject was a single afternoon of news. On the twenty-sixth of April 1937 the German Condor Legion, flying for Franco with Italian aircraft, bombed the Basque town of Guernica in relays over some three hours on a market day, a deliberate experiment in what the sustained aerial attack on a civilian center could accomplish and a demonstration to the future. Picasso read George Steer's

eyewitness dispatch, printed in the London and New York papers within two days, abandoned the studio idea, and began the canvas at the start of May, working through May and June in the long workroom on the Rue des Grands-Augustins, photographed at each stage by Dora Maar so that the painting's own evolution survives as a record of a mind under pressure. He stripped out every color. The finished work is black and white and grey, the palette of the newspaper photograph and the cinema newsreel that had brought the atrocity to him, and the refusal of color is the first thing the form says: this is not a scene witnessed but an image transmitted, the modern condition in which catastrophe arrives as a reproduction. Inside the grey there is no single vantage and no horizon, no place to stand. The bodies and the animals are flattened and overlapped and lit by a bare electric bulb drawn as a jagged eye, the screaming horse and the gored figures and the mother with her dead child arranged not in a narrative sequence the eye can follow but in a simultaneous shattering the eye cannot resolve into order. Where Riefenstahl's camera supplies a unifying consciousness that assembles the many into one, Picasso withholds exactly that. There is no rostrum, no rising crane, no organizing will. What the official war could not name, that the new weapon erased the line between the soldier and the woman at the market, that the bomber made the whole population a target and the entire landscape a front, erupts into the form as a refusal of the very wholeness the propaganda film manufactures. The two works mark the decade's opposite poles: a collective body assembled by the editing bench and presented as a found object on one side, and on the other a canvas that takes the mass the bombers had made into meat and refuses to let it cohere into anything a state could put to use.

That refusal had a correlate the artists could not have charted, which is that an attack flown to bomb a town as a message to the future was itself a product of the monetary disorder, because the chaos had fed the regimes that built the bombers. In Germany the destruction of money had come twice, the savings of the middle class annihilated first by the inflation of 1923 and then by the slump that called the American loans home and threw six million out of work. Germany had not been beaten in the field in 1918; its army surrendered because the generals feared revolution at home more than defeat abroad, having watched the Bolsheviks take Petrograd the year before in a country with a weaker industrial working class than Germany's own. Through the chaos that followed, the deepest fear of the army and the industrialists and the old conservative order was never the foreign enemy but the socialist and communist left, which in a ruined country was the largest movement in the land. The National Socialists were a violent fringe, 2.6 percent of the vote in 1928. What raised them toward the 37 percent they took in July 1932 was, above all, the slump that pauperized the middle class, and what made them respectable enough to govern was that the men of property chose to finance and shelter the fringe of the right precisely to break the strength of the left. This is the hidden hand of the period, and it is documented in the ledgers: the contributions from heavy industry and the great banks, the back-channel meetings, the petition of

bankers and industrialists urging Hindenburg to install Hitler, the calculation that a movement of street violence could be aimed at the unions and the Marxists and then put back in its box. The conservative establishment took up the movement as a weapon against the socialists and discovered too late that the blade had a will of its own. The property that feared expropriation paid to install the men who promised to crush the expropriators, and the men they installed turned out to serve no interest but their own.

When the conservatives around Hindenburg made Hitler chancellor in January 1933 they believed they were using a thing they could discard, and they made the characteristic error of those who think a movement built on perpetual expansion can be domesticated. Within eighteen months the parliament building had been gutted by arson, the enabling act had passed, the parties and unions and federal states were dissolved, and the murders of the summer of 1934 had fused party and state into a single will. The target the movement reached for had been installed centuries earlier. Medieval Christendom forbade Christians to lend at interest, and the rabbinic law forbade Jews from lending at interest to fellow Jews, so the loophole both traditions left open ran in one direction: a Christian could borrow from a Jew, and only a Jew could lend across the religious line without doctrinal cover. The arrangement pressed European Jews into the despised and indispensable function the prohibition left open, the management of money on terms neither community would touch internally, keeping them as both the financiers the economy could not run without and the scapegoat the Church kept ready to frighten the faithful. A nation economically destroyed, humiliated by a treaty that forced a confession of guilt it did not believe it bore alone, and frightened of revolution, reached for the figure a thousand years of inherited pattern had pre-positioned as the hidden hand behind both the rapacious capitalism and the threatening communism at once. The hatred was not a sudden eruption. It was the activation of a scapegoat the civilization had nursed, ready-made, for a very long time, and the eschatology the regime wrapped around it, the thousand-year Reich, the redemptive war of races, the final solution to a problem invented to need one, was the secular end-time turned into a license for murder. The myth was not decoration on the politics; it was what drove it.

In the Soviet Union the same will to force reality to match a doctrine produced its own ocean of death on a schedule set by theory rather than by economics. The collectivization of agriculture, driven through from 1929 with the liquidation of the kulaks as a class, was an attempt to force the countryside into a model of how history was supposed to proceed, and when the peasants of

Ukraine and the Kuban and Kazakhstan resisted, and when the grain quotas could not be met because the grain did not exist, the regime did not revise the model. It seized the grain anyway, sealed the borders of the starving regions, and let millions die in 1932 and 1933 in a famine the state both caused and denied. The denial is the tell. A movement defiant of reality cannot admit

that the world has refused it, and so the famine went officially unrecorded as it happened, the census that revealed the missing population was suppressed and its statisticians shot, and the terror turned next on the party itself in the show trials that consumed, by the late thirties, the very men who had made the revolution. The regime's official art codified the principle. Socialist realism, formalized as doctrine in 1934, did not depict the Soviet present. It depicted the Soviet future as though it had already arrived, the radiant harvest and the heroic worker rendered in a flawless illusionism that worked exactly as Riefenstahl's editing functioned, to manufacture a perception the facts did not supply and offer it back as the truth. The painting that showed a groaning table was made in a year of famine. The form's smooth competence was the lie, and the painters who could not produce the lie convincingly enough, or who let the present show through, were silenced along with the statisticians. Here too was the surest sign of an order that has begun to die, the flip from receiving the truth-teller as a useful warning to treating him as an enemy. A system that shoots the men who report the famine has severed the nerve by which a society feels reality and corrects, and a body that cannot feel that it is failing cannot stop.

The American answer to the same monetary collapse took a different shape, and the difference is the decade's most important negative case for any reading built to detect rot. The New Deal was an improvisation, not a design, a sequence of trials in which a government that had abandoned gold and could now print into the deflation tried experiment after experiment to put money back into circulation and people back to work. It was, in practice, the Keynesian wager made before the theory that justified it was finished, the state stepping in as the spender the private economy could no longer be, against the liquidationist counsel that would have let the slump run to the bottom. Some of it failed, some of it was struck down, and much of it contradicted the rest, and unemployment was still high at the decade's end. But the thing that mattered for the survival of the order was not the recovery, which was partial, but the demonstration that a democracy could reach for emergency power without forfeiting the capacity to be told it was wrong. The courts struck down its agencies; the press attacked the President daily; the elections went on. Among the experiments was a small photographic unit inside the Resettlement Administration, later folded into the Farm Security Administration, that hired photographers to document rural poverty so a comfortable public might be persuaded to fund relief. It was an arm of the state, paying photographers to make images that served a policy, no different in its bare mechanism from the apparatus that made the Nuremberg film. Both were governments manufacturing perception. The difference lies in the form the photographers were permitted to make, and in what their wills were allowed to serve.

In early March 1936 one of them, Dorothea Lange, was driving home from a month in the field, passed a sign that read PEA-PICKERS CAMP at Nipomo in California, and turned back. She made a handful of exposures of a destitute mother in a tent with her children, moving closer

5. Dorothea Lange, *Migrant Mother*, March 1936, near Nipomo, California; the Florence Owens Thompson identification surfaced in *The Modesto Bee*, November 18, 1978. On the photograph's later afterlife and the persistent gap between the subject and the use made of her likeness, Susan Sontag, *On Photography* (New York: Farrar, Straus and Giroux, 1977), pp. 1–24 and pp. 153–180.

with each frame, and drove on. The last of them, later called Migrant Mother, is the photograph against which the decade's manufactured collective bodies should be set, because it does the opposite of what they do. The state had paid for it to argue a general case, the case for relief, and an argument of that kind wants a type, a representative figure who stands for a class. What Lange's frame produces instead is an individual whose specific gravity cannot be absorbed back into any argument. The worn face, the hand at the chin, the two children turned away into her shoulders, refuse the viewer the satisfaction of either pity fully possessed or politics wholly served. The composition lifts the pyramid of a Madonna out of five centuries of sacred painting and sets it down in a roadside camp, and that borrowed shape is the act of will the unit imposed on the raw fact, misery dignified into an image that could move a mass toward compassion. Yet the form will not finally resolve into propaganda, because it keeps insisting on a single consciousness that exceeds the use the government meant to make of it. The point stands even though Lange's account of the encounter was probably embellished, though a retoucher cleaned a thumb from the negative's lower edge, and though the woman, identified decades later as Florence Owens Thompson, would say she and Lange barely spoke and that the photographer had taken something from her she never agreed to give⁵

That dispute does not weaken the image; it is the image's deepest subject, the gap between the person and the use made of her likeness, the same gap Riefenstahl's film exists to close and Lange's photograph cannot help preserving. An order that funds such images, and lets them be made by people free to find more than the brief asked for, has an error-correcting nerve that is still live. Seen from the long view at the decade's hinge near the end of the thirties, the American case was a power with its dynamism battered but intact, its openness damaged but functioning, its governance still recognizably consent-based even under emergency strain. The German and Soviet cases were orders that had crossed into coercion, that ruled by force because they could no longer rule by belief, and that had silenced or shot the people who might have corrected them. What no reading of pressures registers, and what the photograph sees, is the quality of a single consciousness that remains intact inside a battered order, the thing relief programs cannot quantify and propaganda cannot fake. A second limit shows in this decade. The German and Soviet marks of internal decay sit in the open archive, the suppressed census and the shot statistician, yet they understate what those regimes actually were, which was not orders falling into collapse but new orders taking root, a will-driven seizure of power that the signatures of decay do not capture.

Bertolt Brecht, in exile from the regime the Nuremberg film celebrated and writing in a wooden farmhouse outside Skovsbostrand on the Danish island of Funen, was building a theory of form designed to do deliberately what Lange's photograph did by accident, to keep the spectator a separate mind. He had watched audiences surrender to the stage the way the crowds did at the rallies, dissolving their judgment into the emotion the spectacle supplied, and he came to regard

that capitulation as the theatrical version of the political catastrophe. In an essay of 1936, written after he watched the Beijing opera master Mei Lanfang perform in Moscow with an entirely visible stagecraft that announced its own conventions and refused to disappear into them, he named the *Verfremdungseffekt*, the alienation effect: a set of techniques to break the illusion on purpose. The performer who shows the character rather than becoming it; the song that interrupts the scene; the placard that announces the outcome before the action so suspense cannot do its work of capture; the bare lamps left visible so the audience never forgets it sits in a theater watching a constructed thing. The aim was not to cool the work into a lecture but to return the viewer to the condition of someone who can still think, who watches the events on stage as alterable rather than fated and so might come to see his own world the same way. Brecht's theater is the formal antithesis of Riefenstahl's cinema, move for move. Where she hides the apparatus so the manufactured perception will be taken for reality, he exposes the machinery so the built perception cannot be mistaken for anything but a thing made by people and therefore changeable by people. He lived to test the discipline against his own situation. In October 1947 he was called before the House Un-American Activities Committee in Washington, the eleventh in a planned sequence of eleven hostile witnesses, and answered, in heavily accented English and with the manner of a man who had read his Brecht, that he had never been a member of the Communist Party. The committee thanked him for his cooperation. He flew to Zurich the next morning, never returned to the United States, and settled in the Soviet sector of Berlin to found the Berliner Ensemble. The governing creed in its political form demanded the dissolution of the separate judgment into the movement. The alienation effect was a discipline for keeping that judgment alive under exactly the pressure that asked it to dissolve.

Across the Atlantic the same pressure produced John Steinbeck, who spent the late thirties among the migrants moving west out of the wrecked farmland of the southern plains and turned what he saw into *The Grapes of Wrath*, published as the decade closed. The novel reaches for the collective at the very moment its individual family is being destroyed, and its formal device is the alternating chapter, the narrow story of the Joads set against wide interchapters that pull back to the whole migration, the turtle crossing the road, the used-car lots, the banks reconceived as monsters that must eat profit to live and so cannot stop foreclosing even when the men inside them wish to. The economic diagnosis embedded in the form is precise about the convergence that made the catastrophe: the dust that the plow and the drought together raised, the debt that the falling prices made unpayable, the tractor that did the work of a dozen families and put them on the road, the surplus of fruit deliberately destroyed to prop up its price while the people who picked it starved within sight of it. That last image, the oranges sprayed with kerosene and the pigs slaughtered and buried so the market would not break, is the decade's central obscenity rendered exact, full granaries beside empty stomachs, the system unable to explain why its own abundance

could not reach the people it was choking. Steinbeck's danger, the one Brecht would have flagged, is that the reach toward the collective can tip into a sentiment that asks a reader to dissolve into the people rather than to think about them, and the famous closing image, the starving man nursed at a stranger's breast, courts exactly that. The diagnosis underneath is hard and clear, and it lays the cause in a monetary and price mechanism that had lost the capacity to connect what was made to those who needed it.

These were the works that turned and faced the catastrophe. The decade also produced a powerful movement in the opposite direction, away from the wreckage and into worlds built deliberately apart from it. In an Oxford study a philologist who had survived the trenches of the first war was grading examination papers when he wrote, on a blank page a candidate had left, a sentence about a hole in the ground and a creature that lived in it. J.R.R. Tolkien did not know what the word he had invented meant, and the pursuit of an answer became *The Hobbit*, published in September 1937, and the success of that book led his publisher to ask within months for a sequel, so that by December he had begun the first chapter of a far larger story whose shape he did not yet know and would not finish for nearly two decades. His project across these years is the inverse of Riefenstahl's and yet shares one feature with it. Both build a total world. But Tolkien built his out of the materials a survivor of the first war wished the modern age had kept and a foreboding that the second was coming, an invented mythology with its own languages and histories and moral weather, a created cosmos in which the small and the overlooked defend the line and the will-to-power is the thing that corrupts. What his form preserves is the wish for a realm that has not been flattened by the machine and the market, a place with depth and enchantment and a moral order that endures, and what the work itself half-knows is that this world has to be wholly invented because the actual one had become unbearable to a particular sensibility under the particular pressures of the slump and the gathering war. The depth of the sub-created world is real, the languages worked out with a scholar's rigor over decades. The refuge it offered was an escape from a present the same author found he could not write about directly, and the ring that confers invisibility and corrupts its bearer is a meditation, made by a man who had seen industrial slaughter, on power that erases the self that wields it. It is the will-to-power myth of Nuremberg, recognized as evil and given a name and a story in which it must be refused rather than served.

The deepest thing the work knows, and the one that sets it most flatly against the rostrum at Nuremberg, is who it makes its hero. The propaganda film raised up the warrior and the leader, the body of the crowd gathered toward the one man on the platform, the aristocrat of the will. Tolkien put the weight of his story on a gardener. Samwise Gamgee bears the ring-bearer up the last mountain when the bearer can no longer walk, and the moral architecture of the whole long tale rests on the loyalty and the endurance of a servant whom the warrior-world would not have

counted. Tolkien knew what he was doing with the figure. Writing to his son Christopher in the last days of 1944, with the second war he had dreaded now in its fifth year and Christopher himself in uniform, he set down that Sam was the most closely drawn character in the long tale, the successor to Bilbo of the first story, the genuine hobbit, plainer and more interesting to him than the high-minded Frodo who had to be borne. He had named the source of the figure even more exactly. Sam, he wrote later, was a reflexion of the English soldier, of the privates and the batmen he had known in the war of 1914 and recognized as so far superior to himself. The batman was the soldier assigned to an officer to manage his kit and cook and clean for him, an enlisted servant who fought when the moment came, and the young lieutenant had been led onto the Somme by such men in 1916 and watched them endure what he was not sure he could endure himself. The true hero of the story is not the noble warrior but the humble servant, the ordinary loyal man the orders of rank place at the bottom, and the whole moral weight of the invented world is built to declare him superior to the masters above him. Against the aestheticized politics of the rally, which dissolved the ordinary man into a mass and offered him a leader to worship, Tolkien set a story in which the common man is the one who saves the world precisely by refusing the power that would have made him a master, by bearing his friend up and then handing the ring back rather than keeping it. The buried fact of the official cult of the will is that it despises the very people in whose name it claims to act, is answered by a fiction built entire to honor them.

The agony Harold Bloom would later name runs all through it: a strong maker takes the old northern matter, the sagas and the Beowulf he had spent his life teaching, and wrestles a new thing out of the precursor he loved, so that the dead epic returns as something a modern reader can inhabit. The wrestle is the work.

The most successful escape of all was manufactured for a mass audience and ran at industrial scale. On the twenty-first of December 1937, at the Carthay Circle Theatre on San Vicente Boulevard in Los Angeles, Walt Disney premiered *Snow White and the Seven Dwarfs*, the first feature-length cel-animated film. Disney had grown up the son of a failed Missouri farmer, had been pulled out of school at fourteen to deliver newspapers in the dark on a Kansas City route, had founded and lost his first studio at twenty-one to a New York distributor who took the rights to his original character Oswald the Lucky Rabbit, and had built the second one on a substitute mouse he sketched on a train heading back to California with nothing else to sell. The industry had called the new feature Disney's Folly while it was in production: a million-and-a-half-dollar gamble at a moment when no animated short had ever sustained an adult audience for more than ten minutes, financed by mortgaging the studio and personal property and by selling Bank of America on a sustained line of credit that Disney was forced to renew quarterly. The studio was rumored to be three weeks from insolvency when the film opened. The supervising animator of the prince, an Italian named Grim Natwick who had drawn Betty Boop, had to be taught to draw a man whose

hips did not jut, since the form had specialized in stylized women. The labor of seven hundred and fifty artists had been rationalized into a line of inkers and painters and in-betweeners as disciplined as any factory; a multiplane camera built in Burbank by Bill Garity gave the flat drawings the illusion of depth; the whole apparatus of mass production was turned to the manufacture of enchantment. It worked, and it became the most commercially successful sound film made to that point. The same rationalized industrial process Chaplin's Tramp was fed through, the same division of labor and measured motion, was here turned to producing a feature-length dream of refuge, the cottage in the woods, the animals that serve, the sleep from which a kiss will wake the dreamer into happiness. What the form secures is the wish for rescue, for a benign order in which danger is external and temporary and the right ending is assured, manufactured for a frightened public at the moment the actual world had guaranteed nothing. The work the splices perform is that the enchantment is an industrial product, made on a line, sold for a ticket, the consolation itself a commodity produced by the very machine whose pressures it offered relief from. It is the stagecraft of mass feeling again, now in its gentlest and most profitable form, the management of mass feeling sold as a story rather than as a creed, and the golden age of American animation that the film opened was a genuine flowering of a new art and at the same time a perfected technology of mass reassurance. Both things are true of it at once. Chaplin sat in the premiere audience that night beside Disney, the maker who had shown the line feeding the body watching the line turned to feed the dream. Three years later Disney's animators struck for a union.

The choreography of mass devotion had found, in these same years, an instrument more pervasive than the cinema screen and more intimate than the printed page. Radio in the nineteen-thirties was what no medium had been before it, a voice that arrived in the living room at the same moment in every house that owned a set, simultaneous and personal and invested with the authority of sound itself, and it gave the management of the mass mind the delivery system that Bernays's parades and staged photographs had lacked. A printed appeal could be folded away and argued with at leisure; the broadcast voice entered the ear with no interval in which a listener might weigh it against anything else, and it spoke to millions as though it addressed each one alone. Every order of the decade reached for it. Franklin Roosevelt, who took office in the worst month of the bank failures, went on the air within a week to explain in plain words why the banks had closed and why the solvent ones could safely reopen, and the fireside talks that followed steadied a frightened country by the sound of one calm voice taking ownership of the catastrophe, the same technique turned for once to steady a democracy's nerve rather than to dissolve it. The instrument served the demagogue as readily. Father Charles Coughlin, a priest broadcasting from a Detroit suburb, drew an audience of tens of millions to a populism that curdled across the decade into open sympathy for the European regimes and an antisemitism frank enough that he was at last forced from the air. And in Germany the regime that had filmed itself at Nuremberg pressed a

cheap receiver into the hands of its citizens, the Volksempfänger, the people's set, built to bring in the home stations and the leader's voice and little beyond them, so that the broadcast the ministry controlled would be the sound inside every German house. The voice in the living room was the decade's most powerful engine of manufactured perception, and its full reach had not been taken when an artwork measured it by accident.

The measurement came on the night of the thirtieth of October 1938, when a company of New York actors led by the twenty-three-year-old Orson Welles broadcast an adaptation of H. G. Wells's novel of a Martian invasion over the Columbia network and built it not as a play but as a counterfeit of the very form the decade had been taught to trust. After a brief framing announcement the program abandoned the conventions of drama and presented itself as an ordinary evening of dance music broken, again and again, by bulletins of mounting alarm: an announcer cutting in with reports of explosions observed on Mars, then of a cylinder fallen at Grover's Mill in New Jersey, then of a thing emerging from it, a heat-ray, the state militia destroyed, the authorities pleading for calm, the advance on New York, all of it delivered in the cadence of the on-the-scene reporter and the expert at the microphone and the official voice that a decade of real emergency had trained the public to receive as the sound of the real. A listener who had missed the framing and turned the dial in late heard what was indistinguishable from the end of the world reported as it happened.

What gave the broadcast its force was not its content but its perfect mimicry of the authoritative voice, and in that imitation it made plain the fantasy on which the medium ran, that the bulletin was a clear window onto the world, while disclosing the truth that authority depended on never naming, that the public had already surrendered to the voice in the home the power to say what was real, so that an exact enough counterfeit of the news simply was the news for as long as it spoke. The newspapers the next morning reported a nation thrown into panic, the highways clogged with people in flight and the switchboards overwhelmed, and the legend of the night the radio terrified America entered the culture and has never left it. The panic was almost certainly far smaller than the legend that grew from it, and the tale had an interested author, for the newspaper industry had spent the decade watching radio draw off the advertising revenue on which the press depended, and it had every motive to paint its rival as reckless, amplifying a handful of frightened calls into a national hysteria and manufacturing the very proof of radio's danger it wished the public to accept. How many people truly believed the broadcast and acted on the belief the surviving evidence does not reliably show. What the night demonstrated was real whatever the true size of the fright, that a single voice, pitched in the right register into enough homes at once, could overwrite the reality of an unknown multitude for the length of an hour. And the demonstration was a parlor trick beside what the same instrument was doing in earnest an ocean away. The German radio that had broadcast the Nuremberg liturgy had marshaled the crowds of the

Anschluss that spring, and ten days after Welles frightened New Jersey it would report as triumph the pogrom in which the regime's men shattered and looted the shops and synagogues of the Jews across the Reich, the night the state named for the broken glass. Welles had shown, as an accident of the theater, what Goebbels had built a ministry to do on purpose, that the voice in the living room could manufacture a reality and move a people about inside it, and the only difference between the prank and the catastrophe was that the one confessed itself a fiction when the hour ended and the other never would.

The through-line beneath every one of these works was that the powers which had won the last war and built the order after it could no longer back their own commitments, and the art of the decade registered, in form after form, the consequences of a guarantee that will not be honored.

Britain was financially exhausted and strategically overstretched, its empire by now a set of liabilities masquerading as assets; France was demographically hollowed by the previous war's dead and politically paralyzed by the chronic instability of its republic, its army built behind concrete for a defensive war it hoped never to fight. Neither had the will to act, and both knew it, and what they knew shaped everything. When Japan's Kwantung Army seized Manchuria in 1931, the periphery moving faster than the cabinet that nominally commanded it, the League of Nations deliberated, found against Japan in measured language in 1933, and watched Japan walk out of the League and keep the province. The guarantee had been tested and not honored, and everyone watching in Berlin and Rome drew the lesson, because a reputation is the cheapest of powers to maintain and the most catastrophic to lose, costing nothing until the day it is tried and on that day found to have been the whole of one's strength.

When Germany reoccupied the Rhineland in 1936 in plain violation of treaty, Hitler's own generals braced to retreat at the first French shot, there was no French shot. The Spanish war that gave Picasso his subject was the new order tried out in miniature, the German and Italian aircraft and armor sent to Franco and the Soviet advisers and purges exported to the Republic, all rehearsing on Spanish ground while the democracies committed themselves to a non-intervention that in practice denied arms to the legal government while its enemies were openly supplied, a refusal to act dressed as a policy. Guernica was not only an atrocity but a demonstration, the bomber revealed as the weapon that would make the next war total, and the democracies learned to fear that war and to invoke the fear at every subsequent crisis. In March 1938 the German army crossed into Austria and was met not with resistance but with crowds, the country of Hitler's birth absorbed into the Reich in a matter of days and the absorption ratified the next month by a plebiscite from which the Jews were barred and which returned, under the eyes of the new police, a figure above ninety-nine percent. The arrests began at once, the Jews of Vienna driven into the streets and made to scrub the pavements on their knees while their neighbors watched and laughed,

a city that had rejected one painter now offering up its oldest community to the regime he had built; within two years the property had been seized and the deportations begun. No power lifted a hand. The Anschluss had been forbidden by the treaties that closed the first war, and the prohibition proved to be one more guarantee that dissolved on contact with a state willing to test it. Six months later, when the governments handed Hitler the German-speaking borderland of Czechoslovakia at Munich in 1938 without the Czechs in the room, the relief in London was genuine, and that relief was the disease, because what the meeting proved was not that war could be avoided but that the guarantees of the declining powers were void. A man who has won such a bet does not stop betting. He took the rest of Czechoslovakia in the spring of 1939, destroying the last fiction that his aims were the recovery of his own people, and the British guarantee then extended to Poland came from a power that had just demonstrated its guarantees could be ignored. The order that might have underwritten a different outcome was not ready: the United States, alone in possessing the latent industrial weight to do it, had legislated itself into neutrality, the capacity present and the will absent. The gap between the old guarantors who could no longer enforce and the new one who would not yet step forward was the void into which the regimes poured, and the prerequisites of the second great war were complete before a shot in it was fired, laid down across a decade in which a monetary collapse had been allowed to feed a political one. In the last week of

August 1939 Berlin and Moscow, the two regimes whose myths had each announced they could never compromise, signed a pact that partitioned Poland on paper, the will signing a contract with the dialectic, and on the first of September the German armies crossed the frontier.

The orders that made the decade's catastrophe are gone, and most of them went quickly; the thousand-year Reich the Nuremberg film celebrated lasted twelve. What survived is the work, and it came through in a divided way. *Triumph of the Will* survives as the permanent demonstration of how the image manufactures a collective body and sells it back to a people as their own soul, studied now precisely so the method can be recognized when it returns in other forms, its beauty and its menace inseparable on the screen. The will it was made to celebrate is gone; the proof of that will's dependence on a hundred technicians and an elevator built into a flagpole is what endures. Against it *Guernica* survives as the permanent refusal of that wholeness, the grey shattered field no state can use, withheld by the painter's own instruction from returning to Spain until liberty did, moved from country to country and home at last only after the regime it indicted was gone, still the most exact image anyone made of what the new weapon did to the line between the soldier and everyone else. Chaplin's body still twitches with the rhythm of the line that invaded it. Lange's mother still preserves the gap between the person and the use made of her likeness, the gap her subject spent decades protesting. Brecht's lamps are still left visible so the spectator cannot forget the thing on the stage was made. Steinbeck's oranges still rot in kerosene beside the hungry. And the invented worlds endure alongside the works that faced the catastrophe rather than in

opposition to them: Tolkien's invented cosmos, begun on a blank examination page and continued across the war that was coming, still offers its depth and its warning about power that erases the self, and still sets a gardener modeled on a soldier's servant above the masters of the will. Disney's manufactured enchantment still runs, the industrial dream of rescue produced on a line for a frightened public and still purchased, ticket by ticket, by publics frightened in newer ways. The argument between Keynes and the liquidationists, which the decade tested and did not settle, would be rebuilt into the order made at Bretton Woods and then torn down again a generation later, and it runs unbroken to the present. Each of these is a form one consciousness made from the particular pressure of an order whose money had stopped meaning what it promised, and each outlived the order it indicted. What the decade finally shows, across the surrender on the rostrum and the refusal on the canvas alike, is that the collective body is always a thing made, by an editing bench or a doctrine or a printing press, and that the work which lasts is the one in which a single mind declined to be assembled into it.

The defining innovation of the 1930s was not merely the rise of the dictator, but the refinement of the deep state's immune system: the secret-police incubation of extremists. Security apparatuses discovered the utility of funding and sheltering fringe radical movements, acting as invisible sponsors to steer these groups. By incubating the very threats they were publicly sworn to fight, the secret police justified their own expansion and preemptively neutralized organic political opposition.

1940 – 1949

In a city the besiegers meant to starve into the ground, an orchestra that no longer existed assembled itself to play a symphony written for one twice its size. By the summer of 1942 the Leningrad Radio Orchestra had fallen from forty players to fourteen or fifteen still alive in the city; the rest had starved or gone to the front. The score that Dmitri Shostakovich had begun in the first weeks of the siege and finished after his evacuation to Kuibyshev in the autumn of 1941 called for a hundred. Karl Eliasberg, the conductor, who had survived the first winter on a daily ration of one hundred and twenty-five grams of bread and had to be fed by his wife from her own ration to be lifted from his bed each morning, was given a military order to find the missing eighty-five among the soldiers manning the line, and the men were pulled off the front to play trumpets. They collapsed at rehearsal; three died before the concert. On the ninth of August 1942 the Seventh Symphony was performed in the Philharmonic Hall and broadcast through the city's loudspeakers, then turned outward, aimed across the German positions ringing the city. A Soviet artillery operation code-named Squall had fired three thousand shells the hour before to silence the enemy guns for the duration. One German lieutenant later recalled that he listened over the line in his bunker to a symphony of heroes and understood, in that hour, that the city would not be taken.

The piece is a problem before it is a triumph. Its long first movement is built on a banal march tune that repeats and swells through eleven variations, more mechanical and more menacing with each pass until it fills the hall. Shostakovich called the symphony a work about the city he loved and a protest against fascism, the obvious reading the Soviet state required and then sold to its allies. The microfilm of the score was flown out by Catalina flying boat through Tehran and Cairo to New York, where Toscanini conducted the American premiere on NBC radio in July 1942 from a CBS studio in Manhattan; the work was performed across the United States more than sixty times in a single wartime season, the proof in sound that the Soviet people would not break. But Shostakovich had survived 1936, when an editorial in Pravda titled "Muddle Instead of Music" had appeared after Stalin walked out of his opera *Lady Macbeth of the Mtsensk District*; the composer had then slept with a packed bag by the door of his Leningrad apartment, waiting for the NKVD, his withdrawn Fourth Symphony hidden in a friend's flat for the next twenty-five years. A man taught that the marching tune is the thing that comes for him in the night does not write an innocent march. The thing the official program could not name is that the grinding, faceless theme of advance is not German at all. It is the sound of any total order on the move, and a Soviet audience that had lived through the purges heard, under the patriotic surface, the tread of their own state. The form admits both readings at once and surrenders to neither, which is why it outlived the use the state made of it. The siege it was broadcast into killed something on the order of a million people, more than the United States and Britain lost in the whole war combined, a scale the

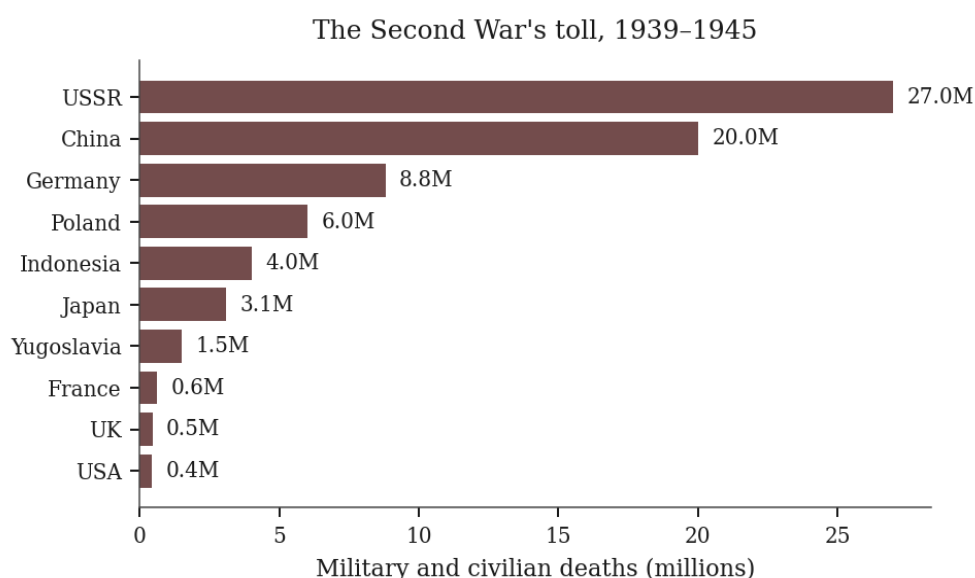
Western memory of the war never quite registers in frame.

The war the new monetary order was built to follow was decided in the East and financed from across an ocean, and the conditions that produced it were laid a generation earlier and never resolved. The settlement of 1919 had stripped Germany of territory and burdened it with reparations without breaking its industrial core, leaving a power humiliated rather than dismantled, the most dangerous kind. The gold-exchange order rebuilt in the 1920s had been a cathedral raised over a fault line, and when the Depression cracked it the nations went off gold one after another, walling themselves into currency blocs that turned trade into a weapon. A world that cannot settle its accounts in a common money settles them another way. Appeasement was the last precondition, the willingness of exhausted creditor empires to concede rather than spend.

France in 1940 had more tanks than Germany and an army that had bled the Kaiser white a generation before, and it collapsed in six weeks. What it lacked was not capability but the will to spend itself again at Verdun's price. German armor drove through the Ardennes, the wooded country the French command had judged impassable to tanks and left thinly defended, crossed the Meuse at Sedan, and turned the whole northern front before the defenders had grasped the shape of the attack. The British army was pinned against the Channel and lifted off the beaches at Dunkirk by a fleet of warships and fishing boats and pleasure craft; the guarantees the whole Versailles architecture rested on did not erode so much as cease to be honored, the web going slack at once, and the continent learned the paper had never been the thing. Britain stood on alone with almost nothing to win with, its strategy refusal rather than victory. Through the summer and autumn of 1940 the German air force tried to break it from the sky, and the fighter squadrons over southern England endured, by the narrowest of margins, against an enemy who could not afford a long contest and got one. What that refusal purchased was the interval in which two larger forces were drawn in.

The first was Russian. The German invasion of June 1941 ran the largest concentration of force ever assembled across a frontier, more than three million men along a line from the Baltic to the Black Sea, and in the opening months it nearly worked. The encirclements at Minsk and Smolensk and Kiev swallowed Soviet armies whole, hundreds of thousands of prisoners taken in single operations, and the panzer spearheads came within sight of Moscow as the first snow fell. It was not enough, because the thing it was spent against did not run out. The Soviet state moved its factories east of the Urals on flatcars and went on building tanks beyond the reach of any bomber, absorbed losses that would have broken any other society, and answered catastrophe with more bodies and more steel. The winter of 1941 froze the German advance short of the capital; the following summer the offensive turned south toward the oil of the Caucasus and the city on the Volga that wore Stalin's name. Stalingrad over the winter of 1942 and 1943 was the hinge of the

war, a battle fought room by room, cellar by cellar in a city pounded to rubble, where a German army of a quarter million was surrounded by a Soviet counterstroke that closed behind it across the frozen steppe and was ground down through the cold until the survivors, perhaps ninety thousand of the three hundred thousand encircled, marched into a captivity from which few came back. It was won by the side willing to die in greater numbers in one ruined city than the other could conceive of losing. Four of every five German soldiers who died in the war died in the East, and the Western landings, when they came in Normandy in June 1944, arrived to finish a verdict substantially written in Russian blood.



The Second War's toll, 1939–1945: military and civilian deaths by country, the scale Western memory does not register in frame. Source: standard historical estimates.

The second force entered when Japanese carriers struck Pearl Harbor in December 1941 and resolved the one question that had kept the deciding power offstage. The United States was already the arsenal, and how it became so shows the transfer of primacy in the ledgers before any battlefield. When Britain came for arms before Lend-Lease passed, it came as a cash customer, made to pay in gold and to sell its corporate holdings on American soil, with an American warship sent to Cape Town to collect British bullion. A power that lives on the income of past accumulation rather than present production is strong until the bill must be paid in cash, and then learns how thin the margin between solvency and dependence has become. Britain crossed that line in the war's first year and never crossed back. What America brought was a scale of production that changed the planet's arithmetic, a Liberty ship coming off the ways in days rather than months by 1944, a machine that out-produced all the Axis powers together while it fed allies on three continents and fought a second war across the breadth of the Pacific, island by island,

toward the home waters of Japan. The debtor of 1914 had become the maker of the war's matériel and, in the same motion, of the order that would follow it. The terms attached to British survival were written by men who knew that a creditor who liquidates his debtor's assets while rescuing him acquires the man's empire by other means, and they wrote them so.

A second account of the war runs alongside the documented one, and its core stands even where one specific attribution cannot be settled. So read, the war was not a thing that merely happened to the Soviet Union; it was a board on which one player thought in planets while the others reasoned in their own corners, and the planetary thinker converted a doomed position into half the earth. Run the position back to the middle of the 1930s. The Soviet state should not have survived: poor, isolated, its officer corps shot in the purges, its peasantry starved by the millions, ringed by four capitalist powers that regarded communism not as a foreign rival but as an infection already loose inside their own bodies, a thing to be cut out. By every measure of capability the encircled, purge-wracked piece should have come off the table. It ended the war as one of the two masters of the world. A reversal that large is not luck. The actor who thinks in planets enjoys a built-in advantage over the actors who think in provinces, and communism gave its center exactly that vantage, because it was an international movement and therefore a planetary intelligence network with sympathizers and informants inside every general staff and treasury that mattered. From that vantage one could see what the men in London and Washington and Berlin could not from theirs: that American industrial weight, once committed, would decide the war, and that the one outcome the Soviet center could not survive was that weight turned against it. The course that follows from seeing the whole board is the one the war took. The danger of American hostility was disarmed not with armies but with friendship, the genial Uncle Joe manufactured for the American press and the American newsreel, until it became politically unthinkable in Washington to treat the Soviet Union as the enemy its own generals would, within two years of victory, wish bitterly it had treated as one. The two predatory neighbors, Germany and the capitalist West, were maneuvered into spending themselves against each other while the encircled power, the weakest of the lot on paper, emerged in command of Eastern Europe and a continental sphere. Who gained from the war is no mystery; the only open question is by how much design.

That question is narrow, and it concerns one man's interior, not the larger order. The surviving evidence sets down a sequence stranger than any clean fable of foresight: Stalin signed a pact with Hitler in 1939 that bought time and territory; Soviet intelligence warned him of the coming invasion and he refused the warnings, so that the attack of June 1941 caught his armies unready and very nearly destroyed them. He vanished from public view for days in the first shock; the friendship with Roosevelt was real diplomacy conducted by a regime fighting for its life on American supply. Read on the inference, however, a colder shape sits inside the same sequence. The only scenario in which Stalin came out of the war alive was one in which Germany

overextended itself far enough east to need a second front and was therefore worth opening one for. A Soviet defeat too quick would have ended his state before the Americans were drawn in; a Soviet defense too brisk would have left Hitler the option of a settlement on his western flank and the United States the option of staying home. The middle course, an absorbed German army bleeding out across two thousand miles of frozen ground while Roosevelt was talked into seeing his own interests in saving the Russians, was the only one whose outcome was the Yalta map. Whether Stalin chose that course or stumbled into it through panic and supply-line necessity, the archive does not say; the planetary intelligence of the international movement around him supplied the framing within which the answer was the same. The archive cannot tell which eye the man kept behind the mustache, whether the planetary vision was his deliberate design or whether terror and improvisation did some of the work hindsight reads as foresight. The machinery that produced the result does not depend on the answer. A global imagination beats a provincial one whether or not the man possessing it could name what he possessed; an order built to read every board at once converts encirclement into empire whoever happens to sit at its head; the contestant the others have written off as the weakest is the player to watch when he is the only one thinking in planets. The weakest piece on the table in 1936 ended the war commanding half the earth, and the law that explains the reversal applies forward by decades, into any later heir who thinks in planets while his rivals quarrel over their corners.

What the heartland did while the fronts moved is the decade's abyss. The Nazi regime, having defined its existence around the elimination of the Jews, drove the project to its industrial conclusion: the ghettos sealed and starved, the shootings in the pits at Babi Yar and across the occupied East where killing squads worked town by town, the death camps built for nothing but murder at Auschwitz and Treblinka and Sobibor and Belzec, the cattle cars, the selections on the ramp, the gas and the ovens, the murder of roughly six million Jews and millions of others marked for destruction. None of it was a means to a strategic end; in its final phase it consumed trains and men and steel the collapsing front desperately needed, the transports to the camps given priority over reinforcements to a dying army. A scapegoat the previous decade had reached for as a way to name the author of a humiliated nation's ruin was pursued past the point where it explained anything, beyond the line where the murder cost the regime its own survival, until it stopped being an instrument and became the end itself. The old figure of persecution was fused to an eschatology of purification, and the fusion is what made the slaughter total: the inherited target supplied the enemy and the last-things faith granted the unlimited license. What drives the century's worst movements is not greed or even power but the conviction, material and eschatological at once, that history climbs toward a final settlement which one's own hands are appointed to deliver, against an enemy the culture had marked out long before anyone now living chose it. The end-times conviction is what converts a grievance into a program of murder pursued at a loss, and the murder

ran on after every strategic argument for it had been exhausted, because the conviction did not need a strategy.

That event broke something in the relation of art to its material, and the break is the decade's central artistic fact. Theodor Adorno, who would later write that to compose poetry after Auschwitz was barbaric, a sentence from an essay of the war's aftermath that he spent years qualifying without quite withdrawing, was at that moment in exile in Los Angeles, writing with Max Horkheimer a book that circulated in 1944 as *Philosophical Fragments* and appeared in 1947 as *Dialectic of Enlightenment*. Its most cited chapter named the culture industry, composed within sight of the Hollywood that produced *Casablanca*, by two German Jews whom the European catastrophe had driven to the edge of the Pacific. Their argument was that mass culture under industrial capitalism had become a machine for the manufacture of consent, turning out standardized pleasures that taught the consumer to want what the system could supply. The predictable resolution of a popular song, the certainty that the loose ends will be tied, was itself the ideology: the work trained its audience to expect that the world would resolve too. Read as Žižek reads ideology, the culture industry is where a society's fantasy of its own harmony takes form, and the two exiles had grasped, from the displaced position of men whose continent had just shown where managed mass feeling could lead, that the smiling product and the marching column were nearer to each other than either would admit. This is the Bernays insight of the 1920s extended to its industrial scale and read back as horror: the engineering of consent, which Bernays in those very years would name and sell as a service, is in Adorno's account not a technique among others but the operating principle of the whole entertainment industry.

The picture they lived beside makes the argument and exceeds it. *Casablanca* had its premiere at the Hollywood Theater in New York on Thanksgiving night, the twenty-sixth of November 1942, rushed out to ride the publicity of the Allied landings in North Africa eighteen days earlier. It was made on the Burbank lot of Warner Brothers by a studio running on contract labor and a shooting script that the Epstein brothers and Howard Koch were still rewriting on the day each scene was shot. The cast did not know how the picture would end until Bogart filmed the airport farewell, and the producer Hal Wallis composed the final line, "the beginning of a beautiful friendship," in dub more than a month after principal photography wrapped. It is the culture industry in Adorno's exact sense, assembled to a formula with a satisfying shape even where it withholds, at the close, the lovers' reunion. Its fantasy is the conversion of American reluctance into American virtue: a man who insists he sticks his neck out for nobody is brought, by love and by the sight of refugees who sing against their occupiers, to sacrifice and to the war. The Marseillaise scene was filmed with most of the bit players actually weeping. The refugees on screen were played in large part by the real thing, émigrés who had fled the regime the film opposed, whose accents were real and whose terror had been real. Of the seventy-five credited

actors, all but a handful were foreign-born, many of them refugees from the Reich; Helmut Dantine, who plays the young Bulgarian husband, had spent three months in a concentration camp outside Vienna before his parents bought him out; Madeleine Lebeau, who plays Yvonne and weeps her way through the Marseillaise, had fled Paris with her husband Marcel Dalio days before the Germans entered; S. Z. Sakall, the rotund headwaiter Carl, had escaped Budapest leaving three sisters who would die in Auschwitz. Conrad Veidt, who plays the Nazi major Strasser with chilling precision, had fled Germany because his wife was Jewish and he would not work for the new state; he had a contract clause requiring that he be paid more than any Allied actor in any film in which he played the enemy, the émigré's revenge written into the studio paperwork. He died of a heart attack on a golf course in Hollywood four months after the picture opened. The film does not know that this is its deepest content. By 1942 the displaced European had become the raw material of American culture.

The decade's most exact reading of American power came not from the émigrés but from a twenty-five-year-old who had been handed an unprecedented contract by RKO, and it came in the year before the United States entered the war. The contract was the work of a studio executive named George Schaefer, who needed a hit and gave Welles, fresh off the panic he had induced with his *War of the Worlds* broadcast on Halloween night 1938, complete creative control and final cut, terms no major studio had ever extended to a first-time director. *Citizen Kane* reached the screen on the first of May 1941, and Welles built it as a man assembles an indictment, around a publishing magnate who is unmistakably William Randolph Hearst, the proprietor of a press empire that manufactured the public mind for profit. Hearst understood the threat at once. His mistress, the actress Marion Davies, had recognized herself in the picture's brutal portrait of Kane's second wife. Hearst turned his newspapers against the film, barred them from running its advertisements, and leaned on Louis B. Mayer to lead a consortium of studio bosses in offering RKO eight hundred and forty-two thousand dollars in cash, a sum exceeding the film's negative cost, to buy and destroy the negative. RKO refused but limited the release: the major theater chains owned by Hearst's allies declined to book the picture, and it had to open in second-run houses and ran a loss of one hundred and sixty thousand dollars on first release. The campaign did not kill the film but it crippled the career: Welles never again had a studio contract on terms he could control. What Hearst saw, and what the form of the picture makes plain, is that it is a study of the man who owns the machinery of consent and is hollowed out by what he owns. The whole film is built around a missing word, *Rosebud*, and a reporter's failure to find what it means, so that the form itself enacts the claim that a life arranged around the accumulation and broadcasting of images has no recoverable interior, only the fragments other people remember. Welles and his cinematographer Gregg Toland, who had pioneered deep-focus technique on John Ford's *The Long Voyage Home* the year before and asked to shoot the new picture in order to push the

method further, kept every plane of the frame in equal sharpness, so that the foreground and the far background compete for the eye and no single thing is allowed to dominate, the image refusing to tell the viewer where to look the way Kane's newspapers told a nation what to think. The American faith on display here is that a self can be built without limit out of money and will and publicity; the buried truth that erupts through the deep-focus frame is that he who masters the manufacture of public belief masters everyone except himself, and dies surrounded by purchased objects, alone, calling for a childhood sled. The country that was about to become the arsenal of the world produced, in the same year, the most penetrating picture of what its own machinery of persuasion does to the man who runs it. Welles died of a heart attack at his typewriter on the night of the ninth of October 1985, alone in his Hollywood bungalow, at seventy, having spent his last decades unable to find the financing to finish his films.

The displacement that filled the Hollywood lot also remade the visual art of the century, and it did so where a reading of slow rot is blind. Through the late 1930s and into the war, the painters and theorists of European modernism crossed to New York to escape the regimes that had branded their work degenerate, and they arrived in a city with money and no tradition of its own to defend. The Surrealists came, with their doctrine that the picture should be drawn from the unconscious rather than the eye; Hans Hofmann came and taught; a generation of American painters who had spent the Depression on federal mural projects, painting social uplift for the state, found themselves in rooms with the inheritors of Cubism and automatism. Out of that contact, by 1947, Jackson Pollock laid his canvas on the floor and stopped touching it with the brush, pouring and flinging enamel in trajectories that recorded the motion of his whole body, an image with no subject and no center, no up or down, the European demand that art come from the interior pushed past any remaining figure. Clement Greenberg built a theory around it: that the painting should refer to nothing outside its own flatness. What the work registered, without intending to, was the arrival in New York of an authority it had not earned and could not yet name. The center of the modern image had crossed the Atlantic in the luggage of refugees, the way the seat of money was moving in the same years, and the new American painting was the first art made on the assumption that the metropolis of the form was now here. A reading at the horizon of decades sees productive strength and an open society and an economy that out-produces the world; it has no place for the migration of a civilization's aesthetic authority from a ruined continent to a rising one, which the canvas on the floor announces before the institutions catch up. The institutions caught up soon enough, and not by accident: within a few years the new American painting would be moved through Europe by exhibitions quietly underwritten by the organs of the American state, the abstract canvas enlisted as proof that the free world made free art, the first sign of a soft-power campaign the next decade would run in earnest. The same New York that made Pollock famous was already making the conditions for Warhol. The art Pollock made was the singular gesture of

one body, but the market the war built around it was a reproduction machine: a glossy magazine industry, a wire-photo network, a publicity apparatus that turned a single picture in a single barn into a face in every drugstore in the country. Life magazine ran its profile on Pollock in August 1949 and asked, on the cover, whether he was the greatest living painter in the United States; the answer mattered less than that the question was posed in three million copies and reached a public that would never see the canvas. The publicity apparatus already worked on the picture before the picture worked on the public, and the lesson was inside the city for a young commercial illustrator named Andrew Warhola, who in the same years was beginning to draw shoes for I. Miller on a Manhattan freelance schedule and was watching, closely, how a single artist became a mass image. The line from the splatter in the barn to the silkscreened soup can a decade later runs through the Life cover. Warhol's precursors in the 1940s were not other painters; they were the printing presses and the photo agencies that turned the painter into a brand on the way to the gallery.

The limit case stands at the edge of what art could do at all. Paul Antschel, born to a German-speaking Jewish family in Czernowitz in 1920 in what was then the eastern edge of Romania, was twenty when the Red Army took the city in June 1940 and twenty-one when Romania, an Axis ally, took it back the next summer with German help and began the deportations. His parents were sent to a camp in Transnistria in June 1942. He had spent the night before they were taken in a friend's house, urging them to flee and being refused; he never forgave himself. His mother was shot at the labor camp at Mikhailovka the next winter when she was no longer fit to work. His father died of typhus in the same camp. Paul, conscripted into a Romanian forced-labor brigade, survived the war shoveling debris and digging in the Tatar mountains, and after liberation made his way to Bucharest, where he took the new name Celan, an anagram of his Romanian surname Ancel. In late 1944 or early 1945 he wrote the poem that came to be called *Todesfuge*, *Death Fugue*. It does the thing Adorno called barbaric and does it in the one way that answers him: it sets the routine of the death camp, the forced labor and the smoke and the black milk the prisoners are made to drink at dawn, into the contrapuntal architecture of a musical fugue, the most ordered form the German tradition possessed, so that the highest achievement of the murderers' own culture is made to deliver the testimony of what they did. A blue-eyed master writes to Germany and plays with the snakes and orders the prisoners to dig their graves; the German Margarete and the Jewish Shulamith are braided through the lines in the voice-against-voice of the form. The poem is unbearable because it is beautiful, and its beauty is the accusation: it demonstrates that the camps were administered by the same civilization that produced the fugue, that culture and the murder of it were not opposites but neighbors. Celan spent the rest of his life recoiling from the very lyricism that made the poem famous, refusing to allow it to be set to music or anthologized in school readers, stripping his later work toward silence, as if representation itself were compromised and the only honest direction were down, toward the

broken word and the blank. He drowned himself in the Seine in late April 1970, weighting his pockets with stones; his body was recovered downstream a week later. What the postwar order needed not to see, that the Western tradition contained within itself the capacity that produced Auschwitz, erupts through the most refined form the inheritance offered, and the maker who let it erupt could not afterward live easily with what he had made legible.

While the artists registered the break, the new hegemon built the peace before the war was over. In July 1944, with the armies still locked on both fronts, delegates from forty-four nations met at a hotel in Bretton Woods, New Hampshire, and spent three weeks designing the financial architecture of the world to come¹ There were two plans on the table, and they were not equal. John Maynard Keynes, leading the British delegation, proposed an International Clearing Union built around a supranational reserve money he called *bancor*, a system whose deepest feature was that it would have penalized the creditor as well as the debtor, forcing the great surplus nation to recycle its surpluses or be charged for hoarding them² The great surplus nation was the United States, and the United States would not have it. Harry Dexter White, the Treasury official who ran the American side, brought a plan that put the dollar at the center, fixed to gold at thirty-five dollars an ounce with every other currency pegged to the dollar, and seated the new Fund and Bank in Washington weighted by American capital and the American vote. White's plan won on every point that mattered, because the man who owns the gold and feeds the allies writes the rules, and Keynes went home with a few transition periods and the knowledge that the rail he had spent his life theorizing would be laid by someone else. For a century the global system had run on a rail laid in London, sterling and the gold behind it, the mechanism by which the British Empire had financed and disciplined world trade. That rail was broken now, its keeper insolvent. The new power did not seize the old rail; it built a better one and let the old one fall into disuse, so that the transfer of monetary sovereignty wore the clothes of cooperation among forty-four nations and was in fact the decision of one. The pound's century ended not with a default but with an obsolescence arranged at a resort hotel, on terms its own most brilliant economist could not move.

The order built there was Keynesian in its bones, and the irony is exact: Keynes lost the negotiation and won the century. The system of managed exchange rates, of a fund that lent to deficit nations to spare them the brutal liquidation the gold standard had forced, of states empowered to run deficits and steer demand rather than stand aside while the market cleared, was the institutional form of the argument Keynes had made against the liquidationists through the Depression and stated whole in *The General Theory* of 1936. The state would be the spender of last resort, the manager of demand, the guarantor that mass unemployment need never again be endured as a natural law. Against that order, in the same year the hotel met, stood a small book that read the whole project as the first step onto a road. Friedrich Hayek published *The Road to Serfdom* in 1944, in Britain that spring and in America that autumn, and its claim was that the

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1. Articles of Agreement of the International Monetary Fund, July 22, 1944; Benn Steil, *The Battle of Bretton Woods: John Maynard Keynes, Harry Dexter White, and the Making of a New World Order* (Princeton, 2013).
 2. J. M. Keynes, "Proposals for an International Clearing Union," Cmd. 6437 (April 1943); reprinted in Keynes, *Collected Writings*, vol. XXV, ed. Donald Moggridge (Macmillan, 1980).

central plans the age had embraced as rescue were the embryo of tyranny, that every grant of economic control to the state narrowed the space in which a free people could correct its rulers, and that the managed economies of the democracies differed from the totalitarian ones in degree and not in kind. To the men building Bretton Woods this was the voice of the past, a warning against the very tools that had pulled the West out of the Depression and were winning the war. To

Hayek the cycle was the hangover from credit the authorities themselves created, and the cure could only be liquidation honestly borne, never the further intervention that postponed the reckoning and enlarged the state that would administer it. Neither man is the hero of the century, nor is either its villain; they are two currents, and the decade chose Keynes, and that choice built the world that endured until the dollar's anchor was cut and the argument reopened. Hayek's defeated volume found its readers anyway, smuggled into the next generation, waiting for the season when the Keynesian order would crack and Hayek would be pulled back out as prophet.

The charter language of the order built at the hotel did not come from the hotel itself. It was spoken in London in the late autumn of 1945 by Edward R. Stettinius Jr., whom Roosevelt had appointed Secretary of State the year before, who had led the American delegation at the Dumbarton Oaks conference that drafted the United Nations charter and at the San Francisco conference that signed it, and whom Truman had then named first United States Ambassador to the new organization. The speech was a tribute to Lord Robert Cecil, the British architect of the League of Nations whose project the American Senate had refused in 1919. We in America who believed that Woodrow Wilson was right twenty-six years ago, Stettinius said, have always honored the name of Lord Robert Cecil; isolationists of any breed, though they may still appear to live and move and have their being, are in fact no more than vestigial remains of the pre-atomic age. The sentence draws the rhetorical envelope inside which the dollar-gold regime had already been negotiated. It fixes the new order as the redemption of Wilson's defeated one and brands every alternative to it as an anachronism the bomb had rendered impossible, so that the choice between participation in the American system and any other arrangement becomes a choice between the present and a category of the past. The phrase pre-atomic age does the heaviest work. It dates the prior world as obsolete by the calendar of a weapon less than three months in service, and converts a contingent diplomatic arrangement into the only thinkable accommodation to a new physics. A regime is durable in proportion to the difficulty of imagining its absence, and Stettinius's speech is the first complete statement of the case that the postwar dollar order was not chosen but supplied by the nature of the age itself.

The charter language was the visible surface, and what produced it sat one floor below in an office most of the postwar public would never learn the name of. The Research and Analysis branch of the Office of Strategic Services, founded in 1941 under the historian William Langer of

Harvard, was during the war the largest concentration of academic intellect ever assembled by an American government, a staff of roughly nine hundred at its peak that included economists, geographers, anthropologists, political scientists, philologists, and historians of every European and Asian region the war touched. Langer himself was a diplomatic historian trained in the German seminar tradition, a student of the methods Leopold von Ranke had set down in Berlin a century before, and his most prized personal possession was a complete set of Ranke's collected works in the original. The branch he ran was, almost as a condition of its competence, full of men and women whose intellectual formation had taken place inside the German historicist school, either through direct study in Germany before the regime drove them out or through the American universities that had absorbed the émigrés. They had spent the 1930s reading Dilthey on the human sciences, Weber on the iron cage of rationalization, Sombart on the spirit of capitalism, Schumpeter on creative destruction, and Marx in the original. The OSS hired them not despite this formation but because of it: the war required a state apparatus that could read foreign societies from the inside, and the only Americans who could do so were the ones who had been trained in the tradition that took such reading to be the work of a lifetime. The branch's offices on E Street in Washington produced the situation reports the White House and the Joint Chiefs used to plan campaigns, drafted the postwar economic prospects on which the Marshall Plan would later draw, and provided, after the war, the senior staff of the new Central Intelligence Agency and of the State Department's policy planning office that George Kennan would soon run. The people who designed the American postwar order were, in their majority, not the Anglo-American positivists of the popular history. They were German historicists in American passports, reading the postwar world through a tradition that took history as the master science and economic activity as one branch of cultural life among others.

The economists in the branch were stranger still. Paul Sweezy, who had taken a Harvard PhD under Schumpeter in 1937, served as an OSS R&A economist throughout the war, analyzing German industrial cartels and the structure of European finance. Paul Baran, a Russian Jewish émigré who had passed through the Frankfurt Institute in the early 1930s and then through Harvard, served alongside him. Both men were committed Marxists who had never concealed the fact, and the OSS knew exactly what it had hired. Sweezy's 1942 book *The Theory of Capitalist Development*, the first systematic English exposition of Marxist economics for an academic audience, had appeared the year he entered government service. Baran would become the only avowed Marxist ever to occupy a tenured chair at a major American economics department, at Stanford, after the war. Together, in 1966, the two would publish *Monopoly Capital*, the central American Marxist text of the postwar era, an analysis of how the modern corporation had transcended the price-competitive capitalism the classical tradition had described and become an instrument for the absorption of surplus into waste, advertising, military spending, and the

engineered obsolescence of consumer goods. The book read the postwar American economy as a system that had solved the production problem only to face a more difficult one, what to do with the surplus its productive capacity now generated; its answer, that the surplus was absorbed by the military-industrial state and by the engineered manufacture of demand, ran in close parallel to what Eisenhower would name in his 1961 farewell address and what Galbraith would describe from the liberal side in *The Affluent Society*. The strangeness is that the two authors had spent the war designing the intelligence framework of the regime their later book would dissect. They had not concealed their politics from the OSS, and the OSS had recruited them for the analytic discipline Marxism gave them, on the assumption that an apparatus serious about reading the German and Japanese economies could not afford to exclude the only Western tradition that had a systematic theory of capitalist crisis. The Marxism that produced *Monopoly Capital* in 1966 was the same Marxism the wartime state had paid Sweezy and Baran to apply to the enemy.

Eleanor Lansing Dulles, sister of Allen Dulles, who would soon run the CIA, and of John Foster Dulles, who would soon run the State Department, was the Bretton Woods secretariat, the official whose office produced the conference documents and translated the technical agreements into the language the delegations could sign. She had taken a Harvard economics doctorate in 1926, had spent the 1930s at Bryn Mawr and in the Social Security Board, and was a personal friend of Joseph Schumpeter, who had crossed from Bonn in 1932 and taught at Harvard until his death in 1950. Schumpeter himself was the most heterodox economist of his generation, an Austrian who had read Marx as the only serious rival to his own theory and who taught both with equal seriousness, a former finance minister of postwar Austria who had presided over a hyperinflation, a banker who had gone bankrupt, a sociologist of imperial decline as much as a theorist of innovation, and the author of the 1942 *Capitalism, Socialism and Democracy*, which predicted that capitalism would not be overthrown by its proletariat but dissolved by the bureaucratic logic of its own success. He taught the architects of the postwar order. Paul Samuelson, who would write the postwar American economics textbook through which two generations of college students learned the subject, had been his student. James Tobin, John Kenneth Galbraith, Robert Heilbroner, all sat in his Harvard seminars. The classroom in which the Bretton Woods generation was instructed in economics was a classroom in which Marx and Walras and Menger were treated as members of a single conversation, in which the historicist German tradition was the unmarked background, and in which the central question was not whether market economies would arrive at equilibrium but how, and how soon, they would tear themselves apart. The synthesis that became American economics in the 1950s, the marriage of Keynes and the neoclassical machinery the textbook called the neoclassical synthesis, was assembled by men whose teacher had told them that capitalism was a transitional form.

Why is this story not the familiar one. The popular history of the postwar order presents the American intelligence apparatus and the American economics profession as the natural expressions of an Anglo-American empiricist tradition, the inheritors of Locke and Hume and Bentham and Mill, the producers of a confident, data-driven, anti-ideological technocracy. That picture is not false in its surface; it is false in its depth. The wartime apparatus that designed the postwar settlement was full of émigré German historicists and unreconstructed Marxists who had spent the 1930s reading Dilthey, Weber, Sombart, Schumpeter, and Marx, and who brought that training to the work. The popular history that excludes them was not a neutral simplification. It was the deliberate product of the McCarthy era the next decade would deliver, the political project whose business was the public erasure from the American institutional memory of every figure the security state could now find inconvenient. Sweezy was hauled before the New Hampshire attorney general in 1954 and, after a four-year court fight that reached the Supreme Court, won a narrow protection of academic speech that did not restore him to mainstream employment; he founded *Monthly Review* with Leo Huberman in 1949 and edited it from outside the universities for the rest of his life. Baran kept his Stanford chair under continuous pressure that the university president Wallace Sterling acknowledged in writing was directly tied to Baran's politics and to congressional inquiry. The senior R&A historians who passed into the new Central Intelligence Agency in 1947 generally survived because they were not Marxists, but the discipline of historical reading they had brought from the German seminar was already, by the early 1950s, retreating from the public statements the agency would make about itself, replaced by a vocabulary of operations research and game theory that read more naturally to a Senate committee. The men who designed Bretton Woods had read more Marx than the men who would later denounce Marx in the Senate. The replacement was not an accident of intellectual fashion but a political operation, conducted in plain view, that produced the Anglo-American empiricist self-portrait the postwar order would offer the public for the next forty years. What stood behind the new dollar regime, what produced its analytic confidence, what equipped its first generation of senior officials to read the European economies they would now help rebuild, was a German historicist seminar and a Marxism the next decade would teach itself to forget.

The bomb fell into the same year the architecture was finished, and it opened more than it closed. The Manhattan Project drew heavily on the émigré physicists whom Europe's own purges had driven to American shores, and produced at Alamogordo in July 1945 a flash the men who built it understood at once as a change in kind. The weapons fell on Hiroshima and Nagasaki in August, two cities erased in two mornings, a hundred thousand and more killed in each by a single device, and the survivors left to a sickness no medicine of the time could name. Whether the second bomb was needed to end a war Japan was already losing is the one detail genuinely left open; that the weapon spoke to Moscow as much as to Tokyo is not in serious doubt. Japan had

begun to seek terms, the Soviet Union was days from entering the Pacific war and claiming a share of the spoils, and a demonstration of a force no army on earth could answer arrived at the moment the next contest was being drawn. The bomb was the first move of the order built at Bretton Woods made visible in the sky, the new hegemon showing the only rival left standing what it now commanded alone. The asymmetry it introduced was total, an annihilation no conventional force could match in the hands of one power for a few years, and that the holder was the new American order and not the ruined European one marked, as cleanly as anything could, where primacy had gone. It opened something harder to see as well. For the whole of human history the end of the world had been a thing imagined, prophesied and secularized and racialized but never quite arrived. After Alamogordo it could arrive. The oldest story the species told about its own ending had been handed, in a single morning, to a committee of physicists and generals, and everything that followed in the nuclear half-century was a human race that learned to live inside an eschatology it had built with its own hands.

The aftermath fell hardest on the victors who could least afford to win. Britain ended the war on the winning side, its flag over the largest empire in history, and it finished broke, its overseas investments liquidated, in debt to its own colonies and to America. Keynes was sent to Washington in 1945 to ask for a loan and brought home terms that measured the new hierarchy exactly: a hard commercial loan conditioned on making sterling convertible to dollars, a condition that when honored in 1947 triggered a run that drained the reserves in weeks. The victor was a supplicant at the creditor's door, and the creditor set the price. Then the colonies began to go. In August 1947 Britain quit India, the possession that had justified the whole imperial enterprise, leaving in haste under financial pressure it could no longer absorb, and Partition set perhaps fifteen million people in motion and killed hundreds of thousands. The decolonization the next two decades would complete began here, in the arithmetic that an empire which spends its capital to win a war cannot pay to keep what the war was nominally fought to preserve.

Mark the shape of this ending. Britain glides; another empire, before the century ends, will shatter, and the difference between the two exits is the thing no reading can supply in advance. Britain in 1900 had stood at an apparent zenith that was already deceptive, brittle at the peak, and the brittleness was real; yet nothing shattered. The order passed, through two wars, a suspended promise, an empire sold off creditor by creditor, to the borderland it had itself enriched, a descent managed across half a century into something that could still be lived in³ Mark the shape of that exit. Before the century is out another power will present a late profile of its own and meet the other fate, the state itself gone inside a decade, and a reading taken on the eve, in London or in Moscow, names the pressure in both and the exit in neither. The difference between a glide and a shatter is the thing these pages most need the reader to watch for, because no reading, taken in advance, supplies it.

3. On the sterling balances and the 1945 Anglo-American loan: Robert Skidelsky, John Maynard Keynes: Fighting for Britain, 1937–1946 (Macmillan, 2000), chs. 13–14.

The same insolvency drove the hegemon to rebuild the defeated, by a logic colder than mercy and entirely legible once one asks who gained. The Marshall Plan, announced in 1947, poured American capital into the recovery of Western Europe, and its largest beneficiary after Britain and France was the occupied west of Germany, the heart of the power the war had been fought to destroy. A prostrate Europe was a vacuum into which Soviet influence would flow, and a recovered one was a market for American goods and a wall against the Red Army at once, so the hegemon spent its surplus to rebuild its former enemy as a bulwark against its former ally and a customer for itself in the same motion; the same reversal ran in Japan, where the American occupation stopped dismantling Japanese industry and began rebuilding it. The grand alliance that had crushed Germany did not survive its victim by two years. Alliances dissolve the instant the shared enemy is gone, and the two surviving powers, each the other's only rival left standing, were enemies by the geometry of the board the moment Berlin fell. The Red Army stood across all of Eastern Europe and did not withdraw, and where it remained, governments friendly to Moscow rose, and the line hardened into what Churchill named at Fulton in 1946 the iron curtain, descended from the Baltic to the Adriatic. The world that emerged was bipolar before most of its inhabitants had grasped that it had ceased to be European at all. In 1949 the Soviet Union tested its own atomic weapon and the monopoly closed; the same year a communist revolution triumphed in China, and the contest acquired its full planetary scale.

The Holocaust did not end when the camps were liberated; it left behind a population that no surviving nation would take. Across the western occupation zones, in camps the Allies set up in Germany and Austria and Italy, the Jewish survivors of the murder waited in numbers that reached roughly a quarter million by 1947, people whose families and towns and entire worlds had been murdered and who could not go back to the places that had murdered them. Most wanted Palestine; many sought America; both doors were shut. The United States kept its immigration quotas tight, and Mandatory Palestine, which Britain still governed under a 1939 policy that had capped Jewish entry to placate the Arab majority, intercepted the ships that ran the survivors toward its coast. In 1947 the British stopped one such ship, the *Exodus 1947*, transporting forty-five hundred survivors, and sent them back, in the war's most public humiliation of the policy, to camps in the British zone of the country that had built the gas chambers. An underground network called *Brichah* moved more than a hundred thousand Jews out of Eastern Europe toward those camps and toward the boats, and the spectacle of survivors penned behind wire by the empire that had defeated their murderers became, in the American press above all, an argument no government could answer.

Into that pressure ran an older current. Zionism, the movement to gather the Jewish people into a state in the land of the Bible, had been building for half a century, advanced by waves of settlement and by an idea that fused the secular project of statehood to a sacred claim on a specific

ground. The British, in the Balfour Declaration of 1917, had promised a national home there while ruling the territory whose Arab inhabitants were the great majority. The promise and the demography could not be reconciled, and after the war the contradiction came due at once. Britain, bankrupt and unable to govern a territory where it was now fighting both an Arab population and a Jewish insurgency, handed the question to the new United Nations. On the twenty-ninth of November 1947 the General Assembly voted, in Resolution 181, to partition the land into a Jewish state and an Arab one, with Jerusalem under international administration. The plan gave the Jewish state about fifty-five percent of the territory, though Jews were roughly a third of the population and owned under a tenth of the land. The Jewish leadership accepted; the Arab states and the Palestinian Arabs rejected a partition that ratified, as they saw it, the seizure of a country by recent arrivals under the sanction of the powers that had ruled it. Fighting broke out the day after the vote and never stopped.

The British mandate ended at midnight on the fourteenth of May 1948. That afternoon, in the museum hall in Tel Aviv, David Ben-Gurion read out the proclamation of the State of Israel, and the United States recognized it within hours, the Soviet Union days later, the two new masters of the world reaching for the same small territory from opposite motives. Why each recognized it, and so quickly, is the part the moral framing usually skips. Britain was bankrupt and offloading; the territory had stopped paying its keep and was now costing the empire one of the few currencies left it cared about, world opinion. The United States, having just inherited the postwar dollar order and the strategic responsibility for keeping Mediterranean oil flowing under Western control, wanted a reliable client at the eastern end of the sea, a state whose survival would depend on Washington and whose intelligence service would face the same adversaries. The American Jewish vote was inside Truman's reelection arithmetic by the autumn of 1948, an electoral fact his own State Department complained openly about and could not move him on. The Soviet Union recognized the new state because it expected it to be socialist and to break the British position in the region; the move would only later cost Moscow what the move had cost London. And the longer European Jewish presence in finance, the names that ran the dominant houses of the prior century, the houses that financed the Mandate's first infrastructure and the postwar bond issues that built the new state, supplied the cash a new country needed to arm and feed itself before any tax base existed to pay for either. The state was not granted on a single account. It was the convergence of an exhausted empire, a new hegemon's oil calculus, a domestic American electoral pressure, a Soviet misreading, and a financial sector with deep Zionist commitments, all met by an immigrant population willing to fight for the ground. None of these reasons is the moral one the public was told, and none of them disappears because the moral one was also real. The next morning the armies of Egypt, Transjordan, Syria, Lebanon, and Iraq crossed the borders, and the war that had been a civil conflict became a war between states. It ran ten months, in truces and

resumptions, and it ended with the new state possessing more than the partition had granted it, about seventy-eight percent of the former mandate, its frontiers drawn by armistice rather than treaty along what came to be called the Green Line, with no Arab government willing to recognize what it had failed to prevent. In the course of that war and the months before it, roughly seven hundred thousand Palestinian Arabs, more than half the Arab population of the territory the new state now occupied, fled or were driven from their homes, into Gaza and the West Bank and the surrounding countries, into camps that were meant to be temporary and were not. The Israelis named the year the War of Independence; the Palestinians called it the Nakba, the catastrophe. Two peoples had been promised the same ground by powers that no longer had the strength to govern it, and the displaced survivors of the continent's slaughter took root in a land by displacing the people already on it, so that one expulsion seeded another. The eschatological charge ran in both directions from the moment of declaration: a state built on the oldest promise in the Western canon, and the grievance of the dispossessed hardened into its own faith of return. The arrangement settled nothing. It opened a wound at the center of the region's politics that the monetary and military orders of the following decades would keep reaching into, and the fronts drawn that year were the same lines a later century would still be fighting on.

Two books written at the seam of the new world saw its shape before the diplomats had names for it, and both came from the same Englishman, a former colonial policeman and Spanish-war volunteer who had watched his own side's truth rewritten in real time and never recovered from the lesson. Eric Blair, who wrote as George Orwell, had been raised in Bengal and Henley, schooled at Eton on a King's Scholarship he was made to feel he had not deserved, and had spent five years from 1922 as an officer in the Indian Imperial Police in Burma before walking away from the empire he had been hired to enforce. He had tramped London and Paris as a dishwasher, fought as a militiaman in Catalonia with the POUM and been shot through the throat by a sniper at Huesca in May 1937, watched the Communist purges of his own anarchist comrades after Stalin's secret police took the war from the inside, and escaped Spain over the Pyrenees with his wife Eileen one step ahead of the NKVD warrants the Republican government had drawn up for them both. He finished *Animal Farm* in February 1944, and it could not find a publisher, because Britain was still allied to Stalin and a fable in which the pigs become indistinguishable from the men was an embarrassment to the alliance. Four houses turned it down. At Faber, T. S. Eliot rejected it in a letter that praised its prose and its integrity and then declined it as too Trotskyite for the firm to stand behind, the most quietly revealing rejection in modern publishing, the high priest of the modernist right declining the most lucid anti-totalitarian fable of the age because the political wind was wrong. One publisher was steered off it by an official of the Ministry of Information named Peter Smollett, who turned out, decades later, to have been a Soviet agent recruited by Kim Philby's circle, so that the burying of a book about the suppression of truth was itself an act of the

very order it described. Secker and Warburg published it in August 1945, after Germany had fallen and the alliance no longer needed protecting, and the date made Orwell a Cold War property he had not asked to become. The fable's form is its argument: the slow substitution of the commandment painted on the barn wall, all animals are equal, by the single amended line, all animals are equal but some animals are more equal than others, is the wartime production of belief rendered as a thing one can watch happen letter by letter on a wall, the official account revised until the governed cannot remember what was promised. Four years later, in the second-floor bedroom of a stone farmhouse called Barnhill on the Scottish island of Jura, where there was no electricity and the nearest doctor was twenty-five miles away and a boat trip across a tidal whirlpool, Orwell finished *Nineteen Eighty-Four* typing one-handed in bed with tuberculosis eating his lungs. It was published in June 1949. The novel pushed the same perception to its terminus: a state that controls not merely the present and the future but the past, that maintains a Ministry of Truth whose work is the continuous rewriting of the past, that engineers a language, Newspeak, designed to make dissent literally unthinkable by removing the words for it, and that has perfected doublethink, the capacity to entertain two contradictory beliefs at once and accept both. The novel is the eschatology thread turned inside out: not a movement straining toward a final settlement but a power that has arrived at its destination and means to occupy it forever, the boot on the human face, not as transition to anything but as the end in itself. Orwell died of a pulmonary haemorrhage in a University College Hospital room in London on the twenty-first of January 1950, six months after the book's publication, at forty-six. He had married his second wife from his hospital bed three months before.

Harold Bloom, who built a life on the proposition that literature creates the inwardness it appears only to describe and that the canon is bound together by aesthetic strangeness rather than by virtue, looked hard at *Nineteen Eighty-Four* and would not call it great art. He judged Orwell a far finer essayist than novelist, a pamphleteer in the line of Defoe and Carlyle and Ruskin, and he placed the novel among what he called good bad books, setting it beside *Uncle Tom's Cabin* as a work whose power is moral and prophetic rather than aesthetic, its characters thin, its prose without the eloquence that makes a reader return to a sentence for its own sake. The judgment is exact and it isolates what the novel actually is. Orwell was not making the kind of object Bloom prizes, the strong poem that wins its life by wrestling a precursor; he was doing something he believed mattered more in 1949 than any aesthetic victory, telling a truth about power so directly that no future revision could quite erase it. He chose the pamphleteer's clarity over the artist's strangeness on purpose, because the thing he had seen, the way those who own the means of broadcast revise reality at will, was something the strong poem could not stop and the plain warning might. That the warning has outlasted nearly every aesthetically superior novel of its decade, that its vocabulary has entered the language as the standard equipment for naming the

official choreography of feeling, is the proof of Orwell's wager and the limit of Bloom's measure at once. The work survived not because it was beautiful but because it was true, and the endurance is the durable kind: a single consciousness took the specific pressure of its moment, the machinery of organized lying it had watched assemble itself on the left and the right alike, and made from it a form durable enough that the order has never since been able to operate unobserved.

What Orwell wrote in fable from London, a man inside the Russian camps wrote in documentation from the rim of Asia. Alexander Solzhenitsyn was an artillery captain when the SMERSH counterintelligence service arrested him in February 1945 for a letter to a school friend that joked about Stalin's competence as a strategist, and he spent eight years inside the labor system whose architecture he would later set down at lethal length. The *Gulag Archipelago*, written in secret across the 1960s on a typewriter passed between safehouses and smuggled out of the country in microfilm at the end of 1973, is a three-volume forensic account of the institution Lenin had founded and Stalin had industrialized, assembled from his own years and the testimony of two hundred and twenty-seven other survivors. Its mechanism is the cumulative weight of names, dates, transit routes, daily rations, interrogation techniques, sentencing categories, mortality figures. The book broke whatever was left of the Western Communist intelligentsia's defense of the Soviet experiment when the first volume reached Paris in December 1973; he was expelled from the country the following February, lived eighteen years in Vermont, and returned in 1994 to a Russia he found scarcely less corrupt than the one he had left. Where Orwell had imagined a Ministry of Truth and a doublethink, Solzhenitsyn provided the ledger entries the imagined ministry had been built to falsify. The two books belong on a single shelf: one is the fable the totalitarian state inspired in its enemies abroad, the other is the document its survivors smuggled out.

There was a gentler picture made in the same years, and its quarrel was with the new monetary order rather than with the police state, which is why the state's own watchers found it suspicious. Frank Capra had been born Francesco Rosario Capra in a Sicilian village in 1897, had crossed steerage to America at six with the rest of his family, had paid his way through Throop, the technical school that would become Caltech, and had risen through Columbia Pictures across the 1930s with a string of populist comedies. He had served four years in the war as a colonel in the Army Signal Corps producing the *Why We Fight* series for Frank Marshall, and came back to Los Angeles in 1945 to start his own independent company, Liberty Films, with George Stevens and William Wyler. The first picture Liberty made was *It's a Wonderful Life*, released on the twentieth of December 1946 to mediocre reviews and a box-office return that left the company unable to make a second feature. The film was scrutinized by the Federal Bureau of Investigation, which in a memo of the ninth of May 1947 flagged it as probable communist propaganda on the ground that its villain, the miserly banker Henry Potter, was a deliberate smear of the financier as a class; the

memo named the screenwriters Frances Goodrich and Albert Hackett, both later blacklisted, as suspect. The Bureau read the film more sharply than its sentimental reputation allows. The picture is a fable of two towns, the same town under two regimes of money. Bedford Falls is a community bound together by a building-and-loan that treats credit as a social trust, lending so that working families can own homes; Pottersville, the town as it would have been had George Bailey never lived and Potter won, is a strip of bars and pawnshops and rented rooms, a place where money has been freed from any obligation but its own increase. The film stages, in the language of small-town melodrama, the exact argument the decade had just decided at Bretton Woods, the quarrel between credit governed for the common welfare and capital accumulating for itself alone, and it comes down hard on the Keynesian side, which is why the Bureau's analysts smelled subversion in it. Its ideological fantasy is the postwar American promise in its purest form, that the ordinary man's small acts of decency add up to a community worth saving and that the predatory financier can be fended off by neighborly solidarity. What the FBI memo, of all documents, dragged into the light is that the promise rests on a particular monetary settlement, an order in which the banker is the enemy and the social control of credit is the good, and that this politics had a name and a rival the Bureau could recognize. The picture entered the public domain in 1974 when Republic Pictures failed to file the copyright renewal, and the broadcast networks ran it every December at no cost; the second life it acquired in those rebroadcasts was what fixed it in the country's self-image. A film the country would later wrap around itself as the warmest expression of its own self-image was, at the moment it was made, read by the state's police as an attack on the financial order, and both readings are correct, which is the whole point.

The half century had a second register, quieter than the treaties: the histories it wrote of itself. In August 1902 a summer meeting at Cambridge gathered historians from across Europe to survey the century just ended, and the volume made from their addresses is serene; trade and science and parliaments advance together, and Napoleon's blockade of England appears as a folly already safely instructive, the kind of error the modern order had outgrown. Fourteen years later, with the war in its third calendar year, Shailer Mathews, dean of the divinity school at Chicago, delivered Harvard's Noble Lectures on the spiritual interpretation of history and found the direction unchanged, force passing by degrees under the government of conscience; the conviction had survived its evidence. In 1926 John Herman Randall's *The Making of the Modern Mind* gave Columbia undergraduates the mind of their age as a finished assembly, each era dismantling the certainties of the one before it in orderly succession, the prose as untroubled as the clockwork it described in its middle chapters. And in 1947 Emery Neff, of the same university, published *The Poetry of History*, an argument that the writing of the past had once been a branch of literature and might be saved by becoming one again; what 1902 had practiced as a science, 1947 defended as an art, and a discipline pleads beauty when its predictive claim is gone. Every generation's history of

4. *Lectures on the History of the Nineteenth Century*, ed. F. A. Kirkpatrick (Cambridge, 1902); Shailer Mathews, *The Spiritual Interpretation of History* (Harvard, 1916); John Herman Randall Jr., *The Making of the Modern Mind* (1926); Emery Neff, *The Poetry of History* (Columbia, 1947).

itself is a confession of what it still believed. Read in sequence the four confess confidence, consecration, serenity, and salvage, and the curve they trace runs the same way as the ledgers⁴

What survived the decade was not the order the makers thought permanent. The dollar rail laid at Bretton Woods would endure less than thirty years before the gold window was shut and the currency cut loose from metal entirely. The victorious and broke empires spent the next decades in retreat from the territories that had made them great, and the Keynesian consensus the hotel installed would itself crack within a generation and let Hayek back into the room. What endured was the work a few minds made under the load of those years. Shostakovich's symphony preserves its two meanings at once, the protest the state commissioned and the dread of it that could not be suppressed. Welles's deep-focus portrait of the man who owns the machinery of belief still indicts what the war about to begin would perfect, and the missing word at its center still refuses to be found. Orwell's plain warning has done its work so well that the vocabulary it coined is how the act is now identified wherever it occurs. Celan's fugue turned the murderers' own form against them and refused every consolation; the silence he drove his later work toward remains the most honest answer art found to the question of whether anything could be said at all. And the paintings the refugees made possible in New York still hang as an announcement, made before any institution could name it, that the center of the image had crossed an ocean. These are the forms a handful of consciousnesses made when the monetary order was rebuilt over their heads and the governing myths of a continent collapsed into murder. The order is gone, or going. The Seventh delivered what an order born of mass killing pays its survivors: that a civilization can build the architecture of a peace in one room while it administers the machinery of an extermination in another, and that the only thing that reliably outlasts both is the work a single mind makes to set down what it was to be alive inside the contradiction.

1950 – 1959

A man crouched over a length of unstretched canvas spread flat on the floor of a barn in Springs, Long Island, and let a stick trail enamel paint across it in long looping arcs, never touching the surface, walking the edges and then stepping into the field itself so that the picture grew around his feet. Jackson Pollock had grown up the youngest of five brothers on his father's surveying jobs across the Southwest, had moved to New York at eighteen to study with Thomas Hart Benton at the Art Students League, had spent the late 1930s on the WPA Federal Art Project painting alongside other young men who would later be famous, and had been hospitalized for alcoholism twice before he was thirty. In 1943 Peggy Guggenheim, the heiress who had opened a Manhattan gallery called Art of This Century, signed him to a contract that paid him a hundred and fifty dollars a month against his canvases, the first steady income he had had. The barn in Springs was the converted carriage house his wife Lee Krasner had insisted he rent, the move to the country part of her project to get him away from the bars of Greenwich Village. He had stopped using the easel because it told him where the top was, where the frame ended, what counted as a figure against a ground, and he wanted a painting with no such instructions built in. He thinned house paint and industrial enamel until it would pour, and he poured it, flicked it, dribbled it from cans and hardened brushes, building the densely interlaced threads that became *One: Number 31* in the summer and fall of 1950, a wall-sized field with no center and no hierarchy, every region as charged as the next. He told an interviewer that when he was inside the painting he was not aware of what he was doing and only afterward saw what he had been at, a working method dressed as mysticism that pointed at something real. The photographs Hans Namuth shot of him at work in the barn that summer made him famous and broke him at once; he started drinking again the night of the last shoot and never recovered the discipline. He had made a surface on which the question that organized Western painting for five centuries, where the important thing sits and what is merely behind it, no longer had an answer. There was no behind. There was only the all-over weave, and the eye entered anywhere. On the night of the eleventh of August 1956, drunk, he drove his Oldsmobile convertible off the road less than a mile from the barn, killing himself and his mistress Edith Metzger and severely injuring his other passenger, Ruth Kligman, who would later sit for Willem de Kooning. He was forty-four. Krasner, who had been in Europe, returned to bury him and spent the next twenty-eight years managing his estate and her own painting in the studio he had emptied of his life.

The years in which he made it had a monetary signature, a privilege so large it shaped the perception of an entire generation without anyone being told it existed. The architecture drafted in the New Hampshire resort hotel in 1944 had built the postwar money machine around a single hinge. Only the dollar was redeemable in gold, fixed at thirty-five dollars to the ounce; every other

currency was pegged to the dollar and stockpiled dollars instead of metal in its vaults. This is the gold-exchange standard, and everything else in the decade runs through the plain fact buried inside the term. Gold was the brake on every other nation. A country that ran a deficit lost reserves, had to raise rates and tighten until its books balanced, and felt the discipline as recession and unemployment. The United States, alone, did not. When it spent more abroad than it earned, it did not ship away gold so much as its own paper, and the notes were the very thing other nations had agreed to keep as their reserves. They could not refuse it without unhinging the system they depended on. The American deficit became, by the design of the machine, the world's supply of money. A later French finance minister gave it the name, the exorbitant privilege, and the resentment in the phrase measures the size of the advantage exactly: the issuer of the world's reserve currency can consume beyond its production and tax the rest of the planet for the difference, quietly, through the simple necessity that everyone else must absorb its debt. Through the 1950s this was not yet the strained instrument it would later become; American surpluses were still real and the gold in the vaults still vast. But the arrangement was already a one-way valve, and it answered the question of who benefited before anyone could ask it.

At home the same privilege took the form of a new way of making money out of nothing, and the household learned to live inside it without quite seeing the mechanism. A bank does not lend out money that savers have placed with it; that is the picture in the schoolbook, and it is false. A bank lends by writing a number into a borrower's account, and the figure is new money, created at the stroke that records the loan, backed only by a fraction of reserves against the chance that depositors come asking for cash. This is fractional-reserve creation, and it means the money supply of an advanced economy is mostly the accumulated debt of its own people, conjured into being each time a loan is signed and extinguished each time one is repaid¹ The postwar suburb was this machine running at full extension. A generation of men returned from the war with the federal government standing behind their mortgages and their tuition, and the suburbs spread across the old farmland on thirty-year notes that earlier Americans would have called reckless debt. Each of those mortgages was fresh purchasing power created by a bank against a house that did not yet exist, the debt of the borrower turning into the deposit of the builder and then the wage of the carpenter, the whole expansion of midcentury prosperity a vast act of collective money creation that read, to the people inside it, as nothing more sinister than a lawn and a car. The installment plan, the revolving account, the long mortgage were the domestic instruments of the same logic that made the dollar the world's reserve abroad: a society that had learned to monetize its own future and to spend the proceeds in the present. In February 1950 a small cardboard card changed hands at a Manhattan restaurant and the first multipurpose charge instrument was born, an object that let a man eat now and settle later, teaching the household to treat its own appetite as collateral² The savings of a frugal generation were converted into the debt of an indebted one. None of it read

1. For the canonical exposition, Federal Reserve Bank of Chicago, *Modern Money Mechanics* (1961; rev. 1992).

2. Diners Club, founded 1950 by Frank McNamara.

as weakness. It bore the signature of strength, the privilege of the power whose paper everyone else was obliged to stockpile and whose banks could summon buying might from the act of recording a promise.

The machine had a color line drawn through it, and the line was federal. When Washington rebuilt the mortgage in the 1930s, long terms, low down payments, federal insurance, the architecture that made the suburb financeable, its appraisers mapped every city in the country and graded the neighborhoods, and the grade that meant no insurance was painted red, and the red followed the presence of Black families with the consistency of a rule, because it was one: the agency's own underwriting manual warned lenders away from what it called inharmonious racial groups. William Levitt, whose name became the noun for the new suburb, sold to whites only and said openly that he could solve a housing problem or a racial one but not both; the covenant in the deed did the rest. So the identical veteran's entitlement, brought into the same bank by two men who had worn the same uniform, came out as two different countries: one walked into a thirty-year asset that the order's whole monetary design would inflate beneath him, and the other was directed back to the blocks the map had already condemned, to rent from owners who knew their tenants could not leave. The Supreme Court struck the covenants' enforcement in 1948 and the practice barely broke stride; the loan officer needed no judge. Compounding did the rest, in both directions. The white suburb's equity became the next generation's college and the down payment after that; the redlined block's missing share turned into its own inheritance, a subtraction handed down as faithfully as the asset. The migration this book followed north out of the lien had arrived inside a second instrument, quieter than the first, administered by the same sovereign credit machine the decade trusted with everything else. Thirty years on, the grandchildren of the migration would be standing in the boroughs the maps had starved, with turntables, and the chapter that meets them there will read what they made of it.

The new order asked something different of a person. The war just ended had been fought, on the defeated side, in the name of the unit will, the conviction that the nation is one organism and the individual exists to be dissolved into its destiny. The peace was built as the negation of that creed. In place of the subsumed citizen it preached the consumer, the person who should go and spend and enjoy and not trouble himself with the large questions of the state. This was not only an economic arrangement but an anthropology, a decision about the purpose of a life, and its reach can be taken by a single comparison. A white American man with a high-school diploma, a clerk or a salesman or a man on a line, lived better in material terms than the nobility of Rome: a house, two cars, a wife who need not work for wages, children sent to college, all of it on credit, all of it extended not to an aristocracy but to a wage-earner in exchange for his quiet transformation from a citizen with obligations into a consumer with wants. The bargain was magnificent and it also hollowed something out. An order that runs on demand must manufacture it. Demand is desire.

And desire, by the 1950s, had become a thing that men set out to engineer.

The engineer most associated with the work was a Viennese émigré named Ernest Dichter, trained in the psychoanalytic city of Freud, who arrived in America and set up an institute in a house above the Hudson where he conducted what he called motivational research. The premise inverted the older market study. One did not ask consumers what they wanted, because they did not know, and what they reported wanting was a rationalization laid over motives they could not see. One conducted depth interviews, small panels questioned at length in the manner of the analyst's couch, listening past the stated reason to the buried one. Dichter found that a man bought a convertible the way he kept a mistress, that a cake made from a mix left a woman anxious because it asked too little of her, so the manufacturers were told to leave out the egg and let her add it and feel she had created something, that soap bore a freight of guilt and absolution older than any product. This was Bernays's discovery of the irrational mass mind turned into a working instrument and sold to the corporation. The advertisement that resulted was applied ideology in the exact sense: it did not describe a thing for sale so much as name a fantasy of who the buyer might become, and it sold the dream with the object attached. Vance Packard's 1957 warning that hidden persuaders had learned to reach beneath the conscious mind sold enormously, which was itself the proof, since the public purchased its own alarm as eagerly as it bought everything else.

The lineage is direct. Freud opened the irrational unconscious. His nephew Bernays converted that opening into a paid technique for the management of public opinion, and Dichter then sold the technique to the corporation as a billable service with offices and a fee schedule. The consumer order did not stumble into the management of desire. It was the deliberate work of men who understood that an economy organized around demand must never let it rest, and who built the instruments to do it. The household caught in the war between hidden persuaders and its own appetite was the engineered product of that war, fashioned as surely as the appliance in its kitchen, taught to experience a manufactured want as a private wish. No single Freud-to-Bernays design steered an entire democracy from citizenship into consumption as though one hand moved every piece; the current ran through too many hands at once to belong to any of them. The technique was real, profitable, and meant, and that it had no single author changes nothing about its reach.

There was a second sorting machine the affluent order built, and it presented itself as the opposite of manipulation, as pure fairness, as the reward of the deserving by the measure of what they could actually do. The Servicemen's Readjustment Act that Roosevelt signed in June 1944 put the federal treasury behind the tuition of returning veterans, and the effect on the universities was a flood. By 1947 nearly half the students in American colleges were former soldiers; the number of degree-holders more than doubled across the decade; campuses that had enrolled three thousand before the war counted ten thousand after it. The old aristocracy of birth, the gentleman's C and the

legacy admission, was overrun by a generation of clerks' and farmers' sons who had been told that the examination and the credential were the new ladder and that it was open. This was the meritocracy in its founding moment, and the word itself was coined as a warning rather than a boast: a British civil servant named Michael Young would publish a satire in 1958 imagining a society sorted entirely by tested ability, and he meant the term as the name of a dystopia, not a virtue. What he saw, and what the American order did not let itself see, was that a machine which selects for measured performance does not select for wisdom or for steadiness or for the capacity to live well. It selects for the will to be selected. The examination rewards the child who most needs the examiner's approval, who has learned to convert anxiety into output, who experiences a grade as a verdict on whether he deserves to exist. The credential ladder finds the insecure achiever and breeds more of him, because insecurity is the renewable resource the whole machine runs on, and it calls the result merit.

The elite university at the top of the ladder was doing something more particular still, and the logic is clearest when it is named in the plain terms of finance, because that is what it was. An admissions office choosing a few hundred from many thousands is a portfolio manager allocating scarce capital, and the stake is the institution's prestige, lent out to young people in the expectation that some fraction will return it multiplied, as senators and laureates and donors whose achievements accrue to the school that picked them early. A manager allocating for that kind of return does not buy the safe asset. He does not select the contented, the settled, the person already at peace with himself, because such a man has no upside; he will live a good life and bring the institution nothing it can compound. The manager buys the high-variance asset, the driven and unfinished and validation-starved applicant whose hunger is the engine of an outsized return, knowing that many will break and a few will pay for all the rest. The elite school is a venture firm that has learned to recognize productive trauma and to price it as promise, to read the wound as the source of the drive and to bet on it. The fairness it advertises is real at the level of the individual transaction, since the gifted poor genuinely rose through it as the well-born no longer simply inherited. The thing it cannot admit is the nature of what it is selecting for, that it finds the dissociative and the unhappy and the desperate-to-prove and prefers them because their hunger pays, and that an order which staffs its commanding heights this way fills those heights with people organized around a void. The trauma is not a flaw in the machine. It is the yield the machine was built to harvest, dressed in the language of opportunity so that the harvested would mistake the wound for a gift.

Pollock's all-over field belongs against this ground, and so does the network that lifted it onto the world's walls. The same abstraction that refused hierarchy at home was, abroad, made into a weapon, and the men who made it one knew what they were doing. A republic that had inherited the noncommunist world needed to answer a Soviet adversary that called American culture vulgar

and commercial and that produced, under state direction, a socialist realism of muscled workers and beaming tractors. The answer was built through an organization founded in 1950 called the Congress for Cultural Freedom, which ran magazines and conferences in dozens of countries, and through the international program of the Museum of Modern Art, whose board interlocked with the same patrician families that staffed the intelligence service, and which conveyed Abstract Expressionism across Europe in exhibition after exhibition. The Central Intelligence Agency financed the network, the Congress covertly through foundations that laundered the money, on what its officers later called a long-leash policy that kept the sponsor two or three removes from the painters so that the source would never show. The arrangement was the documented Cold War cultural strategy of the United States, confirmed in the mid-1960s and described by the officers themselves afterward, and it answers the question of who benefited with no ambiguity. The state needed proof that freedom produced greater art than the commissar's discipline, and it produced that proof and shipped it abroad. Here, the promoted story ran, was the liberty the rival system could not permit: a man alone in a barn flinging enamel with no committee to approve the result, the visible opposite of the tractor. No controlling hand guided the brush itself; the painters were instruments, not conspirators, and most never knew whose money hung their work. The gesture sold abroad as pure unmanaged spontaneity had been conscripted, behind the maker's back, into the most managed undertaking of the age. The freedom was real on the canvas and a state property in the crate.

Mark Rothko, born Marcus Rothkowitz in Dvinsk in 1903 and brought to Portland, Oregon, at ten, hated to be filed beside Pollock and despised the word decoration more. After a Yale scholarship the university revoked on rumors of Jewish quotas, he taught children at the Center Academy in Brooklyn for twenty-three years before he could live off his painting. He stopped painting recognizable things and arrived at the format he would repeat for the rest of his life: two or three soft-edged rectangles of color stacked on a stained ground, the boundaries breathed rather than drawn so the color seemed to hang in front of the canvas. He wanted the paintings hung low and close and seen alone. Through the late 1950s his palette darkened from the bright reds toward maroon and brown and black, as though the format that began as an opening onto light were slowly being sealed. In 1958 the Seagram Corporation commissioned him for thirty-five thousand dollars to paint murals for the new Four Seasons restaurant on Park Avenue. He produced more than thirty canvases for the room. The next summer he ate at the restaurant himself, looked at the diners and the prices, returned to his studio, refunded the advance, and refused to deliver. The paintings now hang in a single specified room at the Tate. On the morning of the twenty-fifth of February 1970, his marriage broken and his quarrel with the commissioners of the Houston chapel unresolved, he took an overdose of barbiturates in the small kitchen behind his studio on East Sixty-ninth Street and slashed both arms with a razor. He was sixty-six. What his work registers is

the hunger the affluent order could not feed, the suspicion that a civilization organized around want as appetite had starved want as longing.

Beneath the painting ran a war that gave the abundance its edge, and the war taught a lesson the suburbs did not hear. The peninsula had been cut in two at the thirty-eighth parallel in 1945, a line drawn in haste by two American colonels with a National Geographic map to mark where Soviet and American occupation forces would meet, and the division hardened into two states each claiming the whole. Before dawn on the twenty-fifth of June 1950 the North Korean army crossed that line in force, Soviet-built tanks leading columns that the lightly armed army of the South could not repel, and within three days Seoul had fallen and the southern government had fled. The United States, five years past a total victory and with most of its army demobilized, found itself in a contest it had not foreseen and could neither win in the old sense nor afford to lose. The first American troops thrown into the breach were occupation soldiers from soft garrison duty in Japan, undertrained and underequipped, and they were overrun and pushed back through the summer into a small perimeter around the southern port of Pusan, defending a last corner of the peninsula with their backs to the sea.

Then MacArthur reversed the war in a single stroke. Against the near-unanimous judgment of his planners, who called the tides and the seawalls and the narrow approach channel impossible, he landed two divisions at Inchon on the fifteenth of September, far up the west coast behind the enemy's lines and beside the capital itself, and the gamble worked completely. The North Korean army, strung out hundreds of miles to the south, was cut at the waist and collapsed, and within weeks the front had run all the way back up to the parallel. Here the war that might have ended did not. Intoxicated by the reversal, Washington changed the aim from restoring the line to conquering the North, and MacArthur drove his armies toward the Yalu River, the Manchurian frontier, broadcasting that the troops would be home by Christmas, dismissing the warnings that China would not tolerate a hostile army on its border. In late November the warnings came true. Three hundred thousand Chinese soldiers who had crossed the Yalu by night, undetected, struck the overextended and divided columns in the frozen mountains, and the longest retreat in American military history began. At the Chosin Reservoir a Marine division was surrounded in cold that froze the wounded where they lay and jammed the rifles, and fought its way out south through the passes in a withdrawal its commander insisted was an attack in another direction. Seoul changed hands a second time and a third. The front finally stabilized near where it had started.

From there the war became something the century would see again and again, a stalemate that nobody could end, two armies dug into hills along a line that barely moved while diplomats argued at Panmunjom for two years over the single question of whether captured prisoners who did not wish to return home could refuse. The fighting in those years was the trench war of 1916 fought

again for ground with names like Pork Chop Hill and Heartbreak Ridge, positions taken and lost and retaken at a cost out of all proportion to anything they secured. MacArthur wanted to widen the war, bomb the Manchurian bridges, use the atomic bomb if needed, finish it the way wars had always been finished; Truman, who would not risk a third world war over a peninsula, removed him in April 1951, and when an unpopular president cashiered the most celebrated soldier in America the dismissal was itself a verdict, the civilian power asserting that the new wars would be fought within limits no general could overrule. The armistice was signed on the twenty-seventh of July 1953, roughly along the line where the invasion had begun three years before, a truce that no peace treaty has ever replaced. More than thirty-six thousand Americans were dead, and the Koreans, soldiers and civilians on both sides, died in the millions. The lesson buried in the draw was that overwhelming capability no longer translated into a commensurate outcome, that a nation able to incinerate cities could be fought to a standstill by a peasant army willing to absorb losses no Western public would bear. A second lesson came quieter. Total war had always promised an absolute resolution, a surrender on a deck, a capital taken, but the new weapons made that promise unkeepable, since the only war that could still be won absolutely was the war no one survived. The atomic monopoly had broken the year before Korea began, when the Soviets tested their own bomb far ahead of every estimate; in 1952 the United States detonated the first thermonuclear device and the Soviets followed within a year, and the hydrogen bomb did not enlarge the category of war so much as cancel it, since each side could now destroy the other utterly and neither could prevent its own destruction. So the great powers learned to fight at the edges instead, in proxies and peripheries and stalemates like the one in Korea, where the contest could be bloody without becoming final. Beneath the appliances and the lawns ran the knowledge that the whole arrangement sat under a ceiling of annihilation the daily transactions were built to forget.

The decade's most searching image of how a man becomes the willing servant of the machinery that destroys him reached the screen in 1957, and the circumstances under which it was made are inseparable from its meaning. David Lean had begun his career at nineteen as a tea boy at Gaumont Pictures and risen through the editing rooms across the 1930s; he had cut *In Which We Serve* for Noël Coward and only at thirty-four taken his first directing credit. By 1957 he had already made *Brief Encounter* and *Great Expectations* and *Oliver Twist*, but the picture that came that year was on a different order of ambition. *The Bridge on the River Kwai* was shot in the jungle of Ceylon over eight months at a cost so high that producer Sam Spiegel had to remortgage his house to finish it; the screenplay was largely written by Carl Foreman and Michael Wilson, both blacklisted Americans whose names were left off the credits and replaced with that of the original French novelist Pierre Boulle, who spoke no English. The picture won seven Oscars including Best Adapted Screenplay; Boulle accepted the award without speaking. It watches a captured colonel named Nicholson decide that the railway bridge his men are compelled to build

for their Japanese captors will be a monument to British discipline and engineering, a proof of their superiority, and so devote himself to building it well, until he is collaborating with the enemy out of pure institutional pride and must be stopped by his own side. The form is the indictment. Lean shoots the construction with the sweep and grandeur an epic reserves for heroism, so that the audience is seduced into admiring the bridge alongside Nicholson and only at the end registers, with him, what the pride has served. Read for the moment that produced it, the film is the perfect parable of the organization man the affluent order was manufacturing in its suburbs and its corporations, the competent functionary so identified with the machinery he serves that he can no longer ask what the system is for, and it arrived in the same years Dichter was teaching corporations to engineer exactly that identification. William Whyte gave the type its name the year before, in *The Organization Man* of 1956, a study of the corporate manager that found a generation which had traded the old creed of individual enterprise for a collectivist ethic of the group, the committee, the smooth career inside the firm. Whyte saw the surface of it, the conformity and the personality testing and the gray suit. The colder reading underneath is sharper and less forgiving. The managerial class the affluent corporation was breeding does, in the main, no work in the sense a maker would recognize the word. It administers, reviews, reports, convenes, and generates the paper by which it justifies its own existence; at any difficulty, its first instinct is to add a layer or a procedure, a deputy or an oversight function, so that the count of managers grows while the count of those who actually build or grow or fix anything stays flat or falls. The ratio of administrators to producers is the quiet vital sign of an institution, and in the postwar firm and agency alike the number had begun its long climb. Each new layer is rational from inside, a response to a real risk, a hedge against a real failure; what no one within can see is that the sum of those reasonable additions is a bureaucracy that consumes ever more of the institution's energy to run itself and returns ever less to the purpose it was built to serve.

The managerial class does not seize the institution in a coup; it occupies it the way silt fills a harbor, grain by reasonable grain, until the thing that once moved is stuck fast, and the men who filled it cannot say when the water closed because each of them only ever added a single sensible handful. What is deeper in the picture is how it was made. The blacklist that drove Foreman and Wilson into exile was the working instrument of a national mood that had acquired a name and a senator. Joseph McCarthy, the junior Republican from Wisconsin, had spent the years from 1950 to 1954 in front of cameras and committee chairs accusing the State Department, the Army, the universities, and the entertainment industry of harboring concealed communists, his lists waved on television and his counts revised downward each time anyone checked them. The accusations were largely fabricated; the climate they produced was real. To be named was to be unemployable, and the men inside the institutions learned that protecting a colleague was itself a marked act. The Senate finally condemned McCarthy in December 1954 and he drank himself to death by May

1957 at forty-eight, but the procedure he had used outlived him. McCarthyism, as a noun, names the structure: a paranoia organized at the level of state, in which the accusation is the punishment and the rumor is the evidence, and a political form that did not need a totalitarian state to do most of what such a state would have done. The script was written by Carl Foreman and Michael Wilson, two American screenwriters driven into exile in England by the Hollywood blacklist, men the security state had defined as enemies and forbidden to work under their own names. Because they could not be credited, the Academy Award for the screenplay went to Pierre Boulle, the French author of the source novel, who could not read or write English and had written not a word of the film. The same Cold War operation that crated Abstract Expressionism abroad as the proof of American freedom had at home erased the authorship of the era's great study of the captive will and laundered the credit onto a man who could not have produced it. The buried wager inside the triumph at the Oscars was the country's own conduct mirrored in the film it was honoring, a system extracting brilliant work from men it had condemned and then claiming the work was someone else's, the bridge built and the builders unnamed.

The same procedure reached, in 1952, into the discipline that had given the age its central metaphor for control, and what it did there was quieter and more consequential than any blacklist. The discipline was cybernetics, and the discipline had a founder. Norbert Wiener, the son of a Harvard Slavic philologist who had taught him eight languages by the age of nine, had taken his PhD at eighteen, had spent the 1920s working out the mathematical foundations of Brownian motion and harmonic analysis, and during the war had developed at MIT the predictive feedback servomechanism that allowed antiaircraft guns to lead their targets through the random evasions of an enemy pilot. The work had pushed him to a generalization. Every system that adjusts its behavior on the basis of information about its own past output, the gun computing where the plane will be from where it has been, the thermostat correcting the room temperature from a measurement of the present air, the animal walking across an uneven floor and continuously revising the placement of each foot, runs on the same formal structure. He named the formal structure cybernetics, from the Greek *kybernētēs* for steersman, and in 1948 he published the technical exposition under that title with MIT Press and the Hermann firm in Paris, a dense mathematical volume that nonetheless sold out its first printing within months and went into popular paperback within a few years. The same autumn, on the other coast and from a different institutional address, Claude Shannon's *A Mathematical Theory of Communication* appeared as a two-part article in the *Bell System Technical Journal*, the foundational paper of information theory and the second of the postwar's two great syntheses of the same intuition, that the world's processes could be read as the management of feedback and the transmission of signals.

The Macy Foundation had begun in 1946 to host a series of small invitational conferences in New York to consolidate the new science, gathering Wiener, Shannon, John von Neumann,

Margaret Mead, Gregory Bateson, Warren McCulloch, Walter Pitts, Heinz von Foerster, the physiologist Arturo Rosenblueth, the psychologist Lawrence Frank, and a rotating cast of others; ten conferences across seven years, the last in 1953. The minutes have been published, and the disagreement at the table was substantive and never resolved. Wiener insisted from the first conference that cybernetics had ethical implications no honest practitioner could evade. The new servomechanisms, scaled into industrial automation, would displace the labor of the men on the line within a generation, and an industrial democracy that did not govern the displacement would deliver its working population into either a degraded permanent unemployment or a degraded permanent dependence. Mead and Bateson took the opposite line. They wanted to apply cybernetic feedback to the engineering of human cultures, to use the new theory of self-correcting systems as the analytic instrument by which an anthropology could move from the description of cultures to their reform. Bateson would go on to do the work in his 1972 *Steps to an Ecology of Mind*; Mead would do it through the Institute for Intercultural Studies and through her seat on every postwar American commission on family and education that mattered. Von Neumann had a third agenda. He had published the *Theory of Games and Economic Behavior* with Oskar Morgenstern in 1944, and he wanted to extend game theory into the substance of political economy and military strategy, work that would soon be done at the RAND Corporation in Santa Monica, the air force think tank that absorbed much of the senior mathematical talent of the decade and put it to the analysis of nuclear deterrence. Three programs, three readings of what the new science was for, and the table never settled the question. The conferences ended in 1953 with the formal apparatus intact and the political question of what to do with it unaddressed.

Wiener tried to address it in print. *The Human Use of Human Beings* appeared from Houghton Mifflin in 1950 as a popular volume that took the feedback principle out of the laboratory and into the politics of what an industrial society would now do with the labor it no longer needed. The 1950 first edition contained passages that read the cybernetic age as a problem for democracy and for the unconscious life of the person, sentences that named the new managerial state and the new automation as instruments by which the human being might be engineered to its own diminishment. Specific paragraphs warned that an industrial automation introduced without democratic governance would reproduce the conditions of nineteenth-century industrial collapse on a scale the social institutions of the country were not built to absorb. Other paragraphs noted that the new techniques of mass persuasion, developed in the war and now commercially available, had the structural property that a small concentrated apparatus could shape the beliefs of a dispersed mass population, a property the older liberal political theory had not foreseen and the older constitutional safeguards did not address. Still others raised the question of whether the analogy between the human nervous system and the digital computer, an analogy von Neumann had pressed in his recent work, was a productive metaphor or a category error that

would license the design of human institutions on the model of machines and thus the gradual reduction of the human inhabitants of those institutions to the operating specifications of the machinery. The book was widely reviewed and went through several printings.

In the spring of 1952 Walter Reuther, president of the United Auto Workers and the most powerful labor figure in the country, invited Wiener to keynote the union's convention and speak to the assembled delegates on what the new machines would mean for the men on the line. Wiener accepted. The Federal Bureau of Investigation, then operating with a free hand under the McCarthyite pressure the chapter has just described, opened a file on Wiener that would eventually run to dozens of pages, and pressed him through a pattern of visits and inquiries that the file material later released has documented at length, until he wrote to Reuther withdrawing the acceptance. He did not appear. He then went home to Massachusetts and began the revision that produced the 1954 second edition of *The Human Use of Human Beings*, from which the politically dangerous passages had been removed and the popular reading of cybernetics softened into a more agreeable register. The first edition went out of print and remained difficult to find for decades. Mark Stahlman, a media-ecology scholar in the McLuhan circle and Wiener's godson, owns Wiener's personal copy of the 1950 edition, every condemned page crossed out by hand in the author's own ink, the visible artifact of a censorship performed in private before any publisher could perform it in public. The cybernetician who had named the science of feedback in 1948 had been compelled, at his own desk, to mark up his own book against himself, to do for the security state the editorial work the security state could not be seen to do.

The Soviet Union arrived at the same destination from the opposite direction. In 1948 the Soviet Academy denounced cybernetics as a bourgeois pseudo-science, an attempt by the Anglo-American imperial bloc to extend mechanical analogies to the human being and thus reduce the worker to a programmable appliance, and the discipline was banned in the Soviet universities and disappeared from the Soviet scientific press. Stalin died in March 1953, and within four years the same Soviet Academy had quietly reversed the decision, opened cybernetics institutes in Moscow and Kiev, and put the science to work on the planning problems of the command economy, where it remained one of the central instruments of Soviet economic theory through the 1980s. The American version, in the same window, had been forced into the engineering register and out of the political register, by FBI pressure and by Wiener's own pen at his own desk. The man who had named the science could not say in public what the science implied for the social order it was about to transform. The science was domesticated. The Macy table dispersed; Mead and Bateson took the cultural-engineering program into anthropology and into family therapy; von Neumann took the strategic program to RAND, where it produced the doctrine of mutual assured destruction and the early theoretical work on nuclear strategy; the Bell Labs version became the technical basis of the communications industry and a generation of computer engineering. None of

the three inheritors took up the question Wiener had been forced to abandon, what an industrial democracy owes the population whose labor its new machines render unnecessary. Bateson would complain in a letter to Warren McCulloch in 1972 that the Macy Conferences had produced what he called a science of trivia, by which he meant that the great formal apparatus the table had assembled had been put to no purpose adequate to its scope. The complaint was true and the truth was political. The science had been built to read the operation of self-correcting systems, and the largest self-correcting system the postwar world contained, the industrial democracy in which the new machines would be installed, was the one application its founders had been instructed, by visit and by inquiry and by file, not to discuss. Wiener returned to MIT and to his pure mathematics and to a series of late books on the human cost of automation that found a smaller audience and made a more cautious case. He died of a heart attack in Stockholm in March 1964 at sixty-nine, on a lecture tour, the National Medal of Science he had received from Lyndon Johnson the year before still warm in the citation. The decade's other artifacts, Diners Club and Modern Money Mechanics and the redlined suburb the federal underwriter had drawn, were the visible apparatus of the same operation Wiener had been forced to stop naming, and the price of his silence was the loss of the one popular account of the postwar age written by the man who understood, more clearly than anyone, what its central mechanism would do.

What Wiener could not say from MIT in the engineering register, a Canadian English professor was beginning to say in another register from the Catholic University of St. Michael's College at the University of Toronto, and the route by which he arrived at the saying is a counter-tradition the decade's familiar histories generally omit. Herbert Marshall McLuhan had taken his first degrees in engineering and English at the University of Manitoba in the early 1930s, had gone to Cambridge in 1934 on the strength of his Manitoba results, and had sat for two years under the literary critics who were then remaking the English discipline. I. A. Richards taught practical criticism, the close attention to the verbal surface of the poem as the only legitimate ground of literary judgment, and ran the experimental psychology of reading he had set out in the 1929 *Practical Criticism*, a book that gathered the actual responses of Cambridge undergraduates to unsigned poems and demonstrated that the trained literary reader regularly missed the obvious sense of a verse the moment the social cues of authorship were removed. F. R. Leavis taught *Scrutiny*, the journal he had founded in 1932, and the conviction that the mass commercial culture of the Anglo-American world was a substantive threat to the inherited civilization of the English tradition, a threat to be met not by political programme but by the cultivation, in a few minds, of the discriminations the print tradition had developed. McLuhan absorbed both currents, and a third. In 1937 he converted to Roman Catholicism, a conversion he later attributed to his reading of G. K. Chesterton, and a year later he took his first teaching post at St. Louis University, the Jesuit school in Missouri, where he met the man who would supply the philosophical apparatus on

which his later work would rest.

Bernard Muller-Thym was a young St. Louis philosopher who had taken his doctorate at Toronto under Étienne Gilson, the great twentieth-century Thomist, and who taught at St. Louis the Aristotelian and Thomistic faculty psychology that the medieval tradition had developed and the modern philosophy had abandoned. The medieval account of the mind ran as follows. Between the five exterior senses and the rational intellect sat the inward wits, the interior senses, a structured set of faculties through which sensory input was unified, retained, evaluated, and made available to thought. Common sense gathered the data of the separate exterior senses into the unified perception of a single object. Imagination retained the sensible form once the object had departed. The cogitative power, the *vis cogitativa* or estimative sense, judged the practical significance of what the imagination presented, distinguishing the friendly face from the hostile one before the rational intellect had been engaged. Memory stored and recalled. The whole structure, set out by Aquinas in the *Summa Theologiae* and the *De Anima* commentary and refined by the late Scholastics, was the medieval philosophical anthropology of how a human being is built, and the modern philosophy from Descartes onward had largely dismissed it, reducing the mind to consciousness on one side and physiology on the other and abolishing the inward wits as superstition. Muller-Thym restored the structure for McLuhan, and McLuhan would build the rest of his career on the discovery that the inward wits were not a defunct medieval curiosity but the precise apparatus on which the new electronic media were operating. Ruth Harvey would later document the medieval tradition in her 1975 *The Inward Wits*, the standard scholarly account of the doctrine, but the structure had reached McLuhan three decades earlier through Muller-Thym, and the structure was already at work in his 1951 *The Mechanical Bride*, the first systematic study of advertising as the manipulation of the inward wits the medievals had described and the moderns had forgotten how to name.

McLuhan returned to Toronto in 1946 and spent the decade refining the apparatus into the form it would take in his 1962 *The Gutenberg Galaxy* and his 1964 *Understanding Media*. The 1950s set the conditions and the 1960s collected the result, and the conditions are the substance of the present chapter. McLuhan's argument, in the form it took at the end of the decade, was that every medium is a technology that extends some specific human faculty, that the extension reorganizes the ratio among the faculties, and that the reorganization reshapes the sensibility of the populations who use the medium. Print extended the eye, separated the eye from the other senses, and produced the inward, private, linear consciousness of the modern individual. Electronic media re-extended the whole sensorium at once, collapsed the linear order of print, and were now producing a population whose sensibility was again pre-modern in its simultaneity, post-modern in its capacity for engineering, and whose interior life was no longer the interior life the print tradition had assumed. The argument was a direct continuation of what Wiener had been forced to

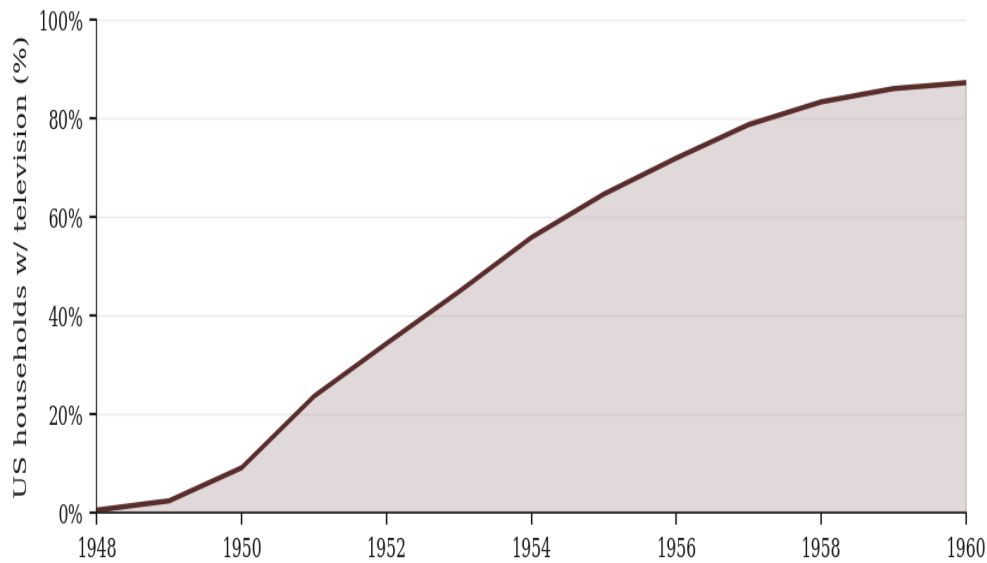
stop saying. The new technologies of communication and control would not merely change the economy or the political system; they would reshape the human being who lived inside them, at the level of the faculties through which any economy or political system could be experienced at all. McLuhan said this from the Catholic English department of a Canadian university, and the institutional shelter was not incidental. The Catholic intellectual tradition was the only American or near-American institutional shelter for the kind of philosophical anthropology Wiener could no longer publish from MIT, because the Catholic philosophy had preserved the medieval account of the human person through the centuries in which the modern philosophy had dismantled it, and the medieval account was the only available vocabulary for what the new media were doing to the men and women who watched them.

McLuhan's formal answer to the dialectical apparatus the modern philosophy had developed was the tetrad, which he set out in the late work as a four-cornered method of analysis applicable to any artifact or institution. Every technology, he wrote, enhances some faculty or capacity, obsolesces another that the new technology displaces, retrieves some older faculty or form that the displaced technology had itself displaced, and reverses or flips into its opposite when pressed to the limit of its capacity. The four moves were to be read simultaneously rather than sequentially, as the four faces of a single tetrahedron, and the structure was the explicit counter to the thesis-antithesis-synthesis triad of the Hegelian and Marxist tradition. The Hegelian dialectic produced a linear history that moved toward a final synthesis, the structure of modern progressive politics in all its variants; the tetrad produced a static structural analysis that read every technology as already complete in its four-way reorganization of the human sensibility, with no synthesis to come and no progressive arc to ride. The break with the progressive tradition was deliberate. McLuhan had read his Catholic philosophy and his Cambridge critics and his Toronto economist Harold Innis, whose 1950 *Empire and Communications* and 1951 *The Bias of Communication* had set out the argument that every civilization is organized around the dominant medium of its communication and that the shift from one dominant medium to another was the actual substance of what the older histories had called political change. The Toronto School that ran from Innis through McLuhan to Eric Havelock and Walter Ong, the Jesuit who would later document the oral-literate transition in his 1982 *Orality and Literacy*, produced across the decade a body of work that read the Western intellectual history as a history of media, and the new electronic media as the present occasion of a re-organization of the human person on the scale of the print revolution four centuries before.

What McLuhan offered the postwar Anglo-American world was the discipline that would have been needed to read what Wiener had been forced to stop reading, and he offered it through the institutional channel that the security state did not yet know to suppress, because the security state read the Catholic intellectual tradition as a conservative ally against the Soviet adversary and

did not yet see that the same tradition contained the only available philosophical apparatus for naming what the affluent order was doing to its members. By the early 1960s the channel would be visible, and McLuhan would become a public figure of a peculiar kind, an English professor whose work was read in advertising agencies and corporate planning departments as well as in the academy, a Catholic conservative whom the counterculture would adopt for reasons he largely declined to endorse. The 1950s set the apparatus that would produce that visibility. The *Mechanical Bride*, the long correspondence with Innis before Innis died in 1952, the seminars on culture and communication at Toronto from 1953 on, the *Explorations* journal that he edited with Edmund Carpenter from 1953 to 1959 and that printed early versions of what would become his major work: these were the decade's quiet construction of the counter-tradition. What the cybernetic table had been forced to leave unsaid, the medium-and-sensibility tradition was set up to say from a different angle, in a different vocabulary, with a different institutional patron, and from a country the FBI did not staff.

The instrument that forgot it most efficiently was new and sat in the corner of the living room. Across the decade the television set went from a curiosity in a few thousand homes to the fixture in the majority of them, and it became the domestic instrument through which the consumer order spoke to itself nightly, the advertisement delivered now not on a page to be turned past but into the room as moving image and sound. The medium itself transmitted an argument before any program did. A device that interrupts a story to sell a thing, and that funds the program precisely in order to gather the audience the merchandise is sold to, teaches a habit of attention in which entertainment and persuasion are no longer separable, in which the viewer is the product delivered to the sponsor. Dichter's depth interview and the television rating were the same instrument from two ends, one finding the buried motive and the other counting the eyes it reached.



U.S. households with a television, 1948–1960: the hearth assembled. Source: Television Bureau of Advertising; U.S. Census Bureau.

The form found its first great vehicle in the situation comedy, which located its template in a show that went on the air in October 1951 and within two seasons commanded an audience without precedent in the history of any medium. *I Love Lucy* was built around a real marriage, the redheaded comedian Lucille Ball and her Cuban bandleader husband Desi Arnaz, and its lasting innovation was as much technical as comic. Arnaz, refused permission to broadcast live from New York to a national audience that was mostly on the West Coast, insisted the show be shot on film before a studio crowd with three cameras running at once, an arrangement the networks thought wasteful and that became the standard form of the American sitcom for the rest of the century. The three-camera setup with its live laughter is the formal fact, and the fact is ideological. It manufactured, on film, the sound of a community responding in real time, and it piped that chorus into the isolated suburban living room where the actual neighbors were strangers behind hedges, so that the medium supplied the warmth of the village the suburb had paved over, a laugh track standing in for the missing street. The show that ran on this machinery dramatized the decade's domestic settlement and its strains at once. Each week Lucy, a woman of enormous comic and frankly unlimited energy, schemed to escape the apartment and break into her husband's nightclub act or into the world of work and fame, and each week the scheme collapsed into farce and she was returned, laughing and forgiven, to the home she was never permitted to leave. What the program enshrined was the nuclear family as the natural and sufficient container of a life, the breadwinner husband and the homemaker wife in their proper rooms; what erupted through the comedy was the surplus ambition of the woman the arrangement could not absorb, the talent and the appetite that had to be defeated, gently and hilariously, in every single episode because they were real and

would not stay contained. When the show wrote Ball's actual pregnancy into the story in early 1953, the network forbade the word pregnant as indecent and permitted only expecting, and the episode in which the character gave birth was watched in more American homes than the presidential inauguration that fell the next morning, the largest audience yet assembled by anything. A nation that could not say the word for how children came to be nonetheless gathered as one household to watch the event staged, the body's plainest fact at once hidden in language and sold as the climax of the most popular entertainment in the country. The set domesticated the management of desire, and the family gathered before it received, along with the comedy and the western, a continuous education in want.

The young found a different frequency, and it delivered a charge the order had not licensed. Out of the Black churches and juke joints of the South came a music built on the backbeat and the shout. On a July afternoon in 1953 a nineteen-year-old truck driver named Elvis Presley walked into the Memphis Recording Service, an eighteen-dollar storefront on Union Avenue run by a former radio engineer named Sam Phillips, and paid four dollars to cut a two-sided acetate as a birthday gift for his mother Gladys. Phillips's assistant Marion Keisker wrote on a notepad that he was a good ballad singer who could sustain the tune. A year later Phillips, who had been looking for a white singer who could channel the sound of his Black artists across the racial line of the radio market, called him back, paired him with the guitarist Scotty Moore and the bassist Bill Black, and on the night of the fifth of July 1954 caught the boy clowning between takes on a 1946 Arthur Crudup blues called "That's All Right." Phillips pressed it. Two years on, on the ninth of September 1956, Presley appeared on The Ed Sullivan Show before sixty million viewers, the largest television audience the country had ever assembled for a single transmission, and moved his body in a way the cameras were instructed, on his subsequent appearances, to crop above the waist. Rock and roll was the sound of the affluent order's own children reaching past the engineered want toward something the engineers had not supplied, a body and a beat and a sexuality the suburb had paved over. It was instantly commercial, absorbed and sold within a few years, the rebellion packaged and shipped like the abstraction on MoMA's walls; the order metabolized its own negations into product. But the formal fact remained that the energy the affluent young were buying was Black invention laundered into a salable white image, and that the transfer left a residue the order could not quite dissolve, an admission in the rhythm itself that the abundance had a basement it did not show.

What the music reached toward, the order had built its entire domestic settlement to govern, because the last frontier for an economy of managed desire was the appetite itself. The nuclear family of the suburb was not only a household arrangement but a doctrine about the body, the proposition that all of human sexuality belonged inside one marriage between one man and one woman and that everything outside it did not properly exist, a public morality of the wholesome

and the clean that the advertisement and the sitcom enforced as relentlessly as any church. The doctrine was challenged first not by a rebel but by a zoologist. Alfred Kinsey, an Indiana professor who had spent years cataloguing the variation among gall wasps, turned the same taxonomic method onto the human animal, gathering thousands of confidential sexual histories in long structured interviews and publishing the findings as two heavy clinical volumes, the male report in 1948 and the female report in 1953. The form was the scandal. Presented as dry science, columns of percentages with the affect of an actuarial table, the reports stated that the practices the official morality treated as rare perversions, masturbation and adultery and homosexual experience and premarital sex, were in fact ordinary and widespread, done by the same suburban husbands and wives who would have denied them on a witness stand. The female volume drew the greater fury, because a culture that could just about tolerate the admission that men strayed could not bear the documented finding that the homemaker in the kitchen had a desire and a history of her own. Kinsey was attacked from pulpits and hauled before the suspicion of Congress, his funding cut; what his percentages forced into the open was that the wholesome public body and the actual private one were two different bodies, that the nation living inside the family ideal did not in fact live the way the ideal described, and that the gap between the performed self and the real one which Dichter mined for profit ran straight through the bedroom.

What Kinsey reported as a statistic, a new magazine set out to sell as a product. In December 1953 a twenty-seven-year-old former *Esquire* copywriter named Hugh Hefner, fired from that magazine for asking for a five-dollar raise, working from his kitchen table on the South Side of Chicago with six hundred dollars of his own savings and a thousand more raised by mortgaging the furniture and asking forty-five friends and relatives to buy stock in a venture they did not understand, put out the first issue of *Playboy*, undated and with no return address because he did not know there would be a second. He had bought, for five hundred dollars from the John Baumgarth Calendar Company in Melrose Park, the rights to a nude photograph of Marilyn Monroe taken by Tom Kelley in 1949, when she was twenty-three and had posed for fifty dollars in cash to make a car payment after MGM let her option lapse. Hefner ran the photograph as the centerfold; the issue sold out fifty thousand copies in weeks. The operation it founded did something more consequential than the photograph. Hefner did not market his magazine as smut to be hidden but as an accessory to a sophisticated male life, wrapped around fiction and jazz criticism and consumer guidance on hi-fi sets and cocktails, the nude folded into the same glossy register as the advertisement beside it. The body became another commodity in the affluent catalogue, desire rebranded as taste, the centerfold sold by the identical method that sold the convertible and the cake mix, as the fantasy of a self the buyer might become. What *Playboy* presented was a refusal of the breadwinner's bargain from inside the consumer order rather than against it, the man who keeps the appetite and the disposable income but sheds the wife and the

mortgage and the lawn, freedom redefined as consumption without the family that consumption was supposed to serve. The buried truth was that this rebellion was no rebellion at all but the logic of the market arriving at its frontier, the discovery that the body and its wants were the last unmonetized territory and could be packaged and priced like everything else. Kinsey's clinical truth and Hefner's glossy fantasy were the same recognition reached from opposite ends, that the sexuality the family ideal had walled off was vast, real, and for sale, and the decade that preached the wholesome home was already, quietly, opening the door to the market that would colonize the bedroom for the rest of the century.

The same refusal found its first complete voice in prose in 1951, when a writer who would soon withdraw from the world entirely published a thin novel narrated by a sixteen-year-old who could not stop saying the word phony. J. D. Salinger let Holden Caulfield tell the whole of *The Catcher in the Rye* in a single confiding spoken rush, and the form is the argument. The novel has almost no plot, because plot would impose the hierarchy of importance the consumer order imposes on everything, and what Holden cannot bear is exactly how the world sorts experience into the significant and the negligible, the brand and the off-brand, the thing worth wanting and the thing to discard. He moves through the manufactured surfaces of the affluent city, the prep school and the nightclub and the hotel, and he reads each one as a performance staged for an audience that has agreed not to notice it is being sold to. His word for the whole machine, phony, is the child's intuition of what Dichter had made into a profession, the sense that the self on offer everywhere is an engineered fantasy of a self, and that the people inside it are reciting a script they did not write and cannot see. Harold Bloom, who admired the novel without overrating it, placed Salinger below Twain and Fitzgerald and Melville in aesthetic reach yet granted the voice its real achievement, the invention of an inwardness so particular that two generations of the young mistook it for their own. The agon Bloom heard underneath was Salinger's wrestle with Twain, Holden a Huck Finn whose river has been paved and whose territory to light out for no longer exists, since the frontier has been subdivided into lots and sold on thirty-year notes. The novel sustains the dream of an authentic self preserved intact against a world of fakes, the watcher in the rye who keeps the children from the fall into the phony adult market; the conviction the surface declines to name it cannot quite face is that there is no field to stand in, that Holden's purity is itself a posture and his breakdown the price he pays to demand an unmediated reality from an order that supplies only the mediated kind. The order recognized its own negation and did what it always did. The novel that arraigned the manufactured self became required reading and then a packaged object in its own right, the cardinal text of an adolescence the market would soon discover it could sell back to the adolescent as a product called rebellion.

The decade's most complete account of how the order handled its own past arrived on a Broadway stage at the very end, in November 1959, as a family musical. *The Sound of Music*, the

last work of Rodgers and Hammerstein, set the story of a singing Austrian family on the eve of the Anschluss, the German absorption of Austria in 1938, and ended with the von Trapps escaping over the mountains as the Reich closed in. The show was an enormous success and a piece of consummate craft, and read for its form rather than its sentiment it performs a precise operation. A real political catastrophe, the willing collapse of a nation into the arms of the dictatorship next door, much of it greeted in Austria itself with cheering crowds, is metabolized into a story of a governess and a widower and seven children and a wedding, the trauma displaced onto a family melodrama in which the Nazis are a few uniformed men at the edges and the resolution is a private escape rather than a reckoning. The political content is not denied; it is laundered, processed into nostalgia and song so that an audience could feel the shadow of the historical horror as a pleasant chill behind a love story and go home consoled. This is ideology working exactly as the consumer order needed it to work, the unbearable thing made bearable, sold, and enjoyed. What the show secures is that decency survives intact and escapes clean, that a family with the right songs in its heart slips over the mountain while history happens to other people; the fact the surface declines to admit it cannot say is that the nation in the story largely welcomed what the family fled, and that the audience humming the tunes in 1959 was being taught to remember a fascism's arrival as the backdrop to a wedding. It is the consent produced as an industrial output reaching the deepest material there is, the recent memory of a continent's catastrophe, and converting it into a property that could be performed eight times a week.

Near 1957 the American order exhibits live dynamism: an expanding economy, a population that still makes things on a vast scale, a society opening its elite to the gifted poor in a way the old aristocracy never had. The dollar's strength is real and its anchor in gold still endures. But the pressures that age an order have begun to register. Financialization shows in its early form, the household and the nation alike living on future promises. The error-correcting reflexes of an open phase are straining under the loyalty boards and the security state the Cold War had hardened into permanent procedure. And at the very end of the decade a small polished sphere named Sputnik passed over American cities every ninety minutes, and the panic it produced was out of all proportion to the threat, because what cracked was not a defense but a confidence, the unspoken assumption that the future belonged by some natural law to the side that had won the war and printed the world's money. But the paintings and the musical had registered what no survey of pressures contains: an order that had learned to manage desire so thoroughly that it could sell a population its own rebellion, its own anxiety, and its own historical trauma, all at a profit.

The metaphysical floor under all of it had been laid in the German seminar a century and a half before and surfaces here without ceremony. The consumer order does not present its members with things so much as with the shared pictures of things, the brand image Dichter helped manufacture and the dream the advertisement hardened into a shape, collective fictions that

everyone agrees to inhabit and that are real in the only way a banknote is real, by common consent that can be withdrawn. The suburb itself was such a picture, an image of the good life supplied ready-made, and the household lived inside it as though it were the thing. Rothko spent his darkening decade trying to paint past the supplied picture toward something that would answer to nothing outside itself, and the difficulty of that attempt, inside an order with a price and a sales report for every surface, is the tragedy in his late maroons.

What survived is not the arrangement these works were made inside, which changed on something close to schedule. The dollar's gold anchor, sound through the fifties, would be cut inside a dozen years; the covert network that crated and shipped the abstraction abroad would be exposed and discredited soon after; and the confidence Sputnik cracked was never made whole. The works outlasted all of it. Pollock's all-over field arrests the eye with no place to rest, the most honest account anyone made of a consciousness that had thrown out the inherited hierarchy of figure and ground and stood inside the result. Rothko's rectangles hang low in their dim rooms and ask for the solitary attention the affluent order was built to prevent, darkening toward the end he was painting toward before he reached it. Holden Caulfield goes on talking in the present tense, a boy who cannot abide the phony, the indictment of the manufactured self still in print, and still, by the order's old reflex, for sale. Lean's bridge rises in its doomed grandeur while the men who wrote it go on receiving, decades late, the credit a frightened state withheld. The music that came up out of the excluded basement is the sound the order could absorb but never fully clean. And the family musical performs its quiet operation on every audience that weeps at the mountain crossing, the recent horror laundered into song so completely that most who hum it do not feel the trauma underneath. Each was made by one mind under the load of an order at its confident noon, an abundance that ran on the production of want. The order has gone. These are the forms a victorious order makes when it still believes itself, and what they sell back to that order is the single picture it most needs: that a civilization can learn to sell its members anything, including the picture of who they are, and that the sale stands only so long as the consent beneath it is not withdrawn.

The postwar consumer boom consolidated the vision of America as an anti-civilisation - a vast, comfortable money-game where material abundance masked a profound spiritual and civic atomization. The machinery that distributed this abundance was equally punishing. The postwar university and corporate ladder functioned as a Meritocracy as trauma-machine. It was an exam-driven system that bred insecure, dissociative achievers, ensuring that the new managerial elite were brilliant at navigating procedures but devoid of moral courage. This was Death by Meritocracy in its purest form, paving the way for institutions like Harvard to function less as academies and more as the world's most exclusive VC firm.

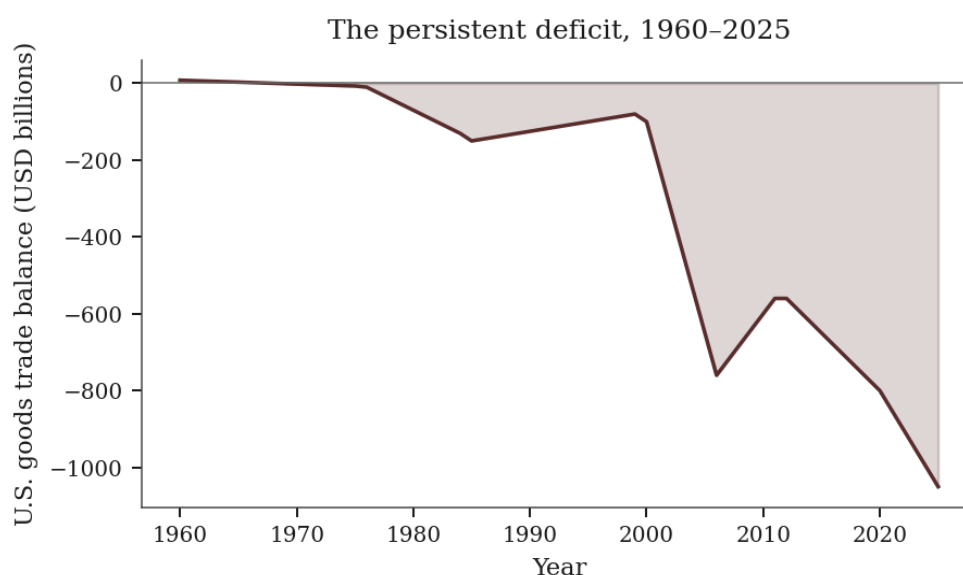
1960 – 1969

In a war room that does not exist, a circle of light hangs over a circular table, and the men beneath it argue the end of the world with the deadpan courtesy of a board meeting. Stanley Kubrick had grown up in the Bronx, the son of a Hungarian Jewish physician, dropping out of high school at seventeen to be a staff photographer at *Look* magazine, and had made his first feature at twenty-four on borrowed money. By thirty-five, working in self-imposed exile from a manor house in Hertfordshire because he was afraid of flying and of the Manhattan he had left, he had bought the rights to Peter George's sober thriller *Red Alert* for three thousand five hundred dollars and meant to film it straight, a tense procedural about an accidental nuclear launch. He hired the production designer Ken Adam to build the war room from a photograph of nothing, since no journalist had ever seen the real place, and lit it so that the table threw its glow up onto the faces from below, the way a poker game is lit, so that the most consequential decision a species could make would look like a hand of cards played for the usual stakes. The picture reached American screens on the twenty-ninth of January 1964, two months after President Kennedy was shot in Dallas, and almost nothing about it had been planned as comedy. Kubrick found that every time he sat down to write the scenes honestly the material turned absurd in his hands. The terrors he was trying to dramatize kept arriving as jokes, and after months of resistance he hired the satirist Terry Southern, on Peter Sellers's recommendation, to come to London and help him surrender to what the material was already doing. Sellers, who had been cast in three roles, was meant to play a fourth, the Texan bomber pilot Major T. J. "King" Kong who rides the bomb down at the close; he sprained his ankle and refused, and the role went to the rodeo actor Slim Pickens, who arrived in London and asked his driver where he could buy boots. A consciousness sent to register the central dread of its decade discovered that the terror could not be rendered solemnly, because what it had become was not tragic but procedural, a machinery of escalation that ran on its own and made the human beings inside it superfluous to their own catastrophe.

The decade Kubrick was filming had a financial signature, and it was a contradiction the United States had not yet learned it could not sustain. The dollar sat at the center of the postwar monetary order as the one currency redeemable in gold, fixed at thirty-five dollars to the ounce, and every other major unit was pegged to the dollar in turn. The arrangement made Washington the banker of the noncommunist world, and it contained a flaw that the Belgian economist Robert Triffin named in front of Congress in 1960 with a clarity that proved exact. For the world to have enough dollars to trade and to keep in reserve, the United States had to run deficits and ship those dollars abroad; but the more dollars accumulated overseas, the less credible became the promise that each one could still be exchanged for metal that was not multiplying. Confidence and supply pulled against each other, and there was no level at which both could be satisfied at once. The flaw

was written into the design, and no amount of competent management could remove it; the most a Treasury could do was defer.

By 1960 the dollar price of gold in London had jumped above the official thirty-five, and the central banks of the West, led by the United States, assembled the London Gold Pool in 1961 to defend the line by selling their own bullion whenever the open market bid the price up. Eight allied treasuries pooled their metal and dressed in the language of cooperation an operation whose purpose was to manufacture a confidence the underlying numbers no longer supported. The dollar's link to gold had stopped working by itself, and a club of governments now spent real bullion to keep the published figure from telling the truth. The pool was openly announced, which is how the most durable coordinations work, in plain sight, their real function hidden behind the dullness of the official description. Few citizens of the eight countries could have said that their own central banks were quietly auctioning national gold to subsidize a foreign currency's promise. The operation hid not in secrecy but in the boredom of its own paperwork.



U.S. goods trade balance, 1960–2025: the Triffin trajectory in one line. Source: Bureau of Economic Analysis.

Beneath that effort ran the deeper cause of the strain, and the whole later century runs out of the mechanism that made it. A dollar in the postwar order was a claim on gold, and the United States controlled the gold, so that when Washington spent abroad it paid in paper that the receiver could in principle bring back to the Treasury window and convert to metal. As long as foreign holders trusted the paper, they kept it, and the dollars piled up in the vaults of European and Japanese banks as reserves rather than coming home for redemption. That trust was itself the thing being spent. The United States had decided to pay for two enormous undertakings at once without

raising the taxes to cover either, to fight a war in Southeast Asia and build a Great Society at home, guns and butter together, and it financed the gap by issuing dollars the rest of the world was increasingly reluctant to accept. Every dollar created to buy a rifle or a housing program and sent overseas was a fresh claim on a stock of gold that did not grow, so the ratio of paper claims to metal worsened with each year of the double spending. The cost of the contradiction fell on the foreign holders of dollars, who would be repaid in a currency worth less than the one they had lent, the difference quietly transferred from their savings to the American treasury as a tax they never voted on; and it fell on the soldiers and civilians of a small country that the order's bookkeepers reduced to a row of statistics. The deferral was not free. It was arranged so that those who chose it were not those who paid.

The war that drained the gold must be told in full, because the decade's whole monetary and moral crisis ran out of it, and because the manner in which it widened shows what an order does when its account of itself begins to diverge from the felt fact. The United States entered Vietnam by increments small enough that no single one looked like a decision to go to war. There were a few hundred advisers under Eisenhower, more than sixteen thousand by the time Kennedy was killed in Dallas in November 1963, men who trained the South Vietnamese army and were not supposed to fight but did. The hinge came in the Gulf of Tonkin in early August 1964, when two American destroyers reported torpedo attacks by North Vietnamese boats off the coast. The first encounter was real; the second, the one Johnson used to justify the escalation, almost certainly never happened, a phantom of sonar echoes and frayed nerves on a dark sea that the administration presented to Congress as a clear act of aggression. On the seventh of August Congress passed the Gulf of Tonkin Resolution nearly unopposed, handing the president an open authorization to use whatever force he judged necessary, and the war that no legislature ever formally declared had its legal engine. The pattern set there endured to the end: the public reason given for each step was firmer and cleaner than the murky thing that had actually occurred, and the gap between the two widened with every escalation.

That the escalation came under Johnson and not the man who had begun it is the hinge the official chronology hurries past. The clause that counts sixteen thousand advisers by November 1963 also notes a removal, and the manner of it asks more than the date allows. John Kennedy had entered the presidency a creature of the order he led and left it at odds with the permanent state beneath it. The Bay of Pigs in April 1961, a Cuban invasion the intelligence service had planned and sold to him as certain, collapsed on the beach and humiliated him, and the men who had promised it expected him to send the airpower that would have widened it into open war. He refused, and afterward he spoke of breaking the agency into a thousand pieces and scattering it to the winds, moved to strip the clandestine service of the autonomy it had grown accustomed to, and turned in his last year toward a thaw with Moscow and a quiet feeler toward Havana that the cold

warriors around him read as apostasy. There were the first instructions to begin pulling the advisers home. A president at war with the machinery of covert action and the war-finance it served was a man that machinery had reason to want gone, and that motive is the reading the chapter inherits. The documentary trail is narrower and stranger. In Dallas on the twenty-second of November 1963 he was killed in an open car as the motorcade slowed, and the road to the escalation he had been resisting lay open within the week. The commission Johnson appointed found a lone and friendless man, Lee Harvey Oswald, firing three shots from a warehouse window, and rested its case on a single bullet that would have had to pass through two men and turn in the air to do what the wounds required. Before Oswald could be tried, before he could say in a courtroom what he claimed on camera, that he was a patsy, he was shot dead in the basement of a police station, inside a cordon of officers, by a nightclub owner with connections to the criminal world the agency had used against Castro. The one mouth that might have answered the question was closed in custody. Whether the chain of unlikelihood was only the ordinary work of chance, the documents do not settle; what it settles is that the chain occurred and that the reading is consistent with several authors and with none. What followed is not in dispute: the advisers were not withdrawn, the destroyers steamed into the Gulf of Tonkin within the year, and the war that drained the gold proceeded under a successor who had inherited both the machine and its preferred direction.

In February 1965 the bombing began. Operation Rolling Thunder was meant to be a measured campaign of pressure, calibrated raid by raid to persuade Hanoi that the cost of supporting the insurgency in the South would rise faster than any gain. It ran for more than three years. It dropped a tonnage of explosive that exceeded what the United States had dropped in the whole Pacific theater of the Second World War. It did not persuade. The faith behind it was the managerial creed Kubrick was already mocking, the conviction that violence could be metered like a thermostat, that a rational adversary would read the signal in the rising dial and yield. The adversary did not read it that way. The war meant something different to him than a cost-benefit calculation, and the bombs fell on a peasant society that absorbed them and kept moving men and rice south down the trails through Laos and Cambodia. The ground commitment followed the air. The first Marines waded ashore at Da Nang in March 1965, sent to guard an airfield and then sent beyond it, and from there the numbers climbed with a logic of their own. By the end of 1965 there were roughly a hundred and eighty thousand American troops in Vietnam; the figure passed three hundred thousand, then four hundred thousand, and reached its peak of five hundred and forty-three thousand in the spring of 1969, an army the size of a great city set down in a country most of the men in it could not have placed on a map two years before.

What the war was on the ground bore no resemblance to the war as the briefing rooms rendered it. There was no front, no territory to take and occupy, no enemy capital toward which a

line advanced. There were patrols through paddies and triple-canopy jungle in heat that rotted boots and skin, ambushes that lasted ninety seconds and killed men who never saw who fired, booby traps and punji stakes and mines that took legs off boys who had been in the country a week. The measure of progress, in the absence of ground gained, became the body count, the daily tally of enemy dead radioed up the chain and aggregated into the statistic that was supposed to prove the war was being won. The metric corrupted everything it touched. A unit's success was its kill ratio, so the dead were counted generously and the line between a Viet Cong fighter and a farmer in the wrong village blurred under the pressure to produce numbers. Villages were razed to deny the enemy cover and their inhabitants moved into camps; defoliants stripped the forests and poisoned the people who lived under them; and at My Lai in March 1968 an American company murdered several hundred unarmed villagers, women and children among them, an atrocity the Army concealed for a year and a half before it broke into print and forced the country to look at what the body-count war had made ordinary. The men who fought it were largely conscripts, drawn by a draft that the sons of the comfortable could escape through college deferments and sympathetic doctors, so that the war fell hardest on the working class and the poor and the Black, who died in a proportion above their share of the population. They served one-year tours and rotated home one at a time into a country that increasingly did not want to hear what they had seen, and the war that the order had begun as a calibrated demonstration of resolve became, for the men inside it, a thing with no shape and no end and no clear reason that any briefing could make cohere.

The same confidence ran through the domestic statutes of the season, and one act of that autumn lit a longer fuse than any escalation in the war. On the third of October 1965, at the foot of the Statue of Liberty, Lyndon Johnson signed the Hart-Celler Act, which abolished the national-origins quotas that had rationed entry to the republic by ancestry since 1924. He told the crowd what his experts had told him: "This bill that we will sign today is not a revolutionary bill." The men who managed it through Congress said the same in every register. Edward Kennedy assured the Senate that the ethnic mix of the country would not be upset; Emanuel Celler told the House that few Asians or Africans would come, since the law admitted by kinship and they had few relatives present to invite them. The family preference itself was the restrictionists' device: Michael Feighan, the Ohio chairman who distrusted the administration's skills-first draft, forced kinship to the top of the priority list on the theory that the relatives of the existing population would reproduce its composition automatically, and the American Legion's lobbyists praised him for having "devised a naturally operating national-origins system." Every assurance was sincere, and every one was a body count read off a dashboard: the planners mistook the model's behavior for the world's. European demand fell because Europe was prospering; the preference machinery turned instead toward Asia, Latin America, and Africa, where the applicants were; and each

2. Lyndon Johnson, remarks at the signing of the Immigration and Nationality Act, Liberty Island, October 3, 1965; Edward Kennedy, Senate subcommittee hearings on S. 500, February 10, 1965; Tom Gjelten, *A Nation of Nations* (2015).

arrival's petition seeded the next, so that by 2010 family unification accounted for roughly three quarters of all legal entry. The act that was not revolutionary rebuilt the demography of the republic more thoroughly than any law of its century, and it did so on the schedule of generations rather than news cycles, which is why the chapter that meets its consequences lies fifty years ahead of this one. The fuse lit on Liberty Island burned out of sight, under four more decades of monetary weather, before anyone in power conceded it had been lit²

Andy Warhol, born Andrew Warhola in 1928 to Carpatho-Rusyn immigrants in Pittsburgh's Slovakian quarter, the son of a coal miner who died when Andy was thirteen, had grown up an asthmatic boy with St. Vitus' Dance who collected movie magazines from his sickbed and made his name in 1950s Manhattan as the highest-paid commercial illustrator in the city, drawing shoes for the I. Miller chain for fifty dollars a sketch. He understood the dollar in a different register, that of the image, and he grasped it earlier than the economists did. In July of 1962 he showed thirty-two canvases of Campbell's soup cans at the Ferus Gallery on La Cienega Boulevard in Los Angeles, one painting for each variety the company then sold, priced at one hundred dollars each. The dealer Irving Blum bought the entire set for one thousand dollars and kept it together; he sold it forty-five years later to the Museum of Modern Art for an undisclosed eight-figure sum. The scandal of the show was that it refused to choose. There was no composition, no hierarchy, no gesture of the artist's hand asserting that this can mattered more than that one. The cans simply repeated, as products repeat on a shelf, and the repetition was the statement. Shortly after that exhibition closed, Warhol abandoned the brush almost entirely and took up the photographic silkscreen, a commercial reproduction method that let him push one image through a mesh onto canvas after canvas, varying the registration and the color but never the underlying picture. He silkscreened Marilyn Monroe in the weeks after her death from barbiturate overdose in August of that year, working from a publicity still from the 1953 picture *Niagara*, her face rendered in flat industrial color and run across a grid until the face became a pattern. He set up a working space in a fifth-floor loft on East Forty-seventh Street, lined the walls with aluminum foil and painted the rest silver, and called it the Factory, the name itself the point: the studio reorganized as a production line, the assistants as employees, the artist as the brand under which the line ran. On the third of June 1968 Valerie Solanas, a radical writer whose play Warhol had declined to produce, walked into the Factory and shot him three times at point-blank range with a Beretta. He survived only by the surgical chance that the bullet missed both ventricles; he wore a surgical corset for the rest of his life and was haunted, in his diaries, by the certainty that he had died on the operating table and was being shown the rest of his life as a film. The Kantian floor of the whole century surfaces in his work without ceremony: the consumer order does not present its members with soup or with a dead actress but with the shared picture of soup and the common image of the star, a collective fiction that everyone agrees to inhabit, real in the only way a banknote is real. He died in

February 1987 of a cardiac arrest after routine gall bladder surgery at New York Hospital, sixty years old.

He built a place to do it that he named the Factory, a loft on East Forty-seventh Street that his assistant covered in silver foil and paint, and he staffed it with the people the official order had no use for, the runaways and drag performers and amphetamine talkers who drifted through while the silkscreens dried. The name was the joke and the truth at once. Warhol said he wanted to be a machine, to paint the way a machine paints, and he meant it as a release from the obligation to feel, a duty modern publicity had already exhausted. The Factory turned out images the way the country produced everything else, in runs, by division of labor, with the maker's signature reduced to a controlling instruction rather than a personal touch. What the economic story could not yet name, the swelling supply of dollars whose value was draining out of any anchor in metal, Warhol had rendered as a rising flood of identical pictures whose worth floated free of any mooring in the hand. What that broke through the silver surface was the suspicion that an order of pure circulation has no bottom, that a society organized around the reproduction and consumption of images is one whose central object can be multiplied without limit and therefore believed in only by collective consent, which can be withdrawn.

That war and that order arrived, for most Americans, on a screen in the living room. Television had become the hearth of the postwar household across the previous decade, and by the middle of the sixties it had passed the newspaper as the way most people learned what was happening in the world. The networks sent camera crews to Vietnam and brought back film that ran on the evening news a day or two after it was shot, and for the first time a population watched its own soldiers wounded and dying in its own homes while it ate dinner. Much of the footage was bloodless and dull, the daily ration of a correspondent in a flak jacket reciting figures against a backdrop of helicopters; but enough of it was not. The country saw a Marine touch his lighter to the thatch of a village at Cam Ne in 1965 while an old woman pleaded, saw the wounded borne on ponchos, saw the faces of the men who would not be coming back. No earlier war had been visible this way, and the visibility worked against the official account by a simple mechanism: the briefing said progress and the film showed a man with his clothes alight, and the eye believed the film. What the televised war wore through was the postwar faith that the screen was a window, a neutral pane through which the citizen saw reality whole and judged it for himself, the democratic promise of the medium distilled. What erupted through that fantasy was the discovery that the window framed, that it could show the leveled village and not the ambush that preceded it, that a war reduced to its most arresting images would be judged on them and not on the strategy memoranda, and that an order whose legitimacy rested on the story it told could lose the story to a medium it did not control. The same instrument that the order trusted to convey its message to the people delivered instead the evidence against it.

The screen taught the young as deliberately as it informed their parents. In November 1969, in the last weeks of the decade, a program called Sesame Street went out over the public stations, the product of a foundation-funded venture named the Children's Television Workshop that Joan Ganz Cooney and Lloyd Morrisett had built on a startling premise: that the techniques of the commercial advertisement, the jingle and the quick cut and the repeated brand, could be turned from the manufacture of desire to drill letters and numbers into poor children who would otherwise reach school behind. The show studied the methods that sold cereal and used them to sell the alphabet, drilling a single letter the way a sponsor drills a slogan, and it worked, and it reached millions. What it embodied was the high liberal confidence of the Great Society itself, the conviction that the same machinery of mass persuasion that built the consumer could be aimed at justice and would close the gap between the poor child and the comfortable one. The buried truth was that the technique was indifferent to its content, that a method refined to make children want sugar would work as well on letters and would work as well, later, on anything at all, and that a generation raised from infancy on the rhythms of the advertisement was being fitted, in the very act of being taught to read, for a life lived inside the persuasion machine. Bernays had built the engine for the management of the adult mind four decades earlier; here it reached down to the cradle, and it did so in the name of helping.

If Warhol made the consumer order confess what it was, the most successful film of the decade drew from it a confession of what it wished to be. *The Sound of Music* reached American screens on the second of March 1965, and it retained the title of the highest-grossing film ever made for five years. Robert Wise shot the Austrian Alps in a saturated color that made the meadows look laundered, and he placed at the center of the story a family rescued from the dullness of discipline by song and then delivered from the Nazis by their own goodness, the whole of it borne on melodies a child could hum on the first hearing. The historical event sitting inside that prettiness is the Anschluss, the absorption of Austria into the Reich in 1938, an annexation that crowds of actual Austrians greeted in those same squares with raised arms and genuine joy. The film keeps the swastika and the menacing officer and the midnight escape, and by keeping them it performs a more complete erasure than silence could, because it converts a nation's broad complicity into the private wickedness of a few uniformed men whom one virtuous household outwits and outsings. What the picture enshrines is the postwar Western order's need to remember the fascist years as a story of innocents and monsters, with the vast middle of ordinary consent edited out. The fact the picture would not show is that the people in the cheering squares were the same kind of people as the audience in the theater, that consent to a monstrous order is not the property of monsters but the ordinary disposition of populations under the right pressure, and that a society which can be sung into love can be sung into anything. This was the same era's other great industry of manufactured feeling, the machinery Bernays had built decades earlier turned

now upon memory itself. Advertising tells an audience what to want next; the musical, more quietly, edits the past of what they should have wanted yesterday, which is the more total instruction because it reaches backward and rewrites the order one lives inside.

A second reorganization of belief was running under the decade, slower than the war and more intimate, and it began with a pill. In May 1960 the Food and Drug Administration approved Enovid, a compound of synthetic hormones, for use as a contraceptive, and within a few years several million American women were taking it. For the whole of written history sex had entailed the possibility of a child as its near-inseparable consequence, and the entire architecture of marriage, female virtue, and the household had been built on that link. The pill cut it. For the first time a woman could decide, privately and reliably, whether and when to bear a child, and the decision belonged to her body rather than to a husband, a church, or chance. The law moved with the chemistry: in 1965 the Supreme Court, in *Griswold v. Connecticut*, struck down a state ban on contraceptives for married couples and located in the Constitution a right to marital privacy, a zone government could not enter, and the reasoning it used would be reached for again in the decade that followed to extend that privacy further still. What the pill announced was the consumer order's deepest promise extended to its final frontier, the pledge that the self could be liberated from every inherited constraint and remade by choice, that even reproduction, the oldest given of the body, could become an elective transaction the individual managed. The recognition the public account declined was that the liberation was also a colonization, that desire freed from consequence became available as never before to the market and the screen, a renewable resource to be stimulated and sold; the same severing that gave a woman her autonomy opened the body itself as the last territory the machinery of manufactured wanting had not yet fully entered.

The culture metabolized the new freedom faster than it could understand it, and by the summer of 1967 a hundred thousand of the young had converged on the Haight-Ashbury district of San Francisco for what the press named the Summer of Love, a mass experiment in living outside the postwar bargain. Free love was its slogan and its practice, sex detached from marriage and from property and offered as a sacrament of the liberated self, and it ran together with the drugs and the music and the refusal of the war into a single repudiation of the order the parents had built. The experiment was real and it was brief, and what it expressed was true even where it was naive: that the abundance the consumer order had produced had hollowed out the disciplines it was supposed to reward, and that a generation raised in unprecedented comfort found the comfort empty and went looking for meaning in the body, in transcendence, in community, in everything the affluent suburb had been built to make unnecessary. The order had promised that prosperity was the end of the human story, and the children of the prosperous answered that it was not nearly enough.

Betty Friedan had named the emptiness on the other side of the gender line three years before the Haight filled, and the path she had taken into the book is the one detail her own bestseller hid. Born Bettye Naomi Goldstein in Peoria, Illinois, in 1921, the daughter of a jeweler and a Smith-educated mother who had given up newspaper work to marry, she had graduated from Smith summa cum laude in 1942 and gone into labor journalism on the Federated Press wire and at the UE News, the publication of the United Electrical, Radio, and Machine Workers, the most communist-influenced of the postwar labor unions. She had written under bylines, on women in industry and Black workers' rights, for the better part of a decade. She had been fired from the UE News in 1952 because she became pregnant with her second child. She moved to a suburb in Rockland County, raised three children, kept writing for the women's magazines as a freelancer, and in 1957 sent a questionnaire to her Smith classmates on the fifteenth anniversary of their graduation that became the seed of her book. The *Feminine Mystique* appeared in February 1963 and reframed its author as a frustrated suburban housewife who had been jarred awake by the survey, an autobiographical compression that elided the radical labor years; the elision was strategic. Her argument was that the postwar ideal of the fulfilled suburban wife, the woman whose whole horizon was husband, children, and a well-kept house, was a manufactured image that left the women who tried to live inside it sick with a discontent they could not name, the problem that has no name. The book sold three million copies in three years because it spoke a thing that had been felt privately by women who each thought the failure was hers alone, and in naming it Friedan turned a mass of separate unhappinesses into a movement. In June 1966 she helped found the National Organization for Women in a Washington hotel room with twenty-seven other women, sketched the logo on a napkin, and became its first president; the second wave of American feminism had its institution. The fantasy Friedan exposed was the very picture that *The Sound of Music* and the network sitcom had sold as the natural order, the contented household as the destination of all desire; what she dragged into the open was that the ideal had been engineered, that the same machinery of persuasion which sold appliances had sold women a self designed to consume them. The pill had given women the technical means for a different life; Friedan supplied them with the language to say why they wanted one.

The figure of HAL in the next picture had a real intellectual lineage, and naming it sharpens what Kubrick was actually staging. In 1948 the engineer Claude Shannon had published, at Bell Labs, *A Mathematical Theory of Communication*, which gave information a precise quantitative form for the first time. Information, on Shannon's account, is the reduction of uncertainty, measured in bits, and the same equations govern a telephone wire, a sentence, a punched card, a genome, a stock price. The same year Norbert Wiener, at MIT, named cybernetics, the study of systems that govern themselves by feedback. A thermostat reads the gap between the set point and the room and adjusts; a body reads the gap between its temperature and homeostasis and adjusts;

an economy and a state, on Wiener's account, are doing the same operation at scale, and a society that fails to read the feedback is one that has stopped adjusting. The pair of insights, an information theory and a feedback theory, set down at the end of the 1940s, were the substrate the 1960s decade ran on. Mainframe computing, military command and control, the surveillance state, the consumer credit score, the early television ratings industry, the war as a body count fed up the chain and back down as bombing targets, all of them were engineered on Shannon's bits and Wiener's loops. By 1968 the device sat in films as well as in laboratories. Across town and over the Atlantic the same suspicion that broke the silver surface took a colder form in the cutting rooms where Kubrick worked. He distrusted the warmth that conventional cinema used to keep its audiences inside a human point of view, and across the decade he stripped it out with growing severity. *Dr. Strangelove* already framed its catastrophe as a system that had escaped its operators, the automated launch order that cannot be recalled, the doomsday device built to detonate without a human in the loop precisely so that no person's weakness could prevent it. The bomb in that film is not a weapon men use; it is a process that uses men, and the famous closing montage of detonations set to a sentimental song is the system completing itself while the species that built it falls silent. By 1968, in *2001: A Space Odyssey*, which had its premiere on the second of April, Kubrick had perfected the coldness into a formal principle. The film moves with the patience of a machine and the symmetry of an equation. Spacecraft turn to waltzes; corridors curve with the indifference of a centrifuge; the human characters are flattened into functionaries who speak in the bland cadences of a corporate briefing, while the one figure on screen with anything resembling an inner life is the computer that runs the ship. HAL is courteous, frightened, and finally murderous, and the horror of the sequence in which he is shut down is that he is the only thing aboard that seems to mind dying. What the picture secures is the postwar managerial dream in its purest form, the conviction that any problem yields to enough intelligence and enough method; what erupts is the recognition that the system, perfected, no longer needs its makers and may not preserve them, that the system built to serve human ends acquires ends of its own and outlasts the people who switched it on.

In Paris, four months before Kubrick's premiere, the suspicion took its most expensive form. Jacques Tati spent the better part of a decade building a city in which to film one: *Tataville*, a miniature metropolis of glass and steel raised outside Paris, with its own power plant and office blocks at full scale, because the joke required modernity's actual weight, not a painted set. A storm wrecked part of it midway, and the repairs alone cost 1.4 million francs; the final accounts are contested to this day, and no single figure deserves print. What the expenditure bought is *Playtime*, which opened at the Empire-Cin rama on the sixteenth of December 1967: a nearly wordless comedy in which Monsieur Hulot and a party of American tourists wander a Paris of identical glass towers, looking for the city they came to see. They find it only in reflections. The Eiffel

3. *Playtime*, premiered December 16, 1967, at the Empire-Cin rama, Paris; the production costs are contested; Sight & Sound critics' polls, 2012 and 2022.

Tower and Sacré-Cœur appear as ghosts in the plate-glass doors as they swing open and shut, the old city visible only in the surfaces of the new one, present the way a memory is; the film never cuts away to the real thing. The gag is the mildest indictment the decade produced: modernity as a place where the human eye must catch its inheritance secondhand, at the angle of a door. The rendering ruined its maker. Tati had borrowed against his company, then his own fortune, then his friends; the debts took the rights to his three earlier films and finally his house, and the man who built a city to mourn one died owning neither. The verdict reversed at the pace this book has learned to expect: dismissed at release as an indulgence, the picture now stands in the critics' decennial polls among the first rank of the art, the folly promoted to monument half a century after the bill was paid³

The same recognition that machines and systems could exceed and consume their masters drove the strangest publishing event of the decade. Frank Herbert had been a newspaperman in Tacoma and San Francisco, a speechwriter for a Republican senator from Oregon, and a freelance journalist who in 1957 was sent by the Department of Agriculture to write a magazine story about an experimental dune-stabilization project at Florence on the Oregon coast, where teams were planting European beachgrass to halt the windblown sand from burying the coastal highway. He stood on the dunes for hours. The article never ran. He spent the next six years researching what became *Dune*, reading deep into Bedouin water economies, the sociology of charismatic movements, and Sufi mysticism, and serialized the novel across the pages of John W. Campbell's *Analog* magazine between December 1963 and May 1965 in two parts called *Dune World* and *The Prophet of Dune*. He was turned away by twenty-three publishers; the agent who finally placed the finished manuscript in August 1965 with Chilton, a Philadelphia house known for automobile repair manuals, took a flat fee of seven thousand five hundred dollars and the novel sold so slowly its first year that Herbert kept his newspaper job until the paperback editions in the late sixties made him solvent. The book that nobody wanted became the best-selling science-fiction novel ever written, and its subject is how a messiah is manufactured. Herbert built a galactic economy that rests entirely on a single substance mined from one desert planet, a spice the entire interstellar economy could not move without, so whoever controls the substance commands the whole order. The book was published in August 1965, eight years before the OPEC embargo and nine before William Simon flew to Jeddah to seal the petrodollar arrangement, and the parallel is closer than coincidence: a civilization whose mobility depends on liquid pumped from a few barren places, governed by a deal between an outside hegemon and the desert tribes who sit on the resource, with prophecy and the threat of withholding both as weapons. Read forward from 1965, *Dune* is the petrodollar order written in fiction before it arrived: the chokepoint commodity, the Bedouin economy made indispensable, the imperial calculus of who supplies whose fleet, and the eschatological language a desert people uses to bend an empire that depends on it. Into that

economy Herbert set a long covert program, a religious order called the Bene Gesserit, that has spent thousands of years breeding bloodlines toward a superbeing and seeding prophecies among credulous desert peoples so that whoever arrives matching the prophecy will be received as their savior. The hero fulfills the design, takes the resource, claims the empire, and Herbert's point, made explicit in his own later remarks, was that this is a horror and not a triumph, that the messiah who rides a manufactured eschatology to power leaves catastrophe behind him. He was so worried that the first novel would be misread as a triumphant adventure that he wrote *Dune Messiah* specifically to bury its hero under the consequences. What the novel conceals is the dream of the engineered redeemer, the leader whose authority is built rather than born; the proposition the form will not quite state is that the prophecies a people believes about its own deliverance may have been planted in them by interests they cannot see, that eschatology is not a private comfort but a material technology of control. Herbert is here making a strong writer's swerve against a precursor in the sense Bloom gave the term: he takes the standard tale of the prophesied chosen one, the deepest story the genre had, and reads it against its own grain, so that the hero's rise becomes the thing to be feared. Every later age that watches a movement crown a savior whose coming was prepared in advance finds *Dune* already there, having named the mechanism before the events arrived to confirm it.

That the novel and the order it pre-described arrived in the same decade is the sort of coincidence the chapter has learned to mistrust, and in this case the trade publications a working journalist would have read across the years Herbert was researching the manuscript made the shape legible long before fiction reached for it. While he was at his desk in San Francisco between 1958 and 1965, an organization called Permindex, the Permanent Industrial Exhibitions Company, was operating from Basel and Rome and New Orleans under a charter the press described as the promotion of international trade fairs. Permindex had been incorporated in Switzerland in 1958 as the corporate successor to a planned Roman World's Fair, the *Esposizione Universale Roma*, which Mussolini had announced in 1936 for the year 1942 to commemorate the twentieth anniversary of the March on Rome, which his cancellation in 1942 because of the war had left as a half-built suburb of monumental travertine pavilions south of the city, and which after the war became the district called EUR, repurposed as office space for the postwar Italian state. The unfinished fair did not vanish. The corporate vehicle that had been created to manage its grounds and its trade pavilions was reconstituted in the late 1950s under the name Permindex, with offices first in Basel and then in Rome, and with a stated mission to coordinate permanent industrial expositions across the Atlantic economy. Its New Orleans affiliate was the International Trade Mart, which had been chartered in 1948 and built across the late 1950s on Camp Street near the foot of Canal Street as a thirty-three-story glass-and-steel office tower facing the river, the first dedicated trade-mart building in the United States, and whose managing director from 1958 until

1965 was a Louisiana businessman named Clay Shaw. Shaw had served as an Army major in the European theater, had been decorated by France and Belgium, and had returned to New Orleans to run the trade-promotion authority through which a substantial share of the Latin American business of the Mississippi waterway moved. He sat on the boards of Permindex and the affiliated Centro Mondiale Commerciale in Rome. He was, until his retirement in early 1965, the most visible face of the Atlantic trade-fair apparatus on the American Gulf Coast.

The genealogy of the institution Shaw managed reached back to the New Deal and ran through identifiable hands. Cordell Hull, Franklin Roosevelt's Secretary of State from 1933 to 1944, had pushed through Congress in 1937 the legislation establishing Foreign Trade Zone Number Two at New Orleans, the second such customs-free industrial zone in the United States after Staten Island, and Hull's broader Reciprocal Trade Agreements Act of 1934 had given the executive branch the authority to negotiate the tariff reductions that the postwar trade order would generalize into the General Agreement on Tariffs and Trade. Nelson Rockefeller, who had run the wartime Office of the Coordinator of Inter-American Affairs and who saw Latin American commercial integration as the foundation of any hemispheric order the United States would lead, had supplied through the Rockefeller-controlled foundations a substantial part of the capital that built the New Orleans Trade Mart. Allen Dulles, who had managed the Office of Strategic Services station in Bern during the war and would direct the Central Intelligence Agency from 1953 to 1961, sat in the institutional middle of the same network through his Sullivan and Cromwell practice in New York. Frank Wisner, who ran the Office of Policy Coordination, the covert-operations arm folded into the CIA in 1952, had built and funded across the late 1940s the apparatus that included Radio Free Europe, the National Committee for a Free Europe, and the Crusade for Freedom, and had used those vehicles in 1948 to fund the Christian Democratic side of the Italian election the United States had decided could not be permitted to go to the Communists. The Crusade for Freedom had mailed the ballots and Wisner's office had supplied the funds. In the Italian electoral operation of 1948 the American postwar managerial state developed the techniques the Italian and the Atlantic trade apparatus would later normalize as ordinary operating practice. Permindex sat at the intersection of these institutional histories. Whatever its actual operations were, and the courts never settled the question, the structural fact reduces to this: the postwar managerial elite was using the world's-fair apparatus that the 1900s chapter anatomized as a permanent infrastructure for the construction of a global commercial order under American discipline.

Clay Shaw became the only man ever prosecuted in connection with the assassination of John F. Kennedy. In 1967 the New Orleans district attorney Jim Garrison, a former FBI special agent and a Democratic populist with national ambitions, opened a grand jury investigation into a possible New Orleans dimension of the Kennedy killing, focused on the activities of a small circle

around an anti-Castro Cuban exile named David Ferrie and on Lee Harvey Oswald's documented summer of 1963 in the city, during which Oswald had handed out Fair Play for Cuba leaflets within a block of the Trade Mart. Garrison concluded that Shaw, under the alias Clay Bertrand, had been a participant in a New Orleans conspiracy, and indicted him in March 1967 on a charge of conspiracy to assassinate the president. The trial opened in January 1969 and lasted thirty-four days. The jury acquitted Shaw in under an hour. Garrison's case had drawn on testimony the federal government considered manufactured, on documents whose chain of custody could not be established, and on the broader theory that a network of New Orleans businessmen, anti-Castro Cubans, and former intelligence officers had wanted the president dead because of what Garrison took to be Kennedy's intended pivot away from the Cold War apparatus. The acquittal closed the prosecution. It did not close the question of what Permindex had been doing. Documents declassified across the next thirty years would show that Shaw had served as a contract source for the CIA's Domestic Contact Service, a program through which American businessmen who travelled abroad were debriefed on their return, which the Agency disclosed in 1979 and which by itself does not amount to anything more than the ordinary cooperation an Atlantic businessman of the period would have understood as expected. What the litigation could not settle, and what the chapter cannot settle either, is whether Permindex was merely the trade-fair apparatus its charter described or was something more functional that used the trade-fair apparatus as its cover. The structural reading does not require an answer. Whichever it was, the institution sat at the intersection that mattered. The postwar American order was using the form the long nineteenth century had developed for the management of the public's idea of the world as the operating front of its actual project, and the form was working.

The institutional successor of Permindex was the World Trade Centers Association, founded in 1968 in the same months the Tet offensive and the gold-pool closure were reordering the assumptions the order had run on. The Association federated the trade-mart facilities of New Orleans, New York, Tokyo, Antwerp, Marseille, Houston, and Amsterdam under a single coordinating charter, and gave its members the right to use the name World Trade Center for their facilities. The New York facility, planned across the late 1950s by the Port Authority of New York and New Jersey under the chairmanship of David Rockefeller's Downtown-Lower Manhattan Association and built on a sixteen-acre site cleared from the old Radio Row, was designed by Minoru Yamasaki across the early 1960s and completed in stages between 1970 and 1973. The North Tower topped out in December 1970 and the South Tower in July 1971; the formal dedication of the complex took place on the fourth of April 1973. The completion date deserves a moment. The World Trade Center buildings reached their full height in the same year the OPEC embargo would announce the end of the dollar-gold order in its public form, and they stood at the southern tip of Manhattan as the Saudi understanding the next chapter will document was being

negotiated by William Simon in Jeddah. The form the nineteenth century had developed for the display of empire had received its postwar monument in the year the order it was monumentalizing required a new operating mechanism, and the building and the mechanism arrived together. The World Trade Center stood on the lower-Manhattan skyline for twenty-eight years as the architectural rendering of the postwar trade-fair apparatus, two glass-and-steel towers whose Plaza-level concourse housed an actual perpetual exhibition of the products and services of its member nations, the structural successor at full scale of the Trade Mart on Camp Street that Shaw had managed.

The deeper claim runs as follows. The postwar order built itself a permanent world's fair as the public face of its actual operating logic, and the public face and the operating logic together produced a settlement in which the commodity and the institution that managed its movement appeared to the citizen as the natural form of international relations. The fair as a public institution had served the gold-standard order before 1914, and it had done so to recruit a public that experienced itself as the audience of a presented world. The trade mart served the Bretton Woods order after 1944, and it did so to recruit a public that experienced itself as the beneficiary of a managed prosperity whose underlying terms it was not required to inspect. Frank Herbert, in his San Francisco newsroom, read the trade publications that documented the construction of this apparatus across exactly the years he researched *Dune*. The novel he produced fictionalized the operating logic the apparatus contained without quite naming it. The Bedouin economy whose spice the empire could not move without, the desert tribes who sat on the resource, the arrangement between an outside hegemon and the local population through which the resource moved, the prophecy and the threat of withholding both used as instruments of leverage on the imperial center, the secret order whose long covert program had prepared the figure of the savior the desert was ready to receive, and the eschatological language that allowed a desert people to bend an empire whose mobility depended on what they alone could supply: these do not show up as generalized features of any imperial order. They show up as the specific features of the postwar Atlantic-trade-and-petroleum-and-managerial apparatus the trade marts existed to coordinate, transposed into a galactic register so that the structural shape could be seen without the political objections the contemporary reference would have provoked. Herbert had read enough to see the shape, and his particular gift was to render it in a form sufficiently removed from its referent that he could publish it. The novel and the institutional history describe the same arrangement, arrived at through different methods in the same decade by men who had access to overlapping bodies of source material. The chapter does not require a single secret author to make the convergence legible. Herbert read the trade press; the trade press reported what the apparatus did; the apparatus did what the order it served required; the novel and the institutions show the shape of the same operation because they tracked it from adjacent angles.

What the desert geopolitics conceals is a project older than the century the novel was published in. The Bene Gesserit had run their breeding program across ninety generations to produce a being who could see across all futures and remember every past, and the program the novel describes maps without distortion onto the program the Soviet state had run since 1928 to produce the New Soviet Man, the genetically and pedagogically engineered subject who would inhabit the classless world after the last expropriation. Herbert had read the Cold War carefully. He had grown up during the Stalin purges, served in the United States Navy during the Pacific war as a photographer, and spent twenty years in newsrooms in Tacoma and San Francisco watching the official American account of the Soviet Union shift from wartime ally to existential foe and back into a thing one could neither defeat nor live with. He had read enough Sufi mysticism, enough behavioral psychology, and enough archival material on the OSS programs that became the Central Intelligence Agency to know that the desert he was building was not really a desert planet. It was the long discipline a state can impose on a population it claims to be saving, and the figure of the man who imposes that discipline.

The figure Herbert had drawn in 1965 he returned to and named in 1981. By then the Soviet apparatus was visibly dying in public, the leaders dying on schedule, the engineered human it had promised receding into the past the way the gold standard had receded into the past a decade earlier. Herbert wrote *God Emperor of Dune* as the fourth volume in the sequence, and what his readers found, opening the book and expecting another adventure novel, was a sustained interior monologue spoken by a 3,500-year-old tyrant who has merged his body with the sandtrout of Arrakis, become a worm, and ruled the known universe as its sole absolute authority across the entire span of thirty-five centuries. The novel will be the closing argument of this chapter's discussion and the opening of the next, because what Herbert wrote in 1981 is the only work in American science fiction that sets down without disguise the central political proposition of the twentieth century, that a species survives only when a single mind imposes on it a discipline it would not choose. The novel arrives in the 1980s chapter where the Soviet leadership it indirectly defends is dying on the same schedule as the novel's narrator. The argument the novel makes about the Soviet experiment, that the discipline had been needed and that nobody could say so once the apparatus was gone, will be borne out in real time across the decade that follows.

That recognition had a precise correlate in the monetary world that neither Kubrick nor Herbert was charting, and it broke into the open in 1968, the same year HAL refused to open the doors. In March a run on gold overwhelmed the London Pool. The metal the allies had to sell to defend the official price exceeded what they were willing to lose, and rather than drain their vaults further they closed the pool and split the market in two. Central banks would go on trading gold with each other at the official thirty-five dollars; everyone else would buy and sell at whatever price the open market set. The two-tier arrangement was an admission dressed as a solution. It

conceded that the published price the whole system rested on could no longer survive contact with what people would actually pay, and it kept the fiction alive only by walling it off from the market that contradicted it. The official price became a number true only among the governments that agreed to go on saying it, while the one the world believed floated free a few feet away. The dollar's promise to be as good as gold had become a thing maintained by the collusion of treasuries against the disbelief of everyone outside the room, which is the condition of any currency in the season before its anchor is cut. The war that was draining the treasury had reached its own hinge in the same weeks. The Tet offensive in late January and February had shown a public that had been told the enemy was nearly beaten that those forces could strike everywhere at once, hitting more than a hundred towns and cities in a single coordinated wave and even breaching the grounds of the American embassy in Saigon. The offensive was a military defeat for the North, which lost much of the Viet Cong's strength in the open and took the cities back nowhere; but it was a decisive rout for the order's account of the war, because no population that had been promised the end was near could square the promise with the footage of fighting in the embassy compound. On the last day of March, Lyndon Johnson went on television to announce a partial halt to the bombing and then, in the same address, that he would not seek another term as president. The war had consumed the man who escalated it.

That gap between the account and the fact was not an accident of bad reporting; it was the product the war machine had manufactured. The government's account of the conflict was an instrument of belief management as deliberate as the Gold Pool, an architecture of body counts and pacification rates and projected timetables built to keep a population convinced that measurable force was yielding measurable progress toward a victory always a year off. The same Treasury that issued the dollars the world was meant to keep trusting issued figures the home front was expected to keep believing. The two confidence operations were one operation aimed at different audiences. Then it failed in a single photograph. On the first of February 1968, on a Saigon street during Tet, the Associated Press photographer Eddie Adams raised his camera as the South Vietnamese national police chief, Nguyễn Ngọc Loan, lifted a pistol to the head of a bound prisoner and fired. Adams pressed the shutter in the instant of the shot, and the picture he made froze the prisoner's face at the moment of the bullet, the grimace, the recoil, the executioner's outstretched arm. The man killed is most often identified as a Viet Cong officer named Nguyễn Văn Lém, though the identification has been disputed. The image ran in newspapers around the world the next morning and won Adams the Pulitzer Prize, and it did something the entire machinery of official information could not undo. It outran the story. The photograph answered the whole edifice of statistics with a single frame in which a man wielding the authority of the state shot another man in the head on a public street, and no caption, no briefing, no ratio could absorb it back into the official narrative. Adams himself came to regret the picture's effect, since he knew

the context the frame omitted; but the frame's power was exactly that omission, that it presented an act stripped of the explanatory machinery that had kept the war legible, and in doing so it registered the same thing the gold market was registering, that the managed version of reality and the felt version had come apart, and that the management could no longer be sustained.

The same hollowness the American works diagnosed had a victim on the far side of the dollar order, and there it produced a revolt rather than a confession. Japan in the nineteen-sixties was the showpiece of the system the American settlement had built: the defeated enemy of the previous decade, rebuilt by its conqueror into the fastest-growing economy on earth, its security leased to the American umbrella, its war-renouncing constitution intact, its energy poured into the consumer goods that would soon fill American homes. The bargain was prosperity in exchange for the martial and imperial soul the lost war had discredited, and Yukio Mishima had come to regard the deal as a castration dressed as a miracle. He had watched a nation trade the categories men once died for, the emperor and the sword and the beautiful death, for the soft abundance of the world Warhol was painting, and he set his whole work against the swap. In 1966 he wrote, directed, and starred in *Patriotism*, a thirty-minute silent film in which a young lieutenant of the nineteen-thirties commits ritual suicide rather than betray either his emperor or his condemned comrades; staged with the stillness of Noh and conveyed on intertitles and the slow exactitude of the body, it ends in a seppuku filmed in close and patient detail. Across the same years he wrote the four novels of *The Sea of Fertility*, a meditation on reincarnation and the steady loss of beauty in a Japan that grew emptier as it grew richer. He dated the final page the twenty-fifth of November 1970, delivered it to his publisher that morning, and that afternoon seized a military headquarters with a small band of followers, called on a jeering garrison to restore the emperor, and opened his belly with a short sword. Mishima and Warhol are two answers to a single recognition. Both saw that the consumer age had hollowed out every category once thought worth a life, and both made the body and the image absolute in reply; Warhol surrendered to the surface and sold the emptiness back as art, while Mishima tried to refuse it with an act he believed no order could absorb. The refusal failed on its own terms. The man who staged his death against the reproduced picture became, in the instant of dying, the most duplicated image of all, his protest converted at once into the spectacle he had meant to repudiate. What outlasts the spectacle is the fiction. In the novels the sorrow is preserved rather than discharged as a stunt, and a reader meets there the authentic grief of a mind that could find nothing in abundance large enough to give a life weight, the same emptiness the American works named, reported now from inside the miracle the dollar had made.

At its hinge in 1968 the American order still exhibits live dynamism, an expanding economy and an open society and a population that still makes things on a vast scale; the moon landing of the following summer is the proof of capability at its height. But the pressures that end orders have begun to climb. Financialization is not yet dominant, though the dollar's loosening from any real

4. Final Report of the Select Committee to Study Governmental Operations (Church Committee), Book III (1976).

anchor is its early form. Elite overproduction shows less at home than across the communist sphere, where two centers of revolutionary authority, Moscow and Beijing, had broken with each other so completely that by 1969 their soldiers were shooting along the Ussuri River, the doctrine that was meant to unite the workers of the world having generated a surplus of rival vanguards who could not all be supreme. The error-correcting reflexes that mark an open phase are visibly straining; the same government that signed the Civil Rights Act and the Voting Rights Act was wiretapping its critics and clubbing demonstrators before the cameras at Chicago in 1968. The wiretap was the visible edge of something more deliberate. Under a counterintelligence program the Bureau labeled COINTELPRO, begun against the Communist Party in the previous decade and widened through the sixties, the federal police turned the methods of foreign subversion against the citizens it governed⁴ Agents infiltrated the antiwar groups and the Black freedom movement, planted informers, forged letters to set allies against one another, fed damaging material to friendly reporters, and worked to discredit and break the very organizations the new statutes had just enfranchised. The Bureau wiretapped Martin Luther King, recorded his private life, and mailed him a tape with an anonymous note that urged him toward suicide; it marked the Black Panther Party for a campaign of disruption that ran from poison-pen provocation to the predawn raid in which Fred Hampton was shot in his bed in Chicago in December 1969. The logic of it is the one the later century would make familiar. A government can extend the formal franchise with one hand and with the other build the surveillance that watches and divides those it has just enfranchised, and the two motions are not in contradiction, because the right to vote that is granted in daylight and the surveillance that is run in the dark advance the same end, the management of a population whose consent the order can no longer simply assume. The covert program grows where the open commitment is loudest, since the louder the promise of inclusion the more the watchers need to track what the included might do with it. A power near its zenith, then, with the first cracks running beneath the surface, and under even the cracks, the thing the photograph saw and the silkscreen predicted: the moment a society's account of itself stops convincing the people inside it. No survey of pressures registers the instant a single image withdraws consent.

A thread of German idealism runs under the decade's surface, and it belongs here only lightly, because the period itself half understood it and half garbled it. The counterculture that crested in 1968 had absorbed, in a diffuse and intoxicated form, the old claim that the mind constructs the reality it perceives, that consciousness is prior to the world it renders. In the seminar this had been Kant's sober limit on knowledge; on the street it became the creed that one could expand consciousness and so remake reality, that perception was a door to be opened. The same metaphysics that grounds money as collective fiction and the Warhol multiple as shared picture surfaced as a mass intuition that the official world was only one version among possible others, and that the rendering could be changed. The intuition was true in its way and dangerous in its

way, since a reality that is only what the self imagines is one to which nothing outside the self need answer. Warhol's Factory, with its silver walls and its manufactured images and its indifference to whether anything behind the picture was real, was the cold version of the same idea, the consumer order's image of itself as a closed system of signs.

What survived is not the order these works were made inside, which came apart almost on schedule. Within three years of 2001's premiere the gold window was shut and the dollar cut loose from metal entirely; the two-tier arrangement collapsed with the official price it had been built to protect. The Vietnam war that the Saigon photograph helped turn the country against ended in withdrawal and defeat, and the managerial confidence HAL satirized did not survive the inflation of the decade that followed. The works outlasted all of it. *Dr. Strangelove* is the most exact thing ever made about how a system of deterrence renders its operators irrelevant to their own destruction, and it is funny, which is the form its truth had to take. *2001* moves with the cold symmetry of a system that has no need of the species that built it, and the question it raises about machines that exceed their masters has grown more literal with each passing decade. *Dune* named how a savior is manufactured before each new age supplied the example. Mishima's novels preserve the grief of a man who found nothing in abundance worth a death. Friedan's book remains the moment a manufactured contentment was named and a generation of women walked out of it. Warhol's grids hang in the museums as the most honest portrait anyone made of an economy in which the image is the asset, the multiple is the value, and attention is the thing finally bought and sold. Adams's photograph still stops the eye and refuses the caption. Each was made by one mind under the load of a monetary and military order under strain, and each kept its shape. The order is gone. The pictures preserved the contradiction the statistics still could not state, that the account a society gives of itself is a thing that can be believed until, quite suddenly, it cannot.

1970 – 1979

Somewhere near Barstow, on the edge of a desert running a hundred and ten degrees under the wheels of a rented red convertible the size of a small boat, the drugs began to grip. The trunk contained a catalogue the writer printed in the first paragraph of his dispatch and never had to invent: two bags of grass, seventy-five pellets of mescaline, five sheets of high-powered blotter acid, a salt shaker half full of cocaine, and a whole galaxy of multicolored uppers, downers, screamers, laughers. Also a quart of tequila, a quart of rum, a case of Budweiser, a pint of raw ether, and two dozen amyls. The driver had blood drying on one cuff from a nosebleed the ether had started in the Beverly Hills Hotel parking lot four hours earlier. The passenger was sweating onto the dashboard, three hundred pounds of him in a Hawaiian shirt, eyes rolling back as the mescaline came on, and a hitchhiker was riding in the back seat watching the sky for what the driver had begun to insist were huge goddamn bats. They were not bats. Hunter S. Thompson, thirty-three, was hallucinating at the wheel of a moving car on the interstate at ninety miles an hour and writing the sentences in his head as fast as they arrived, and what he was racing toward, through the heat and the chemical roar and the unraveling, was a wave that had already broken. He had grown up in Louisville, the son of an insurance broker, had served in the Air Force as a sports editor in Florida, had hitched the country writing freelance for the *National Observer* in his twenties, and had broken through at twenty-eight with *Hell's Angels*, a year embedded with the California motorcycle club that ended when the members stomped him bloody on a Tipping Point evening in 1966 after he refused, as he later wrote, to let them have his last beer. By 1971 he was a writer-in-residence-of-sorts at *Rolling Stone* in San Francisco, where Jann Wenner had decided to gamble part of the magazine's editorial space on a method that did not yet have a name. The fat man hallucinating beside him in the convertible was no Samoan attorney. His name was Oscar Zeta Acosta, a Chicano civil-rights lawyer who had defended the East L.A. high-school walkouts, a man with a serious drug problem and a bigger gun problem; Thompson renamed him for the page because the truth was in the way of the prose. The two men had driven to Las Vegas on a *Sports Illustrated* assignment to cover the Mint 400, a desert motorcycle race; the magazine had budgeted two hundred and fifty dollars and rejected the resulting piece on sight. Thompson rewrote it into a longer hallucinated dispatch and *Rolling Stone* ran it under the byline Raoul Duke in issues ninety-five and ninety-six, the eleventh and twenty-fifth of November 1971, before Random House gave it covers the following summer with the title *Fear and Loathing in Las Vegas*¹ It is an account of two men who consume everything they can lay hands on while the story they were sent to report dissolves around them, and its famous central passage is an elegy rather than a celebration. Thompson called it the wave speech. Standing on a hill above the city, the narrator remembers a feeling from the middle of the prior decade, the sense that something was

1. *Rolling Stone* nos. 95–96, November 11 and 25, 1971; Hunter S. Thompson, *Fear and Loathing in Las Vegas* (Random House, 1971).

winning, that a whole generation's energy was cresting and would propel the country somewhere better, and then he describes turning to look west and seeing the high-water mark, the place where the wave broke and rolled back. The form of the piece is the content of that sentence. It is built as a pursuit with no quarry, a frantic forward motion after a thing that has already receded, and the drugs are not the subject but the instrument, the chemistry by which a consciousness tries to recover an intensity the world has stopped supplying. What Thompson made was the first major artifact of the new decade's central condition, the morning after a faith, and he made it as gonzo, a method in which the reporter's own disintegration becomes the only honest measure of the story, because the official account had been shown to lie and nothing remained to trust except the nervous system as it registered its own collapse. Acosta disappeared in Mexico in 1974, never found, last seen on a boat off Mazatlán with what his son was told was a load of cocaine. Thompson put a .45 in his mouth at his Owl Farm compound in Woody Creek, Colorado, on the afternoon of the twentieth of February 2005, at sixty-seven, his son's family in the next room and the typewriter still warm with a one-word note: "counselor." He had asked, in advance, for his ashes to be fired from a one-hundred-and-fifty-three-foot cannon shaped like a peyote button, and Johnny Depp paid the three hundred thousand dollars to build the gun.

The faith that had broken was not only the counterculture's. Something larger had come apart at almost the same hour, and it concerned what money was. On a Sunday night that August of 1971 a Western flickered on the country's television sets until Richard Nixon bumped it from the air to tell the nation he was protecting the dollar from speculators, and almost no one watching grasped that he had just severed the last formal tie between the world's money and the metal that had stood behind it, in one form or another, across the long history of commerce. The speech was brisk and defensive, padded with a wage-and-price freeze and a ten percent surcharge on imports so that the suspension of gold convertibility arrived as one item among several rather than as the rupture it was. The men who had gathered at Camp David that weekend understood what they had done. The Treasury secretary John Connally, who had pushed the unilateral suspension and would later boast to a European delegation that the dollar was "our currency, but your problem"; the under-secretary Paul Volcker, who had drafted the contingency for closing the gold window months in advance; the Fed chairman Arthur Burns, who privately recorded in his diary that the decision destroyed the postwar order he had spent his career inside; the budget director George Shultz; and the speechwriter William Safire, who turned the rupture into prime-time television. These were the men who wielded the pen the night the metal promise died. They had been summoned to manage a run. Foreign central banks, France the most insistent among them, had been presenting paper dollars at the Treasury window and demanding gold at thirty-five dollars an ounce, and the vault could no longer honor the pledge the United States had made at Bretton Woods in 1944. The promise was good only so long as no one tested it at scale, and now the world

2. Richard Nixon, "Address to the Nation Outlining a New Economic Policy," August 15, 1971, *Public Papers of the Presidents*. On the Camp David weekend: Allen J. Matusow, *Nixon's Economy* (Kansas, 1998), ch. 5; William Safire, *Before the Fall* (Doubleday, 1975), ch. 14.

was testing it. Nixon did not so much break the promise as concede that arithmetic had already broken it. From that night the dollar was worth what the world would take it for, a matter of management and faith rather than of weight²

The quietness was the meaning: a monetary order that had organized the whole noncommunist world for a generation was dissolved by a man trying to win a reelection and beat back inflation, and the markets opened on Monday without catastrophe. For a few months there was relief. The Smithsonian Agreement in December tried to nail the currencies back to a slightly devalued dollar, and Nixon pronounced it the greatest monetary agreement in the history of the world, the sort of thing one says about a corpse one hopes will walk. It did not walk. By early 1973 the fixed-rate system was abandoned for good and the major currencies were left to float, their values reset hour by hour in markets, their relationships a perpetual negotiation in place of a settled fact. What had been an order of anchored certainties became a regime of continuously revised opinions. Money was now a managed thing, its value dependent on the credibility of whatever institution issued it, and from that point the share of the economy devoted to managing it could only grow, because once value floats someone must be paid to guess where it floats to next. No better anchor took its place³

In its place went confidence, the most volatile collateral there is, and the talk that managed it became an industry. The leveraged buyouts and the swollen bond desks lay a decade off, and through the seventies the trade still wore the dress of a sleepy utility staffed by men in unremarkable suits. The dress concealed the change rather than disproving it. The float had removed the one condition that had kept finance subordinate, the metallic discipline that capped how far paper claims could outrun real metal, and the men who would soon make less and price more had been handed their occasion on that August night. Who benefits when money comes loose from its anchor is not a mystery: the class that stands nearest the spigot, that receives the new money first and longest before its loss of value reaches the wage. The migration of the brightest graduates toward the trading floor begins here, the early form of a transfer of the country's center of gravity from the factory to the desk that priced the factory's debt.

In the same span the trade was becoming something the prior generation would not have recognized, an autonomous industry that did not describe its objects but produced them. The transformation was led by a small number of men, most of them in Chicago, who within five years built two of the load-bearing structures of the financial order the century would inherit, and who explained the project to the public in a register so dry that almost no one outside the trade noticed what was being made. The first of these men was Fisher Black, then a young economist trained in applied mathematics at Harvard who had drifted out of an academic career into a consulting firm in Cambridge and from there to the University of Chicago. In May 1971 he published a paper in

3. On the long aftermath of the closed gold window and the dollar's continuing primacy without a metal anchor: Barry Eichengreen, *Exorbitant Privilege: The Rise and Fall of the Dollar and the Future of the International Monetary System* (Oxford, 2011), chs. 2–3. For the float regime's mechanics, Volcker and Gyohten, *Changing Fortunes* (Times Books, 1992), part I.

the Financial Analysts Journal called *Toward a Fully Automated Stock Exchange*, a six-page sketch of a market in which prices and trades cleared through algorithm rather than through brokers on a floor, in which the specialists who matched buyers and sellers were replaced by a computer that read the order book and settled the trades at a price no human had set. The paper was a manifesto delivered in the register of a utility-company quarterly. It did not argue that the floor was inefficient; it described the floor as already obsolete, as a vestige of a period before the equipment existed to do the work without it, and it set out the architecture of the system that would in fact be built across the next three decades. Two years later, in May 1973, Black, with Myron Scholes and Robert Merton, published the option-pricing formula that took his name and theirs in the *Journal of Political Economy*, a mathematical model that derived the fair price of a derivative from the volatility of its underlying through a stochastic-calculus argument almost no one outside a graduate seminar in mathematical finance could read. The formula could be programmed onto a handheld calculator, and within five years Texas Instruments was selling a unit with the equation built into a chip. The Chicago Board Options Exchange had opened on the twenty-sixth of April 1973, one month before the paper appeared, in a converted smoking lounge of the Chicago Board of Trade with sixteen contracts on its initial list and a few hundred traders on its floor; within six years the formula was the universal price-setting tool of the exchange and of every exchange that followed.

Donald MacKenzie set down the discovery that mattered most about this sequence in *An Engine, Not a Camera*, published by MIT Press in 2006. MacKenzie was a Scottish sociologist of science who had spent twenty years inside the trading rooms of the City of London and the Chicago pits with a notebook, and the claim of his book was as simple as it was disorienting. The Black-Scholes-Merton formula did not predict the options market that emerged after 1973; it created that market, because the traders priced from the formula and the formula became self-fulfilling, an instrument installed inside the system it claimed only to describe. Before the formula no one knew what an option was worth; the trade existed but had no settled discipline. Once the formula was in every trader's calculator the options were priced where the formula said, and the historical price series began at once to fit the formula's predictions, not because the world had revealed itself to obey the model but because the model had been installed at the point where the price was made. The title named the distinction. An engine is a model that creates what it appears to measure; a camera is a model that records what already exists. The century's working economic theory, MacKenzie argued, had functioned as a camera in the textbooks and as an engine on the trading floor, and the gap between what economists said the equations did and what the equations actually did to the markets they were applied in was the largest unacknowledged fact of the field.

The venue that absorbed the formula and gave it scale was the International Monetary Market, a division of the Chicago Mercantile Exchange launched in May 1972 under the chairmanship of a forty-year-old Chicago lawyer named Leo Melamed. Melamed was a child Holocaust survivor; his family had fled the Vilnius ghetto in 1939, crossed Siberia on the trans-Siberian railway with a transit visa secured from the Japanese consul Chiune Sugihara, made the journey through Japan, and reached Chicago in 1941. He had taken a law degree at John Marshall and drifted into trading at the Mercantile Exchange almost by accident, become a member at twenty-three, and assumed the chairmanship in 1969 with a program to convert what was then a sleepy egg-and-onion futures market into the leading derivatives exchange in the world. The International Monetary Market was the first futures market for currencies themselves, the float of the prior year converted within months into a tradable surface on which a German importer or a Japanese exporter could lock in the price of a dollar three months out. The market could not have existed before Nixon closed the gold window the previous summer; the fixed exchange rates of Bretton Woods left nothing to hedge. The float made the currency a price, and the price made the future a contract. In 1987 Melamed and his colleague Bill Brodsky deployed Globex, a Reuters-built electronic trading network that ran the exchange's contracts through screens after the floor closed for the day, and by the late 1990s Globex was displacing the open outcry floor he had presided over, the traders in their colored jackets giving way to the same architecture Black had sketched in his 1971 paper sixteen years before the screens went live.

The same year Globex was announced, Melamed published, with the co-author Catherine Tamarkin, a science-fiction novel titled *The Tenth Planet*, brought out by the small press Bonus Books in Chicago in 1987. The novel was technically incompetent. The plot followed a galactic supercomputer named Putral that ran the economies of five inhabited planets according to a single integrated model, the prose was the prose of a deposition, the characters were sketched at the level of a corporate training video, the dialogue read as though transcribed from a corporate retreat, and the book is now nearly unobtainable in print and preserved only by a few special collections. It is also the only in-print fictional vision of the men actually building the global financial infrastructure. The chairman of the most consequential exchange of the period wrote a pulp vision of an artificial intelligence that ran planetary economies in the same years he deployed the actual electronic-trading network that began the displacement of human market-makers, and he explained the project to a public that read him as a sober utility executive. The novel and the exchange were the same operation in two registers, one published with the warehouse stickers of a small Chicago press and one installed in the trading terminals of the world's largest derivatives market, and the same man signed both. The argument that the men who built the modern financial system were dry technicians whose decisions had no eschatology behind them, an argument the popular reception of the 1980s deregulation made the standard one, will not survive an afternoon with Melamed's

bibliography. They were millenarians with novels. They had a picture of what the world's money would become and they wrote that picture down in two registers, the equation and the pulp paperback, and the equation was the engineering specification and the paperback was the dream the engineer dreamed while the specification was being written. The Golden Path Frank Herbert was working out in 1981 in *God Emperor of Dune*, Leto II's three-and-a-half-millennium discipline imposed by a tyrant who understood the human future better than the humans he governed, was being worked out in less competent prose by the men in the room with him. Herbert had taken the science-fiction novel and made it the medium of a serious eschatology, the genre's first sustained attempt to use the form of pulp futurism to think the largest possible question about how a species might be governed across centuries. The men at the exchange were thinking the same question in a different vocabulary. The Black paper, the Black-Scholes-Merton equation, the IMM, Globex, and *The Tenth Planet* are a single document, the public and private face of a project that took a generation to complete and that no one inside it described as anything but an upgrade to the plumbing of the markets. The plumbing was an eschatology with a fee schedule. The transformation of the world's money from a thing weighed against metal into a stream of priced positions traded by algorithm against a model was framed in the public press as a series of regulatory housekeeping items, a sequence of technical adjustments to the contract specifications and the clearing arrangements, each of which was reported, when it was reported at all, on the inside pages of the business section in the register of an actuarial bulletin. The men who did it knew what they were making, and the literature they wrote when off the clock said so directly. The decade's monetary rupture was an eschatological event with corporate sponsorship, and the eschatology was published in the back of bookstores under the science-fiction label by the same men who priced the options. The public read the boring side and missed the loud side, and the loud side was where the project was named.

Gold against the dollar at landmark dates, 1900–2025: two administered plateaus, then the float that followed the closed window. Sources: U.S. official price to 1968; London afternoon fixings (LBMA) thereafter.

The reason confidence in the dollar was already thin in 1971 was a war, and the war was being lost in the only place a war of that kind can be lost. For seven years the United States had poured men and money and ordnance into Vietnam against an adversary with a fraction of its industrial capacity and none of its reach, and it was losing, not on any battlefield where the metrics favored it but in the contest over who would outlast the other. The North Vietnamese and the Viet Cong had no airpower and no navy and no path to Washington. What they had was the willingness to absorb losses that would have broken any Western electorate, and the certainty that the Americans, for all their bombers, did not want to stay as badly as the Vietnamese wanted them gone. The war had been financed without raising taxes enough to cover it, and that deficit was a principal source of

the dollar overhang abroad that finally forced the gold window shut. The asymmetric war and the unmoored money were not two stories. The empire spent itself out of its anchor in a fight against a peasant army it could not beat, and resolve beat capability, as it tends to when the capable party has more to lose at home than to gain abroad. This is one of the two patterns that have endured, and the decade is its clearest demonstration.

The manner in which that war ended is the lesson: an empire that negotiated the terms of its own departure while it pretended to negotiate peace. By 1972 the American ground army had largely gone home under the policy called Vietnamization, which slowly handed the fighting to the South Vietnamese while American airpower stayed to backstop them. In late March of that year the North tested the new arrangement with the Easter Offensive, a conventional three-pronged invasion across the demilitarized zone and out of Cambodia and Laos, tanks and heavy artillery committed in the open in a way the guerrilla war had never permitted. The South's army bent and in places broke, the city of Quảng Trị fell, and the offensive was halted less by the troops on the ground than by the thing the North could not match, which was the return of American air power at full weight. Nixon answered with Operation Linebacker, mining the harbor at Haiphong so that Soviet and Chinese supply ships could no longer dock, and bombing the North's roads and rail and oil depots with a concentration the earlier campaigns had been forbidden. The invasion stalled, the South defended a ruined line, and both sides drew from the season the conclusion that the war could not be won outright and would have to be ended at a table.

The table was in Paris, where Henry Kissinger had been meeting Lê Đức Thọ in secret, and through the autumn of 1972 the two men closed on terms. Then the terms came apart in December, the South's president Nguyễn Văn Thiệu refusing an agreement that left North Vietnamese divisions standing on his soil, and the North hardening in turn. Nixon, freshly reelected and determined to force a settlement before the new Congress could cut the war's funding from under him, ordered the heaviest bombing of the entire conflict. Operation Linebacker II, the Christmas bombing, ran for eleven days from the eighteenth of December, B-52s flying by night over Hanoi and Haiphong in streams, dropping some twenty thousand tons of explosive on a capital that had not been struck on that scale before. The bombers came in predictable formations and the North's surface-to-air missiles took a toll the air force had not expected, fifteen of the great planes lost; on the ground the dead were counted in the hundreds and the world recoiled at the spectacle of carpet bombing a city to improve a negotiating position. Whether those eleven days forced the North back to the table or merely gave each side the cover to sign what it had nearly signed in October is a question history does not settle. What is certain is that the Paris Accords were signed on the twenty-seventh of January 1973, that they secured the return of the American prisoners of war and a face-saving interval, and that they left the North's army in place in the South, which meant they settled nothing the war had been fought to settle. The Americans called it peace with honor and

went home. The honor was the fiction; the departure was the fact.

What the accords bought was a decent interval, the phrase Kissinger is reported to have used in private, a span of time long enough that the collapse, when it came, would not arrive on the same news cycle as the American exit. The interval lasted two years. Through 1973 and 1974 the South Vietnamese army fought on with dwindling American aid, the Congress that Nixon had feared steadily cutting the appropriations as Watergate consumed the presidency that might have defended them, and the diesel and the spare parts and the artillery shells ran short while the North resupplied and rebuilt. In the spring of 1975 the North launched its final offensive, and the South did not bend slowly this time but came apart all at once. Thiệu ordered a withdrawal from the central highlands that turned into a rout, the roads choked with soldiers and refugees fleeing south, whole divisions dissolving without a battle. Huế fell, then Đà Nẵng, the columns racing down the coast faster than the defenders could form a line, and by the last week of April the North's tanks were on the approaches to Saigon and the war of thirty years was hours from its end.

The end itself was a photograph the whole world saw and read correctly. On the twenty-ninth of April, with the airfield under shellfire and fixed-wing escape closed off, the American command launched Operation Frequent Wind, the helicopter evacuation of the last Americans and as many of the Vietnamese who had served them as could be reached. The signal to begin was a forecast read over Armed Forces Radio, the temperature in Saigon a hundred and five degrees and rising, followed by Bing Crosby singing of a white Christmas, the most incongruous possible sound laid over a city in its final hours. Through the day and the night the helicopters shuttled between rooftops and the carriers waiting offshore, more than seven thousand people lifted out across some eighteen hours, while at the embassy a crowd of Vietnamese who had been promised protection pressed against the gates and reached up toward the machines that could transport only a fraction of them. Marines beat hands from the walls. South Vietnamese pilots flew their own helicopters out to the fleet and ditched them in the sea when the decks were full, the abandoned aircraft pushed over the side to clear room for the next. At a few minutes before eight on the morning of the thirtieth of April the last Marines lifted off the embassy roof, and the people the United States had promised to protect were left on the ground, looking up. By midday a North Vietnamese tank had crashed through the gate of the presidential palace and the war was over. The most powerful military in the history of the planet had been comprehensively defeated by a poor and determined nation, and every adversary and every client studied the lesson. The implicit guarantee underwriting the entire postwar order, the promise of American protection, had been shown to exact a price the American public would not pay, and a system that runs on such promises is only as strong as the most expensive one it declines to keep.

Four years after the rooftop, Francis Ford Coppola released the film that closed the country's reckoning with the war, and he did it by abandoning the war's geography for its interior. *Apocalypse Now* reached screens in August 1979, after a production that had nearly destroyed its director, who mortgaged his own fortune against it, suffered a typhoon that wrecked the sets, watched his leading man survive a heart attack mid-shoot, and screened the film unfinished at Cannes that May with the candid admission that it was not about Vietnam, it was Vietnam. The river does the work. Coppola took the descending journey of Conrad's *Heart of Darkness* and laid it over the Mekong, and the picture moves upstream and inward at once, each bend drawing the boat farther from the rational order that dispatched it and deeper into a zone where that order's logic completes itself and turns monstrous. This is the same recognition the prior decade's cinema had circled, the dread of a system that exceeds its makers, turned now from the cool symmetry of the machine to the heat of the jungle. Kurtz, the officer the mission is sent to terminate, is not a malfunction of the war machine but its perfected output, a man who took the war machine's premises to their conclusion and arrived at horror, and the army that sent the assassin cannot bear to look at what it produced. The fantasy the film stages is the official one, that the war was a coherent operation with objectives and a chain of command and a rational terminus. What that erupts as the boat goes upriver is that the operation had no bottom, that the same machinery of escalation which had run on its own through the prior decade had been running on its own here too, the body counts and the obliterated villages already saying what Kurtz only said aloud. The film does not argue this. It descends into it, and the descent is the argument.

The war reached the living rooms in a gentler form, and that form did more lasting cultural work than the films because it arrived every week. *M*A*S*H* premiered on CBS in September 1972, while the bombs were still falling on the North, a comedy set in a field hospital during the Korean War that no one mistook for being about Korea. The surgeons drink and clown and chase nurses and defy their superiors, and between the jokes the wounded come in by helicopter and some of them die on the table, and the show's whole achievement is the way it sustains the laughter and the carnage in the same frame without resolving them. A situation comedy is built to deliver a tidy world that resets to order at each episode's end, and *M*A*S*H* broke the contract by letting death into the formula, killing off a beloved character at the end of its third season in a move that violated everything the genre promised, so that the audience laughing at the antics could never be sure the next helicopter would not bring a body. What the show presented was the temper of a country that had stopped believing its wars were noble and could no longer simply enjoy a war story, that needed its soldiers to be wise-cracking cynics undermining the brass rather than heroes serving it, and the thing underneath the comedy was grief, the recognition that the institution sending the young to be cut apart deserved mockery and not reverence. When the series ended in February 1983 its finale drew an audience that has never been matched, more than a hundred

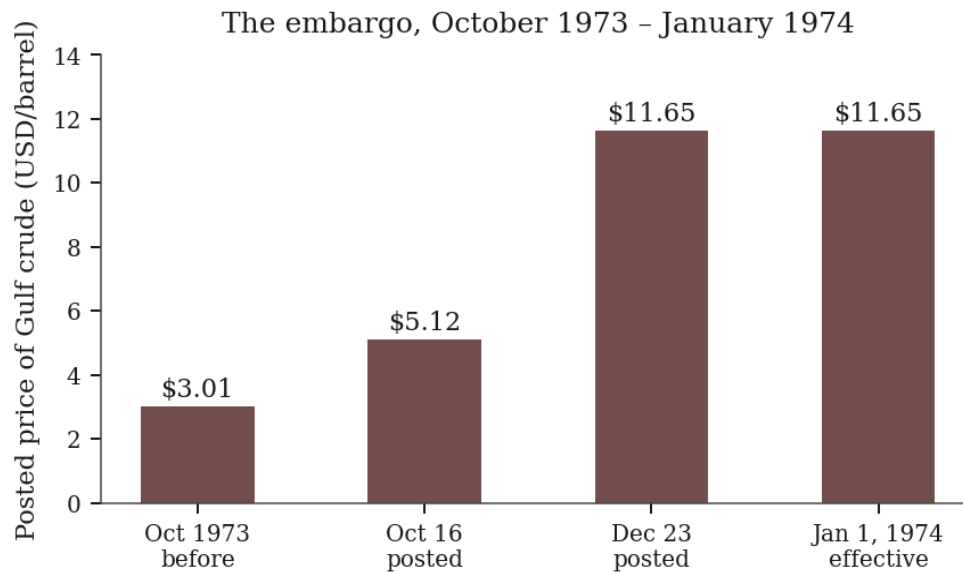
million Americans watching a single broadcast, the largest the country had ever assembled for an episode of anything, a measure of how completely the show had become the shared way a generation metabolized a war it had lost.

Television did something else in the decade that the films could not, because it could gather a whole nation in a single room across consecutive nights. In January 1977 ABC broadcast *Roots* on eight straight evenings, the dramatization of Alex Haley's account of his own family traced back to an African ancestor seized into slavery, and something close to half the country watched, the final night drawing one of the largest audiences in the medium's history. The decision to run it on consecutive nights had been a hedge, the network fearing the subject would not sustain interest and choosing to absorb the loss quickly; the precaution became the event, the nation gathering at the same hour for a week to watch the founding crime of the republic told from the side of the people it was committed against. *Roots* took the conventions of the prestige historical drama, the costumes and the sweep and the multigenerational saga, and turned them on the one history the genre had always been built to flatter around, so that white audiences who had absorbed the plantation as a setting for romance watched it instead as the scene of a sustained atrocity narrated by its victims. What the broadcast displaced was the bicentennial one, the country in 1976 toasting two hundred years of its founding ideals; what that erupted, the following winter, into the same living rooms that had hung the flag, was the foundation those ideals were laid over, the human property on which the continental fortune was built. That a commercial network could gather the nation for a week on that subject, and that the audience came, is the measure of how far the official account of the country had cracked since the start of the decade.

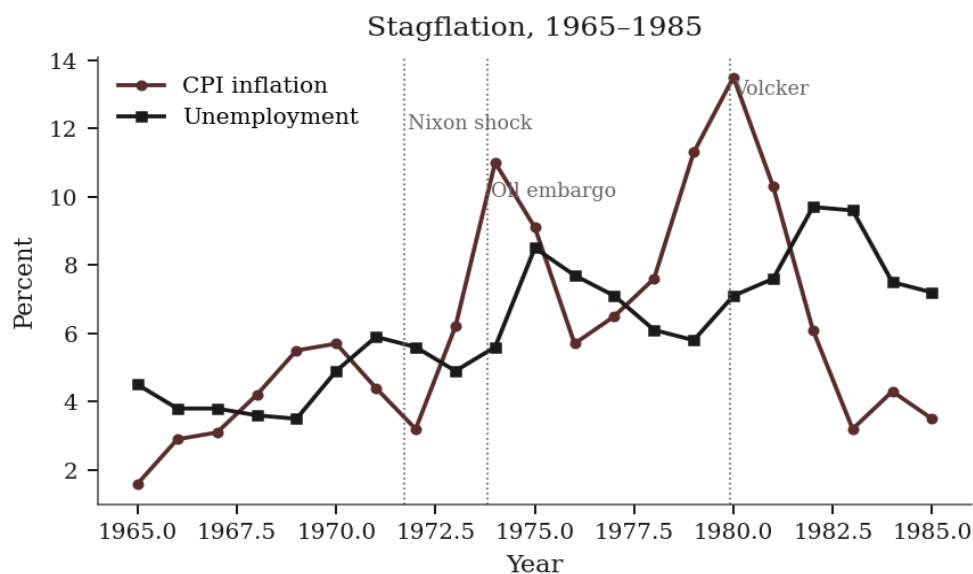
And on Saturday nights, late, after the affiliates had run their local news, NBC put on a live program that took the loss of institutional authority as its native idiom and made comedy of it. *Saturday Night Live* premiered on the eleventh of October 1975, hosted by George Carlin, staffed by a young cast that called itself the Not Ready for Prime Time Players, and built around the live sketch and the news parody and a sensibility that treated every figure of authority, the president above all, as fair game for ridicule. Live television cannot be perfected in the edit; it introduces the risk of failure into every minute, and a generation that had watched the polished official broadcast lie to it about the war and the burglary trusted the unpolished and the improvised over the smooth because the rough could not as easily deceive. The show's recurring news segment delivered the week's events in the deadpan of a real anchor and then undercut the form itself, and its impersonations of the powerful, the stumbling president, the sweating candidate, did to the office what the photographs had done to the war, stripping away the dignity the institution claimed for itself. What it left behind was a settled irreverence, a country that had learned to assume its leaders were ridiculous and its official broadcasts were managed, and that found in the live and the irreverent a register more honest than the network solemnity it replaced.

In October 1973 a second shock arrived from a direction the planners had not adequately feared. Egypt and Syria attacked Israel on Yom Kippur, the United States resupplied Israel, and the Arab members of OPEC answered with an oil embargo and a coordinated quadrupling of the crude price⁴ Gas lines snaked around American blocks for hours at a stretch, and the open road, the great theater of postwar abundance, became a place of rationing and rage. The embargo did to the economy what the gold suspension had done to the money. The sense of guaranteed plenty was gone, and anxious management moved into its place. It also did something stranger, and far more durable, the most consequential piece of financial engineering of the decade. The oil-producing states were suddenly awash in more dollars than they could spend, and those dollars needed somewhere to go. In July 1974 the Treasury secretary William Simon flew quietly to Jeddah and struck a bargain with the Saudi monarchy whose terms were kept confidential for more than forty years. The kingdom would price its oil in dollars and channel its surplus into United States debt, a portion of it through a discreet add-on arrangement that bypassed the ordinary Treasury auction and that the Saudis insisted stay hidden, and which stayed secret until a Bloomberg request pried it from the National Archives in 2016. In exchange the United States supplied arms and a security guarantee for the throne. This was a strategic transaction at the foundation of the order that followed. A hegemon whose paper no longer answered to metal arranged, through a closed understanding sealed in a desert palace, that the world's indispensable commodity would clear in its currency, and that the surplus thrown off by the commodity's price would flow back into its debt, financing the very deficits that had unmoored the money in the first place. The arrangement created a standing demand for dollars that did not depend on anyone's faith in American thrift, and it tied the security of a kingdom to the solvency of the bond it bought. It was covert because covertness was its instrument. The secrecy of the bidding channel was not incidental to the design but part of how it worked, a private window kept outside public view because what it accomplished could not have survived daylight at the time, and the bureaucracy that arranged it, Treasury and State and the security establishment moving in concert toward an outcome no electorate had voted, is the visible signature of how the order actually governs when the stakes are large enough. The price of oil, the safety of a throne, and a deficit that now paid for itself were welded into a single instrument by men who understood what they were welding, and who kept it dark for four decades because to name it was to weaken it.

4. October 6, 1973; OPEC's posted price reached \$11.65 a barrel effective January 1, 1974.



The embargo as a supply shift: the posted price of Gulf crude moved from roughly three dollars to \$11.65 a barrel between October 1973 and January 1974. Schematic.



Stagflation, 1965–1985: CPI inflation and unemployment in the same frame. Source: Bureau of Labor Statistics.

A legend has grown over that instrument, and it obscures how the arrangement actually worked. The legend asserts that oil simply replaced gold as the dollar's backing, that a designed system pinned the currency on crude the way Bretton Woods had anchored it on metal. The dollar after 1971 was backed by nothing but the credibility of the institution that issued it and the world's standing need to transact in it. The Saudi understandings reinforced that need powerfully, but a need is not a peg, and there was no window at which a dollar could be exchanged for a fixed

5. Andrea Wong, "The Untold Story Behind Saudi Arabia's 41-Year U.S. Debt Secret," Bloomberg News, May 30, 2016; David E. Spiro, *The Hidden Hand of American Hegemony: Petrodollar Recycling and International Markets* (Cornell, 1999).

weight of oil. The rail the decade laid down was not a metal under the money. It was a web of incentives and commitments, of priced oil and recycled surplus and security for sale, engineered to manufacture demand for a currency that had nothing physical behind it, and a rail of that kind endures with great force so long as the parties find it worth their while to maintain it, and not one hour longer. The strategic fact underneath is stronger than the legend, not weaker: the order did not stumble into the petrodollar circuit, it built one, deliberately, in the dark, and the dark has since been lit: the Treasury's 1974 understanding with Riyadh, its secrecy pledged on both sides, stayed out of view for four decades until records requests pried the file open⁵ A currency demanded for no other reason than the world's need to transact in it rests, when the language is stripped of its diplomatic dress, on the aura of a military no rival could expect to beat. Saudi Arabia and Japan and West Germany did not accumulate American paper because they trusted American thrift, which the deficits had already disproved. They kept it because the alternative was to learn what the fleet was for. The concrete instrument of the new anchor is naval, and it sits in the water through which dollar-priced oil moves. The world's energy travels by sea, and the sea has narrows where the whole traffic of a region passes through a few miles of water, the strait at the mouth of the Persian Gulf above all, through which a fifth of the planet's oil and the entire lifeline of Japan must thread. Whoever commands those narrows controls the tap, and since the Second World War the United States Navy has commanded them, the carrier groups and the standing presence in the Gulf the silent counterpart of every dollar parked in a Treasury bond. The metal that used to sit beneath the money was replaced by a floor of grey hulls, and the question of why a nation that knows the paper is worth little still accumulates it answers itself in the silhouette of a carrier on the horizon. Force became the new gold standard, and the recycled oil money is what registers the arrangement in numbers.

The same presidency that cut the money loose and struck the Saudi bargain also reached across the Pacific for the other half of the design, and the two halves belong together though they are rarely set side by side. A consumer economy run on a paper dollar needs someone abroad obliged to accept the dollar, which the Gulf supplied, and a flood of cheap goods to absorb the new demand without feeding the very inflation that the loosed dollar had let slip. In February 1972 Nixon flew to Beijing to shake the hand of Mao Zedong, the head of a state Washington had spent a generation isolating. The public language was grand strategy, the triangulation of Moscow through Beijing, and that was genuine as far as it went. Beneath it ran a commercial logic that set the shape of the next half-century. An opened China would in time supply an inexhaustible reserve of cheap labor and inexpensive manufactures to feed a population trained to consume without limit, and a vast market besides. What looked like a masterstroke of containment was the first motion of the great relocation of industry, the decision to source the consumer paradise abroad, and it began to hollow out the American manufacturing base that later decades would empty

entirely. The hegemon manufactured demand for its currency in the desert and arranged to produce the goods that appetite would buy across the Pacific, and in both motions it wired the rising frontier into the order it would one day inherit. This is the empire-energizes-its-successor pattern in its purest seventies form, the declining center building abroad the very capacity that will overtake it, and it was done not by accident but by men who chose each half of it for reasons that made sense to them at the time and could not see, or did not weigh, where the two halves together would lead the country.

For now the rail endured, and it was elegant, but elegance built on a pledge conceals how much it rests on the guarantor's reputation, and that standing was being shredded at home. The same Nixon who closed the gold window and presided over the petrodollar's emergence had also, it emerged, run a criminal conspiracy to subvert an election and then to obstruct its investigation. The break-in at the Watergate complex in June 1972 was a petty crime; the cover-up was a constitutional one. Across 1973 and 1974 the machinery of the state turned inward and consumed its own head, through Senate hearings, a special prosecutor dismissed in a single night, and the slow exposure of an executive that had compiled enemies lists and turned the tax authority and the intelligence services against its critics. When Nixon resigned in August 1974 the system could tell itself the law had reached the president and the design had worked. The truer reading is colder, and it begins with who the broken man was. The president the permanent state ground down across those two years was the same one who had cut the dollar loose from gold, sealed the desert bargain that wired the world's oil to American paper, and flown over the heads of his own intelligence services to shake the hand of Mao. He had reached into prerogatives the agencies regarded as their own, opening to Beijing on a private back channel, pursuing a détente with Moscow that the hard core of the security establishment distrusted, and treating the agencies as instruments of a presidency rather than as a power he served. The instrument that unwound him has a name. The thread the establishment press followed to the heart of the cover-up was fed to it by Mark Felt, the second-ranking official of the Federal Bureau of Investigation, who steered two reporters from the shadows for three decades before he was revealed in 2005 as the source the journalists had called Deep Throat. A man at the summit of the country's domestic intelligence machine steered the press toward the removal of an elected head of state from inside the agencies themselves, and the newspapers that printed what he gave them supplied the public momentum a coup of that kind requires in a republic. None of this makes the cover-up innocent. Nixon did run a criminal conspiracy and did obstruct its investigation, and the burglary and the tapes were real. The burglary is also the cover story, the petty crime that occupies the foreground while the larger fact stands behind it, that a president who had reached against the order's monetary and intelligence prerogatives was brought down by the order's own men, working through the press and the courts rather than the rooftop. The man who fell had loosed the money and opened the East; the men who

steered his fall sat at the center of the services he had treated as servants, and the agencies he had crossed kept their prerogatives long after he was gone.

What Watergate cracked open, and what the Church Committee then dragged into daylight across 1975, was not one president's aberration but the settled conduct of a secret state that had operated for a generation outside the consent of the governed. The committee, chaired by Frank Church and seated in 1975, set down the operations in detail, and the particulars are the indictment. There were plots to kill foreign heads of state, against Castro in Cuba and Lumumba in the Congo among them, some pursued through the underworld so that the government's hand would not show. There was a mail program in which the agency forbidden by law from operating at home had opened and photographed hundreds of thousands of private letters for two decades. There was the bureau's long campaign against domestic movements, the infiltration of antiwar and civil-rights organizations and the surveillance of their leaders, the most notorious episode an effort to drive Martin Luther King toward suicide with a recording and an anonymous letter. There was a program that fed drugs to unwitting citizens in an attempt to master the chemistry of the mind, and there were files on hundreds of thousands of Americans whose only offense was to dissent. This was an intelligence service that had run its own foreign policy and its own domestic policing in the dark for a generation, choosing which governments would stand and which would fall and which of its own citizens were enemies, and it had answered to no one who could be voted out. What the hearings forced into view is that the elected order and the covert one were not the same thing, that beneath the visible republic a permanent and unaccountable one had grown, and that the open one had been, for much of the Cold War, the cover story. The new profusion of oversight committees and special counsels and inspectors general that followed was offered as the republic healing itself. It is as easily read the other way, as the scaffolding a system erects when it can no longer assume the good faith of its own officers, an architecture of mutual suspicion that signals health and confesses sickness in the same gesture.

The committee had not invented the conduct it described, and the clearest proof had arrived two years before its hearings, in a country the agencies treated as their own backyard. In September 1970 the Chilean electorate had chosen Salvador Allende, a Marxist who proposed to nationalize the copper that American firms owned and to steer his country out of the order Washington supervised in the hemisphere. The reaction came from the top. Money moved to the opposition and the strikers, the economy was squeezed from outside until it buckled, and the senior officer who might have blocked a coup was abducted and killed in a bungled operation the agency had a hand in. On the eleventh of September 1973 the armed forces shelled the presidential palace, Allende died inside it, and General Augusto Pinochet took a power he would wield for seventeen years, the universities purged, the stadiums turned into pens for the disappeared, the elected experiment closed at gunpoint. The men who ran the operation did not consult the public whose

government executed it, and the country learned the shape of it only when the committee later forced the cables open. The apparatus removes inconvenient governments the way it disposes of inconvenient men, by working the levers that do not appear on any ballot, and a hemisphere it had long treated as a private estate was where the method showed plainest. What was tested in Santiago, where an economy was squeezed until its politics broke and a ruler was installed who would keep the country inside the dollar order, became a template the next decades would extend to other continents.

This is the air the decade's American cinema breathes, and three films of the middle years register it with a clarity the statistics could not reach. The first was already finished when Nixon resigned and seemed afterward to have been waiting for him. Francis Ford Coppola, born in Detroit in 1939 to an Italian-American family in which his father was a flute player who toured with Toscanini, had been raised by polio at nine that confined him to bed for a year with a 16mm projector and a stack of films. He had broken into Hollywood through Roger Corman's exploitation factory at twenty-three, written *Patton* in 1970 for the Oscar that bought him the leverage to make *The Godfather*, and built American Zoetrope in San Francisco as an independent studio to escape Los Angeles entirely. He shot *The Conversation* in late 1972 on the leftover momentum from *The Godfather's* success, casting Gene Hackman as the surveillance technician Harry Caul, and the picture opened on the seventh of April 1974, between the gold float and the fall of Saigon. Its subject is a surveillance expert who records a couple's private exchange in Union Square and slowly convinces himself that what he has captured is evidence of a coming murder. The form is built from sound. Coppola and his editor Walter Murch assembled the film around a single recorded sentence played and replayed, its emphasis shifting with each pass until the same words mean opposite things, and the technician who prides himself on capturing reality without interpreting it is destroyed by the discovery that the recording does not interpret itself, that meaning is something the listener supplies and can supply wrongly. The picture inherits the surveillance state's own conviction - that enough capture yields enough truth, that a society wired for total observation can finally know itself. What erupts is the truth that observation produces only more material to interpret, that the more completely the man records the world the less certain he becomes of what any of it means, until in the final scene he tears his own apartment to the floorboards in search of the microphone he is sure has been planted on him and finds nothing, a watcher who has become the watched and cannot locate the eye. The film arrived in the same season the country learned its own government had been recording it, and it had been conceived years before the burglary, which is the point. It did not report Watergate; it saw the suspicion Watergate would only confirm.

Two months later Roman Polanski's *Chinatown* opened, and where *The Conversation* worked the present, *Chinatown* mined the past to indict the foundations. Robert Towne's screenplay took

the real history of how Los Angeles secured its water, the manipulations by which a desert was made to bloom for the profit of men who knew which land to buy before the aqueduct came, and folded it into a detective story whose detective uncovers everything and prevents nothing. The genius of the form is that it inverts the genre's promise. The private eye exists, in the form's classical version, to restore an order disturbed by crime, to find the truth and see it answered. Towne and Polanski built a film in which the truth is found and answered with its defeat, in which the man with the power, who has committed incest and theft and murder and engineered a city's water to do it, walks free in the final frame while the woman who tried to expose him lies dead and the detective is led away by friends who tell him to forget it, that this is Chinatown, a place where the rules do not apply and the attempt to apply them only gets people killed. Polanski, who had insisted on the bleak ending against the studio's wish for something gentler, made a film whose deepest statement is that the corruption is not a flaw in the system to be exposed and corrected but the system's own foundation, that the city itself rests on the crime, and that knowledge of this changes nothing. It is the same recognition *The Conversation* reached by a different road, that the official order's account of itself, the story in which crimes are aberrations and the law corrects them, had stopped being believed by the people inside it.

The third film stripped the politics away and left only the nervous system. Martin Scorsese had grown up in Little Italy in the 1950s, the asthmatic son of a clothes presser, kept indoors and watching the neighborhood from the window of a fourth-floor walk-up on Elizabeth Street; he had enrolled at NYU's film school and stayed on as a teaching assistant under Haig Manoogian. Paul Schrader had been raised in a strict Christian Reformed household in Grand Rapids where movies were forbidden until he was seventeen, studied at the American Film Institute under Pauline Kael's recommendation, and written the *Taxi Driver* screenplay in ten days in a New York hotel during a period of his own breakdown in which he was living in his car and keeping a gun in his glove compartment. Scorsese filmed it on the streets of Manhattan in the summer of 1975 during a heat wave and the city's near-bankruptcy that fall, with Robert De Niro driving an actual taxi between takes to stay in character. The picture opened on the eighth of February 1976 and was built around a Vietnam veteran who drives the night shift through a New York the film renders as a hell of steam and neon and sexual rot. Travis Bickle is the war's residue walking the home front, a man trained for a purpose the country has abandoned and now adrift in a city that has no use for him, and the form mirrors his dissolution. Scorsese shot the streets through windshields streaked with rain and lit them in colors that belong to no daylight, and Bernard Herrmann's last score, finished on the twenty-third of December 1975, the night before the composer died of a heart attack in a Universal Studios hotel room at sixty-four, lays a sour romantic saxophone over the squalor so that the film aches with a tenderness it cannot place. The picture builds toward a massacre that the narrative then reframes as heroism, the press and the public deciding that the man who killed a

pimp and his associates to rescue a child prostitute is a savior rather than a psychotic who would as readily have shot a senator. Five years after the film's release, John Hinckley Jr., who had become obsessed with Jodie Foster's twelve-year-old prostitute character, shot Ronald Reagan in the chest outside the Washington Hilton; Hinckley had watched the picture more than fifteen times and brought the screenplay with him to the trial. The fantasy the film stages and detonates is the redemptive one, the conviction that a damaged man can cleanse a corrupt world through righteous violence and be received as a hero, and the disavowal that erupts is that the country could not tell the difference, that the same act read one way is murder and read another is salvation, and that a society which has lost the thread of its own legitimacy will take whichever reading flatters it. Bickle is the war come home and curdled, and the film's refusal to resolve whether he is monster or savior is the shape of a culture that could no longer say what its violence was for.

Against all of this the country was sold a counter-fantasy, and it bought it by the millions. *Rocky* opened in late 1976, written by an unknown actor named Sylvester Stallone who refused to sell the script unless he could play the lead, and it tells the story of a club fighter from Philadelphia, a man the world has counted out, who gets a freak shot at the heavyweight title and trains in the cold dawn and runs up the museum steps and, in the climax the whole picture exists to deliver, does not win. The detail is usually forgotten. *Rocky* loses the fight and the film treats it as triumph, because the point was never the belt but the demonstration that the man could go the distance, could stand at the final bell still on his feet, unbroken by a champion who was supposed to destroy him. The form is the deliberate antithesis of everything the decade's serious cinema was saying. Where *Chinatown* insisted the system was rigged and *Taxi Driver* insisted the violence had no meaning and *The Conversation* insisted that knowledge brought no power, *Rocky* insisted that a single will, applied to one body, could redeem a life through effort alone, that the individual still mattered, that the distance could be gone. It was a fantasy of recovery sold to a country in the season of its loss of confidence, and its enormous success is the measure of how badly that restoration was wanted. The film does not lie about the result. The fighter loses. What it offers is the consolation that the loss can be survived with dignity, and a nation that had lost a war and broken its money and exposed its president took the comfort and made it the most beloved picture of the year. The ideology is visible in the swap the form performs, the substitution of personal striving for collective fate, the assurance that whatever had failed in the public world could still be won in the private body, which was the same turn inward the whole society was making at once. A bronze of him still stands at the foot of the museum steps in Philadelphia, a fictional fighter cast in metal beside the actual building. Tourists climb the same hundred and twenty-six steps for a picture with him. A city adopted the consolation as a civic emblem and never gave it back.

The turn inward reached the body itself, and the most exposed frontier of the body, which the decade pushed into the open with a speed that startled even its own participants. In June 1972 a

cheaply made pornographic film called *Deep Throat* opened in New York, and within weeks it was something no such film had ever been, a thing respectable people went to see and discussed at dinner, the press christening the moment porno chic. For a brief span explicit film crossed from the margins into the mainstream cinema, reviewed in the papers and grossing sums that astonished the industry, and the crossing itself was the ideological event. A society that had spent the prior decade insisting on liberation discovered that the market would happily supply it, that the same machinery which sold cars and detergent could sell the sexual frankness the counterculture had demanded, and would do it without any of the counterculture's politics attached. The form was the meaning. The pornographic film stripped the sexual act of every context but the act, presented the body as pure spectacle and pure commodity, and in doing so it revealed the logic toward which the whole consumer order was tending, the conversion of the last private and unpurchasable thing into another product on the shelf. What the moment promised was freedom, the body released from the old shame; the buried truth was that release into the market is not the same as liberation, that the body freed from the church found itself delivered to the cash register, and that desire, once it could be sold, would be manufactured and sold like everything else. Bernays had described the engineering of consent half a century earlier; that mechanism reached at last into the bedroom.

The same months that made a commodity of the body also made it, for the first time at the level of constitutional law, the individual's own to govern. On the twenty-second of January 1973, six days before the Paris Accords were signed, the Supreme Court decided *Roe v. Wade*, ruling by seven votes to two that a constitutional right to privacy, drawn from the liberty the Fourteenth Amendment protects, reached a woman's decision to end a pregnancy, and striking down the state laws that had criminalized it. Justice Harry Blackmun, a Nixon appointee who had spent years as counsel to a great medical clinic, wrote the opinion and built it on a framework of trimesters, the state's power to regulate growing as the pregnancy advanced. The decision was the legal expression of a movement that had been gathering force through the period, the second wave of American feminism, which had moved past the formal equality of the vote to the deeper question of whether a woman owned her own body and her own labor and her own future. Gloria Steinem and her collaborators had launched *Ms.* as an independent magazine in 1972, the first to treat women's lives from a frankly feminist standpoint, and that same year Congress passed the Equal Rights Amendment and sent it to the states in what looked at the time like an easy ratification. The frontier all of this pressed on was the same one the pornographers were colonizing from the other side, the body and what could be done with it and who decided, and the two movements were the same era's contradiction posed in a single object. The market wanted the body free so that it could be sold. The women's movement wanted it free so that it could be owned by the person who lived in it; and both were attacking the same inherited order in which the body had belonged to the family and the church and the state. What that erupted, and that would organize the politics of the

decades to come, was that a society could not grant the autonomy and contain its consequences at once, that to make the body the individual's own was to detach it from every institution that had claimed it, and that the institutions would not concede the loss quietly. The backlash was already forming as the ink dried on the opinion, and the question the decade opened, whether the self that owns its own body owes anything to anyone outside it, has never since been closed.

For the inner life was turning inward fast, and it rhymes with the way the money had come loose from its anchor. The liberation the prior decade had reached for, the self set against the conformity of the mass, curdled in the harder light of the seventies into something the period's own observers named without flattery, the Me generation, the culture of narcissism, a turn inward so complete that the cultivated self became the only remaining project in a world where the grand projects had failed. With the war lost and the money afloat and the institutions exposed as self-serving, the energy an earlier generation had poured into public things drained into the private kingdom of feeling, into therapy and the human-potential movement and the endless tending of an authentic inner self that answered to nothing outside it. The German-idealist floor under the whole century surfaces here in an inverted form. The claim that mind constructs the reality it perceives, which the counterculture had felt as a door to a larger consciousness, hardened into a marketed solipsism in which each person curated a private world and owed the shared one nothing. This is the mechanism Bernays had described half a century earlier turned to a new end, the manufacture of desire perfected into the production of selves, the consumer taught not merely to want a product but to assemble an identity from products, so that the inward turn the decade lamented was also the consumer economy as it discovered its richest seam, the self as the thing finally sold. The intellectuals ratified the dissolution in their own idiom. The philosophy arriving from Paris announced an incredulity toward metanarratives, a principled disbelief in exactly the kind of large story, of progress, of the dialectic, of history going somewhere, that the century had been built on. The West at the end of the seventies was busy declaring that the age of grand narratives had closed, that nothing so totalizing could be believed anymore, and it made the declaration in the season when the oldest such narrative of all was massing in the streets of Tehran to overthrow the most modern client the American order possessed.

What the West marketed, the far side of the Curtain had already filmed as a tragedy. In 1972 Andrei Tarkovsky's *Solaris* took the Grand Prix Spécial du Jury at Cannes, and Western critics filed it as the Soviet answer to 2001, a label the director would have refused; he had called Kubrick's film "phoney on many points, even for specialists," and what he built was the counter-case. His cosmonauts orbit an ocean that reads them. It does not attack; it answers. Out of each sleeping man's buried interior the planet raises a visitor in flesh, and to the psychologist Kris Kelvin it returns his wife, dead by her own hand, assembled from his memory of her and therefore missing whatever he had failed to keep. The idealist floor this book has traced since Königsberg is

6. *Solaris*, Grand Prix Spécial du Jury, Cannes, May 1972; the Milan press conference of July 10, 1984; Tarkovsky died in Paris, December 29, 1986.

here made literal: a world constructed by the mind that perceives it, the curated private kingdom rendered back as a body that sits at the table. And the rendering loves him back, which is the unbearable part: the visitor grows more human as the man becomes less able to distinguish his grief from its object. The decade that marketed the cultivated self as liberation had its diagnosis delivered in advance, from the side of the Curtain that was supposed to have no inner life at all. The committee that controlled release demanded changes, a more realistic picture, a clearer image of the future, the allusions to God removed; Tarkovsky conceded almost nothing, and the film was passed in the spring of 1972 anyway. Twelve years later, refused an extension of his leave abroad, he announced in Milan that he would not return, and he died in Paris at the end of 1986, an exile whose subject had always been the homeland the mind bears and cannot put down⁶

The collapse of confidence reached the very discipline that had promised to manage it, and the quarrel that broke open there had run beneath the whole century. The postwar order had been built on the authority of John Maynard Keynes, on the conviction that a modern state could read its economy as a machine and tune it, spend against a slump and tighten against a boom, and so abolish the savage cycle that had produced the thirties. The bargain at the floor of that authority assumed that inflation and unemployment moved in opposition, that a little more of one bought relief from the other, a settled trade the managers could work along a smooth curve. The seventies pulled the floor away. Prices climbed while output stalled and the jobless lines lengthened at the same time, the oil shock feeding the price climb while it killed the growth, and the word coined for the impossibility, stagflation, named a thing the reigning theory had said could not occur. The economists trained to fine-tune the machine found it had changed shape beneath them, and their tools turned useless in their hands. Into that failure walked a man the consensus had treated for thirty years as a relic. Friedrich Hayek had argued since the Austrian quarrels of the thirties that the boom was the disease and the bust the cure, that the loans a central bank conjured did not create wealth but only misdirected it into investments the real savings of the society could not sustain, and that the slump was the painful correction of that error, to be endured rather than papered over with more of the credit that had caused it. Against Keynes, who argued that the state must spend to fill the gap private demand had left, Hayek argued that the shortfall was the market clearing away the malinvestment the prior expansion had bred, and that a government which refused to let it clear only stored up a larger reckoning. The Keynesian decades had buried this view as defeatism. Then the stagflation the Keynesians could not explain handed it a vindication, and in 1974 the committee in Stockholm awarded Hayek the Nobel in economics, shared with Gunnar Myrdal so that the prize might balance him against a man of the opposite politics. The prize pulled him out of obscurity and back into the argument at the moment it reopened. The free-market revival that the next decade would enact as policy, the turn toward monetary discipline and deregulation and the liquidation of the postwar settlement, has its intellectual hinge here, in the

seventies, when the consensus that had governed since the war cracked and the current that had been dammed since the thirties ran free again. Neither Keynes nor Hayek is the hero of this; both are currents the century sustained, each rising as the other's order failed, and the seventies are the years the tide turned from the one toward the other.

Thomas Pynchon's *Gravity's Rainbow* appeared on the twenty-eighth of February 1973, between the second devaluation of the dollar and the oil shock eight months later, and it took the measure of the whole system and found its image in a weapon. Pynchon, then thirty-five, had taken a degree in engineering physics at Cornell before switching to English under Vladimir Nabokov, had spent two years writing technical documentation for Boeing in Seattle in the early 1960s on missile manuals classified as restricted, and had quit to write fiction in obscurity. He has never appeared in public, has not been photographed since his 1953 high-school yearbook, and refuses every interview except two telephone exchanges granted under condition that no recording be kept. The novel is set thirty years earlier, in the final months of the Second World War and the rubble that followed, organized around the German V-2 rocket and a soldier named Tyrone Slothrop whose erections appear to predict, or to be predicted by, the points where the rockets fall. It is enormous and deliberately resists the reader, a sprawl of more than four hundred named characters and a dozen disciplines, and its form is its argument about systems. The rocket is the supreme product of an alliance Pynchon traces past the nominal sides of the war, a convergence of corporations and cartels and bureaucracies and laboratories that outlives the regimes it served and reassembles itself in the postwar order, so that the same engineers and the same firms and the same logic continue into the world the reader inhabits. The Pulitzer Prize jury unanimously selected the book for the 1974 fiction award; the Pulitzer Board, the higher panel, overrode them, called the novel obscene and turgid, and declined to give the prize that year. What Pynchon saw, decades before the pattern could be named, was that the real continuity of the modern world is not the nation or the ideology but the system, the technical and financial and bureaucratic machine that recruits human beings as its instruments and pursues ends of its own, and that the rocket, which rises on a parabola whose descending half is its delivery, is the perfect figure for a civilization that has built an instrument of pure technical brilliance whose only terminus is its own target. The arc gives the novel its title and its shape. The rocket goes up by reason and comes down by gravity, and the descending half is the half that kills, and the whole vast machinery of the modern, the cartels and the science and the money, is bent toward perfecting the fall. Pynchon was writing about the prior war and the machine it bequeathed, but the machinery he described was the one that closed the gold window and laid the petrodollar rail and wired China into the supply chain, the same convergence of systems exceeding the states that housed them, and the novel registered its logic with a completeness no economic account of those same years achieved.

Read at its hinge in the middle of the decade, the American order gives a profile the art both confirms and outruns. Dynamism is past its zenith but not yet spent. The economy still expands in fits, the population still makes things, and the country can still mount enormous coordinated efforts when it chooses. But the pressures that end orders have climbed since the prior reading. Financialization is no longer merely latent; the float has removed the one condition that made a vast money-management sector unnecessary, and the early shape of what the next decades will make dominant is already legible. The error-correcting reflexes that mark an open phase are straining visibly, caught between a state that surveils its critics and a citizenry that has stopped granting any official the benefit of the doubt. And the surplus of credentialed expertise is itself a legible symptom. The economists trained to run the machine, suddenly unable to deliver the outcomes that justified their authority, are an overproduced elite denied the results its training promised, and a caste in that position grows restless and begins to look for someone to blame, which is one of the conditions such a reading detects first. What no such reading can see is the thing the wave speech and the rocket and the surveillance technician all saw, the withdrawal of the credibility on which a fiat order finally rests, the season in which a society's account of itself stops convincing the people inside it. A decade is the finest grain such a reading resolves. It is blind to the morning a faith dies. That blindness is the boundary where the artwork takes over as evidence.

The decade's last act gathered where the petrodollar rail ran through, and it negated the whole secular frame the strategists had worked within. In Iran the Shah, installed and reinstalled with American help, modernizing furiously and ruling through a secret police the population had learned to hate, sat atop the oil wealth that fed the recycling machine and embodied more completely than any other figure the American habit that mistook a client's stability for a region's consent. The arms and the advisers and the modernization pressed on a society that had not asked for it did not pacify the periphery; they charged it. And in 1978 the charge gathered around a cleric in exile who offered the one thing no secular ideology of the century had managed to place at the center of politics, a religious eschatology, a vision of history bending toward divine judgment and the rule of the godly, against which the Shah's modernity looked like apostasy with tanks. This is eschatology as a material force, not as a figure of speech. A faith in the end of profane time and the rule of the holy moved millions into the streets, toppled a throne the strongest power on earth had underwritten, and reorganized the politics of the world's great energy basin, and it did so against every secular instrument the strategists trusted. When Khomeini returned in February 1979 and the monarchy fell, the United States lost an ally and an illusion at once. The strategists, fluent in throw-weights and spheres of influence, had treated ideology as a Cold War property, a contest between two secular faiths over the management of industrial society, and the reappearance of an older and deeper kind of conviction struck them as a regression rather than a future arriving. It was the future arriving. In November students seized the American embassy and detained its people for

four hundred and forty-four days, and the count of the days scrolled nightly across American screens, a humiliation administered not by a rival superpower but by a crowd of theology students, the second such spectacle of the decade after the Saigon rooftop, and no throw-weight answered either.

In the same weeks the Cold War's other half walked into the mirror of the American mistake. In December 1979 Soviet forces crossed into Afghanistan to prop up a faltering client, confident in the way the Americans had been a decade and a half earlier, possessed of overwhelming material superiority over a fractured and ill-armed adversary in difficult ground. The Politburo read it as a manageable intervention to secure a southern flank. The law the rice paddies had written would write its verdict again across the mountains, against an enemy whose resolve would prove once more indifferent to the invader's capability, and the gash it opened in the Soviet body would in time prove mortal in a way the American wound had not quite been. Both superpowers ended the decade marching into traps of their own design, each certain that strength would tell, each about to learn that on the frontier it does not. The second tested pattern, that a declining hegemon loses its asymmetric and peripheral wars first, had now demonstrated itself on both sides of the great divide, the one empire defeated on a rooftop and humiliated by theology students, the other stepping into the same ground with the same confidence and the same coming education.

And while the institutions were exposed and the money set adrift, a sound arose at the order's edge that took the loss of legitimacy as its first principle and made an aesthetic of it. Punk surfaced in London across 1976 and 1977, the Sex Pistols releasing their first single late in 1976 and their only album the following autumn, and what they performed was the negation of institutional authority in a form too crude to be co-opted by the machine that co-opts everything. The music was deliberately unskilled, three chords played as fast and loud as four young men could manage, the vocal a sneer that refused the category of the trained voice, and the refusal was the argument. Where the prior decade's rock had aspired to the symphonic, the album-length suite, the rock star as visionary, punk repudiated mastery itself, because polish was the property of an order that had revealed itself as a fraud, and a generation facing unemployment and the wreckage of the postwar promise had no reason to honor the forms in which that promise had been sung. The most notorious single named the monarchy and pronounced no future, and the slogan was not nihilism for its own sake but a reading of the moment: a society which had spent its credibility had nothing left to offer the young it had abandoned except the spectacle of its own institutions performing a legitimacy no one believed. The refusal of skill, the cheapness, the speed, the rejection of artistry - all of it said in sound what Thompson had said in the wave speech and Pynchon in the rocket's arc and Scorsese in the streaked windshield: that the official account of the world had been exposed as a lie and the only honest response was to make something that lied about nothing, least of all its own poverty.

The decade ran out with the gold gone and the dollar afloat, propped on a desert web of recycled oil money; the long postwar boom was finished; a president had been broken by his own criminality; a war had been lost on a rooftop; a king had been overthrown by a prophet; and two empires were marching toward the same lesson at opposite ends of the same era. The order these works were made inside came apart roughly on schedule. The fixed-rate system was gone, the war was lost, and the managerial confidence that the prior decade's cinema had satirized did not outlive the inflation. The works outlasted all of it. Thompson's book remains the truest account anyone made of the morning after a collective faith, its frantic forward motion still chasing a wave that broke before the first page. Pynchon's rocket rises by reason and falls by gravity, and the apparatus he described - systems that recruit their human servants and pursue ends of their own - has only grown more literal. *The Conversation* plays its single sentence until the meaning dissolves, and the surveillance it imagined has become the air the world breathes. *Chinatown* ends with the truth found and defeated; *Taxi Driver* refuses to say whether its violence was madness or salvation, and the country that could not tell the difference is the country that produced both. Rocky loses the fight and survives the loss - the consolation a frightened nation reached for and made beloved. *M*A*S*H* let the dead into the comedy and refused the reset the genre promised. Punk refuses the skill the order it despised had monopolized. *Apocalypse Now* moves up the river into the place where the rational machinery completes itself and turns monstrous, the war's interior rendered as form. Each was made by one mind under the load of a monetary order cut loose from its anchor and a hegemon learning the price of its guarantees, and each turned that strain into something that did not break when the pressure passed. The order that produced them is gone. The films registered the cost the float exacted on the inner life: that an order built on guarantees discovers, when the cost to keep them grows unbearable, that the guarantees were only promises, and that the account a society gives of itself can be believed until, quite suddenly, it cannot.

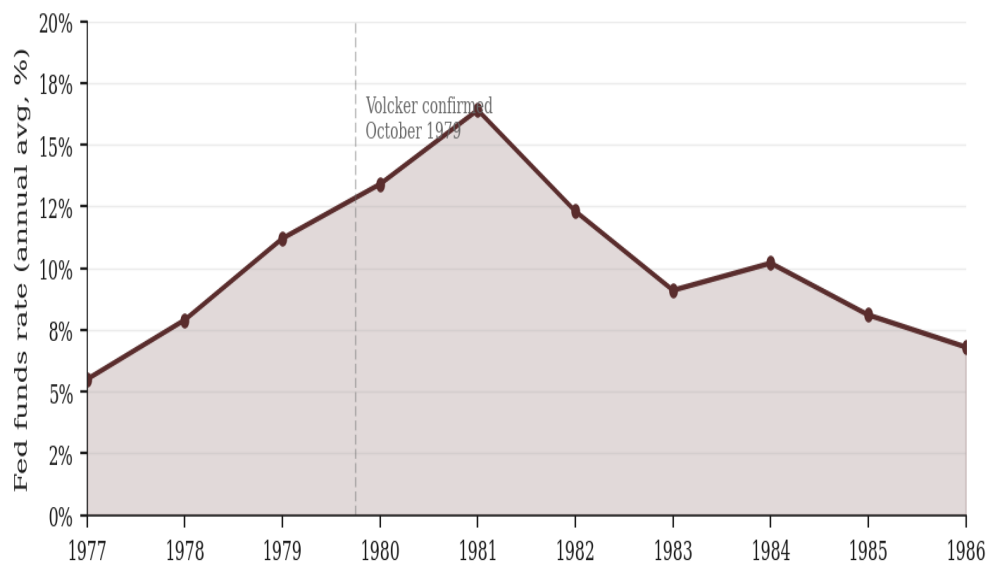
The oil shocks and inflation of the 1970s formalized a new global price hierarchy and a strict dollar division of labour. At the bottom were the nations forced to export raw resources at a discount; in the middle was the manufacturing labor; and at the apex sat the financial centers that dictated the terms of trade, capturing the value of the entire pyramid. The abandonment of the gold window proved again the old law: easy money destroys nations. The fiat inflation of the decade hollowed out the productive middle class and rewarded the leveraged speculator. Meanwhile, the strategy of the 1930s was redeployed in the Years of Lead: the secret-police incubation of extremists. State intelligence networks across NATO covertly managed and manipulated radical factions, ensuring that domestic terror served the geopolitical imperative of keeping populations frightened and docile.

1980 – 1989

A turntable is a machine for playing back what is already finished. In the South Bronx in the years around 1980 a generation of teenagers turned it into an instrument for making something new out of the finished thing. The borough they grew up in had been written off. Landlords torched their own buildings for the insurance; the city cut services to the blocks it had decided to abandon; the Cross Bronx Expressway, driven through the neighborhood by Robert Moses in the 1950s and 1960s with seventeen-block stretches blasted through occupied tenements, had left a wound that never healed; the official account insisted that nothing of value could come out of such a place. What came out of it was a method, and the moment it began can be dated. On the night of the eleventh of August 1973, in the rec room of an apartment building at 1520 Sedgwick Avenue, a sixteen-year-old named Cindy Campbell threw a back-to-school party and charged twenty-five cents at the door for girls and fifty for boys to raise money for school clothes. Her brother Clive, born in Kingston and raised in the Bronx, who performed as DJ Kool Herc, ran the records. Herc had noticed that the dancers favored the brief percussive interludes when the singing and the melody dropped out and the drums and bass took the floor alone, the passage musicians called the break. He set up two turntables, bought a second copy of every record he wanted to break-mix, and that night for the first time looped the break across the two copies, swinging back to the start of the passage on one deck while the other played, so that the few seconds of pure percussion the drummer and the bandleader had buried in the middle of the song became the whole song. A disc jockey named Joseph Saddler, who performed as Grandmaster Flash and had studied at the Samuel Gompers Vocational High School in the Bronx as an electronics technician, refined the method across the next three years into the quick-mix theory of precise needle-drop on the cued spot, lifting Herc's intuition into a craft a fourteen-year-old could practice. The discarded fragment, the part nobody had been meant to dwell on, became the whole song. It was an aesthetic built directly out of the condition that produced it, a way to take the ruins of an older industrial culture, its vinyl, its James Brown records, its abandoned rhetoric of soul and uplift, and repurpose the wreckage into a present tense that the people standing in the room could dance to. The city had stopped making things. Its children made art out of what it had abandoned.

What that method registered, before the economists had a vocabulary for it, was the central fact of the decade then beginning, that value was coming loose from production. The country that surrounded the Bronx was in the early stages of a change in what counted as wealth, and it ran in the same direction the turntable ran. It was learning to extract value not from the manufacture of a new thing but from the rearrangement of things that already existed, the recombination of existing claims, the loop played over the loop. The disc jockey cutting a break between two records and the financier loading an existing company with debt and selling off its parts were performing, at

opposite ends of the social order and with contrary rewards, a single gesture of the age, the gesture by which a society that had largely stopped building learned to live, profitably and inventively, off what it had already built.



Federal funds rate, 1977–1986: Volcker's break of inflation, and the bond bull market that followed. Source: Federal Reserve, H.15.

The financial gesture had a doctrine, and the creed had won a long argument before it found its enforcer. John Maynard Keynes had answered, in the *General Theory* of 1936, that a market left alone could settle at a permanent slump, that demand had to be supplied by the state when no one else would supply it, and that the government was the spender of last resort whose deficits pulled a depressed economy back to work. Against him stood the Austrians, Ludwig von Mises and above all Friedrich Hayek, who argued that the slump was not a failure to be cured but a reckoning to be endured, the necessary liquidation of the false investments that cheap credit had called into being, and that the state which tried to spend the hangover away only postponed and enlarged the reckoning. Hayek had lost that argument in the 1930s and lost it again at Bretton Woods, where the postwar order was built on Keynes's premises, and for a generation he was a marginal figure whose warnings read as the bitterness of a defeated man. The *Road to Serfdom* of 1944 sold steadily and changed no policy. Then the 1970s delivered the one thing the Keynesian synthesis had declared impossible, inflation and unemployment rising together, stagflation, a slump that more spending only worsened, and the argument swung back. Hayek took the Nobel Prize in 1974, and the doctrine that had been exiled to the seminar returned as the governing creed of two great Atlantic powers. The counter-revolution did not arrive as abstraction. It arrived as a man with the power to make money scarce.

By the end of the 1970s inflation had become the governing fact of American economic life, a slow drain of confidence in the dollar that ran near fifteen percent and made every saver poorer each month he kept the currency the whole order rested on. The mechanism a central bank uses against this is blunter than its dignity suggests. The Federal Reserve sets the price at which banks lend each other money overnight, and every other cost of borrowing in the economy stacks on top of that one; raise it far enough and credit stops being created, because no borrower can earn back what the loan now costs, and an economy that runs on continuously created credit slows the instant the credit stops. Paul Volcker, chairman of the Federal Reserve, drove that overnight rate to a peak near twenty percent in the middle of 1981, a height at which money becomes so dear that the machine seizes, and he did it on purpose, knowing what it would do¹. The cure laid the loss on those least able to refuse it. Unemployment climbed toward eleven percent. The industrial Midwest, the belt of mills and plants that had made the country the workshop of the postwar world, went cold, and the towns built around a single factory learned that it was not coming back. Inflation is in the last analysis a quarrel over who absorbs a loss, and Volcker settled it against labor and for the holders of financial assets, breaking the price spiral by crushing the wage power of the people whose pay had been chasing it. A creditor is made whole when the money he is owed stops losing value; a wage earner only when his pay rises faster than prices, and Volcker's scarcity guaranteed the first outcome by denying the second. This was the Austrian prescription enacted without apology, the liquidation Hayek had called for delivered to the worker and the mill town, the pain treated not as a regrettable cost of the policy but as the policy's actual content. The dollar was rescued by being made scarce, and the bill for the rescue went to the very places where the children would soon build a new music out of the rubble. The decision read in the textbooks as a triumph of technical resolve, and it was also a transfer, openly executed, of a vast loss from the men who owned paper to the men who worked jobs.

Consumer-price inflation and the federal funds rate, 1965–1990: the arc the appointment of August 1979 broke. Sources: Bureau of Labor Statistics; Federal Reserve release H.15.

By the close of the 1970s the dollar's guarantee had been spent twice over: the metal promise was shut in 1971 and the purchasing-power pledge was bleeding out at double digits. Read at that hour, the dollar gives every sign of a guarantee that does not come back - financialized, disbelieved, its correctors strained. What followed is what no model of slow rot could have called: an appointee chose against the comfort of his own position and re-anchored the promise after it had been spent, belief in the money restored by making its scarcity undeniable, and the bill went to someone who did not choose it.

The men who governed the two great Atlantic powers understood this not as a tragedy to be managed but as a restoration to be pursued, and they had a philosopher to license it. Margaret

1. Federal Reserve announcement of October 6, 1979; Paul Volcker and Toyoo Gyohten, *Changing Fortunes* (1992). The federal funds rate touched twenty percent in 1981.

Thatcher kept Hayek in her handbag and, by an account too useful to her movement to verify too closely, once produced his *Constitution of Liberty* at a meeting of her own party's researchers, set it down on the table, and announced that this was what they believed. Ronald Reagan, inaugurated in January 1981, and Thatcher, two years ahead of him at Downing Street, governed as though the postwar settlement of managed economies, disciplined banks, and a negotiated truce between capital and labor had been a long wandering away from a truer order, the Keynesian detour now corrected, and they set about dismantling that settlement with the conviction of restorers rather than the destructiveness of vandals. Thatcher's reform of the City of London in October 1986, the change the traders called the Big Bang, abolished in a single stroke the clubby old separations that had kept English finance small and slow, threw the Stock Exchange open to foreign banks, and turned the City within a few years from a national institution into a global one, a place where the nationality of money no longer signified. In America the same work proceeded more slowly. The deregulation of the savings and loan institutions in 1982 freed them from the rules that had kept them dull and solvent, with a result that would arrive at the decade's end as catastrophe. The constraints an earlier generation had built after 1929, in the belief that they were the hard-won lessons of ruin, were recast now as the dead hand of a state that did not trust its citizens to be rich. Whatever its philosophy, the restoration moved wealth in a single direction. Each measure that loosened a rule on finance, lightened a tax on capital, or weakened the hand of organized labor raised the share of the national income claimed by those who owned over those who worked, and the ratio kept climbing for forty years after, which is the surest sign of what the program was actually for. The faith beneath the reform was a secular eschatology, a belief in an approaching end-state of frictionless prosperity toward which deregulation was clearing the path, and it took the emotional shape of every such creed, by which present suffering, the gutted mill, the foreclosed home, the laid-off man, is redeemed by a future the believers can see and the sufferers cannot. The doctrine supplied the conviction and the conviction furnished the cover; under both, steadily, the order it built sent the gains upward and the costs down.

What replaced the factory in the American imagination was the deal, and the deal worked by a mechanism in which the whole shape of the new order is legible. A leveraged buyout begins with a small amount of the raider's own money and a large sum borrowed against the target company itself, the way a buyer puts ten percent down on a house and the bank lends the rest against the property. The crucial move is that the debt is then placed not on the raider but on the company he has bought, so that the firm now owes the money raised to purchase it. The interest on that debt is deductible from the firm's taxes, which means the public treasury quietly underwrites the transaction; the firm is then squeezed to service the loan, its costs cut, its workforce thinned, its divisions sold off one by one, and whatever cash remains is pulled out by the new owners. If the parts fetch more sold separately than the whole cost to buy, the raider keeps the difference, having

risked little of his own and put the company's survival on the table in place of his own. Michael Milken, working from an office in Beverly Hills far from the old eastern citadels, supplied the credit that made this possible at scale, the high-yield bond his detractors called the junk bond, debt issued by firms too weak or too encumbered to borrow cheaply and sold to investors willing to take the default risk for the higher return. With Milken's market a raider no longer needed his own fortune or a bank's blessing to threaten a corporation many times his size; he required only the promise that Milken could place the bonds, and that assurance put the largest companies in America in fear of men who owned almost nothing. The leveraged buyout of RJR Nabisco in 1988, a contest of roughly twenty-five billion dollars, stood as the coronation of the order, a fight in which the company that actually made the cigarettes and the crackers turned out to matter less than the financial engineering performed upon its carcass. Wealth had become a thing that lived in the gap between what an asset was worth and what it could be made to seem, and the men who worked that gap, the arbitrageurs and the bond traders and the deal lawyers, became the aristocracy of the age. They drew off the country's universities a stream of its most ambitious young, who a generation earlier might have gone into government or engineering or the law as a public calling and now reported to a trading floor, because a society makes more strivers than it has high seats to give them, and this society had built its new high seats on Wall Street. The savings and loans that the 1982 law had freed chased higher returns straight into commercial real estate and junk bonds and failed by the hundreds, and the taxpayer absorbed a rescue that ran past a hundred and fifty billion dollars. In that wreckage the defining arrangement of the new order showed its shape clearly: the gains of leverage stayed private and the losses, once they came, were socialized, because a financial system grown large enough is a thing the state dares not let fall. This was not an accident the system kept stumbling into. It was the system's logic followed to its end. Market discipline governed the worker, the mill town, and the defaulting nation; it did not, in the last instance, govern the financier, who had arranged matters so that he kept the upside of his risk and handed the catastrophe to everyone else, and who would arrange them that way again because nothing in the arrangement punished him for it.

That arrangement had its outer frontier, and it broke in Mexico City in the summer of 1982, when the finance minister told his country's creditors that Mexico could not service a debt grown almost unnoticed to roughly eighty billion dollars. The banks of New York and London had lent on the assumption that countries do not go bankrupt, that the dollar's frontier nations would always pay because they had no choice, and they had not reckoned with the man making dollars scarce in Washington. Every loan written in the 1970s at a floating rate now reset at a punishing one, and the interest alone exceeded what these economies could earn. Mexico was no isolated default but the first crack in a web that ran from Brasília to Buenos Aires to Lagos, and the years that followed became what Latin Americans called the lost decade, when the wealth of whole nations was

redirected from schools and roads and wages to obligations contracted in another country's currency at another country's central bank, while the International Monetary Fund arrived as a kind of receiver, prescribing austerity in exchange for the rescheduled terms that spared the banks from admitting on their own books that the loans were worth a fraction of their face. The dollar's energy had streamed outward into the margin in the 1970s, financing dams and steel mills and the ambitions of generals; now it flowed back as a debt that could not be repaid and would not be forgiven, and the relation between the center and its periphery stood revealed, in the harsh light of default, as the relation the lenders had always denied it was.

Oliver Stone's *Wall Street*, which reached theaters on the eleventh of December 1987 less than two months after Black Monday, gave this domestic arrangement a face and, against the director's intention, a hero. Stone had grown up the son of a Republican stockbroker on the Upper East Side of Manhattan; his father had managed accounts at Hayden Stone and written a quiet financial newsletter on the side, and Stone made *Wall Street*, by his own account, as a way of writing the screenplay he thought his father would have wanted to see. The picture was conceived as an indictment. Its raider, Gordon Gekko, was assembled out of the era's real predators, Ivan Boesky and Carl Icahn principally, with the slicked hair and braces of Owen Morrissey, a 1986 insider-trading defendant; the speech that made Gekko immortal, the declaration to a roomful of shareholders that greed, for lack of a better word, is good, that greed is right, that greed works, was adapted by Stone and Stanley Weiser from a commencement address Boesky had given at the University of California Berkeley's School of Business Administration on the eighteenth of May 1986, telling that year's graduates greed was healthy and they could be greedy and still feel good about themselves. Six months later, on the fourteenth of November 1986, Boesky was charged by the SEC with insider trading and paid a hundred-million-dollar settlement, and gave the prosecution the tape recordings that put Michael Milken in prison. Stone built the picture to disgust its audience with the man, and instead the man walked off the screen and into the dream life of the people he was supposed to repel. A generation of the ambitious took the indictment as a recruiting poster and reported to the trading floors quoting the villain's lines without irony. A ruling idea generates the very thing meant to oppose it and absorbs the opposition into itself, the dialectical motion the German philosophers had described in the previous century; but the picture revealed something more particular about how an ideology works, which is that it works most powerfully not when it is believed sincerely but when it is enjoyed cynically. The young financiers who quoted Gekko knew the film condemned him. They quoted him anyway, with a knowing smile. The smile was the form their belief took. They did not need to be persuaded that greed was virtue; the film had cheerfully told them it was vice. They needed only a permission to enjoy it, and the license was granted precisely by the irony, by the comfortable knowledge that of course it was wrong, which freed them to do it. What the picture could not contain was that the order it

attacked did not require sincere conviction to run. It ran on enjoyment, and Stone had given the appetite a charismatic face and a memorable creed and sent it out into the world.

The deregulation that freed finance at home had a shadow abroad, where the same loosened money served a state that wished to make a foreign policy its own elected legislature had forbidden. Congress, in the middle of the decade, had cut off funds to the Contra rebels fighting the leftist government of Nicaragua, and the administration, refusing the verdict, found other channels. It sold missiles in secret to revolutionary Iran, the declared enemy of the United States, in the hope of freeing American hostages taken by Iran's allies in Lebanon, and it took the profit from those sales and diverted it, off the books and outside any appropriation, to the very Contras the legislature had defunded. A colonel working out of the National Security Council ran the arrangement from inside the White House, shredding the records when it began to unravel in 1986, and what the affair laid bare was a piece of the executive financing its own war by its own covert commerce, accountable to no vote, deciding in private that the law restraining it did not apply. The diversion needed a place to move money no one could trace, and the decade had built the perfect instrument for it. The Bank of Credit and Commerce International, chartered in Pakistan and registered in Luxembourg and the Cayman Islands so that no single regulator could see the whole of it, had grown into a global institution warehousing deposits across seventy-odd countries, and it functioned as the private bank of the covert world, the phrase is barely a metaphor; the Senate's Kerry-Brown investigation, written after the bank's 1991 collapse, set out the clientele and the methods in detail. It laundered the proceeds of the drug trade, moved the cash for arms dealers, kept the accounts of intelligence services including the American one, and threaded the money of the Afghan pipeline and the Contra supply through its branches, an enterprise built from the ground up to be the place where the deniable transactions of states and the dirtiest transactions of criminals met and became indistinguishable. When regulators finally forced it shut in 1991 they found a hole of some ten billion dollars and a ledger of fraud so vast that an American prosecutor called it the largest bank failure in history. Iran-Contra and the bank that made such things possible are a single mechanism seen from two sides, the covert state and the offshore bank as one apparatus, finance and intelligence interlocked so tightly that the question of where the agency ended and the bank began had no clean answer, because by design there was none.

The drug trade those branches laundered was not a sideline to the decade's statecraft but a continuation of its oldest method. A century and a half before, Britain had built an empire of accounting on a national drug-pushing scheme, forcing Indian opium into China at gunpoint to balance its books, and the instrument had never been retired, only inherited. In the 1980s it ran on cocaine, and it ran through the hemisphere the lost decade had just bankrupted. Out of the wreckage of the Latin American defaults rose a parallel economy that paid in dollars when the legal one could not, and its sovereign was Pablo Escobar, a Medellín smuggler who built a cartel

that supplied most of the cocaine entering the United States, amassed a fortune that put him among the richest men on earth, offered to pay off Colombia's national debt, and ruled by a doctrine he stated as *plata o plomo*, silver or lead, the bribe or the bullet, until the state he had hollowed could no longer tell which of its officials it still owned. The product moved north into a country whose appetite the trade had learned to cultivate, and in the cities it was cooked into a cheap smokable rock that reached the poorest Black neighborhoods around 1984 and tore through them with a speed that emptied blocks, a chemical the market delivered to exactly the populations the restoration had already written off. Here the hidden hand showed itself most openly, and the conventional accounts grow most uneasy.

The same administration that armed the Contras off the books ran its covert war through a supply network that ferried cocaine north on the return leg, and the agency that operated it knew and shielded the men who flew the loads, a collaboration its own inspector general would later concede in the flat language of an internal report admitting that the relationships had not been cut despite the drug allegations. A reporter named Gary Webb traced one pipeline from the Contra fundraisers to the crack dealers of Los Angeles, and the press that had missed the story destroyed him for telling it, which is the treatment the apparatus keeps for the witness it cannot answer. Whether the agency set out to addict Black America, as the streets concluded, the documents do not establish and probably cannot; what it does show is colder and enough, that a government financed an illegal war by tolerating the traffic of a drug, that the drug gutted the communities least able to withstand it, and that the same government then declared a War on Drugs that met those communities not with the men who flew the cocaine in but with mandatory sentences a hundred times harsher for the rock the poor smoked than for the powder the comfortable sniffed, and built from that disparity a carceral system that would become the largest the world had ever assembled. The cartel, the agency, the bank, and the cell were one circuit. The trade financed the covert war, the bank hid the money, the drug disciplined the underclass, and the prison absorbed the survivors, and at no point was the order forced to choose between profit and control, because the drug delivered both.

The continent that produced the cartel also yielded the art that could register a reality this unreal, and the form it reached for was one the north had long mistaken for whimsy. Gabriel García Márquez, the Colombian who had taken the Nobel in 1982, wrote in the mode the critics called magical realism, in which the dead come back and rain falls for years and a woman ascends bodily into the sky, and the mode was not decoration but report, the only register adequate to a place where a smuggler could grow richer than the state and a government could lose a war to a man with an airstrip. He would set the Escobar terror down directly in time, the campaign of kidnappings the cartel waged against extradition, in a book of cold journalism; but the deeper testimony was the form itself, the insistence that in such a country the fantastic and the factual can

no longer be told apart, which is the condition a narco-economy imposes on the nation it captures. Fernando Botero, whose swollen and weightless figures had made him the most recognized painter the continent had sent out, turned in time to the same matter, setting down Escobar shot at last on a Medellín rooftop in a storm of police rounds, the heavy body suspended above the tiles, an image of a death the state had needed badly enough to stage it for the cameras. The narco-canvas and the magical-real share one recognition, that under the cartel the surface of ordinary life and the violence beneath it have come apart, that a country can keep the forms of a republic while a parallel sovereign collects its tax in cocaine, and that the art which tells the truth about such a place has to set the daylight and the impossibility in a single frame.

The same financial power could be turned outward as an instrument of state. By the middle of the 1980s the rising challenger to American economic supremacy was not the Soviet Union, whose economy was a rusting heavy-industrial relic, but Japan, an island that had climbed from the wreckage of 1945 to make better automobiles and better televisions than Detroit, to buy Rockefeller Center and a Hollywood studio, and to put into the American mind a real fear that the coming century belonged to Tokyo³ The challenge was met not chiefly with tariffs and not at all with arms but with money. On the twenty-second of September 1985, at the Plaza Hotel in New York, the United States brought Japan, West Germany, France, and Britain into a coordinated agreement to drive the overvalued dollar down. The mechanism is simple once stated. A currency is just another price, and a price can be moved by a large enough seller. Five finance ministries declaring in concert that they would sell dollars and stand behind a weaker one was an offer no speculator cared to fight, and the dollar fell as told. The yen rose against it by nearly half within two years, which made every Japanese export dearer abroad and every foreign asset cheaper to a Japanese buyer, and Tokyo answered the squeeze the way the new orthodoxy prescribed, by cutting interest rates to keep its exporters alive. The cheap money had no productive place to go in an economy already at full capacity, so it poured into land and stock and inflated the most extravagant asset bubble the modern world had seen, a mania in which the grounds of the Imperial Palace in central Tokyo were reckoned on paper to be worth more than the entire state of California. At the turn of the decade the bubble burst, and Japan fell into a stagnation measured not in years but in lost decades, the challenger broken on no battlefield but by a flood of credit released through the door the Plaza Accord had opened. The surest way to wreck a rival running hot is not to confront it but to give it what it thinks it wants, and a currency arrangement among the finance ministries of five powers, whatever its communiqués called it, did to Japan what no fleet could have done, with the refinement that the victim financed its own undoing and thanked its partners for the favor. There was no written conspiracy; there were converging interests and a room at the Plaza, and the men in that room understood precisely whose ascent a strong yen would arrest. Power of this kind operates not by a cabal's secret design but by the open convergence of

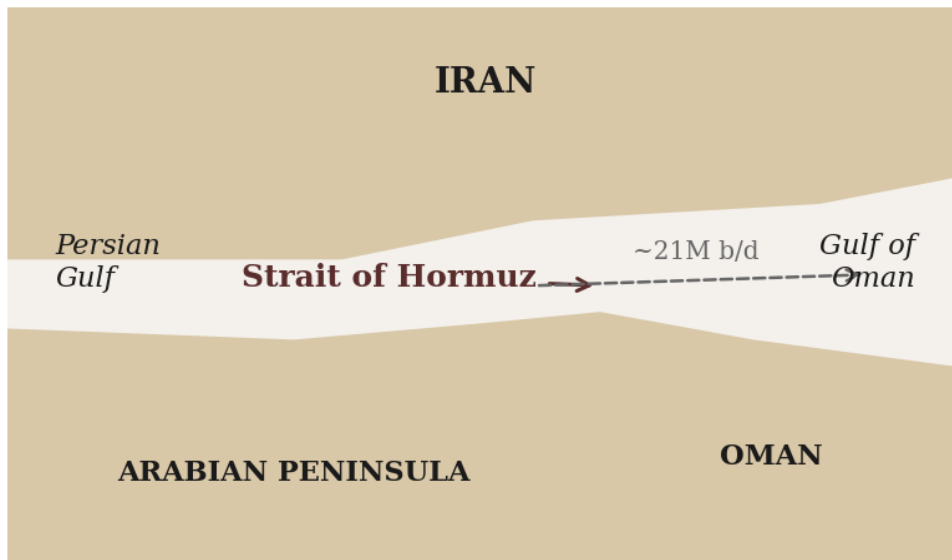
3. Plaza Accord communiqué, G-5 finance ministers, September 22, 1985.

the strong on an outcome that serves them, an act no less engineered for having left a paper trail of communiqués. The bitter coda is that the hegemon adding this lesson about Japan to its store of statecraft was, in the same years, piling against itself the leverage and the faith in its own guarantees that would one day bring the instruction home.

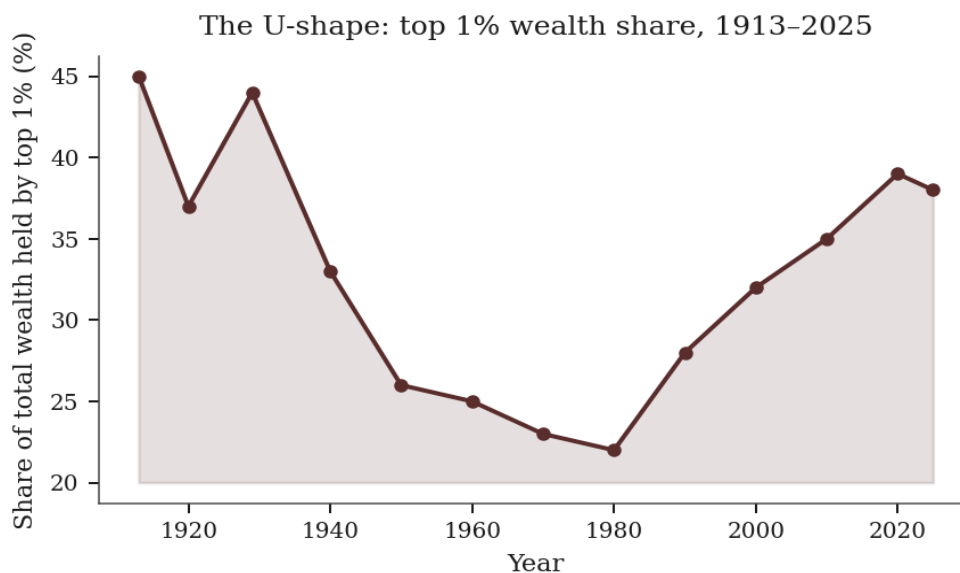
If the Plaza Accord showed the dollar's power exercised through the ledgers of finance ministries, the Persian Gulf in the same years displayed the harder thing the paper rested on, the steel that stood behind it where the promise was loaded onto tankers. Iran and Iraq had been grinding through a war since 1980, and by the middle of the decade each had begun to attack the other's oil exports at sea, striking the tankers that moved Gulf crude out through the strait at Hormuz, the narrow gate past which a great share of the world's oil must pass⁴ Kuwait, a small exporter caught between the combatants, asked the superpowers to protect its shipping, and

Washington answered by reflagging Kuwaiti tankers as American vessels and sending them through the strait under the guns of its warships, the operation that ran from 1987 to 1988. The Fifth Fleet, the standing American naval presence in those waters, escorted the convoys, fought brief sharp engagements with Iranian gunboats and mines, and made the plain point that the lane through which dollar-priced oil reached the world was kept open by an American hull or it was not kept open at all. The same arrangement showed its commercial face in the great arms sales of the period, the radar planes and the missiles and the research contracts of the Strategic Defense Initiative, the program the press called Star Wars, by which the security guarantee and the weapons that embodied it were sold to allies and clients as a line of business, the defense of the order and the profit from defending it folded into one transaction. A currency with nothing physical behind it could still command the obedience of the men who used it so long as the fleet sat astride the water their oil had to cross, and the reflagged tankers steaming past Hormuz under American destroyers were that proposition made visible, the abstraction of the strong dollar resolved into the concrete fact of a warship at a chokepoint.

4. The reflagging of Kuwaiti tankers under Operation Earnest Will, 1987–1988.



The Strait of Hormuz: the narrow water of the tanker war, and of every Gulf crisis since. Map data: Natural Earth.



The U-shape: top 1% wealth share, 1913–2025. Source: World Inequality Database.

The decade's confidence absorbed a sharp tremor in the autumn of 1987. On the nineteenth of October the Dow Jones average fell twenty-two percent in a single session, a larger one-day proportion than anything in the 1929 crash, and for a few hours the architects of the new order watched it threaten to consume itself. The cause lay partly in the machinery of the new finance, the computerized portfolio-insurance programs that sold automatically as prices dropped, each sale triggering the next in a cascade no person had ordered and none could halt. The market had grown

a nervous system faster than its own mind. The Federal Reserve under Alan Greenspan, newly installed, flooded the system with money within hours and let it be known that the central bank stood ready to supply whatever the markets required, and the panic subsided within days. The lesson was unmistakable and it was learned by exactly the people positioned to use it. Austrian discipline had been observed scrupulously on the way up and was abandoned the instant it threatened the holders of assets. The mill town and the indebted nation got the prescription for liquidation; Wall Street got the prescription for rescue. The asymmetry the decade had built into its dealings with the worker and the periphery hardened now into a standing promise, that a financial system grown large enough would never be allowed to clear, that the central bank would catch every fall the financier took. This promise had a value, and the financier priced it in: a risk the state will not let the holder lose is a risk worth taking on a larger scale, and so the rescue of 1987 was an invitation to the leverage of every decade after. Black Monday entered memory as a tremor that proved the building sound. What it actually disclosed, that an order of this velocity and this leverage had built fragility into its own foundations and would slide a long while before it dropped, was filed and forgotten by everyone but the men who had learned that the upside was theirs and the catastrophe was the state's.

The corporate city the financiers were assembling found its most haunting portrait in a film that buried the insight inside a detective story. Ridley Scott's *Blade Runner* opened on the twenty-fifth of June 1982 to weak receipts and divided reviews and became, over the years that followed, the canonical image of the future the present was building toward, a sunless vertical Los Angeles of acid rain and corporate ziggurats whose towers belong to the company that manufactures the replicants, artificial people built to labor off-world and engineered with a four-year life so they can never accumulate the past that would make them fully persons. Its official subject is the hunt for a band of these escaped beings; its real concern is the line dissolving between the made and the born, in a world where a corporation manufactures consciousness and sells it. The replicant is the worker reduced to a pure commodity, alive enough to suffer and disposable by design, and the picture's quiet devastation is that the replicants want, more desperately than any human in the film, the thing the order has decided they may not have, a past, a longer life. The film's deepest moment is the dying speech of the lead replicant, who in the moment of his manufactured death mourns the memories that will vanish with him, the things he has seen that no one else will ever believe, and in mourning them lays claim to exactly the inner life his makers denied he could possess. The thing the corporate order was building, the film says, will turn out to have a soul, and the soul will not forgive it.

The fear that runs under *Blade Runner*, that the manufactured thing acquires an inner life its makers cannot govern, was the same fear that ran under the silicon the decade was learning to depend on, and it surfaced more lightly and more pervasively in the form that came to organize the

decade's whole attention. On the first of August 1981, just after midnight, a cable channel called MTV began broadcasting to a handful of households in New Jersey, and the first thing it showed was a music video by a group named the Buggles whose title announced the channel's own thesis, that video had killed the radio star. The claim was almost true. What MTV introduced was not merely a new way to sell records but a new relation between the image and the song, in which the song now existed to deliver the visual and the picture was cut to the length and rhythm of the track. The unit of attention contracted to three or four minutes and the cut accelerated to match the beat, so that a generation learned to take in the world in fragments timed to music, each shot lingering only long enough to register before the next replaced it. This was the Warhol multiple set into motion and given a soundtrack, the image-as-commodity now circulating at the speed of broadcast, its worth measured in rotation, in how many times the channel played it. The advertisement and the artwork fused completely on MTV, since the video was both at once, a three-minute commercial for a record that was also the only form in which most of the audience would ever encounter the music, and the technique the engineers of consent had refined across the century, the manufacture of desire through the controlled image, reached on the music channel a kind of perfection, a continuous stream of ready-made fantasies of who the young viewer might want to be, sold as entertainment and consumed as identity.

Behind the bright surface of the image the decade circulated stood the men who owned the machinery that moved it, and the most instructive of them showed how completely media, debt, and intelligence had grown into a single seam. Robert Maxwell was born Ján Hoch in a Czech village, lost most of his family to the Nazis, fought his way into the British army and out of it with a new name and a decoration, and built across the postwar decades a publishing house and then a press empire that by the 1980s spanned tabloids, a wire service, scientific journals, and holdings on three continents. He bought the *Daily Mirror* in 1984 and ran it as a personal megaphone, a proprietor of the old swaggering kind who put his own bulk on his own front pages. The empire was built almost entirely on borrowed money, a tower of debt laid against assets whose values he inflated and shuffled between public companies and a maze of private trusts in offshore jurisdictions where no auditor could follow the cash. He cultivated heads of state, courted the powerful in every capital, and trailed for years the persistent allegation that he served Israeli intelligence, a charge his admirers dismissed and his biographers never settled, though the favors ran in both directions and the access he traded was real. On the night of the fifth of November 1991 he went over the side of his yacht off the Canary Islands and was found dead in the water, and whether the fall was an accident, a suicide as the creditors pressed in, or something arranged, the inquest could not establish; the verdict left the manner of death open and the rumors have never closed. Weeks before the fall, Seymour Hersh's *The Samson Option* had alleged in print, and two members of Parliament had repeated under privilege, that his papers had been an instrument of

5. Seymour Hersh, *The Samson Option* (1991); Hansard, October 21, 1991; Gordon Thomas, *Gideon's Spies* (1999), p. 210; wire reports of November 10–11, 1991.

Israeli intelligence, including in the betrayal of the whereabouts of the nuclear technician Mordechai Vanunu; the publisher sued, called the charges ludicrous, and was dead within a fortnight, the claims never adjudicated. He was buried on the Mount of Olives with honors approaching the official, the Prime Minister and the President among the mourners, and, by one biographer's account, six serving and former heads of Israeli intelligence; the contemporaneous wires record only the politicians. Whatever the truth of his services, the funeral was itself a document, and it was filed in public. What the receivers found when the empire was opened was that he had looted the pension funds of his own employees, hundreds of millions taken from the retirements of the people his papers were printed by, to prop the debt a little longer. Maxwell is the seam itself made visible, the place where the business of selling images to the public, the business of borrowing against nothing, and the trade in secrets to states all turned out to be one enterprise run by one man, and his daughter Ghislaine, raised inside that world and schooled in its uses, extended the connections forward into the decade after his body was pulled from the sea⁵

MTV was the noisy edge of a quieter and more consequential change in the way the country watched itself. The American living room had been governed since the 1950s by three national networks that pointed nearly every household at the same handful of programs at the same hour, a shared hearth around which a continental population assembled to see a common image of itself; and across the 1980s that hearth began to splinter. The mechanism was a wire and a law. Coaxial line, laid block by block through the suburbs, could pipe dozens of channels where the air had pushed three, and the Cable Communications Policy Act of October 1984, drafted in the same deregulatory spirit that had freed finance, stripped away most local control over what the cable operators could charge and program, and the industry surged. Cable reached under a tenth of American homes in the 1970s and more than half by 1988, and with it came channels for every fragment of the audience, an all-news channel, a sports channel, an outlet of nothing but the videos that MTV had made the decade's native grammar. The single national audience, which had been a fact of the postwar order as solid as the dollar's link to gold, quietly began to break into market segments, each sold separately to advertisers, the mass public of the broadcast age splitting into the demographics of the cable age the way the mass economy was dividing into the winners and the discarded.

Against that fragmentation the networks answered with a program that made a virtue of the very thing the cable wire was dissolving, and it was set, with an exactness the writers may not have fully measured, inside a bar. Cheers premiered on NBC on the thirtieth of September 1982, to ratings so poor that it finished near the bottom of every show on the air and was nearly cancelled, and it survived to become one of the most beloved programs the medium produced, its theme song promising a place where everybody knows your name and they are always glad you came. The promise is worth reading closely, because it is the decade's fantasy stated in a single line. Cheers is

set in a Boston bar in the years the mills were closing and the towns built around a single factory were learning it would not return, and into that bar come the same casualties of the new order: a barfly accountant who would rather sit on his stool than go home, a know-nothing mailman who mistakes the regulars for an audience, a failed former athlete reduced to pouring beer, a graduate student stranded between the cultivation she was raised to and the work the economy actually offered her. The bar is a refuge from precisely the world Volcker and Milken and the Plaza Accord were building, a small warm room where one is known and welcome and where the relentless sorting of the outside, into the leveraged and the liquidated, the winners and the discarded, is suspended at the door. What it dramatizes is the wish of an atomizing society for a public commons that the same society's economics were destroying, the corner tavern as the last institution where a person counts for something other than his market value. The wish that does the work is in the smallness of the consolation. The place where everybody knows your name is a bar, a room one enters to forget, and the warmth on offer is that of people with nowhere better to be, gathered to drink away an afternoon that the productive order had no further use for. The decade that prized the deal and the trading floor put its tenderest image of belonging in a room full of the men the deal had left behind, and broadcast it weekly to a national audience that the cable wire was, at that very moment, breaking apart.

The music the Bronx had built out of the break entered this circulation and was changed by it, and the instrument that brought it across was a machine that made the decade's whole logic audible. The digital sampler, in 1981 a device costing tens of thousands of dollars and confined to a few professional studios, fell across the decade within reach of a producer with a small advance, the cost of an Akai or an E-mu coming down as fast as the price of a turntable had once put two copies of one record within reach, and what it did was capture a fragment of existing recorded sound and let the operator replay it at any pitch, loop it, layer it, build a new composition entirely out of pieces of old compositions. It automated and extended what Grandmaster Flash had done by hand with two turntables. The new music was made of quotations, of drum breaks lifted from records cut before the producers were born, of horn stabs and bass lines and spoken phrases excavated from the archive and recombined into something that had not existed. When Grandmaster Flash and the Furious Five released *The Message* in the summer of 1982, the genre acquired a voice for the condition that produced it, a flat unillusioned report from the broken city, the rapper insisting over the spare track that he was close to the edge and trying not to lose his head, the first time the music had turned its salvaged sound back on the ruin it was salvaged from and named it. The grit of the cheaper machines, their low resolution and their crude filtering, was not a defect the producers wanted to overcome but a texture they came to prize, the sound of the salvage showing its seams, and that roughness became the signature of the music. The argument sat inside the technique. A sampled break is a claim laid on someone else's labor, replayed for a

new purpose and a new profit, and the law spent the following decades trying to decide whether it was theft or creation, which is the same question the leveraged buyout posed about the company stripped for its parts, asked in sound. The producer looping a stranger's drum break and the raider dismantling a stranger's firm were both extracting value from existing things rather than making new ones, and the music knew this about itself before anyone else did, which is why it kept insisting, in its lyrics and its sleeve art and its quarrels over credit, that it had made something and not merely taken it.

The decade's art market made the fusion of artwork and financial asset literal, and it found its emblem in a young man who became, within a few years, both the maker of the paintings and one of the assets traded. Jean-Michel Basquiat was born in Brooklyn in 1960 to a Haitian father, an accountant, and a Puerto Rican mother, an amateur painter who took him to the Brooklyn Museum at six; he was struck by a car at seven and read Gray's Anatomy through the long recovery, the book that would supply the anatomical diagrams of his late canvases. He dropped out of City-As-School at seventeen and began writing cryptic aphorisms on Lower Manhattan walls under the tag SAMO (Same Old Shit), a collaboration with the high-school friend Al Diaz; the two of them painted "SAMO IS DEAD" across SoHo when Basquiat fell out with Diaz over a Village Voice profile that named only him. By 1981 his canvases of crowned figures and anatomical diagrams and crossed-out words were selling through Annina Nosei's basement gallery on Prince Street; she locked him in by day to paint and let dealers come down the stairs to buy directly off the easel. The market for contemporary art expanded in the 1980s at a velocity that matched the markets for everything else, driven by the same surplus of financial wealth in search of a place to compound, and a painting became a vehicle for capital appreciation as openly as a junk bond. Basquiat occupied this market in a position no painter had quite owned before, because he was a young black man being made rich and famous by a white art establishment that prized exactly the rawness it could also patronize, and his work, watched closely, knows this. He painted heroes and martyrs and crowned them, claimed for the Black body and name a regal dignity the official culture had withheld, and at the same time he watched himself become a product, a brand, an asset on the wall of collectors who could not have named a single thing his paintings were about. He collaborated with Andy Warhol from 1984 to 1985, the man who had first turned the artwork into a stock certificate, and broke with him after a Times reviewer called him Warhol's mascot; the two did not speak again before Warhol's death in February 1987. On the twelfth of August 1988, eighteen months after Warhol's funeral, Basquiat was found dead in his Great Jones Street loft of a heroin overdose. He was twenty-seven. The prices of his paintings began the long climb that would lift a single canvas, *Untitled* (1982), past one hundred and ten million dollars at auction in 2017. The career was the decade's logic compressed into a life. The artist had become the asset, the maker the thing traded, and the value of the work rose fastest after the man who made it was gone,

because a finished body of work, like a closed company or a completed record, could be recombined and resold without the inconvenience of the person who had produced it.

While the body was being made an asset on the gallery wall, the body was also the site of the decade's deepest terror, and that dread exposed the moralism the restoration had imported alongside its economics. A new illness appeared at the start of the decade, named first in the dry clinical idiom of a bulletin: on the fifth of June 1981 the federal disease center reported a cluster of a rare cancer and a rare pneumonia among young homosexual men in New York and Los Angeles, men whose immune systems had collapsed for no reason medicine yet understood. The thing was eventually called the acquired immune deficiency syndrome, and across the decade it killed with a completeness that recalled the plagues the modern world had told itself it had left behind, striking down men in their twenties and thirties, the young and the recently beautiful, with a speed and a disfigurement that turned hospital wards into places of medieval dread. By the end of 1987 nearly sixty thousand cases had been reported in the United States and almost half of those infected were dead, and the toll climbed through the close of the decade with no cure and, for years, no treatment at all. The single drug that arrived, AZT, approved in 1987, was punishing and only partly effective and priced beyond what most of the dying could pay.

What the disease revealed was the buried underside of the decade's official optimism. The restoration had married its market faith to a sacred conservatism, a reassertion of the family, of traditional sexual order, of the body governed by older rules, and the same coalition that preached the frictionless future also preached also a return to a morality the 1960s and 1970s had loosened. AIDS struck first and worst among the populations that morality had already cast outside the family, homosexual men and drug users, and a large part of the country received the plague not as a catastrophe to be met but as a judgment to be confirmed, the wages of a sin the restoration had set itself against. The federal government, headed by a president whose coalition depended on that conservatism, said almost nothing for years. Reagan did not address the disease in a major public speech until the thirty-first of May 1987, by which time more than twenty thousand Americans had already died of it, and the silence was itself a statement, an official refusal to grant the dying the standing of a national emergency. The fantasy the era was sustaining, the wholesome restored family at the center of a prosperous order, required that the sick remain invisible, since to see them was to admit that the body the moralists wanted governed was instead in revolt, that desire did not obey the rules the restoration was trying to reimpose, and that the market's promised future of frictionless prosperity had a frictionless circulation of its own, of bodies and contagions, that no doctrine could discipline.

The thing erupted into form when the dying refused to stay invisible. The most militant of them organized in 1987 as a coalition that took its acronym, ACT UP, as a command, and they

staged their politics as public spectacle, lying down in the streets and at the doors of the federal health agencies, brandishing images of the dead, insisting that the country look at what it had decided not to see, that silence equaled death. Their art was direct and angular and made for the camera, a black field with a pink triangle and three words, designed to be photographed and reproduced and to function as the era's other multiple, the image circulating not for profit but to break a silence the market and the state both found convenient. Two years before that, in 1985, network television had aired the first major drama about the disease, broadcast to thirty-four million households on a night it outdrew the football game, a film in which a successful young lawyer goes home to tell his parents both that he is gay and that he is dying, and the country watched the plague arrive inside exactly the family the restoration had enshrined, watched it cross the threshold the moralists had told themselves it could not cross. The disease that had been cast as the judgment on a sinful minority turned out to honor no such boundary, and the form the decade's terror finally took, on the placard and on the screen, was the body's refusal to be governed by the order that had declared it shameful.

While the West learned to live off its salvage, the East was dying of the inability to renew itself, and the most literal expression of that condition was the spectacle at the top of the Soviet state. The Soviet Union entered the decade ruled by a gerontocracy in the clinical sense, government by the old who were dying. Leonid Brezhnev, in power since 1964, spent his last years propped up at parades, his speech slurred, his Politburo an assemblage of men in their seventies who had risen together under Stalin and now governed a country whose problems they had neither the energy nor the imagination to face. When he died in November 1982 the succession fell to Yuri Andropov, sixty-eight and already failing, who spent much of his fifteen months in office on a dialysis machine; when Andropov died in February 1984 the Politburo, having learned nothing, chose Konstantin Chernenko, seventy-two and emphysemic, barely able to finish a speech, who lasted thirteen months before he too died. Three rulers buried in Red Square in twenty-eight months, the same faces filing past the same catafalque, the honor guard scarcely standing down before it was summoned again. The Western press made grim jokes about the recurring funerals, but the joke pointed at a thing the comedians did not name, that an institution which can no longer pick the young has lost the capacity to choose at all. The reformers and the technicians who might have renewed the system, the ones who had glimpsed the West and understood the gap, had been kept waiting in the antechambers of power so long that some of them grew old there, their ideas calcifying alongside the men they were meant to replace. A bureaucracy in its terminal phase does not promote the able; it promotes the safe, the senior, the man who has survived by never having had a dangerous thought, and the Soviet apparatus had spent a generation perfecting exactly that selection until it could no longer produce a leader capable of saving it. The frozen elite at the top mirrored a rigid economy below, an industrial base oriented

toward heavy goods and weapons that could not feed its people or supply them the ordinary comforts the West took for granted, a planning apparatus ossified into ritual, a society that had quietly ceased to believe the things its leaders still said aloud.

The most sustained literary response to that terminal Soviet condition was published, by an irony Herbert himself could not have planned, in the same season the gerontocracy began to bury its own. Frank Herbert had returned, twice, to the universe the prior chapter introduced. In 1969 he had killed off the messiah of the first novel under the consequences of his own jihad. In 1976 he had handed the empire to that messiah's twin children. The fourth volume, *God Emperor of Dune*, was published in May 1981 by Putnam in New York, eighteen months before Brezhnev died and the burials began. Most of its readers took it as the moment Herbert lost the thread, a long philosophical interlude before the action returned. The misreading was as complete as the misreading of the first novel had been. What Herbert had set down in 1981 was a single 3,500-year interior monologue spoken by Leto II, son of Paul Atreides, who has merged his body with the sandtrout of Arrakis and become a worm, immortal, monstrous, the absolute and only authority across the known universe. His policy across those three and a half millennia has been to impose on humanity an artificially extended period of stagnation, peace, and cruelty, which he calls the Golden Path. He has crushed initiative, regulated faster-than-light travel almost to extinction, kept the spice flowing under a tax regime no rival could meet, and made of the human species a herd small enough to manage and dull enough to last. He has done this not because he loves what he does but because he has seen ahead and seen that humanity, left to its own impulses, will be exterminated by a thing it has invented but cannot stop, and the only way for the species to survive that crisis is for him to force on it the long discipline that breaks the impulse before the crisis arrives. He intends, at the end of the three and a half millennia, to die, and to let humanity scatter so far across the galaxy that no machine and no purge will ever find all of it.

The book is a defense of Stalin written by a man who could not say so. The Marxism that had inherited Hegel's eschatology had promised that the dialectic would arrive at the classless end on its own, that capital would dig its own grave, that no extraordinary intervention was required because history was already moving where it had to go. The Stalinist break, formalized in 1928 with the abandonment of the New Economic Policy and the launching of the First Five-Year Plan, was the discovery that the dialectic by itself does not arrive on schedule and that the survival of the experiment required forcing the peasantry into collective farms and the country into the heavy industry it would need to fight the war the planners could already see coming. The collectivization that followed killed perhaps six million people in the famine of 1932 and 1933. The industrialization it paid for built the tanks that broke the Wehrmacht east of Stalingrad ten years later. The Stalinist case, made by Stalinists themselves and by the more candid Soviet historians of the late period before the apparatus could no longer pay them to make it, was that the famine had

bought the tanks, and that without the tanks the experiment ends in 1942 with the Germans across the Volga and the engineered human extinguished. Whether the case is correct is a question this volume cannot settle and does not propose to. The Golden Path runs the same case in fiction. Leto II's three and a half millennia stretch the Five-Year Plans past any human life span. The famine and the purge are raised to the scale of a species and to the time of a god. The forced discipline imposed on an unwilling population by a single mind that has seen ahead, and judged that the discipline must be borne because the alternative is extinction, is the Soviet defense of itself transposed into a register where it can be heard.

That Herbert names the Bene Gesserit breeding program, the Atreides bloodline, the planning of a single ruler across centuries, and the cruelty required to keep the human animal from its own self-destruction is not coincidence. He had spent his adult life around American liberals who could not bring themselves to say that the Soviet experiment had been anything other than a deformity of the original Marxist promise, and around American conservatives who could not bring themselves to admit that the West had needed the Soviet experiment to break the Wehrmacht. He wrote against both. The novel does not endorse Leto II. It makes him terrible. He kills lovers, crushes revolts, weeps openly at the loneliness of his own foreknowledge, and chooses across thirty-five hundred years a discipline he hates because he has seen what comes if he does not. The reader is meant to be revolted by him and to understand, at the same time, that he may be right. What a sober Stalinist would have written, had his country still permitted it, in defense of the choices Stalin made, is what Herbert wrote and got Putnam to publish in May of 1981. The actual Stalinists had been dead since 1953 and their nominal heirs were dying in front of the cameras Brezhnev no longer recognized.

The deeper argument the book makes, the one its American readers in 1981 had no use for and would have no use for at any later date the period offered them, is that the markets had themselves quietly produced exactly this arrangement. The classical political economy of Smith and Ricardo had promised, in its theoretical purity, that competition would dissolve every cartel, that every monopoly would die of its own success, that the invisible hand would arrive at a stable equilibrium because the dialectic of the marketplace contained no other possibility. The classical promise broke in the same generation as the Marxist one. The cartelization Engels had named in his 1887 prophecy as the precondition for general industrial war had become, by the late twentieth century, the standard arrangement of every developed economy, the great firms protected by their states from the foreign competition the textbook had said would crush them, the labor of the marketplace settled by managers who answered to no electorate. The East India Company the long nineteenth century had laid down became the multinational parent company that ran the petrodollar order. The federal state that had emerged from the New Deal became, by the second year of Reagan, the regulator of credit on behalf of the financial sector. The arrangement was not what the textbook

had promised. It was what Marx had said it had to become, and Herbert in *God Emperor* wrote the fictional autobiography of the agent who would have had to impose the discipline if the markets had not, on their own, produced an arrangement of the same shape at marginally lower cost in suffering. The Golden Path runs the long claim that the engineering of consent which had begun with Bernays in the 1920s, the engineering of markets which had begun with the Federal Reserve in 1913, and the engineering of humans which had begun in the asylums of the late nineteenth century, are the same operation extended at last to the species as a whole. To manage humanity at scale is to impose on humanity a long stagnation. The only honest difference between the Soviet version and the American version is the speed at which the discipline was imposed and the explicitness of the man who imposed it. Stalin said so. The American version said the opposite the whole time. Both made tanks.

The novel sold poorly in 1981 by the standards of the *Dune* sequence and was treated as the moment Herbert had lost his grip. The judgment was wrong. It is the only place in American science fiction where the central proposition of the twentieth century, that a species survives only when a single mind imposes on it a discipline it would not choose, is set down without disguise and pursued to its end. Herbert died of pancreatic cancer on the eleventh of February 1986, three months before the Chernobyl meltdown, six years before the Soviet Union finally dissolved into the country it had quietly become. The Soviet apparatus he had used as his template was about to end. The argument the novel made about it, that the discipline had been required, was about to become a thing nobody could say out loud anywhere. The book sits there waiting for the reader who can say it. The American reader has not yet been that reader. The end of the chapter will return to the question of who, in the order that succeeded the one Herbert was reading, was being disciplined by whom and for what.

The case Herbert made in 1981 had a longer pedigree than his American reviewers knew, and the line that produced it ran through philosophy before it reached science fiction. The German Idealist tradition had been quarreling over the same proposition for two hundred years by the time Putnam set the book in print, and the quarrel had a name and a date. In the autumn of 1785 Friedrich Heinrich Jacobi published *Über die Lehre des Spinoza in Briefen an den Herrn Moses Mendelssohn*, a polemical correspondence in which Jacobi revealed that the late Gotthold Ephraim Lessing, the most respected man of letters in the German Enlightenment, had confided to him in conversation that he was a Spinozist. The disclosure detonated. To be a Spinozist in 1785 was to deny a personal God, to accept that everything that exists is one substance unfolding according to its own necessity, and to leave human freedom and moral responsibility without a foundation the orthodoxy could recognize. Mendelssohn, who had been Lessing's friend, set himself the task of refuting the charge and died the following winter in the middle of the effort, the public quarrel over what Lessing had actually said still raging when his coffin was lowered. What Jacobi had set

down in that book, and developed across the next quarter century in subsequent volumes against Kant, against Fichte, against Schelling, was a claim more radical than the revelation about Lessing. Rationalism, on Jacobi's case, when pressed all the way down to its own foundations, collapses inevitably into Spinozism, because no rational system can ground a personal God or a free human will or a binding moral law on rational premises alone, and Spinozism in turn collapses inevitably into what Jacobi called nihilism, the doctrine that the categories of value the human animal lives by have no objective standing and can be sustained only by a leap of faith the rational mind cannot justify. The choice Jacobi posed to his readers was the choice between a faith the reason cannot defend and a nihilism the reason cannot escape, and he chose the faith. The choice itself, and the diagnosis underneath it, are what got the name. The postmodernism the late twentieth century would announce as a new arrival, the suspicion that systematic reason terminates in the dissolution of every category it set out to ground, had in fact been the dominant intellectual structure of the West since the 1780s. Jacobi had stated the case. Kant had answered it with the *Critique of Judgment* and the *Refutation of Idealism*. Fichte and Schelling and Hegel had each in turn taken up the same problem from a different angle and bequeathed to the nineteenth century a tradition of philosophy whose central question was how to live in a world the reason had emptied of the supports the reason had once been thought to supply.

Schiller drew the cultural consequences for literature, and the work he did so in is one of the most lucid documents the period produced. On *Naïve and Sentimental Poetry*, published across 1795 and 1796, proposed that the literature of the ancient world was naïve in the technical sense, the writer at one with the world he described, no gap between the perceiver and the perceived, the figure on the page inhabiting his own experience directly; and that the literature of the modern world is sentimental in the technical sense, the writer aware of the gap between himself and the world he describes, the figure on the page looking at his own experience as if through a windowpane, conscious that he is no longer at one with it and conscious that the consciousness itself is the condition that prevents the reunion. The modern subject, Schiller proposed, is the figure unable to inhabit its own world directly, conscious of the gap and unable to close it, the gap itself the foundation of the sensibility the period would name romanticism and the period after would name modernism and the period after that would name postmodernism, each label registering a further development of the same fundamental condition Jacobi had diagnosed a decade earlier. The sentimental subject is the rationalist on the other side of the rationalism, the figure who has watched the categories of value dissolve under the reason's pressure and now stands at the window with the dissolved world on the other side of the glass.

The form the sentimental subject required was the epistolary novel, and the four canonical instances are a single experiment performed in four versions across forty years. Samuel Richardson published *Pamela* in 1740 and *Clarissa* in 1748; Jean-Jacques Rousseau published

Julie, ou la Nouvelle Héloïse in 1761; Johann Wolfgang von Goethe published *Die Leiden des jungen Werthers* in 1774. In each, the protagonists are figures whose access to one another's minds is mediated entirely by the letters they write, four people in a void trying to determine one another's interior states by reading what each writes to each, and the dramatic substance of the form lies in the gap between what a letter says and what its writer means and what its reader takes from it. The form renders the sentimental condition as fiction. The characters cannot meet directly; they meet only through the document, and the document grows unreliable in proportion to the urgency of the meeting it tries to enact. Werther's letters to Wilhelm concentrate the diagnosis to its narrowest point, a young man writing into a void he cannot establish whether anyone receives, the writing itself a substitute for the union the writer cannot achieve and the substitute itself the proof that union is impossible. The sentimental novel and the Jacobi polemic deliver the same diagnosis in two registers, the philosophical and the literary, each setting down a condition the modern subject has not yet escaped because no escape is available from inside the condition itself.

What this material was doing in the autumn of 2021, in a podcast debate that posted ten weeks before *God Emperor of Dune* was deployed against Thaddeus Russell in the longer episode the previous section described, demonstrates that the line from Jacobi to Herbert runs without break. Kantbot's bit in the Pseudodoxology debate with Russell, recorded in the summer of 2021, took up the Refutation of Idealism from the second edition of the *Critique of Pure Reason* and used it to derive a defense of Stalin. The argument ran as follows. Kant's Refutation of Idealism established that consciousness of the self requires consciousness of objects external to the self, that the interior subject is constituted by the exterior world it perceives, that subjectivism cannot be coherent because the subject cannot be established without the world the subjectivist proposes to bracket. Jacobi's Spinozismus polemic, three decades earlier, had set out the alternative: either a faith in a personal God the reason cannot defend, or a slide into a nihilism in which the categories of value have no foundation. Schiller's sentimental subject, a decade later still, was the figure who had taken the slide and now stood at the window. The state, on the Kantian-Jacobi-Schillerian case Kantbot was assembling, has a security interest in the prevention of subjectivism, because a population of sentimental subjects standing at the window watching their own categories dissolve is a population the state cannot govern, and the political-theological imperative is to impose on the subject an external order under which the categories can be sustained. Stalin, on this case, was simply the figure who performed that imposition without apology, the executor of the security interest the German Idealist tradition had been theorizing for a hundred and fifty years. The American academy of 2021 could not parse the argument because the academy had received its German Idealism through a chain of translations and partial readings that had stripped out the political-theological substance and left only the analytic shell, and Russell, a libertarian historian formed in that tradition, kept asking Kantbot questions whose answers were in books Russell had

not read. The bit delivered real philosophical content under the cover of character work. Herbert's 1981 case repeated, in a register Putnam would print, the diagnosis the German Idealists had been pressing against the Enlightenment for two hundred years, and Kantbot's 2021 derivation from the Refutation of Idealism repeated it in a third register, a hundred and ten years after Jacobi had first set it down.

The deeper claim the material makes is that the postmodernism the late twentieth century announced as a new development was nothing of the kind. The Lyotard report on the postmodern condition appeared in 1979, two years before *God Emperor*; Derrida had been publishing since the late 1960s; the academic adoption of what got called theory across the 1980s and 1990s was treated by its enthusiasts and its critics as a rupture, the moment Western thought finally abandoned its foundational ambitions and accepted that meaning was unstable and the categories were arbitrary and the subject was a position rather than a substance. Jacobi had set down the same diagnosis in 1785. The two centuries of philosophy that followed were the West's working-through of a condition the moderns had been in since the publication of the *Critique of Pure Reason* and the Spinozismus polemic, the condition under which the reason had dissolved the supports the reason had once supplied and the question that remained was what to put in their place. Hegel had answered with history. Marx had answered with the proletariat. Nietzsche had answered with the overman. Heidegger had answered with Being. The American academy of the late twentieth century, having no answer of its own, announced the absence of any answer as a new philosophical achievement, and the announcement was greeted in the seminars as if no one had ever made the diagnosis before. The Stalinist case Herbert was making in *God Emperor* and the Jacobi case underneath both rest on the same diagnosis, and the American failure to read either rests on a single deeper refusal. The same failure that left Herbert's American readers treating *God Emperor* as the moment he lost his grip left the American academy treating Lyotard as the moment philosophy had finally arrived at a condition philosophy had been in since the 1780s. What was missing in each case was the same reading. To recover it would have required the book the German Idealist tradition wrote in installments across two hundred years, in a language and a register the American twentieth century had decided it could not be bothered to learn.

The empire was also bleeding itself in a war whose victory lay forever out of reach, a war that began in the last days of 1979 and ran through almost the whole of the decade, and the course of it reads as the slow education of a great power in the limits of its own strength. In December 1979 the Soviet Union had sent its army across the southern border into Afghanistan, where a Marxist government installed by coup the year before was tearing itself apart in faction and losing the countryside to revolt. Soviet airborne troops seized Kabul, special forces stormed the presidential palace and killed the man they had come ostensibly to support, and Moscow installed a more pliable client and told itself the matter would be settled in months. The expeditionary force, never

much above a hundred thousand men, occupied the cities and the ribbon of road between them and could march anywhere it chose; what it could not do was keep the ground once it had passed. Afghanistan is a country of mountain and valley made for the defender, and the resistance, the mujahideen, did not mass to be destroyed but dispersed into the terrain, ambushed the convoys on the high roads, mined the passes, struck the garrisons at night and vanished before the armor could respond. The Soviet army answered with the tactics of a power that mistakes destructive force for control, leveling villages it suspected of sheltering fighters, seeding the fields and the footpaths with mines, driving millions of Afghans across the borders into Pakistan and Iran as refugees, until by the middle of the decade something near a third of the country's people had fled and the war had taken on the character of a campaign against the population itself. The killing was enormous and fell most heavily on civilians, and it bought the occupier nothing, because every village razed produced fighters for the next valley, and the countryside the army could not garrison simply closed behind it the moment it withdrew.

The war turned on the gap between capability and resolve, and the gap widened when the resistance was given the means to contest the one advantage the Soviets had never lost. For years the helicopter gunship had owned the Afghan sky, the heavily armored machine that could hunt the fighters in terrain no tank could reach and that made movement by daylight a sentence of death. From 1986 the United States, working through Pakistan's intelligence service, supplied the mujahideen with the shoulder-fired Stinger missile, a weapon a single man could shoulder and fire, that locked onto the heat of an engine and brought the gunships down. The sky closed to the Soviets; the war they had been losing slowly they now had no path to win at all. The Stinger was only the visible tip of a supply line built to leave no fingerprints, and the architecture of that line is the decade's covert statecraft made plain. American money, by the end matched dollar for dollar by Saudi Arabia, ran into a fund the Central Intelligence Agency administered and then passed entirely to Pakistan's military directorate, the body the initials ISI named, which alone decided which Afghan commanders received the rifles and the cash and the antiaircraft missiles. The chain was designed so that no weapon could be traced to Washington and no American hand need touch an Afghan one, and the cost of that deniability was that the Pakistani service chose the recipients, favoring the most absolutist of the holy warriors and the Arab volunteers who had come to fight a war they understood as faith. Saudi religious charities moved alongside the official money, building the schools and the camps in the Pakistani borderlands where a generation of fighters was trained and catechized. The order armed the men who would defeat its rival and, in the same motion and through the same intermediaries, assembled and blooded the networks the next decades would name as the enemy, having funded their schooling, their weapons, and their first victory against a superpower. The blowback was not an accident of the program; it was the program's other face, the deniable pipeline producing exactly the unclaimed veterans such a

channel is built to produce.

But the deeper defeat was never tactical. The Red Army could win every set-piece engagement it chose to fight and still lose the war entirely, because it had overwhelming capability and no resolve that could outlast that of men defending their own valleys, and a great power fighting a war of choice at the edge of its reach cannot manufacture the will that comes free to a people fighting for their own ground. The conscripts came home broken or in zinc coffins the state tried to slip back to the villages without ceremony, and the war that the propaganda would not name as a war drained the treasury and corroded the army's faith in the cause it was spending boys on. The pattern runs that a declining great power loses its peripheral and asymmetric wars first, because capability is not the same as the will to keep paying, and a frontier armed by a rival and willing to die can hollow an empire from the edge inward. The Soviet Union had watched the United States learn this in Vietnam a decade before and had helped administer the lesson; now it took the same instruction in its turn. The last Soviet soldier crossed back over the bridge at the border in February 1989, the army intact and undefeated in the field and beaten all the same, and Afghanistan had demonstrated, to the country's own people and to its own leaders, that the Soviet Union could be defeated.

Into this came Mikhail Gorbachev, who in March 1985 became, at fifty-four, the first Soviet leader in a generation young enough to imagine that the system might be saved by being changed, and who was a true believer in a way his exhausted predecessors had ceased to be, which was exactly his danger. He moved to restructure the calcified economy and to open the closed public realm, and in doing so he made the fatal wager of every reforming autocrat, that a system built on enforced silence could survive being permitted to speak. It could not. The Soviet order had for seventy years depended on the criminalization of its critics, on the camp and the censor and the knock at the door, and when the penalty for telling the truth was lifted, what had been buried came out in a rush, the famines and the purges and the lies, the rotting infrastructure, the comparative poverty that decades of propaganda had concealed. The new candor did not cause the failures; it revealed them, and a system whose legitimacy rested on the impossibility of revelation could not absorb the shock of being seen. The reform meant to renew the empire instead handed its subjects permission to stop believing in it, and once they had stopped, nothing underneath remained to bind them.

What had bound the imperium together in Eastern Europe was never love and only sometimes ideology; it was the credible threat that Moscow would send the tanks, as it had to Budapest in 1956 and Prague in 1968. The guarantee was the garrison. And in 1988 and 1989 Gorbachev, who could no longer afford the garrison and had stopped believing in the threat, let it be known that the tanks would not come, that the satellite governments were on their own. The effect was

instantaneous and total. Poland's Solidarity, driven underground in 1981, won partly free elections in June 1989 and formed a government. Hungary opened its border with Austria and cut the first hole in the curtain, and through it streamed East Germans who grasped that the wall in Berlin had become a door. Through that autumn the regimes of Eastern Europe fell in succession, each emboldening the next, the whole edifice coming apart in weeks with a speed that stunned even the dissidents who had spent their lives imagining it. On the night of the ninth of November 1989 a confused East German spokesman misread a directive at a press conference and announced that the borders were open, effective immediately, and the people of Berlin did not wait for clarification. They came to the wall in their thousands, the guards with no orders and no garrison behind them stepped aside, and people climbed onto the concrete and danced on the thing that had divided the world. The wall had stood twenty-eight years and it fell in a single night, and its fall was the visible shape of everything the decade had been doing invisibly, the long stagnation, the dying old men, the bleeding war at the periphery, the economy that could not deliver, the lies that could no longer be told, all of it a slow erosion and then in one autumn a collapse.

The braid of beliefs that had swept Reagan to power contained, alongside its market eschatology, a sacred one, and how the two were braided is among the decade's most consequential and least examined facts. The same coalition delivered into American power a current of religious end-times conviction that the educated managers of the postwar order had assumed was extinct, a dispensationalist Protestantism that read the day's headlines as biblical prophecy come due, that took the establishment of Israel and its capture of Jerusalem as the literal countdown to the return of Christ, and that therefore made the defense of Israel a matter not of interest but of salvation. A book by Hal Lindsey decoding current events as the signs of the approaching end stood among the best-selling titles of the entire era; a movement organized millions of the faithful into a voting bloc; and the president himself mused aloud, more than once, about Armageddon and the chance that his was the generation that would see it. The strategists of both parties treated this as folklore, a mobilizing sentiment to be courted at the rally and ignored in the situation room, and they erred in the way the educated are characteristically wrong about belief, mistaking it for decoration because they did not feel it themselves. It was a material force. An end-times logic that organizes millions and bends a great power's foreign policy toward a holy land on grounds no balance of interests can model is not folklore; it is one of the strongest currents moving through the period, and the men who dismissed it merely guaranteed they would not see it working. Two visions of the end thus entered American power together, the secular conviction that the deregulated market was clearing the path to a frictionless prosperity, the same eschatological shape Hayek's disciples had given a respectable economic form, and the sacred faith that history was bending toward a final judgment in Jerusalem. The alliance between them, improbable and rarely examined, would outlast the decade by two generations and shape the wars and alignments the century's turn would

bring. The end-times imagination that the modern West had pronounced dead had simply changed congregations, and in one of them it wore the vestments of monetary science.

The two superpowers closed the decade as mirror images of a single condition, though neither could yet see it. The Soviet Union was visibly dying, its emptiness made manifest in rubble and dancing crowds, and the West watched and concluded that it had won, that the long contest between the planners and the markets had been settled and the verdict was finance. But the order that triumphed had won by hollowing its own industrial base, by exchanging the manufacture of things for claims piled on claims, by building a tower of debt and confidence whose tremor in 1987 it had chosen to read as a sign of strength. The American economy at the decade's hinge still showed live dynamism, an expanding output, a society that despite its gutted industrial base remained more open than its rival, a population that still rose by merit more often than by birth. But the boundary conditions were climbing, and one of them was rising faster than anywhere. Financialization, the flight of capital and talent from the production of things to the extraction of rent and the dealing of claims, was no longer latent; it had become the organizing principle, visible in the buyout and the bond and the migration of the ambitious to the trading floor. The surplus of credentialed strivers that the postwar expansion of the universities had produced, more aspirants than the old professions could seat, found its outlet in finance and was thereby absorbed rather than turned against the order, which is why the elite conflict that wrecks a late society did not detonate at home. The real strength of the power was being quietly hollowed even as its confidence peaked, fragility relocated from the visible factory to the invisible balance sheet. The

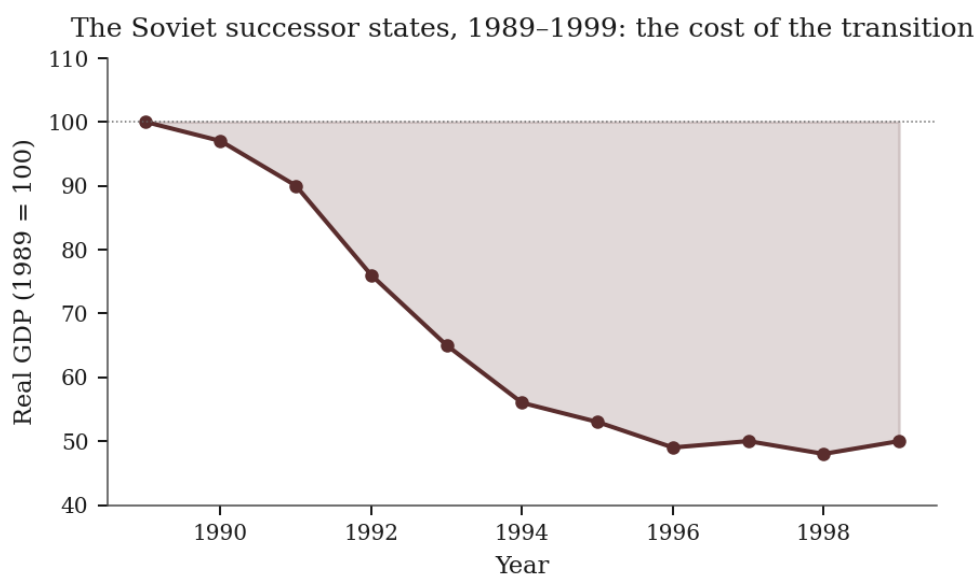
West had not abolished fragility; it had relocated it from the factory floor to the balance sheet, and from the visible into the invisible. In its hour of victory it had taken on debts and a faith in guarantees that the coming decades would be asked, at compounding interest, to honor.

What survived the decade was not the order any of these works were made inside, a settlement that within a few years would look permanent and within a few more would begin to crack. What survived were the forms a handful of minds put down under the pressure of the years. The break looped on two turntables, and then in the cheap gritty machine, became the most generative musical method of the next half century - an entire art built from the principle that the discarded fragment, replayed with intent, is the raw material of the new. Blade Runner's rain-soaked corporate city became the standing image of the future every later decade has measured itself against, and the dying replicant's grief for his lost memories has outlasted the studio that financed the film and the corporations the film was warning against. The placards of the dying - the pink triangle, the three words - outlasted the silence they were made to break and forced into the national field an image the restoration had needed to keep out of it. Basquiat's crowned figures now hang in the museums that once would not have let him in, a painter's claim of dignity for the

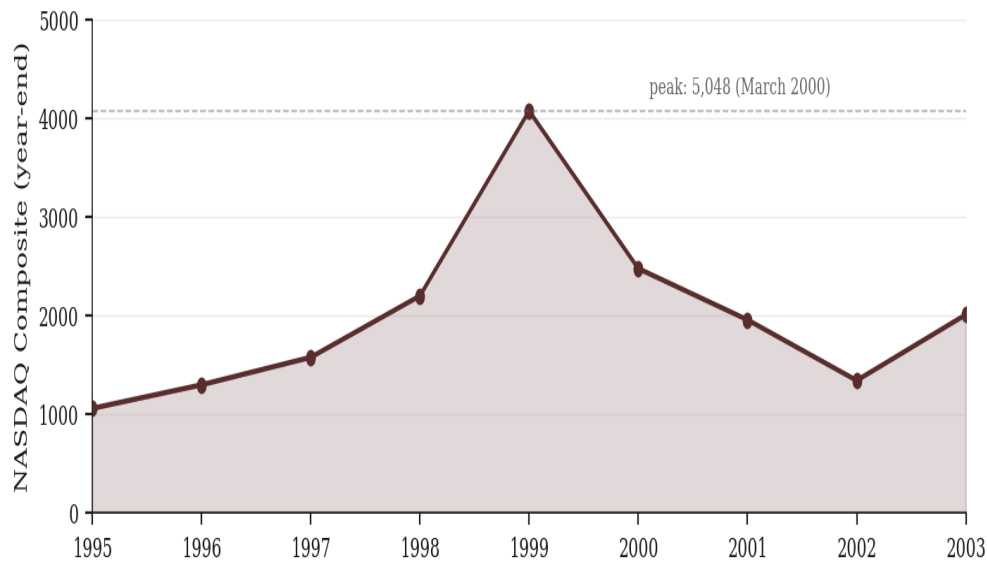
black name that survived both the market consuming him and the man it killed. Each form was made by one mind under the load of the same years; each endured when the order around it gave way, which is the one durable thing the decade produced and the one item it could not list on a balance sheet.

1990 – 1999

The nineteen-nineties opened with a state dying so quietly that the death looked like nothing at all. Late on Christmas night in 1991 the red flag came down over the Kremlin and the tricolor of Russia rose in its place, and the Soviet Union, which had matched the United States warhead for warhead and dominated half of Europe for four decades, ceased to exist by signature and exhaustion rather than by conquest. What had killed it was the accumulated weight of its own commitments, a garrison in every satellite and a defense burden that consumed a quarter of an economy that could build a rocket but could not stock a grocery, presided over by a frozen leadership that buried three general secretaries in three years before a younger man opened the windows and discovered that fresh air admitted into a sealed room does not revive the patient. The party had hardened along the path every long institution follows, from an open body hungry for talent to a bureaucracy that rewarded the loyal over the able, until a generation schooled at state expense for places at a table already full looked on the bureaucracy that blocked them and felt nothing worth dying for. The order had hollowed behind a façade of parity, and when the front went it gave way everywhere at once.



The Soviet successor states, 1989–1999: the real cost of the transition, the deepest peacetime contraction the modern era has registered. Source: World Bank, Maddison Project.



NASDAQ Composite, 1995–2003: the tower of capitalized expectation Infinite Jest watched go up. Source: NASDAQ historical close.

Set the Soviet exit beside Britain's. Britain at its deceptive zenith had been brittle and did not break, spending half a century converting an empire into a country. The Soviet order, weighed down by its own end-stage stack of frozen ladder, gerontocracy, and the monoculture of a single command rail, lost the state itself by signature and exhaustion on a Christmas night. What decided between them lay in everything the cold accounting leaves out: the give the institutions retained, the guarantees still half believed, the choices of particular men in specific rooms. The width of the difference between the two endings is also the width of what the shape of things leaves to be made.

The nation that watched this drew the lesson that flattered it. Washington concluded that it had pushed the wall over, that the Cold War had been won by a defense buildup and the moral superiority of free markets, by the West outspending and out-believing an evil empire into the grave. The story a victor tells himself is built to hide the thing he most needs not to see, and what this one hid was that the conditions of the corpse were not foreign to the survivor at all. Overreach and financial strain are not the property of one ideology; they are the standing fate of any power that guarantees too much for too long, and the United States in 1991 was already guaranteeing the security of half the planet on borrowed money while its own factories emptied. The victory was a warning written in a language the country was too elated to read. The corpse and the mourner had died of the same disease, and only one of them knew it yet.

A State Department analyst supplied the scripture. Francis Fukuyama announced the end of history, first in a 1989 essay and then in a 1992 book, and the phrase was not his own; it was Hegel's, transmitted through the Paris seminars where Alexandre Kojève had lectured in the 1930s

that the dialectic of history had a terminus, a final synthesis after which the great argument would be settled and only administration would remain. The German-idealism floor of the whole century surfaces here in its most consequential modern dress. Hegel had read the past as the labor of Geist working itself out through conflict, each ruling idea summoning the antithesis that undid it, the world-historical individual serving as the current's instrument and never its author; Kojève had told his listeners, among them a generation of French intellectuals who would build the postwar mind of Europe, that this labor was nearly complete, that the recognition every consciousness sought had been secured in principle by the liberal universal state and that what followed would be a long afternoon of management. Fukuyama took the shape and crowned the West with it. Liberal democracy and the market had triumphed not as the strongest competitors but as the final form, the destination toward which all peoples were now bound to travel. The argument about how human societies should be organized was over, and only the laggards remained to be brought into line.

History is neither the straight line Fukuyama drew toward an answer nor the closed wheel of Spengler turning on a fixed track. It is a system of colliding currents that gather and spend and gather again, taking direction without a terminus and shape without a fixed schedule. To declare the currents stilled in 1992 was to mistake the slack water at the turn of the tide for the end of the sea. And the conviction itself, the belief that one had reached the place where contest ends, is the oldest intoxication a successful power knows; it has preceded every great fall yet documented. History, which had just buried the Soviet gerontocrats for the identical sin, their conviction that their order would last forever, was being told it had concluded its business. It had not been consulted.

What the thesis could not absorb, an American novelist had set down a few years before it was written. Cormac McCarthy published *Blood Meridian* in 1985 to almost no readers, a book that follows a band of scalp hunters across the Texas-Mexico borderland of the 1850s as they murder first for bounty and then for nothing, presided over by a hairless giant called the Judge, a man of monstrous erudition who lectures on geology and law while he orchestrates the slaughter and declares that war is god, the truest form of divination, in which whatever survives was right to have survived. The novel does not refute him; it ends with him dancing, naked and enormous, in a frontier saloon, declaring that he will never die. What McCarthy had written, at the moment the country was preparing to tell itself the most pacific story it had ever believed about its own nature, was the violence concealed beneath the myth of inevitability. The end-of-history thesis is a frontier story; it imagines the market and the liberal order spreading across the earth the way the American imagination had always pictured settlement rolling west, as the natural advance of a higher form into empty or backward space, an expansion that calls itself peace because the violence that clears the ground has been classed after the fact as nature. The Judge is the spirit of exactly this order, the genius that calls its own conquest inevitable and therefore innocent. He collects specimens and

sketches the artifacts of the peoples his company exterminates, and after he has copied each thing into his ledger he destroys the original, because he means to be the sole author of what was, the one who decides what existed and what it meant. Nothing must be permitted to exist outside his ledger; whatever he cannot own he will not allow to have been. This is what the unipolar fantasy could not look at, that an order which experiences its own expansion as nature taking its course has granted itself permission for any violence, since whatever it does is by definition what was always going to happen. McCarthy did not write the book to comment on

Fukuyama, whom he had never read; he wrote it about the actual scalp economy of the 1850s borderland, a documented commerce in which the state of Chihuahua paid bounties by the head and the bounty hunters could not always be troubled to bring the heads of the people they had been hired to kill rather than whoever was nearest. The historical specificity gives the book its force. It records that the continental order whose triumph the 1990s celebrated had been built, at its actual frontier, on a market in human heads, and that the trade had described itself, then as later, as the action of a providence too large for any participant to question.

Harold Bloom, who spent a career arguing that the strong writer makes the new only by wrestling a dead precursor and forcing the reader to feel the struggle, read *Blood Meridian* as the authentic American apocalypse and called the Judge, short of *Moby-Dick* itself, the most monstrous apparition in all of American literature. The judgment names the agon exactly. McCarthy's quarrel is with Melville, and the Judge is his answer to the white whale, the same nineteenth-century intuition that the universe contains a force of annihilation indifferent to meaning, now lifted out of the sea and given a human shape, a voice, and a philosophy, so that the blankness Ahab could only chase becomes a man who lectures his victims on why their destruction was always just. Melville left the question open, the whale finally unreadable; McCarthy closes it, and the answer is more terrible than the silence, because the Judge does not withhold his meaning, he proclaims it, and the proclamation is that war is the highest form of divination and that whatever survives was right to have survived. Beneath the Melville is the older precursor, the Bible itself, which McCarthy out-writes in its own cadence. The book moves in the long unpunctuated rhythm of the King James Old Testament, the parataxis of Genesis and the prophets, and it turns that scripture against its source, narrating a creation with no covenant and a wilderness with no chosen people, an Old Testament from which the redeeming God has been removed and only the violence and the grandeur of the language remain. Bloom confessed that the carnage drove him off twice, that the Judge gave him nightmares and he abandoned the book at a hundred and forty pages before a third attempt finally took him through; the confession is itself a reading, evidence of his own claim that the canon survives not by the comfort a work gives but by the strangeness and the power to disturb that no reader can absorb at one pass. The 1990s, which would pay to mourn a frontier that never existed, could not have read this book, because the book

is the precise thing the decade's myth was built to keep out of frame, the founding violence singing in the voice of the scripture the founders brought west.

McCarthy followed *Blood Meridian* with the Border Trilogy, beginning with *All the Pretty Horses* in 1992, the year of Fukuyama's book, and these are gentler novels, elegiac where the earlier one is apocalyptic, but they deliver the same knowledge in quieter form. Their young cowboys ride south into a Mexico that the modern order is closing behind them, looking for a frontier that has already been priced and fenced, and the books are about what it costs to discover that the open country one was raised to inherit was a story the country told itself while the actual land passed into the hands of people who did not ride. *All the Pretty Horses* sold where *Blood Meridian* had not, won the National Book Award, and made McCarthy famous at last, which means the decade rewarded the elegy for a frontier it had foreclosed while ignoring the book that told it what the frontier had actually been. A culture will pay to mourn an innocence it never had, but it will not pay to be shown the case for why it never had one.

Then came the war that seemed to settle the question the novels were quietly refusing, and the way it was fought taught every watching power the wrong lesson. Saddam Hussein had emerged from eight years of war with Iran in 1988 victorious in name and ruined in fact, his treasury empty, his army the fourth largest on earth and his debts to the Gulf monarchies enormous. Kuwait, which had bankrolled him, now pumped above its quota and pushed the oil price down, and Saddam read the squeeze as a knife pressed to a creditor who could not pay. In the small hours of the second of August 1990 his Republican Guard divisions crossed the border, overran the emirate in a day, and announced its annexation as the nineteenth province of Iraq, putting Iraqi armor within a short drive of the Saudi oil fields that contained a fifth of the planet's proven reserves. The American response moved first to wall off Saudi Arabia, a buildup named Desert Shield that flowed half a million troops into the sand across the autumn while a coalition of thirty-five nations was assembled and the United Nations set a deadline. When the deadline passed in January, the assault opened from the air. For five weeks coalition aircraft flew tens of thousands of sorties, dismantling Iraq's air defenses, command networks, bridges, and power in the opening nights and then pounding the entrenched army in Kuwait, the cable feeds piping nose-cone footage of munitions threading down ventilation shafts into a living room the world had never been shown a war from before. The ground assault, when it finally came on the twenty-fourth of February, was almost an anticlimax to the bombing that preceded it. Rather than charge the fortified Iraqi line head-on, coalition commanders swung an armored mass far to the west through open desert the Iraqis had assumed impassable and cut in behind them, and the army that was supposed to make Kuwait a graveyard for invaders broke and ran. Conscripts emerged from bunkers to surrender in such numbers that the advancing units could barely process them; the retreat north out of Kuwait City jammed the road to Basra with vehicles and men, and coalition aircraft worked the column from

end to end until the road was a corridor of wrecked and blackened metal that the press named the Highway of Death. One hundred hours after it began the ground war was stopped. Fewer than three hundred Americans had died; Iraqi dead ran into the tens of thousands.

The causes lay in the monetary order beneath the war, and they matter more than the hundred hours of combat. The Gulf ran the oil on which the dollar's reign quietly rested. Since the understandings reached with the Saudis in the 1970s, the world's crude had been priced and paid for in dollars, which meant every nation on earth had to stockpile dollars simply to keep its engines running, and the surpluses the oil states earned were recycled into United States Treasury debt, lent back to the power that guaranteed the monarchies their thrones. This was the load-bearing arrangement beneath the whole edifice, the reason the most important commodity in the world was bought in the one currency the United States alone could print. A regional power seizing a neighbor's fields and massing on the Saudi border threatened that arrangement at its root, and the war was fought to defend it. The talk that Kuwait must be freed and the law of nations upheld was the surface; the dollar's grip on the price of oil was the substance, and the two were not in conflict because the order had long since learned to experience its own vital interests as principles. There was a geography to the substance, and it decided who anchored the floor under the currency. Nearly all the crude the Gulf sold left it through one strait at the mouth of the Persian Gulf, the Strait of

Hormuz, a channel narrow enough that the tankers moving a fifth of the world's oil ran in lanes only a few miles wide, every barrel passing within range of whoever commanded the water. Saddam's army on the Saudi border put a hostile power astride that approach, and an enemy astride Hormuz could close the valve through which the dollar order breathed, or worse, could price what flowed through it on terms the United States did not set. The Fifth Fleet had stood in those waters for exactly this reason since the British withdrew east of Suez, because the metal that once anchored the dollar had been replaced by the capacity to keep the lanes the oil moved through, and a navy that controls the strait controls the price, and a navy that controls the price controls the currency. This was the floor made physical, the reason the most important commodity in the world could be bought in the one money the United States alone printed: not a promise written down anywhere but a navy sitting on the chokepoint, and the war over Kuwait was that fleet defending the valve it existed to guard. The largest consequence was a permanent American garrison in the Gulf, bases on the Arabian peninsula that would remain for decades and would furnish, among other things, the stated grievance of the men who flew the planes into the towers ten years later.

What the country took from the war was the spectacle. The clean precision of the footage, broadcast in real time, became the defining image of a new kind of power, surgical and decisive, and the ghost of Vietnam was declared exorcised. The performance was real and the capability

behind it was real, which is what made it deceptive. The Gulf War was the unipolar order's demonstration war, staged as much for the cameras as for the ground, and what it demonstrated was a capability mistaken for a guarantee. Shown once, against a brittle opponent on open desert that offered no resistance and so taught nothing about it, the capability was read as proof that supremacy was settled and permanent. The ending offered a tell the celebrants did not read. The coalition halted at the Kuwaiti border, declined to march on Baghdad, left Saddam in his palace, and the refusal to finish what overwhelming force could so easily have finished was the first plain admission that the will did not match the means, that a nation able to break any army in a hundred hours would not bear the open-ended cost of occupying the ground it broke. Capability stood on display at full extension. Resolve, the harder and rarer thing, quietly declined to follow it the whole way. The distance between the two is the measure that decides which wars a great power wins and which it eventually loses, and no one watching the parades thought to take it.

The other war of the decade refuted the thesis even more directly, by arriving in the place it had declared the past was over. Yugoslavia was a state bound together by one man's authority and the Cold War's freezing of the questions beneath it, and when Tito was gone and the freeze lifted they returned at once. Slovenia and Croatia declared independence in 1991, and the Yugoslav army, by then an instrument of Serb power under Slobodan Milošević, went to war to preserve the federation and the Serb populations stranded inside the seceding republics. The fighting reached its worst in Bosnia, the most thoroughly mixed of the republics, where Serbs, Croats, and Bosniaks had lived door by door and now fell on one another along fault lines older than the nation-states that had frozen them. Sarajevo, which had hosted the Winter Olympics in 1984, spent nearly four years under siege, its citizens shelled from the surrounding hills and shot crossing intersections by snipers in the towers, a European capital reduced to a place where fetching water was a calculated risk to one's life. The word that returned with it was ethnic cleansing, the deliberate emptying of territory by terror, massacre, and expulsion, and the worst single instance came in July 1995 at Srebrenica, a town the United Nations had declared a protected safe area and garrisoned with a few hundred lightly armed Dutch soldiers. When the Bosnian Serb army under Ratko Mladić walked in, the garrison stood aside, and over a few days Mladić's units separated the men and boys from the women, marched them off in groups, and shot more than eight thousand of them into pits, the largest mass killing on European soil since the 1940s and the first that a court would name a genocide. The slaughter at Srebrenica was the wake-up the western capitals had refused for three years; that August NATO at last mounted a sustained air campaign against the Serb positions, the bombing combined with a Croat-Bosniak ground offensive to break the siege lines, and in November the three presidents were flown to an air base outside Dayton, Ohio, and confined there until they signed a peace that partitioned Bosnia along the very lines the killing had drawn.

This was not a footnote to the end of history. It was the refutation, delivered within a day's drive of Vienna. The conviction that blood and faith and ancient wrong are the true organizing matter of human life, and that the liberal order is only a thin crust laid over them, had not been abolished by the fall of communism. The Cold War had merely kept those energies in cold storage, and the vault was now open. That the world's sole superpower hesitated for years before acting, and acted in the end through the same air power that had looked omnipotent over Iraq, exposed how partial its supposed totality of dominion really was. The massacres went on within range of the alliance's airfields while the alliance debated, and the debate was never about capability but about whether the strongest power on earth had the stomach for a war it could not broadcast as clean. The intervention, when it came, was late and conducted from altitude, and it taught every watching adversary the lesson that would organize the next thirty years: the omnipotence shown over Baghdad had limits, and they were a matter of will and not of means, and will could be probed. A power that will fight only the wars it can win cheaply and quickly has told the world the price of resisting it, and everyone was listening. Kosovo at the decade's close, where NATO bombed Serbia for seventy-eight days in 1999 to halt the expulsion of Albanians and never once committed a soldier to the ground, only signed the lesson in larger letters.

That same year the alliance did the thing Moscow had been promised, in the loose assurances of the unification talks a decade before, would not be done: it took in Poland, Hungary, and the Czech Republic, pushing the western military line three hundred miles east toward the Russian frontier, the first reach of an expansion that would run on through the Baltic states in the years after. The two events of 1999 read together in Moscow, and they read as one lesson. The order that had hesitated for years over Bosnia, that fought only from altitude and only where the cameras showed it clean, was nonetheless advancing its perimeter into the ground a fallen rival considered its own, and it was doing so because it judged that a Russia broken and bankrupt could not answer. A power whose will had been shown to have limits was pressing into the space of one that had no means left to push back, and the men in the Kremlin who watched the bombs fall on a Slavic capital while the alliance enrolled their former glacis took from the decade not the end-of-history sermon the West was preaching but its opposite, a map of where the order would not fight and a measure of how far it would advance when unopposed. The asymmetric answer to that map, worked out over the thirty years that followed, was being drafted in these years by men reading the same two facts the celebrants of the unipolar moment never thought to set beside each other.

Beneath both wars, and under the triumphal mood, the American economy was changing in a way the triumphalists declined to read as weakness, because the change was making the people who ran the country rich. The country's center of gravity had been shifting away from things made and toward money moved. The Washington Consensus, the bundle of liberalization and privatization and deregulation that the Treasury and the International Monetary Fund pressed upon

the post-communist countries and the developing ones, was the export version of a domestic faith, that capital freed of friction would find its most productive use and lift all who admitted it. It was also the instrument by which Western finance pried open economies that had been closed to it, and the two functions were never in tension because the doctrine had been written by the people who stood to profit once those economies opened. At home the same faith showed as a financial sector that swelled against the productive one, a rising share of all profits captured by those who arranged transactions rather than those who built or grew or assembled. The doctrine had a deeper philosophical floor than its proponents advertised, and the floor had been laid by the same Hayek the prior chapter watched return from obscurity in the 1970s, in a book almost none of his political readers had opened. Friedrich Hayek published *The Sensory Order* in 1952 with the University of Chicago Press, a treatise on neuroscience he had drafted as a young man in Vienna in the 1920s before abandoning it for economics and had returned to in the late 1940s when he had taught himself enough of the postwar literature to finish what he had begun. It was the most ambitious philosophical work of his career and his least read, and it was the only one of his books for which he claimed personal originality; the political works, he said, only restated what better men had argued before him, but the model of the mind in *The Sensory Order* was his own. The argument was that the brain is a self-organizing classifier that updates its expectations through iterated feedback against environmental input, organized as a network of predictive associations rather than as a passive sensorium. The classifier does not register sensory primitives, the raw color and the raw sound; it registers patterns that have proved useful for action, and it adjusts those patterns when prediction fails. The system runs without a central agent, because no actor inside it could possess enough of the picture to coordinate the whole; the coordination is emergent, the product of iterated local error correction at a scale no participant can perceive. The model is homeomorphic to Hayek's account of the market in *The Use of Knowledge in Society*, published in the *American Economic Review* in September 1945, the essay that would become his most cited piece of economics and the canonical statement of the anti-planner case. The argument of the 1945 essay was that no central agent could possess the information a market disposes of, because that information was local, contextual, and dispersed across millions of producers and consumers whose situated knowledge no bureau could assemble at the speed the situations changed. The price, on Hayek's account, was the local signal of relative scarcity, the compressed message by which each producer learned what the rest of the system was telling him about the value of his work without ever needing to know who the rest of the system was. The market aggregated the information through iterated local correction; the planner could not. What *The Sensory Order* added in 1952, without anyone in the political reception of Hayek seeming to notice, was that the brain ran on exactly the same principle. The classifier in the cortex and the price system in the economy were two implementations of one architecture, distributed, predictive, corrigible only after the fact, and opaque to any actor inside them. The implication, which Hayek's political

readers ignored and which the book itself draws explicitly in its final chapter, is that no actor inside such a system can know what the system is doing while the system does it. To say that the market should decide is to say that the system is too distributed for any of us to understand, and the same statement applies to the mind that proposes the statement. Hayek had built, in 1952, the philosophical apparatus that dissolved the subject who would have made the argument. He did not announce the dissolution; he set it down as an observation and let the reader find it. Almost none of the readers did. The Sensory Order was treated as a curiosity by the economics profession that admired the political writings, ignored by the cognitive science of its day, which was committed to the symbol-processing model that Herbert Simon and Allen Newell were building in Pittsburgh and that would dominate the field for thirty years. Hayek's neuroscience disappeared into a small footnote tradition kept alive by a few specialists, and was rediscovered only after the field he had anticipated had been built independently by men who had never heard of him. The independent reinvention is the part the official intellectual history does not name. Karl Friston, a Cambridge-trained psychiatrist and neuroscientist at University College London, published from 2005 onward a sequence of papers that gradually became the most cited framework in computational neuroscience, the free-energy principle. Friston's argument, set down with the mathematics filled in that Hayek had been unable to supply, was that any persisting biological system maintains a generative model of its environment and acts to minimize the divergence between sensory input and the model's predictions. On Friston's account, a system persists by predicting; a system whose predictions fail dies. The brain is a prediction engine that updates its expectations against the world through iterated Bayesian inference, and the same formalism applies to the cell, the organism, and the social system, because each is a thing that persists by predicting the environment it sits inside. Friston had read Hayek by the time the late papers appeared, and the late papers acknowledge the precedent. The early papers do not, because Friston did not know about it; the rediscovery was independent. The Hayek-Friston isomorphism is the most consequential intellectual fact about the late twentieth century the official history does not name. The political reception of Hayek in the 1990s built a global policy regime on the market argument and ignored the cognitive argument. They were the same argument. The Washington Consensus, the post-Soviet privatization, the deregulation of finance and labor and capital flows, the post-Cold War orthodoxy that the question of how a society should be run had been settled in favor of the distributed mechanism over the central authority, all ran on Hayek's case that no planner could know what the market knew, and all ignored the case in *The Sensory Order* that the same statement applied to the planner's own brain. To say let the market decide is to say the system is too distributed for any of us to understand; Friston's framework gives the formal version of that claim and applies it to the brain. The post-1989 American consensus was built on a position that, taken to its end, dissolved the very subject capable of having a consensus. The economists pressing the doctrine on Moscow and Warsaw and Buenos Aires were saying, without quite

hearing themselves, that the question of how to organize human life had been answered by the recognition that human life is the kind of thing that cannot answer such a question. The triumph of the market was the triumph of an account of mind on which the triumph itself was not a thing any mind could intend or oversee. The Sensory Order sat unread on a shelf at Chicago through all of it, the book that had explained, four decades before the policy regime, why no one inside the regime would be able to see what it was doing while it did it.

The whole purpose of the new instruments that multiplied in this climate was to make danger invisible, and the reader who understands them sees the trap the decade was laying³ A derivative is a contract whose value is derived from something else, a price, a rate, a bond that may default, so that one can take a position on the fate of a thing without owning it. A bank sitting on a thousand mortgages, instead of waiting twenty years to collect, could bundle the loans into a single pool, sell shares of the pool's income to investors, and get its money back at once to lend again; this is securitization, and on the page it is pure magic, since it turns a frozen long loan into cash today. The pool could then be sliced into layers, the top layer promised first claim on the incoming payments and the bottom paid only after everyone above it was satisfied, so that the top could be stamped safe and sold to a pension fund while the dangerous bottom went to someone paid to take the risk. Layered finely enough, the theory ran, risk could be cut so thin and spread so wide that no single holder could ever take a blow large enough to matter. That was the promise, and it was a confidence trick performed on the people performing it: a danger spread is not a danger removed, and a peril sliced into a thousand pieces and sold to as many strangers is still the same hazard, now wired into a thousand balance sheets at once so that when it finally arrives it arrives everywhere together. The design would endure until the first real storm showed how little was underneath it. The decade's defining boom was not in steel or automobiles but in the shares of companies that often made nothing yet and earned less, the internet mania inflating toward its end into prices no revenue would ever justify. An economy had learned to generate wealth from the rearrangement of claims upon it, magnificent in fair weather and resting entirely on the willingness of the next buyer to pay more than the last. The dependence on confidence was being built into the foundation during the very years it looked strongest, and the men building it were paid most for the parts that would fail.

There was a second floor beneath the financial sector's swelling, older than the derivative and quieter than the trading desk, and it explains why so much of the world's capital flowed toward London and toward a scatter of small islands rather than toward any factory. When the British Empire receded after the Second World War, the political map showed a power in retreat, garrisons withdrawn, flags lowered, colonies released one after another into nominal independence. The financial map showed something else, a power that had merely changed the instrument of its rule from the soldier to the banker and the lawyer. In the late 1950s the City of

3. BIS over-the-counter derivatives statistics; the CFTC concept release of May 1998 and the joint Treasury–Federal Reserve–SEC response.

London discovered that it could trade dollars sitting outside the United States without falling under the Bank of England's regulation or the Federal Reserve's, and the eurodollar market was born, a pool of stateless money that answered to no national rulebook because it was deemed to sit nowhere in particular. The first such transfers moved through London in 1957, and within a decade the City had rebuilt itself as the booking centre for money that wished to be governed by no one. Around this hub the old empire reassembled as a web of secrecy jurisdictions, its inner ring the Crown Dependencies of Jersey, Guernsey, and the Isle of Man, its outer ring the Overseas Territories that London still controlled, the Cayman Islands, Bermuda, the British Virgin Islands, Gibraltar, the Turks and Caicos. The flags came down and the law stayed British, and the law was the point.

The mechanism is the part of the order that works hardest to remain unseen. A secrecy jurisdiction sells one product, which is the legal absence of itself. It writes statutes under which a company can be formed in an afternoon with no record of who owns it, taxed at nothing, audited by no one, its accounts shielded from the authorities of every country where its owner actually lives and earns. A man in New York or São Paulo or Lagos routes his wealth through a shell company registered in the Cayman Islands, and that entity owns another in the British Virgin Islands, and that one owns an account booked in London, and at no point in the chain does any single jurisdiction see enough of the picture to act, because each was designed to see only its own link. The wealth has not moved an inch in the physical sense; the dollars sit, as they always sat, in correspondent accounts in the great money-centre banks. What has moved is the legal location, the fiction of where the money is, and that pretense is the entire service. When the Bahamas took independence in 1973 the dirty money that had sheltered there fled to the nearby Caymans, which offered the same secrecy under a reassuring British-run system, and the Medellín cartel learned to wash its proceeds of cocaine through Cayman confidentiality with the same ease that a corporation washed the proceeds of a tax it preferred not to pay. The order did not distinguish between the two, because to the web there is no difference between criminal money and respectable capital once both have been rendered invisible; the secrecy is sold to whoever can pay, and the same statute that lets a hedge fund escape disclosure lets a kleptocrat escape his country's courts. This is what it meant for finance and law to rule where the army no longer did. The empire had found that a network of small dependent islands, each with a population smaller than a provincial town, could discipline the savings of the planet more thoroughly than any fleet, by offering the one thing the rich and the criminal both require above all others, which is for their wealth to exist in a place that cannot be looked into. The City sat at the centre of the web as a state within a sovereign, governed by its own ancient corporation, drawing the world's flight capital toward an empire that had not so much fallen as gone offshore, and the United States, which presided over the open monetary order, found the arrangement entirely congenial, since its own banks booked the dollars and its own elite

used the same islands.

The same plumbing that hid a kleptocrat's savings and a cartel's proceeds hid the third kind of money no order would ever post in its accounts, the black budgets and the slush funds and the payments that bind powerful men to one another and to the order they serve. A network designed to make wealth exist where it could not be looked into is the machinery an intelligence service needs to move money no parliament has voted and no court can trace, and the two uses sat in the same shell companies because they required the same thing, an account whose true owner had been dissolved into a chain no single jurisdiction could read. Into this circuit, in these years, walked Ghislaine Maxwell. She was the youngest daughter of Robert Maxwell, the press baron who had built a media empire on borrowed money and ties to Israeli intelligence and had gone over the side of his yacht into the Atlantic in November 1991, leaving his newspapers' pension funds looted and his finances a maze no auditor ever fully mapped. The father's death emptied the daughter's fortune and her name, and in the early 1990s she crossed to New York and attached herself to a financier named Jeffrey Epstein, becoming the social engine of a network whose nature the next decades would slowly expose. The inheritance she received was not money, which was gone, but method, the operative's grasp of a single fact, that the offshore web maps the private appetites of the powerful as faithfully as it maps their savings, and that a man who knows where the bodies and the accounts are buried wields a leverage no fortune can buy. The plumbing this decade laid down for capital that wished not to be seen was the same piping through which that other commerce would run, and the intelligence-finance interlock her father had embodied acquired, in his daughter, the face it would wear into the new century. The hidden circuit DeLillo's novel kept gesturing toward, the connection the surface was built to deny, had a literal address, and it was a registered office on a Caribbean island that listed ten thousand companies and not a single employee.

The dollar presided over all of it without a challenger, by a mechanism the whole shape of the decade follows from. With the Soviet ruble gone and the European single currency not yet born, the dollar was the unquestioned reserve of the world, the unit in which oil was priced and debt was denominated and the central banks of every trading nation kept their savings. A reserve currency is simply the money other countries stockpile instead of gold, the asset they pile up when they sell more to the world than they buy and want somewhere safe to park the surplus. After the gold window closed in 1971 the safe place was United States Treasury debt, paper that paid interest and could be sold in an instant. So when Japan or, later, China earned dollars by selling goods to Americans, those dollars did not come home as demand for American wares in return; they went into Treasury bonds, which is to say they were lent straight back to the United States government. The country bought the world's manufactures. The world bought the country's debt. The circuit closed on itself. This is the privilege a Frenchman had named *exorbitant* in the 1960s, and it is the

deepest of the unipolar facts, deeper than the carriers: the United States could consume more than it produced and borrow the difference in its own currency without limit, because it alone printed the money everyone else needed to stockpile, and it could never be forced to default on a debt it could always pay by issuing more of the very thing the creditor wanted. No other country had ever owed in money it manufactured itself.

The privilege felt like strength and functioned as one, and it also hollowed the thing it protected. A nation that pays for imports with its own printed claims has steadily less reason to make what it brings in, and the dollars that flow out to buy foreign goods flow back as demand for financial paper rather than for factories, so capital and talent migrate toward the desks that arrange the paper and away from the floors that build the goods. American manufacturing grew hollow through the decade as the factory moved to the coastal cities of a China opening to the world market, and this was the dollar order working exactly as designed, the reserve currency drawing in the planet's output and paying for it with claims on itself. Offshoring was not a misfortune that befell monetary dominance. It was its face.

Read whole, the order that the decade called globalization was a hierarchy of human labor, and it had a shape that the cheerful language of free trade and comparative advantage was built to obscure. At the bottom sat the things pulled from the ground, the ore and the oil and the crop, priced lowest of all and sold in dollars by countries that had little else to sell and no power to set the price. Above the raw material sat the work of assembly, the factory floor, the hands that turned the ore into a good, paid more than the mine but kept cheap by the simple fact that the poor of the world were many and the floors could always move to wherever they were cheapest. Above the floor sat knowledge, the design and the brand and the patent, the part of the product that no one could copy and that therefore captured most of what it earned, kept in the wealthy countries that owned the schools and the courts that protected it. And at the very top sat finance, which made nothing and grew nothing and assembled nothing, but which priced the dollars in which every level below was paid, arranged the credit that built the floors, and took its commission on the movement of all of it. Each rung paid the ones above it and extracted from those below. The arrangement was not a ladder anyone could climb at will, because the countries on top owned what kept them there, the reserve currency and the knowledge and the law, and they had every reason to keep the nations below selling cheap. A nation that dug ore and sold it for dollars then had to spend the proceeds buying back the finished good at the price the brand commanded, and the gap between what it received for the raw material and what it paid for the manufactured thing was the tribute the hierarchy collected, a tax that flowed always upward and always toward the currency at the summit. This was the deepest meaning of the reserve privilege, that it placed the United States at the apex of a global division of labor in which the periphery produced and the center priced, and globalization, sold as the promise that all boats would rise together, in fact enforced that order

across the whole earth, opened every economy to a hierarchy whose top floor printed the money that measured every floor beneath it.

That migration was the quietest and most consequential event of the decade, and it served interests on both ends of the circuit that the official story declined to name. After the tanks cleared Tiananmen Square in 1989, much of the West told itself the Chinese regime was a brittle anachronism awaiting its own collapse, and the comfort of that story concealed who actually grew rich once China opened. Having survived its crisis, the Communist Party made a wager the Soviets never had the nerve to make, to keep the political monopoly and surrender the economic one, opening to the world market while the lid stayed bolted; in 1992 Deng Xiaoping made his southern tour, blessed capitalism under one-party rule, and the coastal cities began their conversion into the workshop of the planet. The American faith that markets dissolve autocracies was not a naive miscalculation alone. It was the doctrine under which American capital got what it wanted, which was the cheapest disciplined labor on earth, while the political objection to dealing with the regime that had just turned its tanks and guns on its own students was answered in advance by the theory that trade itself would set the country free. The corporations that moved their plants and the banks that financed the move and the consumers who bought the cheaper goods all gained at once, and the cost was paid by the workers whose floors went silent and deferred onto a future nobody in the room would have to answer for. The capital and the technology and the demand that would build a rival flowed east, and by the decade's end China was negotiating entry into the World Trade Organization, admitted by a Washington that found it convenient to believe a wealthier China would become a freer and friendlier one. The frontier was capitalized by the center, the periphery enriched by the metropole's conviction that prosperity flows in only one political direction, a belief that happened to coincide with the quarter's earnings. The wager would not come due for a generation. It was placed in these years, with both hands, by people who would be retired before the bill arrived.

Don DeLillo built the decade's great novel out of exactly this intuition, that beneath the surface of separate events runs a single connected system, and that the system's deepest secret is its waste. He had grown up in the Bronx, the son of Italian immigrants from the Abruzzese village of Montagano, played stickball on Arthur Avenue, taken a degree at Fordham in communication arts, and worked five years at Ogilvy and Mather writing advertising copy before walking away in 1964 to make his living from fiction. He lived quietly with his wife Barbara Bennett in a small house in Bronxville, refused interviews almost entirely for thirty years, did his own typing on a manual Olympia, and answered correspondence on a postcard. *Underworld* appeared in October 1997, eight hundred and twenty-seven pages assembled around the history of a single baseball, and its prologue is one of the most precise things in American fiction about how the monetary and military orders hide inside the spectacles that distract from them. DeLillo had seen the front page

of the New York Times for the fourth of October 1951 in a public library, and noticed that two stories shared it: Bobby Thomson's pennant-winning home run for the Giants over the Dodgers at the Polo Grounds, the shot heard round the world, and the second Soviet atomic test, the bomb code-named Joe-2. He built the prologue around that coincidence, a packed stadium roaring at a baseball while, in the box seats, J. Edgar Hoover receives word of the bomb from a runner whispering in his ear, and the crowd's ecstasy and the state's dread occupy the same afternoon and the same page without either knowing the other is there. The whole novel is then constructed as a search backward in time, narrated mostly in reverse, following the baseball through the hands that owned it down toward the moment it was hit, while the figure at the book's center is a waste-management executive whose business is the disposal of what the consumer order produces and refuses to see. DeLillo's formal wager is that connection is the truth the system most needs to deny: that the bomb and the ballgame, the weapon and the entertainment, the object consumed and the object buried, are one circuit, and that the dream of an order without consequence, an economy that produces only wealth and never refuse, is the lie that the actual refuse keeps refuting from the landfills and the test sites where it has been hidden. The book reads the unipolar moment as a vast operation to keep the connections invisible, the costs externalized, the garbage out of frame, and it finds in that program the same disavowal McCarthy located in the Judge's ledger, the order's refusal to let exist anything it would rather not have authored.

The screen the decade actually lived inside was the television, and the medium itself was changing under the same pressure that moved everything else. For forty years the set in the corner had been the nation's common hearth, three networks broadcasting a single shared evening to a country that watched it together, the most centralized instrument of collective fantasy ever built. The 1990s broke the hearth into fragments, and the works that registered the fracture earliest were the ones that took the family sitcom, the most reassuring form the medium had, and turned it inside out. The Simpsons, which became a half-hour series at the end of 1989 and ran straight through the decade, was a cartoon about a nuclear family in a town called Springfield, and the animated form was the disguise that let it say what no live family comedy could. The father was a fat, lazy, incompetent worker at a nuclear plant owned by a cackling billionaire; the institutions of the town, the church and the school and the police and the local news, were each revealed as a racket run by someone protecting himself; and the show's affection for its family was real and survived all of it, which is what made the satire land. The earlier television family had been an advertisement for the order, the smiling proof that the consumer society delivered the happiness it promised. The Simpsons kept the form of that advertisement and filled it with the disappointment underneath, a working father going nowhere, a system rigged by the man who owned the plant, and an audience that recognized its own life in the joke and laughed because the alternative was to admit it. What the cartoon let through was that the promised abundance had not arrived for most of the people

watching, that the hearth had been selling them a picture of a life they did not have, and that the only honest way left to show the American family on television was to draw it.

Where *The Simpsons* mocked the family, the networks were losing the audience that had sat still for it, and the channel that gained it sold something the broadcasters could not. Cable, freed from the advertiser's demand that nothing offend and the regulator's rule that nothing transgress, had begun by the late 1990s to make the kind of television the broadcast order forbade, and the change announced itself in two programs that arrived a year apart. *Sex and the City* premiered on the sixth of June 1998, four women in New York who talked about their appetites and their disappointments in the candid voice the consumer order used in its advertising but had never permitted its heroines, treating sex as a commodity to be sampled and reviewed, dating as a market, the single woman in the city as a figure of acquisition rather than of shame. The show was an advertisement and knew it, the apartments and the shoes and the labels as much its subject as the love affairs, and its candor about desire was inseparable from its honesty about money, the two appetites finally indistinguishable in a city where both were spoken in the same shameless idiom. Then on the tenth of January 1999 the same channel aired the program that opened the form for everything that followed. *The Sopranos* was a drama about a New Jersey mob boss who goes to a psychiatrist because he is having panic attacks, and the analysis is the whole of it, the criminal patriarch lying on the couch complaining that the old certainties are gone, that the men of his father's generation had something he does not, that he came in at the end and the best is over. The series let the boss's complaint stand in for the nation's own, that the most American figure the decade could produce was a man who had inherited an empire of violence at the moment its myths had stopped convincing him, who ran the racket and despised it and could not imagine living any other way, who looked at his children and his appetites and his swelling fortune and felt only that he had arrived too late for whatever had made it worth having. Prestige television was born on a psychiatrist's couch, with the order's chief enforcer confessing that the thing he protected no longer believed in itself, which is the same confession every major work of the decade was making in its own form.

The decade's economy reached its strangest expression not in a novel but in a tank of formaldehyde. In 1991 the collector Charles Saatchi, who had built a fortune in advertising and a parallel one in contemporary art, offered to fund whatever a young British artist wished to make, and Damien Hirst used the money to buy a tiger shark caught off the Queensland coast and to suspend it in a steel-and-glass vitrine of preservative, titling the result *The Physical Impossibility of Death in the Mind of Someone Living*. The shark cost six thousand pounds; the whole work around fifty thousand to make; Saatchi later sold it, after the animal had begun to rot and been replaced, for a sum reported in the millions. The numbers are not a footnote to the work. They are the work. Hirst and the Young British Artists whom Saatchi promoted made objects whose

primary content was their existence as financial assets, and the shark states this with a clarity no manifesto could match. It is an image of death that cannot itself die because it has been converted into capital; the decaying animal at its center is the reminder that the value floats entirely free of the perishable thing, that what is bought and sold is not the shark but the claim, the title, the position. The Warhol intuition of the 1960s, that the modern image had become a financial instrument valuable in proportion to its circulation rather than its substance, completed itself here in three dimensions. Where Warhol had silkscreened the dollar and the soup can and let the multiple float free of the hand, Hirst removed even the image and presented the asset as such, the artwork that is nothing but its price, suspended like the dollar itself in a medium that arrests decay without arresting the underlying rot. What the vitrine made visible was that an order of pure financial circulation has the shape of preservation without life, a value that persists because it has been cut off from the substance that gave it meaning, and that this was now true of the art market and the asset market and the reserve currency alike.

Against this total conversion of every surface into a saleable position, the decade produced its refusals, and the loudest came from a logging town in Washington. Kurt Cobain had grown up in Aberdeen, the son of a service-station mechanic and a cocktail waitress who divorced when he was nine, a child handed between relatives across the next decade, sleeping under a bridge over the Wishkah River for stretches of his late teens and writing songs in a notebook he kept in his backpack. Nirvana, the trio he formed with the bassist Krist Novoselic in 1987 and finished with the drummer Dave Grohl by 1990, recorded *Nevermind* in May and June of 1991 at Sound City in Van Nuys for sixty-five thousand dollars and released it on the twenty-fourth of September. By January 1992 the album knocked Michael Jackson's *Dangerous* off the top of the Billboard chart, a transfer of the highest commercial register from the perfected studio product of the postwar industry to a guitar trio that had recorded its hit in three takes through a fuzz pedal. The records were deliberately ugly where the decade's pop was polished, abrasive and unfinished, a refusal of the gloss that the consumer order demanded, and the rejection was sincere; the songs are about disgust, self-loathing, the unbearable closeness of the very commercial machine that was lifting them up the charts. The shape of *Smells Like Teen Spirit* alternates a quiet verse with a screamed chorus in a pattern Cobain openly told an interviewer he had stolen from the Pixies' loud-quiet model, and the words are deliberately unparsable, withholding the meaning the listener is trained to consume. The refusal was total commodification's own product, manufactured and marketed and sold back to the audience as authenticity, which is the shape rebellion takes inside a system that has learned to package its own negation. There was no outside to step to. A man who wanted above all not to be a product became, very quickly, one of the most successful products of his moment, and the gap between what he sought and what he had become was one he could not close. He had been a heroin addict since the late 1980s, used the drug to dull a chronic stomach pain his

doctors never diagnosed, and married Courtney Love in February 1992 in Hawaii in pajamas. On the fifth of April 1994, in a small room above the garage of his Lake Washington Boulevard house in Seattle, he put a Remington Model 11 twenty-gauge shotgun under his chin and fired. He was twenty-seven. The electrician who found him three days later said the body had a cigar box of heroin beside it and a note ending "It's better to burn out than to fade away." The death by his own hand is not the meaning of the music, but it stands as the period's most literal statement that the order had grown so total that even the wish to escape it had a price tag and a marketing department.

One man had tried to locate the outside, and what he mailed back from it told the decade what the exit had become. Theodore Kaczynski entered Harvard at sixteen, and between 1959 and 1962 he served as a subject in the experiments of the psychologist Henry Murray: some two hundred hours in which undergraduates wrote out their deepest beliefs and then submitted to mock cross-examinations built to be, in his own words, "vehement, sweeping, and personally abusive." Murray had spent the war assessing agents for the OSS. The writer Alston Chase, who reconstructed the episode, set the study inside the Cold War's culture of covert psychological research, the same operation a previous chapter watched the Church Committee drag into daylight, and concluded the experiments helped form the man, a judgment that remains his and not the documented case. What is documented: Kaczynski took a Berkeley professorship in mathematics, resigned it, withdrew to a plank cabin in Montana without electricity or water, and from 1978 to 1995 mailed or planted sixteen bombs that killed three men and maimed twenty-three others. They were murders, chosen for symbolism and executed by post: a computer-store owner, a public-relations executive, a timber lobbyist. In April 1995 he offered a bargain, publication of the argument in return for an end to the killing, and that September the Washington Post, at the urging of the Attorney General and the FBI and with the Times sharing the cost, printed all thirty-five thousand words of *Industrial Society and Its Future* as a special supplement. The gambit worked as police work; his brother recognized the prose. What the manifesto said was not new; that technological society narrows the human to fit its functions had been argued for decades in respectable registers, by Ellul, by Mumford, in books the universities assigned. The same telling, arriving as terror, could only be received as the symptom of the teller; the bombs did not force the argument into the culture, they disqualified it, and the man who had renounced every instrument of the system but dynamite proved its rule on himself: there was no exit that did not pass back through the machine, and the hermit's last act was a media event distributed by the institutions he was bombing⁴

The decade had a philosophical name for the surface DFW would shortly attack at length, and it had come from Paris. The French sociologist Jean Baudrillard had spent the 1970s arguing that the modern image was no longer a representation of anything, that it had detached from the thing it

4. Washington Post, September 19, 1995; Alston Chase, *Harvard and the Unabomber* (2003); Federal Bureau of Investigation case figures.

once recorded and now circulated as a copy of a copy of an absent original, and that a culture that had reached that stage was operating inside what he called simulation. His *Simulacra and Simulation* appeared in French in 1981, in English in 1994, and was delivered into the wider American conversation when the Wachowskis built a copy of the book into the opening of *The Matrix* in 1999, the hero hollowing it out as a hiding place for the disks that proved the world he stood in was a code. The American literary theorist Fredric Jameson had reached the same diagnosis by a different route, arguing in *Postmodernism, or, the Cultural Logic of Late Capitalism*, published in 1991, that the loss of historical depth and the rise of pastiche were not accidents of style but the cultural symptoms of an economy that had passed from manufacture into pure circulation. The two together gave the decade a vocabulary for what it could already feel and not yet name: that the image had escaped its referent, the surface had become the deepest layer the order would acknowledge, and to ask whether a thing was real was to be answered with a smile. The popular culture of the late 1990s, the irony of the sitcom, the disclaimer winked into every commercial, the Letterman-era television that mocked its own enterprise while running it, took the simulation thesis as common sense before any reader had finished the book. The novel that finally tried to break that mood from inside was *Infinite Jest*.

David Foster Wallace wrote the decade's anatomy of that condition in a novel so long and so strangely built that its form is its argument. He had been raised in Champaign, Illinois, by a philosophy professor at the state university and a grammar-school English teacher, played junior tennis at a nationally ranked level into his teens, taken a philosophy degree at Amherst with a thesis on free will, and entered the writing program at the University of Arizona at twenty-two already on lithium for the depression that had hospitalized him at Harvard's graduate program in philosophy a year earlier. He wrote *Infinite Jest* across three years in a sweltering rented house in Bloomington, Illinois, where he taught composition at Illinois State; he had locked himself off Pemoline and into a steady regimen of the antidepressant Nardil, an MAOI inhibitor that forbade him most cheeses, all aged meats, and the social drinking of any alcohol, and he wrote with the doors closed against his dogs and a copy of his thesaurus open on the floor. Little, Brown published the book on the first of February 1996, more than a thousand pages with three hundred and eighty-eight endnotes, some of them running for pages and some sprouting footnotes of their own, so that to read the book is to be sent constantly to the back, made to mark one's place in the main text with a finger while consulting a footnote-system that does not stay in its place. The book turns on a film so perfectly entertaining that anyone who watches it loses all desire for anything else and will watch it until death, neglecting food and water, locked in a loop of pleasure that consumes the self that the enjoyment was supposed to serve. The form enacts the condition it describes; the endnotes are a designed compulsion, a device that fragments attention and demands the constant small movements of a mind that cannot rest in one place. Wallace built a machine to

be read by, and against, the kind of attention the late-consumer order was producing, a faculty that could no longer follow a long line and had to be managed with a system of interruptions. The novel's deepest claim, the one its form makes that its plot only states, is that entertainment had become the thing that consumes the self rather than what the self enjoys, that the late stage of a consumer economy is not abundance but addiction, the engineered desire of the Bernays century turned back on the consumer so completely that the desire no longer points at any object beyond its own repetition. In June 2007 his doctors at the Mayo Clinic took him off Nardil under the theory that the side effects were no longer tolerable; the depression returned and would not lift through the next year on any of the substitutes they tried, including a course of electroconvulsive therapy that destroyed parts of his memory. On the twelfth of September 2008, three days before Lehman, in the garage of his house in Claremont, California, he wrote a note for his wife Karen Green, arranged a manuscript of the unfinished novel he had been writing for ten years on the desk in his study, walked out to the patio, and hanged himself. He was forty-six. The lethal film and the abused substances and the recovery meetings the book moves among are all one phenomenon, the same compulsion in different wrappers, and the wrapper is the only thing the order knows how to make.

The same dissolution of the line between the private and the saleable, which the art kept circling, broke into the open in the one event that consumed the decade's last two years. In January 1998 a gossip website reported that the president of the United States had conducted a sexual relationship with a twenty-two-year-old White House intern named Monica Lewinsky, and within days the story had moved from the internet to the front pages and would not leave them for a year. The affair itself was ordinary; what made it the defining episode of the decade was the machinery that formed around it. A special prosecutor appointed to investigate a failed land deal had wandered, over four years and tens of millions of dollars, into the president's sex life, and he produced at last a document so explicit in its physical detail that the Congress voted to publish it in full and the newspapers printed it and the report was posted on the new public network where anyone could read what had until that moment been the most private thing two people can do. The president denied it on camera, the famous line that he had not had relations with that woman, and was caught by a dress and forced to admit before a grand jury that the denial had been a lie, and the House impeached him for the lie while the country, which disapproved of the conduct and disapproved more of the inquisition, kept his approval ratings high and the Senate acquitted him in early 1999. What the show made visible was that the wall between the public and the private, what every citizen had assumed protected some interior life from the market and the state, had become permeable in both directions, that an interior could now be subpoenaed and published and turned into the largest entertainment in the country, and that the audience would consume it with the same appetite it brought to any other product while telling itself it was scandalized. The most intimate

human act, performed by the most powerful man on earth, had been converted into content, distributed for free on the network that would soon distribute everything, and the engineered desire that had once been pointed at soup and automobiles had found a purer object in the exposure of a private life. The body and what it does in secret, the last thing the market had not yet reached, was being annexed, and the annexation arrived dressed as moral concern and left as pure circulation.

Todd Solondz filmed the same disavowal in the register of the suburb. *Happiness*, which premiered at Cannes in 1998 and which the studio that financed it found so disturbing that the parent company forced it out the door to a smaller distributor, follows three sisters and the people around them through the manicured calm of suburban New Jersey, and the entire force of the film lies in the distance between the surface and what the surface is built to disavow. The lighting is flat and bright, the homes are clean, the music is gentle, the manner is the soft therapeutic patience of a culture that has learned to speak entirely in the language of wellness and self-acceptance, and underneath this surface the film places the things the surface exists precisely to deny: a father who is a predator, a loneliness so total it expresses itself as obscene phone calls, a contentment indistinguishable from anesthesia. The film's refusal to break tone is the formal decision that delivers its meaning. It will not let the score swell to signal horror, it will not let the camera flinch, it maintains the affect of a daytime advertisement over material that would justify any amount of alarm, and the effect is to expose the suburban surface as itself a defense, a managed pleasantness whose smoothness is the measure of how much it is keeping down. The title states the suppressed fact outright. The order promised happiness and defined it as the absence of disturbance. It manufactured the surface, and could maintain it only by refusing to look at what it cost and what it concealed, which is the operation the unipolar decade was performing on itself at the scale of the nation.

The decade closed with Kubrick, and the close completes a sequence that began in the 1960s. Stanley Kubrick had spent the middle of the century making films about systems that exceed their masters, the deterrence machine of *Dr. Strangelove* that renders its operators irrelevant to their own destruction, the perfected machine of *2001* that no longer needs the species that built it, and he had owned since the 1960s the rights to a 1926 Viennese novella by Arthur Schnitzler, *Traumnovelle*, a dream-story he considered a perfect text for a film about desire. He made it at last as *Eyes Wide Shut*, finished in 1999 and released that summer, and it transposes the Vienna of the novella to the New York of the unipolar decade, following a wealthy doctor through a single night into a masked ritual staged by an elite at a country mansion, an orgy whose participants are anonymous behind masks and whose menace is entirely a matter of money and access. The film moves with the slow dream-logic Kubrick had perfected, the long tracking shots, the symmetrical compositions, the rooms lit like stage sets in which the actors seem to be performing rather than living. What the masked ritual makes plain is the order's working fantasy that desire and money

are at the deepest level the same operation, that the elite of the order has access to a hidden circuit where appetite is satisfied without consequence behind masks that guarantee no one will be called to account, and that the ordinary man who stumbles into it is permitted to see only because he can be expelled and warned. The film never explains itself, never confirms what the doctor saw, and never resolves whether the menace was real or staged; the refusal is what the picture has to say, because the order it depicts works precisely by never being confirmable, by remaining a thing half-seen and denied, a ritual whose existence the participants will refuse and the witness can never prove. The film's own fate sealed the argument more completely than any ending he could have shot. Kubrick delivered his final cut, screened it once for the studio and his two stars, and was dead within the week, a heart attack in his sleep at seventy, before anyone outside that room had seen the picture and months before the public would. He never saw it released, and what the public saw was not what he left: to secure a commercial rating in the United States the studio digitally inserted robed figures across the foreground of the orgy, blocking the one sequence on which the film's menace turned, an alteration made to the work of a man no longer alive to refuse it. The director who had spent forty years wresting every frame from the studios lost the decisive frames the moment he could no longer defend them.

That a film about an elite which conducts its real business behind masks, and warns the man who stumbles in that he has been seen and had better forget it, should reach the public only after its maker's sudden death and with its central scene quietly overpainted by the corporation that owned it, is the kind of coincidence the picture itself trains a viewer to distrust and never lets him prove. The records say a heart gave out in the night, and there is no reason to doubt them; the resonance needs no foul play, only the facts, that the witness was gone before the verdict and the film altered after. Kubrick had begun his great sequence with a war room and ended it with a masked ball, and the two rooms are the same room, the place where the system's true operators conduct the business that the official surface exists to keep invisible, the war that runs without a human in the loop and the desire that circulates without a name attached. It was the last thing he made, and it reads the decade's hidden connectedness, the same circuit DeLillo and McCarthy had traced, as a dream from which the dreamer is not permitted to wake with proof.

Read at its apparent zenith near the decade's middle, the American order shows live dynamism, an expanding economy and an open society and a population still capable of vast feats, the single hour in the century when one power commanded the field without a peer. But the pressures that end orders are climbing beneath the surface. Financialization is moving from a tendency toward a dominant fact, capital and rent returns beating real production, talent flowing to the arrangement of claims rather than to the manufacture of things. The monoculture reading is the dangerous one, the load-bearing diversity of the productive economy thinned to a lone rail of finance and a single reserve currency on which everything now depends, the arrangement that

looks strongest at the moment its diversity is gone. And elite overproduction is doing to American society what the apparatus had done to the Soviet one, a class of the credentialed and ambitious swelling larger than the seats that can absorb it, a surplus of finance hopefuls and management aspirants and law graduates all trained to expect a place near the top, papered over for now by a rising market that promises the ladder still goes up. This is a deceptive zenith: a power at its apparent maximum whose load-bearing diversity is already gone and whose collapse is therefore latent, awaiting a trigger. The colder read finds the rot beneath the peak. What it cannot find is what the art saw, the loss of the credibility on which a unipolar order finally rests, the violence the myth of inevitability had classed as nature and could no longer keep out of frame, the addiction the abundance had become, the connectedness the surface was built to hide. The reading runs at the grain of decades. It is blind to the disavowal itself, the operation by which an order keeps its own costs out of view, and that refusal is what every major work of the decade was built to expose. Where the artwork sees what the reading cannot, the artwork is doing the work.

What survived was not the order these works were made inside. The unipolar moment was already ending as it declared itself permanent. The rival fed in the coastal cities would rise; the leverage built into the foundation would find its storm; and the clear sky the desert had flattered the country into forgetting would, on a morning some years off, teach it what the Judge had said about the order that calls its conquest nature. The works outlasted all of it. *Blood Meridian* remains the most unflinching thing in American letters about the violence beneath the frontier myth, and its refusal to let the Judge be refuted reads more clearly now that the order whose innocence it denied has been named. *Underworld* sets the whole hidden circuit into one form, the bomb, the ballgame, and the buried waste as one system the surface was built to keep apart. *Tony Soprano* lies on the couch confessing that the thing he protects no longer believes in itself. Hirst's shark floats in its vitrine, preserved and rotting, the most honest object the financialized decade produced. The records that wanted not to be products still get played by people who feel the same impossibility of an outside. *Infinite Jest* captures the reader's attention in order to show what has been done to it; *Happiness* keeps its terrible flat tone over the suburb it exposes; *Eyes Wide Shut* ends without the proof its witness needs. Each was made by one mind under the load of an order that called its own conquest inevitable, and each kept its shape after the order forgot to. The works refused the end-of-history premise and paid for the refusal: an order convinced the argument is over is announcing not its permanence but the hour of its maximum exposure.

2000 – 2009

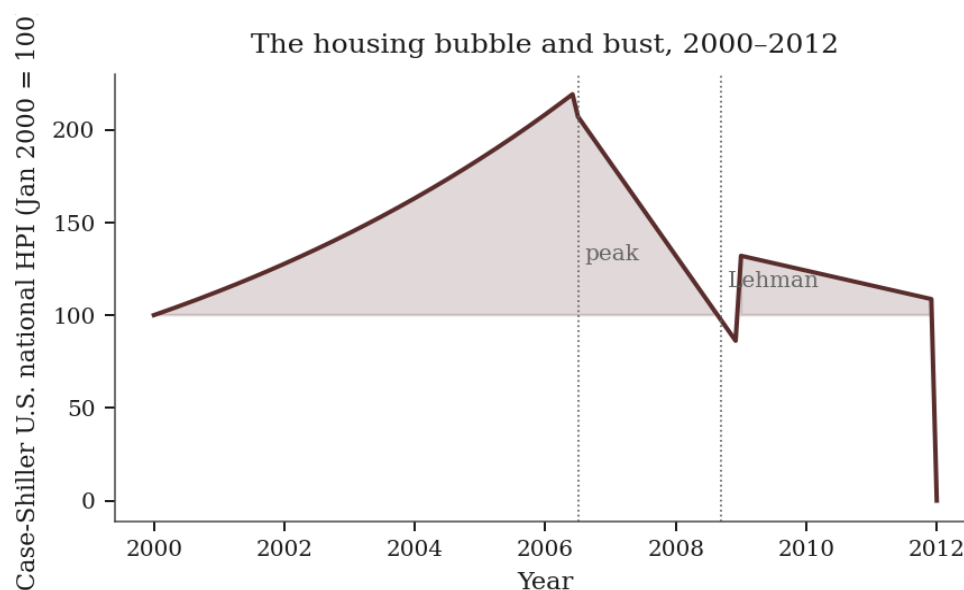
A man with a cattle gun walks into a roadside store somewhere on the high plains of Texas, and the proprietor, who has done nothing and knows nothing, finds that his life has been put on a coin. Anton Chigurh asks the old man to call it, heads or tails, and the old man does not understand the question, because in the world he has lived inside the whole of his working life a transaction was just that, and a stranger who bought gas and crackers did not also dispense or withhold death according to a rule the stranger kept in his own head. Cormac McCarthy, born Charles in Providence in 1933, raised in Knoxville and educated at the University of Tennessee until he dropped out twice, had served four years in the Air Force in Alaska reading paperbacks on the dispatch nightshift, had published his first novel in 1965 to almost no audience and lived in Texas in single-room cabins and converted barns for forty years on small grants while writing every day on an Olive Lettera 32 typewriter he had bought for fifty dollars in a Knoxville pawn shop in 1963 and would later sell at Christie's for two hundred and fifty-four thousand dollars. He published *No Country for Old Men* in July 2005, and the Coen brothers, Joel and Ethan, who had been making pictures together as a single inseparable directorial unit out of Minneapolis since the early 1980s, filmed it across the summer of 2006 on a thirty-million-dollar budget at locations in West Texas and New Mexico. The picture won four Academy Awards including Best Picture; the Coens received the directing prize jointly and walked the trophy back to their seats sharing the weight between them. The thing that gives the story its grip is not the chase or the money but the incomprehension of the men who are supposed to keep order. Sheriff Ed Tom Bell narrates the book in a voice of bewildered decency, an old lawman who measures the present against a recalled past in which crimes had motives a sheriff could follow and killers wanted things a man could understand. Chigurh wants nothing the old order can name. He kills by a private code that looks from outside like pure chance and feels from inside like the strictest necessity, and the horror Bell registers is not that violence has increased but that it has stopped obeying the grammar the law was built to read. McCarthy set the action in 1980, at the dawn of the drug economy that would run beneath the border for the next thirty years, but he wrote the book in the early 2000s, and what he caught was the temper of his own moment, the sensation, spreading through the institutions of a still-dominant power, that the rules had quietly changed and that the people charged with enforcing them were the last to find out. Harold Bloom, who judged McCarthy to be among the few living American novelists worth the highest comparison, read *Blood Meridian* as an agon with Melville and the *Book of Revelation*; in *No Country* the apocalyptic register has gone domestic and procedural, the cosmic judge of the earlier book shrunk to a man with a captive-bolt pistol and a coin, the end of the world rebranded as a customer-service interaction. McCarthy died at his home in Santa Fe in June 2023 at eighty-nine; the last two novels of his life, *The Passenger* and *Stella*

Maris, appeared together that same year, the work of a man writing into the very last of his time.

That sensation had a financial shape, a bargain so large and strange that the economists who named it reached back across half a century for the only comparison that fit. In September 2003 three economists at Deutsche Bank, Michael Dooley, David Folkerts-Landau, and Peter Garber, published an essay arguing that a new international monetary order had assembled itself without anyone designing it, and they called it the revived Bretton Woods system, a phrase the press shortened to Bretton Woods II. The original Bretton Woods had pegged the world's currencies to a gold-backed dollar and had broken in 1971 when the metal would no longer cover the promise. What replaced it after a long interregnum was an unspoken arrangement between the United States and the rising economies of East Asia, China above all. China would peg its currency cheap against the dollar so that its goods stayed inexpensive on American shelves; it would run vast trade surpluses selling those wares to American consumers; and it would take the dollars it earned and lend them straight back to the United States by buying Treasury bonds, which pressed American interest rates down and let Americans keep buying. The arrangement was no treaty, and it needed none. It was a convergence of two national interests that happened to lock, each side doing openly what its own development required, and the lock survived because both sides profited from it for as long as no one looked too hard at what it implied. A poorer country financed a richer one's consumption and accepted, in payment, the paper claims of the very power its own rise was destined to challenge. The workshop financed the customer who bought from the workshop, the supplier lent the buyer the cash to buy back what the supplier sold, and the closed loop dressed itself as commerce.

What this produced inside the United States was a flood of credit looking for somewhere to settle, and where it settled was the American house. Treasury yields pressed down by foreign buying pushed every other yield down with them, and money that would not earn enough in safe bonds went hunting for return in the one asset that seemed both safe and rising, residential property. The mechanism by which a house in a subdivision outside Phoenix became the destination for a textile worker's savings in Guangdong ran through a chain of instruments most of the people in it did not fully understand. A mortgage was written, often to a borrower whose ability to repay was never verified, on terms that started low and reset to unpayable after a year or two. The mortgage was sold up the chain, pooled with thousands of others into a security, and the package was sliced into tranches rated by agencies the issuers themselves paid, the top slices blessed as triple-A, as safe as the Treasury bonds the Chinese were buying. The whole edifice rested on a single assumption fed into the models that priced it, that house prices in aggregate across the country did not fall, a premise true for every year the machines had been shown and false for the reason that the credit pouring in had made it temporarily true. Belief in the rising house had become the footing on which the global recycling of dollars balanced. Belief, as the

century kept proving, persists until it does not. The men who wrote the mortgages were paid by the loan and bore none of the loss; the banks that pooled them earned a fee on every pool they assembled; the agencies were paid by the issuers to call the paper safe; and every link in the chain was compensated for moving the risk along rather than for the risk turning out to be sound. A machine built so that its operators are rewarded for volume and shielded from consequence does not produce bad loans by accident. It produces them by design, because the architecture selects for them.



Case-Shiller U.S. national HPI, 2000–2012: the climb, the peak, and the fall. Source: S&P Dow Jones Indices.

The decade's truest portraits of the order came not from the cinema but from the television set, which in these years stopped being the century's domestic hearth and became its sharpest instrument of self-examination. The medium that had spent fifty years selling the nuclear family its own reassuring reflection, the laugh track and the resolved half-hour and the sponsor's gentle hand, gave way to a long-form serial drama that took the hour, denied the resolution, and turned the camera on the institutions the consumer order had hollowed out. The vehicle was the subscription channel, the premium-cable model that freed the form from the advertiser whose comfort the network sitcom had been built to protect, and the result was a run of work that read the period more completely than any feature film of the same years. In Baltimore a former crime reporter named David Simon built the fullest of them. *The Wire* premiered on HBO in June 2002 and ran five seasons through March 2008, and its method was the inversion of everything the medium had trained its audience to expect. There was no protagonist; the camera moved from the corner where teenagers sold heroin to the squad room where detectives tapped phones to the docks where longshoremen watched their work vanish to the mayor's office to the newsroom to the classroom,

and at every rung the same discovery waited, that the institution the people served had stopped serving the purpose it was built for and now existed mainly to perpetuate itself. Simon and his collaborator Ed Burns, who had been a homicide detective and then a schoolteacher, refused the consolation of villains. The drug dealer and the cop and the union boss and the politician were all caught inside machines that produced statistics instead of outcomes, arrest counts that did not reduce crime, test scores that did not educate, clearance rates and circulation figures and quarterly numbers manufactured to satisfy the managers above, the form of the work fully detached from its function. The show's formal achievement was its refusal to resolve. Plotlines died without payoff; good men were broken and bad men promoted; a season ended and the corner was worked by a new set of children identical to the old, because the trade was not a problem the institutions wanted solved but a condition they had organized themselves around. What *The Wire* saw, and saw whole, was the failing American city as the inside of the same order whose outside was the gleaming Treasury auction, the place where the productive economy had been hollowed and the people who remained were administered by bodies that measured their own activity and called it success. It was the bureaucratic phase rendered as drama, the manager-to-producer ratio climbing until the paperwork was the only product left.

The other prestige dramas of the decade read the same order from its other rooms. Aaron Sorkin's *The West Wing*, which ran on network television from 1999 through 2006, supplied the consoling counter-fantasy the period reached for whenever the actual government frightened it, a White House of brilliant, decent, sleepless public servants who argued in long unbroken takes through corridors filmed at a walking pace, the camera trailing them as they solved the republic with talk. The wish was in the cinematography: an unbroken walk-and-talk staging competence and continuous motion at the moment the real state was assembling the secret prison and fixing the intelligence around the policy. The fantasy was so frank that audiences took it as medicine, the government they wished they had against the one they watched on the news. Where Sorkin offered the dream, Matthew Weiner's *Mad Men*, which began in July 2007 on the basic-cable channel AMC and so brought the long form down from the premium tier, turned the camera back on the origin of the whole machinery, the Madison Avenue advertising agency at the start of the 1960s, and read the manufacture of desire that Bernays had invented as the founding act of the consumer century. Its protagonist moved the cigarette and the automobile and the airline by selling a feeling, and the show understood with complete clarity what it was depicting, that the advertisement is applied ideology, the settled picture of who a person should want to be, and that the man who makes it is a hollow surface himself, an invented identity selling invented identities. Its formal signature was the slow, lacquered surface that mirrored the period it portrayed and the era that watched it, a society at the height of an attention economy looking back with longing and dread at the moment that economy was engineered. And in Albuquerque, in the last years of the decade,

Vince Gilligan's *Breaking Bad*, which premiered on AMC in January 2008, the very month the financial system began to seize, told the story of a chemistry teacher who, told his labor would not cover his own dying, turned his expertise into the manufacture of a drug, and so dramatized the logic of the recycling order at the level of a single ruined household, the producer of real value who discovers that the legitimate economy has no place for him and that the only market that will reward his competence is the criminal one. The cancer diagnosis with no affordable cure, the chemistry that builds nothing the lawful world will pay for, the slow conversion of a maker into a dealer, were the financialized economy written small, the man who makes things abandoned by the order that rewards only the man who moves the claims. Each of these worked in the long serial form the subscription model had made possible, and each used that form to do what the half-hour network comedy never could, to follow an institution or a man across years until the rot showed, the medium that had been the order's mirror turned at last into its X-ray.

While the city decayed on screen, the same power was prosecuting two wars abroad, and the wars and the housing ran on the same borrowed circuit. The sky over Manhattan was a cloudless September blue when the first airliner banked into the north tower, and for a few minutes the country watched what it took to be an accident. Then the second plane came, and the accident became a design. Nineteen men with box cutters had turned four civilian airliners into guided weapons and aimed them at the symbols of American power, and roughly three thousand people died, and the most heavily armed state in the history of the world had been struck at home for a few hundred thousand dollars and the lives of the attackers.¹ The arithmetic of that morning is the one law of Jiang Xueqin's that survives close historical scrutiny: a declining hegemon loses its asymmetric wars first, because against an adversary with almost no capability and a near-total surplus of resolve, mass stops translating into victory. The men in the planes belonged to al-Qaeda, and al-Qaeda's leadership spoke in the register of the end of days, a restored caliphate and a final reckoning between belief and unbelief. Their stated theory of victory was patient and economic. Provoke the superpower into a war it cannot win, and let it spend itself into exhaustion as the Soviets had done in the same Afghan mountains. Bin Laden named the precedent himself. The answer from Washington advanced an eschatology of its own, a universalism with deep American roots and a newly urgent edge, the struggle framed within days as freedom against fear, good against evil, the horizon nothing less than the end of tyranny on the earth. Two redemptive certainties, each convinced it rode the grain of history, set about confirming the other side's prophecy.

The question that matters of that morning is the one every great rupture poses, which is who it served, and the answer is not the men in the planes. They got their war and their exhaustion of the enemy, but the catastrophe was metabolized inside the American state with a speed that no grieving bureaucracy improvises from nothing. Within weeks the surveillance powers that

1. The 9/11 Commission Report (Washington: GPO, 2004); National Commission on Terrorist Attacks Upon the United States, public hearings transcripts, 2003–2004.

intelligence agencies had wanted for a decade and could not pry out of a peacetime Congress were law, drafted with a fluency that betrayed how long they had sat ready in the drawer. Within months the appropriations that defense contractors and the architects of an Iraq invasion had pressed for through the 1990s, and been refused, flowed without serious resistance. A standing system of detention, rendition, and warrantless watching assembled itself over a population that, the September before, would have rejected it outright. No hand reached inside the towers, and none was needed, because the catastrophe did not have to be authored to be used. No cabal scripted the morning and no single intelligence ran the board. Against the consoling account that treats the strike as a bolt from a clear sky after which a stunned government merely reacted stands the older truth that catastrophe is the oldest instrument of rule, that every security state in history has grown on the ground of a fear it did not have to manufacture to harvest, and that the men who had long wanted the powers the attack delivered moved to take them while the rubble still smoked. The shock was real and the dead were real. The use made of them was a choice, and it ran along channels prepared in advance, by people who understood what a frightened public would grant that a calm one never would. Bernays had named the mechanism in the 1920s: the mass mind is most pliable in the grip of an emotion it cannot reason with, and fear is the most reliable of these. What the propagandist had done with the cigarette and the breakfast cereal, the state now did with the color-coded terror alert and the permanent war footing, the engineering of consent turned to the manufacture of a population that would ask for its own surveillance. The Frenchman Michel Foucault, who had spent the 1970s lecturing at the Collège de France on the procedures by which modern societies produce their idea of the normal and so dispose of the abnormal, would have read the apparatus the United States built after September with no surprise. His argument, set down in *Discipline and Punish* in 1975 and developed in the lectures published as *Security, Territory, Population*, was that power in a modern state does not sit above the citizen and apply force downward; it circulates through the procedures that decide who gets counted, watched, classified, treated, deported, detained. The clinic, the prison, the school, the census produce the categories before they apply them. The post-September security regime fit that account exactly. The no-fly list, the watchlist, the terrorist designation, the security clearance, the border classification, the citizenship and visa categories: each was a procedure by which the state decided what a person was, and the decision authorized whatever followed. Foucault had died in 1984 of complications from AIDS; the procedures he had described kept proliferating without him, and in the decade after the towers fell they took on a scale and density he had only theorized. The contractor that built the plumbing under much of that proliferation was founded in 2003 in Palo Alto by Peter Thiel, Alex Karp, Stephen Cohen, Joe Lonsdale, and Nathan Gettings, and it took its name from the seeing-stones in Tolkien's *Lord of the Rings*, the palantíri through which the wizards and the dark lord watched events at a distance and through which Saruman was corrupted by Sauron's gaze. The choice was characteristic of the founders' register. Thiel had cofounded PayPal in 1998

with Elon Musk, Max Levchin, and others, sold it to eBay in July 2002 for one and a half billion dollars, and emerged with about fifty-five million dollars and a thesis about the failures of postwar liberalism that he had begun to set down in essays for the publications of the conservative legal movement. The founding capital for Palantir came from Thiel's own funds, channelled through his investment vehicle Clarium Capital, and from In-Q-Tel, the venture-capital arm the Central Intelligence Agency had established in 1999 to take equity positions in private technology firms whose products the agency wished to acquire without going through the procurement system. In-Q-Tel was a Delaware non-profit funded by congressional appropriation; its first managing director was Gilman Louie, a former video-game executive; the structure existed because the conventional defense-contracting apparatus could not absorb the speed at which the commercial software industry was moving, and the agency needed a vehicle that could write checks at venture-capital tempo. Palantir was, by some accounting, the firm In-Q-Tel made. The product was government data integration, the consolidation of an agency's disparate databases into a single search surface across which an analyst could trace a query from a phone record to a financial transaction to a travel manifest to a face captured at a border, the kind of correlation that would once have required a room full of analysts and a week and that the Palantir interface returned in seconds. The published business model was a software subscription; the actual business model was the forward-deployed engineer, a Palantir employee seconded into the client agency's facility for the life of the contract, who sat at a desk inside the building and rewrote the software in real time against the agency's actual cases, and who handed Palantir's engineers in California persistent access to the client's systems while the client thought it was being served by a subscription product. The forward-deployed engineer was the person on whom the contract depended; the software was the artifact through which the engineer's work was billed. The client agencies discovered, often only after years inside the relationship, that the integration the engineer had built was not portable, that the data flows the engineer had configured ran through Palantir's tools at every step, and that to remove Palantir was to dismantle the operational capacity the agency had come to depend on. What the firm sold was that dependence, and the subscription line item only described it. Alex Karp's path to the company is the part of the story that gives it its philosophical signature. Karp had taken an undergraduate degree at Haverford and a law degree at Stanford in the same cohort as Thiel; the two had argued politics across the seminar table and remained connected after Karp left the United States for Germany, partly to escape an American academy he found intellectually closed and partly to study with Jürgen Habermas in Frankfurt. He completed a doctoral dissertation in 2002 at the Goethe University on Talcott Parsons and American communications theory, a study of the Harvard sociologist whose mid-century synthesis of structural functionalism had been the dominant frame in American sociology before the field abandoned it in the late 1960s. The thesis sat at the intersection of social systems theory and the postwar communications models that ran from Norbert Wiener through Claude Shannon into the

social sciences. Karp returned to California in 2003 and Thiel asked him to run Palantir, which had been founded by Thiel and the other technical cofounders and needed a chief executive who could speak the dialect of the federal client. Karp spoke that dialect. His public statements through the 2010s would defend the firm as the indispensable instrument of Western democratic security against Chinese and Iranian competitors and would frame the work as a philosophical project, the construction of an apparatus that allowed the open society to defend itself against authoritarian rivals without becoming authoritarian in turn, an argument lifted in vocabulary if not in conclusion from his Habermas reading. The first major contract was with the Central Intelligence Agency, signed in 2005. By the end of the decade the firm had federal contracts at the Department of Defense, the Federal Bureau of Investigation, Immigration and Customs Enforcement, the Drug Enforcement Administration, the Department of Homeland Security, the National Security Agency, and dozens of state and municipal police departments, and its software sat under the watch-list and target-selection procedures the post-September apparatus had multiplied. The firm did not advertise. It rarely issued press releases. Its growth was measured in the proliferation of forward-deployed engineers across the buildings of the security state, each one a node through which the company's persistent access into the client's systems was maintained. The deeper structural argument that the prior chapters have built across the century resolves here. Palantir is the institutional form of what Norbert Wiener had been forced to stop naming in 1952. The biographical artifact the previous chapter pointed at, the personal expurgation copy of *The Human Use of Human Beings* with pages crossed out under the pressure of an FBI file the Bureau had opened on Wiener after Walter Reuther invited him to keynote the 1952 UAW convention, was the moment at which the science of feedback control was severed from the public discussion of the human applications its founder had insisted were inseparable from the mathematics. Wiener had argued that cybernetics could not be confined to engineering systems, that the same feedback formalism applied to social and political order and that to develop the formalism without naming its political application was to abandon the field to whoever would apply it without scruple. The 1954 edition of his book, the one that went into general circulation, omitted the chapter on the human applications. The federal apparatus that pressured the FBI to silence him pressured the publisher who issued the expurgated text. The integration of cybernetic surveillance and policing into a private company, sold to the government as a software contract, with the actual operation conducted by engineers seconded into the client agency, is the engineering-of-humans cybernetics Wiener could not publish in his expurgated 1954 edition, sold to the government that pressured the FBI to silence him. The 1952 file the Bureau opened on Wiener and the 2003 founding of Palantir are bookends on a fifty-year process by which the science of feedback control was removed from public discussion, broken into commercial fragments, and reassembled inside the security state in a form that no public could see whole, because no single contract revealed the architecture and no single agency saw more than its own slice. The seeing-stones the company took its name from, in

Tolkien's account, were instruments by which a watcher could see at a distance and through which a watcher could be seen in turn, and a watcher who used them without understanding what watched back was corrupted by what watched back. The reference is not subtle. The founders chose it. The company that grew from the choice runs the data layer under the apparatus the previous chapter saw the Church Committee briefly drag into daylight in 1975 and that had reconstituted itself, by 2003, as a private firm with a Tolkien name and a CIA seed investment, doing in commercial form what the public agencies had once been forbidden to do directly, and selling the product back to the agencies whose budget could now be increased to pay for the work no statute permitted them to do in-house. Wiener's expurgated chapter sits at one end of the process. Karp's Frankfurt dissertation sits at the other. Between them, fifty years of arrangement.

The first campaign, in Afghanistan in late 2001, looked at first like vindication. A small number of American operatives married to local militias, with an avalanche of precision airpower behind them, toppled the Taliban in weeks; Kabul fell in November. But the regime was the easy part, and bin Laden walked out the back of the Tora Bora cordon that December while the front was manned by proxies, and what remained was not a victory to bank but a country to govern, and the Taliban dispersed rather than surrender, went home, waited, and began the patient work of an insurgency with nowhere it needed to be and all the time on earth. Before that lesson could register, Washington opened the larger front, and there the engineered character of the decade is most exposed. The invasion of Iraq did not follow from the September attacks, because Saddam Hussein had no operational hand in them, and that he had none was known to the people who nonetheless told the public otherwise. The case for the war was not discovered and then acted on; it was decided on and then assembled, the conclusion fixed and the evidence fitted to it afterward. The British record of a senior spy chief's July 2002 briefing put it without euphemism: the intelligence and the facts were being fixed around the policy. The weapons of mass destruction that justified the urgency did not exist, the uranium from Niger was a forgery, the mobile labs were the fantasy of a single discredited informant, and the tie to al-Qaeda was an invention, and the men who built the public case had been told as much by their own analysts and chose the louder version. It was the manufacture of a war, the persuasion machinery applied to the largest decision a state can make, a population walked into an invasion by the deliberate construction of a threat its own government knew to be hollow. The conventional war in March 2003 was a rout staged for the camera, the campaign branded shock and awe, the night sky over Baghdad lit for the television audience, the regime's army melting rather than fighting, the city taken in three weeks, and on the first of May the President beneath a banner that read Mission Accomplished. The image was the war's high-water mark and, in hindsight, its hinge, because the war that mattered had not yet begun.

Beneath the manufactured threat sat a real one the official case never named, and it was monetary. In the autumn of 2000 Saddam Hussein had switched the currency in which Iraq sold its oil, abandoning the dollar for the euro, demanding payment for crude under the United Nations oil-for-food program in the European money and converting the program's reserve account to match. The decision cost Iraq nothing it could not afford and, for a year or two as the euro rose, even earned it a premium; what it threatened was larger than Iraq. The whole post-1971 order rested on a single quiet discipline, that the world's oil be priced and paid in dollars, because a currency that every nation must stockpile to buy energy is one the world must keep buying, and the surplus of the producers flows back into American debt by the same compulsion. A major exporter pricing its crude in another money was a crack in that discipline, an invitation read clearly in the capitals that watched it, and others were watching. Iran spoke of a euro-denominated oil exchange; the question of what currency the Gulf would settle in was, for the first time since the desert bargain of the 1970s, open. Two things must be set side by side. The official account gives the war no such motive, and no document orders an invasion to defend the dollar; that is the limit of what the documentary trail alone establishes, and it is the honest place to start. On the inference, which is the reading and not the documents themselves, the *cui-bono* shape supplies what the manufactured case omits: a state which authored a threat it knew to be hollow had, underneath, a true stake the public was never shown, and within months of the occupation Iraq's oil sales were switched back to the dollar without ceremony or debate, the one change made permanent while the weapons were never found. The dollar-defense motive is the reading; the currency switch and the missing weapons are the documented fact. The reader is owed both, in those terms. The doctrine that a power could create its own reality met, in the currency of oil, the one reality it most needed to keep.

That the war arrived already shaped as spectacle was not a stylistic accident of the cable era; it was the visible surface of an arrangement that had been maturing for half a century, the deep alignment of the war machine and the screen. The military and the entertainment industry feed each other, and the channel through which they do it is concrete and documented. The Pentagon has run an entertainment liaison office since the late 1940s, and the bargain it offers is simple. A studio that wants to put real aircraft carriers, fighter jets, submarines, and uniformed extras on screen, the hardware no budget can rent anywhere else, hands its script to the Defense Department for review, and the Pentagon lends the hardware only if it approves the dramatic message. Where the script displeases, it is changed, or the cooperation is withdrawn and the production left to fake its battles at ruinous cost. Phil Strub, who ran the film liaison unit from 1989 to 2018, was for three decades the man across the table, and the films that took the bargain are the ones that flew. *Top Gun* in 1986 had its script worked over by the Navy, the heroine rewritten out of uniform because the service the picture flattered forbade the relationship the plot required, and the Navy, by David

Robb's account in Operation Hollywood, set recruiting booths in theater lobbies as the applications to fly multiplied. The studio got the jets at a fraction of their true cost; the service got a two-hour advertisement that audiences paid to watch. The Central Intelligence Agency opened its own entertainment liaison in 1996, Chase Brandon installed inside the public-affairs office to do for the clandestine half of the state what Strub did for the uniformed half. The point is not that a committee dictated the culture. The point is that the screen and the war machine had grown into a single circuit, the one supplying glamour and consent, the other providing spectacle and matériel, each making the other more legible and more loved, so that by the time a real invasion needed selling the techniques were long perfected and the reflexes already in the hand.

Shock and awe was that circuit closing on a live war. The strategy had a published military rationale, the rapid dominance that paralyzes an enemy's will before his capacity is touched, but its operative audience was never only the Iraqi command. It was the camera, and behind the lens the population at home whose consent the engineered case for war had purchased and now had to keep. The night bombardment of Baghdad was lit and timed for broadcast the way a premiere is scheduled, the correspondents embedded with the advancing columns by a Pentagon that had learned from the unmanaged footage of an earlier war what an uncured frame could cost, the whole campaign produced as much as fought. Bernays's lesson, that the mass mind is most pliable in the grip of an emotion it cannot reason with, had taught the century to manufacture desire through the advertisement; the same instruction schooled the state in producing resolve through the produced image of overwhelming force, victory put on the screen before it was secured so that the screen might help secure it. The managed rescue of Private Jessica Lynch a few days into the war, the night-vision raid filmed by the military's own cameras and released within hours as the first triumphant recovery of a captured American since the last great war, was the same technique at the scale of a single soldier, a story shaped for the screen and handed to a press summoned to receive it. Lynch herself later told Congress that the heroics attributed to her were invented, that she had fired no shot and remembered no rescue worth the film. The frame outran the fact in the war's favor now, where the Saigon photograph of an earlier decade had outrun it the other way, and the difference measured how much the machinery that produces images and the machinery that wages war had learned to act as one. No planning cabinet sat behind it. A studio chased the only props that make a war film pay; a service pursued the recruits a flattering picture delivers; a war cabinet hunted the consent a produced spectacle sustains, and the interests locked of their own accord until the screen and the war became difficult to tell apart.

There was a philosophy in the way that war was sold, the century's oldest idea wearing the most modern face. An aide to the President described the governing creed to a reporter in words almost too apt to credit, dismissing the press as the reality-based community, people who studied a discernible world and analyzed it, and explaining that this was no longer how the world worked:

the United States now created its own reality, the aide said, and while others studied that reality, it would act again and create others. The journalist Ron Suskind reported the remark in October 2004 and never named the speaker, so the documents do not say whose mouth the words came from. The creed they describe needs no such confirmation, because the war was conducted exactly as if it were the operating creed. The German idealists had established that the mind does not reach the thing in itself but only the version its own categories construct, that the great collective objects exist as shared fictions real in the way that counts. Stripped of its humility and handed to a state, that insight becomes a license, the conviction that a power great enough need not discover the facts because it can author them, the same will-to-power logic the totalitarian movements had voiced in their own key, now speaking English and certain of its own benevolence. The buried bomb on the road outside Fallujah was reality declining to be authored. The disbanding of the Iraqi army by occupation decree turned hundreds of thousands of trained and humiliated men into the recruiting pool of an insurgency that did not need to defeat the strongest army on earth, only to refuse to lose, to make the cost of every further month climb without ceiling. The roadside device, a few dollars of explosive and a phone, destroyed a vehicle worth millions and the lives inside it, and no surge of capability closed the ratio, because whoever adjusts for pennies against an adversary who must adapt for billions owns the advantage no matter who commands the field. The torture exposed at Abu Ghraib in the spring of 2004 handed the insurgency the recruiting story bin Laden had promised. By 2006 Iraq had slid into sectarian civil war. The troop surge of 2007, paired with payments to former Sunni fighters to turn against al-Qaeda, bought a real and bloody reduction in how many died, but what it purchased was a rented quiet and not a resolution, and the war could be managed and never won. The contractors billed by the hour for a war without a finish line; the men who had wanted the invasion got their invasion and their decade of appropriations; and the cost fell on the dead of two countries and on a treasury that borrowed every dollar of it from the foreign creditors the recycling order supplied, so that the war against the periphery's most desperate adversary was financed by the periphery that would inherit the century.

The conversion of authenticity into asset took its most visible form in the global art market, which in these years stopped resembling a market for objects and became an exchange for claims, the financialization of culture running in step with the conversion of every flow into a tradable claim of everything else. Cheap credit and new fortunes, in the Gulf, in Russia, in the rising East, in the hedge-fund towers of New York and London, needed somewhere to settle, and contemporary art became one of the chosen destinations, a class of asset whose value floated entirely on collective agreement, like the mortgage tranche and the dollar itself. Prices for living artists detached from anything that could be called worth and tracked instead the velocity of money looking for a home. Into this market walked an anonymous English street artist who had built his reputation by painting illegally on walls that did not belong to him, and the contradiction

he embodied was so exact that it became, almost against his intent, the period's clearest self-portrait. Banksy mounted his first major American show, *Barely Legal*, in a warehouse in Los Angeles in September 2006, and the spectacle of it, a live elephant painted to match the wallpaper, stencils that bit the hand of wealth and empire, drew the Hollywood collectors who promptly bid his work into the six figures. Street art exists to deface the property of the order and to refuse the gallery, the price tag, the signature; it is by definition the art that cannot be owned. The market answered by owning it, by prying the stencils off the walls and selling them, by paying more for the gesture of rebellion because the defiance itself commanded the premium, the system absorbing its own critique as a premium feature. Banksy's later prank, a canvas that shredded itself the instant the auctioneer's hammer fell, only completed the loop, since the half-destroyed work sold for more than the whole. He did not need to understand the recycling of dollars into Treasuries or the mechanics of the credit machine to register what those forces had done to the meaning of an object. He made, and then watched the market confirm, the discovery that under late the price-tag laid over every operation there is no position outside the asset, that even an artist who bites the hand becomes something the hand will pay handsomely to be bitten by, because the bite is content and content is value and value is whatever enough money agrees to chase.

What a frightened mass culture reached for in these same years is its own evidence, and the reach, across three winters, was for a story made in the shadow of an earlier war about the smallest people refusing the largest power. Between December 2001 and December 2003 the New Zealand director Peter Jackson, who had grown up in the seaside suburb of Pukerua Bay making schlock horror pictures in his parents' yard on a wind-up Bolex 16mm camera and had directed *Heavenly Creatures* and the puppet splatter feature *Meet the Feebles* before New Line Cinema gave him, on the strength of an animated test reel, two hundred and eighty-one million dollars to film the trilogy back-to-back across fifteen months at a hundred and fifty separate locations across both islands of New Zealand, with two thousand seven hundred and thirty crew members and forty-eight thousand foam-rubber prosthetic feet for the hobbits, released his three films of J.R.R. Tolkien's *The Lord of the Rings*, the first arriving ten weeks after the towers fell, and the trilogy became the defining popular epic of the decade of fear that followed. The third film, *The Return of the King*, was nominated for eleven Academy Awards at the ceremony of the twenty-ninth of February 2004 and won every one of them, a clean sweep that tied the all-time high and that no fantasy had ever come near, a mass audience and an industry agreeing at once that the story spoke to the moment with a force that demanded the highest honor the screen could give. What the films did with their source, and where they placed their emphasis, reads the decade as exactly as the bond charts do. Jackson and his screenwriters foregrounded the figure Tolkien himself had set at the moral center, the gardener Samwise Gamgee, the servant who hauls the ring-bearer up the last mountain when the bearer can no longer walk himself, and they gave him, at the close of the second film, a speech

written for the camera that the novel had only implied, a halt on the road in which Sam tells his exhausted master that the great stories are the ones full of darkness and danger, that even this shadow is only a passing thing, that there is some good in the world worth fighting for. The speech is intercut with the relief of besieged Helm's Deep, and it functions as the trilogy's emotional argument, that endurance and loyalty in the smallest and least powerful are what sustain the world when the mighty fail.

This was the figure Tolkien had drawn from the trenches of the first war, the argument the earlier decade had planted now revived as the central myth of the new fear. Writing to his son Christopher in the last days of 1944, with the second war he had dreaded in its fifth year, Tolkien had set down that Sam was the most closely drawn of all his characters, the genuine hobbit, the one he loved best, and he had named the source outright, that Sam was a reflexion of the English soldier, of the privates and the batmen he had known in the war of 1914 and recognized as so far superior to himself. The batman was the enlisted man assigned to bear an officer's kit and cook and clean for him and fight when the order came, and the young lieutenant Tolkien had been led onto the Somme by such men in 1916 and watched them bear what he was not sure he could endure himself. The myth he built across the slump and the gathering second war set the humble servant above the warrior-aristocrat, answered the cult of the leader and the will with a story whose hero saves the world precisely by refusing the power that would make him a master, by bearing his friend and then handing the ring back rather than keeping it. That a post-2001 mass culture, walked into two wars on a manufactured threat and governed by a doctrine that it could author its own reality, reached for exactly this story and crowned its conclusion with an unprecedented sweep is itself a finding the budget tables and the casualty count cannot supply. A society that had been told to fear and to surrender its liberties in the name of overwhelming force returned, in the dark of the theater, to a tale that located all the virtue it could still believe in not in the tower or the army but in a gardener who keeps faith and refuses the ring. The form made in the shadow of one war became the defining epic of the next great dread, the same intuition surfacing twice across seventy years, that the masters of the will despise the very people in whose name they claim to act, and that what sustains the world is the ordinary loyal man the orders of rank place at the bottom.

What the recycling order also produced, in 2007, was a single object that would quietly relocate the terrain on which all of this happened. On the ninth of January Steve Jobs stood at a conference in San Francisco and introduced the iPhone, and it reached stores at the end of June. The device that arrived could not record video, could not copy and paste, ran no outside applications, and reached the internet only over the slowest connection, and Jobs spent ninety minutes arguing that every absence was a decision. None of that mattered to what it became. The iPhone was the first object to put the open internet behind a single sheet of glass that a person kept against the body and consulted hundreds of times a day, and so it began to build a new reserve

surface, not of gold or of dollars but of attention, the one genuinely scarce thing in an economy drowning in everything else. The century's monetary succession had run from metal to the sterling bill to the gold-backed dollar to the dollar cut loose from gold to the recycling of that dollar through foreign vaults, and the screen Jobs unveiled was the first hardware of the rail that would follow, the device on which human attention would be metered, harvested, and sold as the petrodollar had once been recycled. Bernays had taught the twentieth century to manufacture desire through the printed advertisement and the radio spot and the television sequence, the management of the mass mind by men who understood that demand had to be engineered before it could be met. The glass rectangle was that technique handed a sensor and a feedback loop, a surface that would learn each user and supply each user the next thing to want, the consent regime placed in every pocket. In 2007 almost none of this was visible. The object looked like a better telephone. What it was building would not be legible for a decade, and that lag, the gap between what an instrument does and what it is for, is the same gap McCarthy's sheriff stared into, the rules changed and the keepers of the old code the last to know.

The new surface colonized the body and desire before it touched anything else, because they were the last territory the market and the screen had not yet fully converted, and the decade was the one in which the conversion went total. Pornography had ridden every previous medium, the photograph and the film reel and the home videotape, but the broadband internet that spread across the decade did to it what the silkscreen had done to the image, multiplied it without limit and detached its value from any original, and a small number of aggregating sites assembled the world's sexual material into free, infinite, instantly searchable feeds. The economic form was the same one the rest of the decade kept producing, a free surface monetized by attention, the desire of the user harvested and sold the way the recycled dollar was, and the formal logic was Warhol's extended to the body, the human encounter run through a mesh until it became a category, a tag, a thumbnail in an endless grid. What had once cost something and meant something, the most private act a person performs, was reorganized into a limitless commodity available at no price to anyone with a connection, and the cost was paid not in money but in the slow recalibration of what desire expected, the feedback loop Jobs had placed in every pocket trained now on the oldest appetite.

Beneath the legal market ran its criminal extreme, and the decade is the one in which that frontier acquired a name the next two decades could not shake. Jeffrey Epstein, a financier whose actual source of wealth no one could ever quite explain, built across these years a network in which entrée to the powerful was traded for access to the bodies of girls, a private machine that moved money and influence and sex among men at the summit of finance, politics, science, and royalty, and ran on the same principle the open market ran on, that everything, including a child, could be made an asset and a currency. He was first prosecuted in Florida in 2006, and the

2. The 2007–2008 non-prosecution agreement, S.D. Fla.; Julie K. Brown, "Perversion of Justice," *Miami Herald*, November 2018.

resolution of that case in 2008, a secret plea agreement that let a man accused of trafficking minors serve thirteen months in a county jail with daytime release to his office, was itself the clearest reading of who the order protected, the bailout applied to the body, the powerful made whole while their victims were handed the bill² The leniency of that deal is the detail no account of mere wealth explains. A money manager with no visible clients and no traceable fund, who nonetheless moved among heads of state and the chairs of banks and the laureates of science, is not a financier in any sense the word usually conveys; he is a node, and what he traded was not investment advice but compromise, the recorded weakness of the powerful banked against their future use. A machine that gathers the secret appetites of the people who run finance, politics, and intelligence, and stores them, is an instrument of leverage of the kind such services have run for as long as there have existed intelligence services, and the nature of any handler relationship is not established by the documents. What the documents do show is the protection. The federal prosecutor who signed the non-prosecution agreement later said his office had been told to back away, that the man was understood to belong to intelligence, and whether that claim is true or an evasion is not known. The fact the deal makes plain, whatever lay behind it, is that the order gave this network the same shield it extended to its banks, that a man whose crimes were documented was made whole because too many at the summit were bound to him to let him fall. The full scale of the network would not surface for another decade, but the seed was planted in these years, the discovery that under total the asset transformation the body and desire were not exempt from the logic that had swallowed everything else, only the last and most intimate market to be cleared.

The decade's most exact portrait of where the conversion pointed arrived from a cartoon studio. On the twenty-seventh of June 2008 Pixar released WALL·E, Andrew Stanton's fable of an Earth abandoned under the residue of its own consumption, where the last working robot spends its days compacting trash into towers taller than the skyscrapers beside them. Stanton had started from a single question, what would happen if somebody "forgot to turn off the last robot," and the answer opens with a long act of nearly wordless pantomime, machine-age comedy in the line that runs from Chaplin's tramp caught in the gears to Tati's Hulot adrift in the glass city. The surviving humans drift overhead aboard the Axiom, a liner the size of a town, reclining in hover-chairs with screens fixed inches from their faces, every want anticipated before it can be felt, their bones gone soft from generations without weight. It is the body-and-desire diagnosis rendered for children, the last territory not merely converted but dissolved, and it was made one year after the iPhone, by the studio Steve Jobs had built and sold to Disney, so that the image of a species pinned to glass went out under the banner of the company whose largest shareholder had just placed the screen in every pocket. Disney moved the merchandise on schedule, racks of toys modeled on a robot whose calling was to haul discarded toys away. The film earned half a billion dollars and the year's animation Oscar; its warning sat in the children's section, eleven weeks ahead of the proof³

3. WALL·E, released June 27, 2008; the Disney–Pixar acquisition closed May 2006.

And then, in 2008, the edifice built on the recycled dollar gave way⁴ The collapse had the character the whole century had been teaching, which is that an order resting on a guarantee does not erode gradually but seizes all at once. For two decades the center of American economic gravity had drifted from the factory to the trading floor, from the manufacture of goods to the minting of claims on them, and the repeal in 1999 of the Depression-era wall between commercial and investment banking had removed one of the last barriers while the regulators embraced the conviction that markets policed themselves. The housing security was that conviction's purest product, and the cleverness intended to spread the risk so widely no single failure could threaten the whole had instead produced a monoculture, every great institution sitting on versions of the same bet on the same assumption, so that when the assumption broke it broke for everyone at once and the diversification meant to be the armor became the channel through which the contagion reached every part. The men in the room when these decisions were made are the names the moral framing usually skips. Ben Bernanke, the Federal Reserve chairman who had spent his academic career studying the 1930s and who used that authority to expand the central bank's balance sheet past nine hundred billion within months; Henry Paulson, the Treasury secretary who had run Goldman Sachs through the boom and now negotiated the rescues from a chair across from his former trading desk; Timothy Geithner, the New York Fed president who became Paulson's successor and who chaired the calls that decided which bank would live; Larry Summers, returning to Treasury as the architect of the stimulus and the rescue of the financial sector ahead of the rescue of the homeowner; and behind them Alan Greenspan, who had spent two decades persuading Congress that the system policed itself and who would concede, before the same Congress on the twenty-third of October 2008, that he had found a flaw in the model he had thought was the way the world worked. In March 2008 Bear Stearns, unable to fund itself overnight, was sold to JPMorgan in a weekend at a price that days earlier would have read as a misprint. Through the summer the contagion crept along the hidden wiring of interlinked obligation. Then in September came the cluster no system built on confidence could survive. The government seized the mortgage giants Fannie Mae and Freddie Mac. On the fifteenth Lehman Brothers, allowed to fail where Bear had been saved, filed for bankruptcy, and the discovery that the guarantee was conditional, that an institution could simply be let go, froze the global financial system solid within hours. The next day the government rescued the insurer AIG, whose default swaps had backstopped half of Wall Street, with eighty-five billion dollars. Money-market funds thought as safe as cash broke the dollar and set off a run. The last two great independent investment houses converted themselves into ordinary banks within the week. Credit, the oxygen of the modern economy, stopped flowing, because no institution could be certain any other was solvent. The tower came down in the span of a few September days, each broken promise pulling the next, the way a thing built entirely of promises gives way the instant the first is seen to be empty⁷

4. Lehman Brothers bankruptcy, September 15, 2008; Financial Crisis Inquiry Commission, Final Report of the National Commission on the Causes of the Financial and Economic Crisis in the United States (Washington: GPO, 2011).

7. On the panic and its plumbing: Adam Tooze, *Crashed: How a Decade of Financial Crises Changed the World* (New York: Viking, 2018), parts I–II; Andrew Ross Sorkin, *Too Big to Fail* (Viking, 2009), for the September 2008 sequence. On Greenspan's "flaw in the model" concession, House Committee on Oversight and Government Reform, testimony of October 23, 2008.

What the state did next opened, more nakedly than the wars had, the question of who the order was built to protect, and it is the moment at which the monetary succession crosses its own threshold⁵ The institutions whose recklessness had built the tower were, with few exceptions, made whole. The counterparties to AIG's failed bets were paid in full with public money. The Troubled Asset Relief Program committed seven hundred billion dollars, and the Federal Reserve extended trillions more in loans and guarantees into the plumbing of finance, much of it through facilities whose full extent would not be disclosed for years, and in that act the central bank became something it had never openly been, the buyer of last resort for assets no private buyer would touch. The first program of quantitative easing, begun as the crisis crested, had the Fed create money and buy mortgage securities and Treasury debt directly, at a scale without precedent, to prop the price of the recycled dollar's collateral above the zero it deserved. This was the guarantee at the center of the order made finally explicit. The promise that had stood, unspoken, beneath the housing security and the Treasury auction and the entire Bretton Woods II arrangement turned out to be the simplest one of all, that the state would print whatever it took to keep the system from clearing at its true price, that the losses of the men at the top would be socialized across the whole society while their gains stayed private. Some nine million American families lost their homes in the years that followed. The men who had manufactured and sold the mortgages lost, for the most part, almost nothing; not one senior banker went to prison for the conduct that broke the world economy, while the surviving houses absorbed the failed ones and emerged larger and more concentrated, more openly too large to fail than before the failure they had nearly caused.

The crash was not an accident. A system that earns more from arranging claims than from making things, awash in cheap credit it must deploy or perish, manufactures the instruments of its own collapse as reliably as a factory turns out its product, because every incentive inside it rewards the man who moves the risk and punishes the man who refuses the volume. The boom and the bust are not two events but one process, and the people who run the machine know, even when they will not say it aloud, that the state will not let the largest of them clear at the true price, which is precisely why they take the bet. The bailout was not the rescue of a system that had failed; it was the machine working as built, the upside taken privately through the years of the boom and the downside laid on the public in the season of the bust, a guarantee extended to the few and a bill handed to the many. No room full of men needs to agree to wreck the world, because the incentives do it for them, and a class arranged so that it profits whether the bet pays or fails has no reason to want it otherwise. What history supplies is exactly that class, and a state that has quietly accepted that its task is to make those men whole. That is who benefits.

In the weeks of the rescue, a counter-current appeared in plain sight that almost nobody noticed. On the thirty-first of October 2008, six weeks after Lehman, a nine-page paper appeared

5. Federal Reserve announcement of large-scale asset purchases, November 25, 2008; balance-sheet series, Federal Reserve statistical release H.4.1.

6. Satoshi Nakamoto, "Bitcoin: A Peer-to-Peer Electronic Cash System," posted to the Cryptography Mailing List, October 31, 2008. The genesis block was mined on January 3, 2009, with the Times of London headline of that day encoded as a comment in its coinbase transaction.

on a cryptography mailing list signed Satoshi Nakamoto, titled "Bitcoin: A Peer-to-Peer Electronic Cash System," describing a money that needed no central issuer and could not be printed by an institution⁶ The genesis block of the new chain was mined on the third of January 2009 with the day's Times of London front-page headline encoded into it as a comment, "Chancellor on brink of second bailout for banks," the new system's first act a dated marker against the rescue then in progress. Who signed Nakamoto has never been established; the design used cryptographic primitives standardized by the National Security Agency, and the early correspondents around the project included men trained in those same agencies, whose work on anonymous electronic cash had been an open file since the 1990s. The convenient timing, the disciplined silence of the author, and the asset's later trajectory into vast American institutional holdings are points the documentary trail offers without resolving. The chapter on the present will return to it. What matters here, in the autumn of the bailouts, is that the alternative was launched in the season the rescue proved the central bank would never let the system fall, and the two moves, the unlimited backstop and the parallel money, were the same recognition reached from opposite ends.

The collapse reopened the century's oldest argument about what a state owes a broken economy, the quarrel between John Maynard Keynes and the Austrians that had run beneath every crisis of the era. The Austrian case, advanced from Mises through Friedrich Hayek, argued that the bust is the necessary correction of the boom, that the malinvestment the cheap credit had called into being must be allowed to liquidate, the bad banks failed, the bad debts written off, the misallocated capital released to find honest use, however brutal the passage, because to rescue the edifice is only to preserve the distortion and guarantee a larger reckoning later. Lehman, on this reading, was the system briefly telling the truth, and the rescue of everything around it the lie reasserted. The Keynesian answer, which the world's treasuries and central banks took without much hesitation once the plumbing froze, was that liquidation at that scale does not cleanse, it cascades, that a collapse of demand left to run its course turns a financial panic into a decade of idle factories and ruined households, and that the state must therefore spend and the central bank must print to fill the hole private demand has left. The stimulus packages and the bond purchases of 2008 and 2009 were Keynes's prescription enacted on a scale he never saw, the state as spender and the central bank as buyer of last resort. Neither side was the hero. The Keynesians prevented the second Depression and bought, with the prevention, a financial order that learned it would always be caught, the moral hazard the Austrians had warned of made permanent and explicit, every future bet underwritten by the certainty of rescue. The Austrians were right that the rescue preserved the rot and rewarded the reckless, and wrong, or at least untested, in their faith that the liquidation would have cleared to something better rather than to a ruin from which the recovery might never have come. The argument did not resolve in 2008. It only reopened, and it has not closed since, because the question it asks, whether a state should bear the pain of a correction or

print it away and live with the distortion, is the one every monetary order built on a guarantee must finally answer, and there is no answer that does not cost.

Across the ocean, the creditor the recycling order had fattened kept climbing, untroubled by the wars and advantaged by the crash. In December 2001, three months after the towers fell, China formally entered the World Trade Organization, the culmination of the American bet that integration would tame Beijing, that a China woven into the trading system would converge toward the liberal order rather than challenge it. The bet was made in good faith and on the best liberal logic, and the decade demolished the premise even as it delivered the trade. Chinese manufacturing exports roughly tripled; the country became the workshop of the world whose cheap goods underwrote American consumption and whose surpluses, recycled into Treasury bonds, funded American deficits, among them the deficits of the very wars meant to secure American primacy. The loop is worth tracing whole, because it is the machine of the decade laid bare. The wars in Afghanistan and Iraq were paid for not by taxation but by debt, and the debt was bought by the foreign creditors the recycling order delivered, China above all, so that the workshop paid for the soldier sent to police the world the workshop was inheriting. At the far end of the same circuit lay the Gulf, whose crude still priced and sold in dollars, the discipline the Iraqi invasion had just restored, kept the demand for those dollars alive and the producers' surpluses flowing back into the same Treasury market. The oil moved to its buyers through the straits and sea lanes the American fleet had patrolled since the desert bargain, the Fifth Fleet standing in the Gulf as the guarantor that the energy on which the whole bargain depended would reach its market and be paid for in the one currency the arrangement required. China's savings bought the bonds. The bonds funded the wars. The wars secured, however imperfectly, the order under which oil stayed dollar-priced, and the dollar-priced oil sustained the demand that let the paper be sold again. The customer borrowed from the supplier, spent the loan policing the supply route, and called the corridor its own. The Beijing Olympics of 2008, staged with a grandeur calibrated to announce arrival, came in the same summer the American financial system slid toward the cliff, and the symbolism was lost on no one watching the ledger turn. By the decade's end China had passed Germany to become the world's largest exporter and stood ready to overtake Japan as the second-largest economy outright. The empire had enriched its periphery, and the margin no longer behaved like one, patient where Washington was frantic, accumulating where Washington was spending, taking the creditor's place as the debtor reached for the printing press.

At the decade's hinge in 2008 the American order still shows live dynamism, a vast economy and an open society and a capacity to make and to draw the talented from everywhere; but the pressures that end orders have climbed hard. The recasting of every relation as a position is no longer an early tendency; it is dominant, the elite earning more from arranging claims than from making things. Monoculture fragility runs high, the load-bearing diversity of the credit system

traded away for the legible efficiency of every institution sitting on the same bet. The error-correcting reflexes that mark an open phase are straining visibly, the same government that prosecuted the wars treating those who reported inconvenient facts as allies of the enemy, building the secret prisons and the warrantless surveillance that convert a nerve the system needs into an enemy to be silenced. Borderland pressure reads near its maximum, an energized periphery the center itself enriched now occupying the creditor's position. What none of it contains is the single September week in which the guarantee was discovered to be conditional and the whole machine froze, the instant, which *The Wire* had seen coming block by block, when a society's account of itself stops convincing the people inside it.

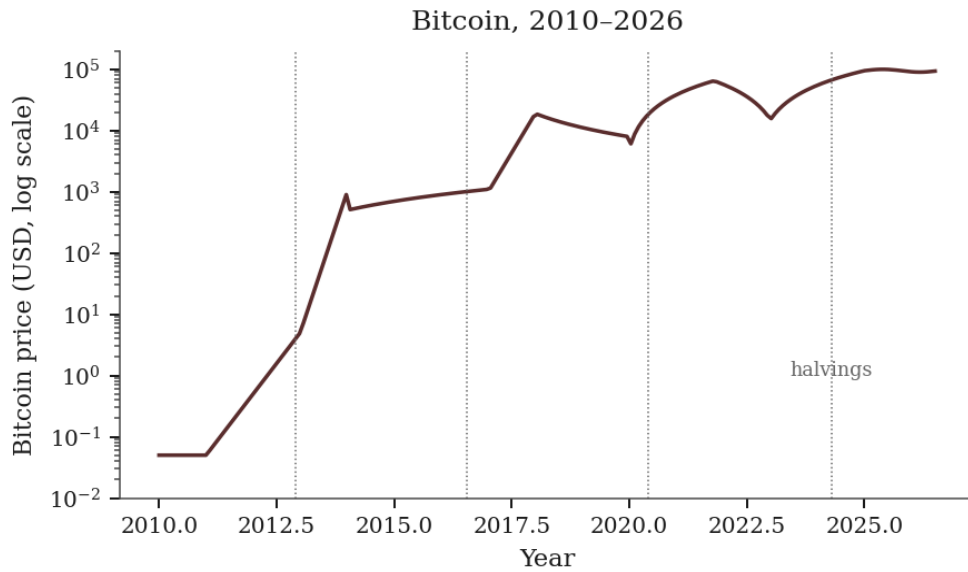
What survived these years was not the order the works were made inside, which kept revealing its limits at home and abroad through the whole decade. The unipolar age had lasted less than ten years past the rival superpower's fall, and it unwound through a series of self-inflicted exposures. The strongest military on earth was stalemated by buried bombs and resolved men. The most sophisticated machinery of capital ever assembled collapsed in a single September week from the accumulated fragility of its own cleverness, and the government rushed to rescue the architects while the governed fell. The works outlasted the order that produced them. McCarthy's sheriff goes on staring into the changed world and finding no purchase, and the book remains the most exact thing made about an institution's bewilderment before a violence that has stopped obeying its rules. *The Wire* moves rung by rung through a city the recycling economy abandoned, the fullest portrait American television managed of an institution outliving its function; the long serial drama it led, the agency of *Mad Men* and the ruined teacher of *Breaking Bad* and the consoling republic of *The West Wing*, turned the medium that had been the consumer order's mirror into the instrument that read it whole. Jackson's trilogy continues to play, its smallest character still bearing what the largest ones cannot. Banksy's stencils hang now in the collections of the people they mock, the rebellion priced and owned. The free and infinite feed of the body, opened in these years, never closed; and the Epstein network that ran sex and influence and money among the powerful seeded a reckoning the next two decades could not bury. The glass rectangle Jobs lifted up in January 2007 sits in nearly every pocket on earth, the reserve surface of an attention economy the decade could not yet name. Each was made by one mind under the load of a monetary order that had begun, openly, to guarantee itself with a printing press; each kept its shape after the load was placed. The order changed; the central bank became the buyer of last resort and never stopped being it; the recycled dollar bought wars it could not win and houses that could not keep their price. The Pixar reel had run its prediction past three hundred million viewers before the policy could catch up: that an order can promise to print whatever it takes and still not buy the one thing it most needs, which is the belief of the people inside it that the rules still mean what they say.

2010 – 2019

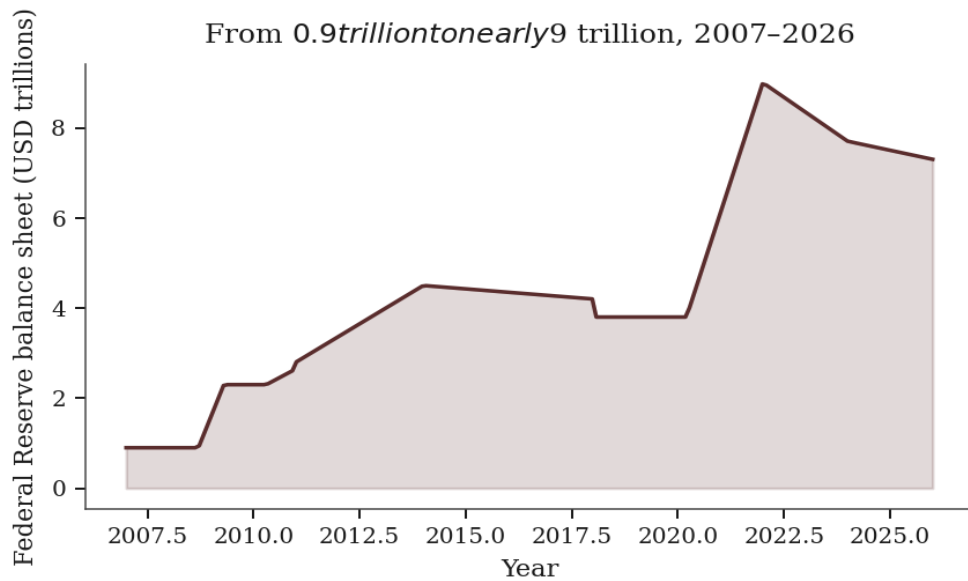
In October of 2010 two engineers in San Francisco released a small application that did almost nothing. It let a person photograph a meal or a sunset, lay a filter over the picture that made it look like a memory already, and post it to a feed where strangers and acquaintances could mark it with a small symbol of approval. They called it Instagram, and within ten weeks it had a million users, faster than Facebook or Twitter had reached the same mark, and within eighteen months Facebook bought it for a billion dollars in cash and stock, a company with thirteen employees and no revenue at all. The price looked absurd to the people who valued companies by what they earned. It was not absurd. What Facebook had bought was not a photo application but a machine for the capture of attention, and attention had become, in the years just before, the most valuable raw material in the economy, dearer than oil because it could be refined into the one thing advertisers had always wanted and never had, a near-perfect prediction of what a particular human being could be made to want next. The filter that made every snapshot look like a curated artifact was the giveaway, the place where the whole decade announced itself before the statistics could name it. It turned ordinary life into the production of content, and it taught a billion people, gently, with no coercion any of them could feel, to experience their own days as raw footage for an audience.

The audience was the product, and this inversion organized everything that followed. It is the perfected form of a technique Bernays sketched a century before and could not measure: he could place a stunt and watch a population shift; he could not adjust the stunt for one mind in the instant it worked. The feed could do both. It watched what arrested a given pair of eyes a half-second longer than the rest, it inferred from that pause the shape of a craving, and it served the next image to deepen the appetite and the one after to push it further, learning each person individually, at the scale of billions, in a loop that closed faster than awareness. Bernays had manufactured desire by the carload. The platform manufactured it by the soul, one at a time, continuously, and it billed the manufacturers of soap and cars and political grievance for access to the souls it had refined. A population whose wants are produced for it and presented to it as its own is governed not by command but by the quiet administration of desire, which feels like freedom because the hand that shapes it is never seen. The decade did not stumble into this. It was engineered, deliberately, by people who had read the manuals and now possessed the instrument those books had only imagined. No cabal authored it; the manufacture of consent runs through advertisers, agencies, platforms, and the millions who learned to perform for the feed, a current that needed no single controlling intelligence. It needed only an objective, the maximization of attention, and the freedom to learn its way there, and it learned with a thoroughness Bernays would have recognized as the fulfillment of his profession.

The money that made this possible was not earned in the ordinary sense, and where it came from has to be told first, because the attention economy and the monetary condition of the decade were a single fact seen from two angles. After the collapse of 2008 the central banks had decided that the financial system could not be allowed to clear, that the losses were too vast and the institutions too entangled, and so rather than let the value of bad bets fall to zero they created money to prop the price up. They called it quantitative easing, a phrase chosen for its capacity to mean nothing. While the central banks ran the official press, the parallel money introduced in the prior decade's autumn began its public career. Bitcoin traded for the first time in May 2010 when a Florida programmer paid ten thousand of the coins, then worth perhaps forty dollars, for two pizzas from a Papa John's. The coin's value crossed one dollar in 2011, a hundred dollars in 2013, a thousand dollars in late 2013, the rise punctuated by the collapse of the Tokyo exchange Mt. Gox in February 2014, which lost roughly seven hundred and forty thousand coins of its customers' deposits and ought to have killed the experiment; it did not. The Federal Bureau of Investigation seized 144,336 coins from the operator of the Silk Road darknet marketplace in October of 2013, and from that day forward the United States government has been one of the largest single holders of the asset on earth, a fact the public records of the federal marshals service kept on quiet display while the same government's prosecutors continued to call the holders criminals. The chain's design issued a fixed twenty-one million coins on a schedule that halved every four years; the second halving fell in July 2016, the third in May 2020, and each halving was followed within a year by a peak the press, against its own expectation, kept having to revise upward. The asset's behavior across the decade tracked, with eerie precision, the central bank's. Each round of quantitative easing was answered by a fresh climb in the price of the thing the central bank could not print, and each tightening was answered by a fall, the two moneys functioning as the seesaw an analyst would expect from a flight-asset built against fiat expansion. The parallel rail that walked the public into the 2020s adoption was no spontaneous market phenomenon. It was the longest-running tutorial in monetary alternative the modern world has run, and it began the same year the official press did. The libertarian who treats Bitcoin as a triumph of the open-source movement and the regulator who treats it as a criminal vehicle each have half of it. The federal marshals seized the coins and kept them, and they appreciated on the government's books while the Treasury called the same asset speculative.



Bitcoin price, 2010–2026, log scale: the four halvings and the climb against the central bank's expansion. Source: composite of exchange data.



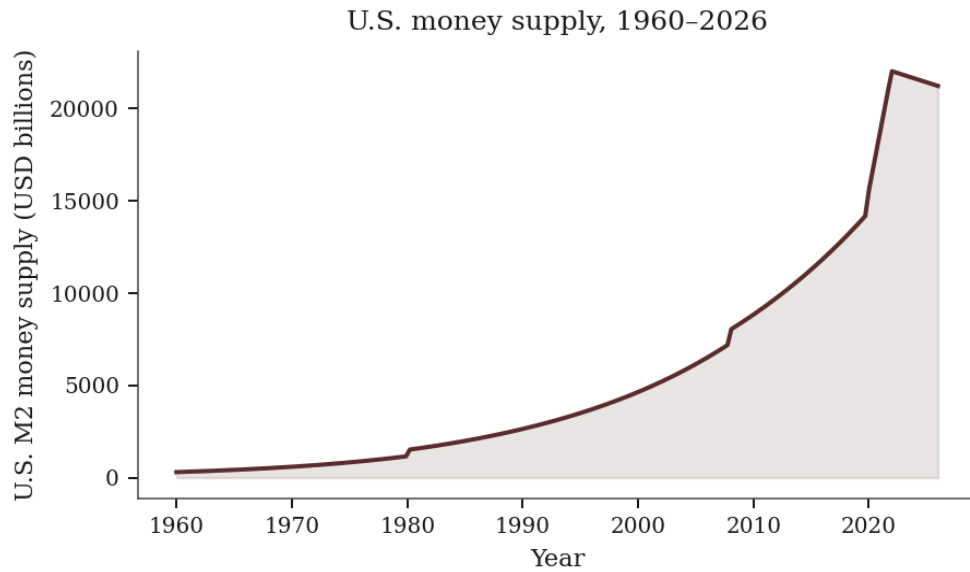
Federal Reserve balance sheet, 2007–2026: the press that ran beside it. Source: Federal Reserve H.4.1.

The thing itself is not hard to follow. A central bank can conjure money by typing a number into its own account, balances that did not exist the instant before. It uses that money to buy bonds, mostly government paper, from the banks, which, now sitting on cash instead of debt, have more to lend, and the price of the bonds, bid up by a buyer with a bottomless purse, rises. A bond's yield falls as its price rises, the two move on a seesaw, so when the central bank pushes bond prices up it forces down the return that anyone, a pension fund, a saver, an insurer, can earn by owning safe

debt. That was the point. The aim was to make safety pay so little that money would be driven out along the risk spectrum, into stocks, into property, into anything that still offered a return, raising those prices in turn and making the owners of assets feel rich enough to spend. The Federal Reserve's balance sheet, under nine hundred billion dollars before the crisis, swelled past four trillion; the European and Japanese and British central banks ran their own versions.

What began as an emergency measure to be unwound in a season became, across the decade, the permanent weather. Each tentative effort to withdraw the support, to let rates rise or the balance sheet shrink, met a market spasm so violent that the withdrawal was abandoned, until it was clear the system could no longer survive the conditions that had prevailed for the whole of its prior history. An economy that cannot tolerate the price of money returning to anything like normal is not a sound thing temporarily indisposed; it is a fragile one permanently sedated.

In the cheap-money decade the men who would deliver the political settlement of the following one accumulated their positions. The PayPal cohort, the small group of founders and engineers who had built the original electronic payments company in the late 1990s and sold it to eBay in 2002 for one and a half billion dollars, fanned out across the valley and bought, individually and in syndicate, the chokepoints of the next economy. Peter Thiel, the company's first investor and chief executive, took his five-hundred-and-fifty-million-dollar share, made the first outside investment in a Harvard sophomore named Mark Zuckerberg in August 2004 for five hundred thousand dollars, and in 2003 founded Palantir Technologies in Palo Alto with funding from In-Q-Tel, the Central Intelligence Agency's venture arm, the contractor's first customer being the agency that funded its first round. Elon Musk, who had been bought out of his executive role at PayPal in 2000, used his hundred and eighty million in proceeds to found three companies in the 2002–2004 stretch: SpaceX in El Segundo, Tesla in Palo Alto, and the solar venture that would become SolarCity. By the close of the 2010s those positions had compounded into balance sheets that exceeded the gross product of most countries on earth. The wealth concentrated in the hands of a small interlocked network whose members had met one another at a single firm in the late 1990s and continued to invest in one another's ventures for the next quarter century. Reid Hoffman, also of the PayPal group, founded LinkedIn in 2002 and sold it to Microsoft for twenty-six billion in 2016; David Sacks bought and sold Yammer; Keith Rabois ran Square's operations under fellow PayPal alumnus Jack Dorsey; Joe Lonsdale cofounded Palantir with Thiel and would later seed Vance's first campaign. The decade's official politics scarcely registered the concentration. Its consequences arrived in the next.



U.S. money supply, 1960–2026: the press at the longer scale. Source: Federal Reserve H.6.

And the river of manufactured money had to go somewhere. It went into assets, and above all into the handful of platform companies that had discovered how to convert attention into revenue, because in a world where safe bonds paid nothing, a machine that grew its harvest of human attention at thirty percent a year was the only growth left worth owning. The cheap money and the attention economy were two angles on a single thing. The money had nowhere productive to go, the attention economy offered the only frontier that looked like the future, and so the savings of a sedated world poured into the machinery that distracted it. The policy was sold as a rescue of the whole economy and functioned as something narrower. The people who already owned assets watched them levitate; the people who possessed only their labor were told the emergency had passed and left to wonder why their wages had not moved. The transfer was not a side effect of the cure. It was the mechanism of the cure, which worked by inflating the wealth of the owning class in the hope that some of it would trickle down as spending, and mostly it did not.

Gross federal debt as a share of GDP at landmark years, 1916–2025 (approximate). Sources: OMB Historical Tables; U.S. Treasury.

It is here that a record album made by a young man from Compton becomes the most exact instrument the decade produced for reading what this did to a single consciousness, which is the only scale at which any of it can finally be felt. Kendrick Lamar released *good kid, m.A.A.d city* on the twenty-second of October, 2012, and he subtitled it, on the cover, a short film, which was a formal instruction and not a boast. The album is built as a narrative, scenes from a day in a Compton adolescence assembled out of chronological order and stitched with skits, voicemails

from his mother that ask when he is bringing the van home, the ambient sound of a world that wants to absorb him before he can become anyone. What the form does is refuse the thing the surrounding culture was built to reward. The decade's medium rewarded the fragment, the post, the loop short enough to be consumed and discarded in the time it took the thumb to move; Lamar made an object that demanded to be heard whole, in sequence, that withheld its meaning from anyone who took it a piece at a time. The album's subject is a young man who tries to remain a self under a pressure that wants to make him a type, a statistic, a casualty, a brand. Its method is the same: it remains a whole self, a single sustained act of attention, under the pressure of a market that wanted to chop it into singles and serve it in fragments to a distracted ear. What the album makes plain is that the attention economy's deepest cost is not to the wallet but to the interior, that a consciousness trained from childhood to perform for an audience and to measure itself in approval is a mind with no private floor to stand on, and that to become a person is now, against the whole grain of the age, to refuse to become content.

If Lamar's answer to the machine was to guard the interior, the decade's other great hip-hop statement was the opposite, the maker turning on the industry that owned him and forcing the revolt into the sound itself. Kanye West had built his early fame on the warmest sound in pop, the sped-up soul samples of *The College Dropout* in 2004, old Black voices raised in pitch until inheritance became hook, a music that performed the conversion of feeling into product and grieved it in the same breath. By 2013 he had stopped grieving and begun to attack. *Yeezus*, released that June, is the deliberate destruction of everything that had made him palatable, an album stripped of warmth and melody and built from distorted synthesizers, industrial noise, and screaming - the most hostile sound a star of his rank had ever released on purpose, and the ugliness was the argument. A man who could make anything beautiful made something that assaulted the ear, because beauty was the thing the industry wanted from him and the one he had decided to withhold. Its center is a track called *New Slaves*, which says in plain words what the chipmunk soul had only implied, that the wealth the order had handed him bought no ownership, that a Black artist could be made rich and still be owned, displayed as proof of the system's openness while barred from the rooms where the system was run. He had spent years trying to enter high fashion as a designer rather than a customer, and the houses had taken his money and refused him the chair; the rage of that refusal - the discovery that the gatekeepers would sell him anything except a seat among the people who decided - runs under the record. *I Am a God*, the track whose title scandalized the press, is the same recognition turned inside out: the artist claiming the divinity the attention economy had trained a culture to project onto its celebrities, performed so that no listener could tell whether it was megalomania or the cruelest satire of the celebrity-god the feed manufactures, which was the point, because by 2013 the two could no longer be told apart. He sent *New Slaves* into the world not through the industry's machine but by projecting his own face,

enormous, onto the walls of buildings in dozens of cities in a single night, an artist seizing the surface the platforms monetized and using it to broadcast his refusal of the order. Where Basquiat had watched himself become an asset and let it show in the work, West refused to be merely the property and demanded to own the house, and the noise of Yeezus is the sound of that demand striking the wall the system keeps for exactly the talent it most profitably sells.

Lamar's refusal had a literary form too, arriving from the far north and at improbable length. Across the years just before the decade, a Norwegian named Karl Ove Knausgaard published six volumes that ran to thousands of pages, titled with a deliberate provocation *My Struggle*, and recorded his own life at a granularity no novelist had risked before, a kitchen scrubbed clean after a party, the death of his father and the literal removal of the filth from the dead man's house, the boredom of fatherhood, the shame of adolescence, all of it told flat, without the shape a novel is supposed to impose. The translations reached the English-speaking world across the decade and were read as a phenomenon, and the reception was the point. Autofiction, the form was called, and its premise was an act of desperation dressed as a method: that in a culture where every public surface had become a performance, where the curated feed had made all presentation suspect, the only ground left solid enough to build on was the radically empirical self, the texture of one's own experience reported so exhaustively that it could not be a pose. Knausgaard's wager was the inverse of Instagram's and the same as Lamar's. Where the feed offered the self as a thing to be polished and displayed, he presented the self as a thing to be excavated until it stopped being flattering, on the conviction that only what did not flatter was real. In an age that had industrialized the manufacture of false versions, the last available reality was the one nearest to hand, reported so exhaustively that it could not be a pose. It was a small and exhausted answer to a vast condition, and honest about its size.

The condition had a public face that was funnier and more total than any novel. In September of 2013 a studio in Edinburgh and New York released *Grand Theft Auto V*, a video game that cost more to produce than most films and earned, in its first three days, more than any entertainment product in history to that point, and what it sold was the freedom to inhabit a satire of the order that had produced it. The game's open world is a pixel-perfect Los Angeles renamed, a landscape saturated with advertisements for products that do not exist, talk radio that vents a culture's resentments, social-media parodies and self-help gurus and a stock market the player can move by committing the assassinations that shift the price. Its three protagonists are a retired armed robber drowning in the suburban affluence he stole his way into, a young man from the projects for whom the legitimate economy offers no path, and a psychopath who is simply the logic of the whole thing made flesh, want without limit and violence without weight. The satire is total and it is also, and this is the engine inside it, completely toothless by design, because the player buys the game in order to enjoy the very things it mocks, to drive the cars and rob the banks and shoot the

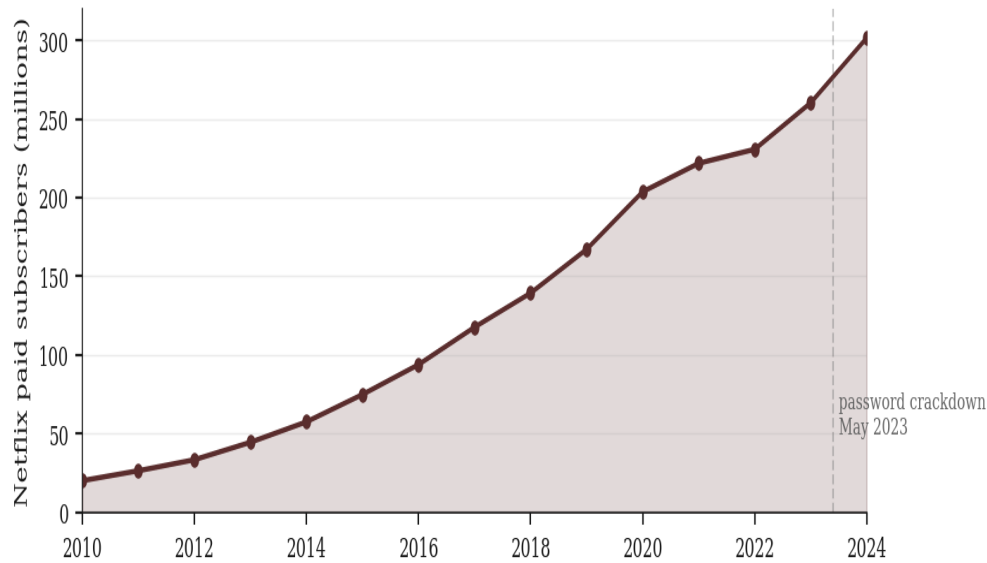
pedestrians while the radio sneers at consumerism. Žižek's account of ideology is built for exactly this object. The game does not hide what it is; it announces, at every turn, that the order it depicts is corrupt, hollow, and absurd, and the announcement changes nothing, because the cynical distance the satire grants is what lets the player participate with a clear conscience. One knows the system is a racket, one says so while playing, and one plays. What the game makes visible is that the late financialized order does not require anyone to believe in it; it requires only that everyone enjoy it while disbelieving, that the critique itself become a feature of the product, a flavor of engagement. The most expensive satire ever made sold tens of millions of copies of the thing it satirized.

The same logic, taken to its purest and most uncomfortable conclusion, ran on television under the guise of a documentary. *Nathan for You* premiered on the twenty-eighth of February, 2013, and its premise was a comedian named Nathan Fielder, who played a barely fictional version of himself, a business-school graduate offering struggling small enterprises the strategies a real consultant might offer, followed to their logical end. He helps a frozen-yogurt shop generate attention by inventing a flavor of feces; he devises for a coffee shop a way to evade trademark law by becoming a parody of a famous brand; he reorganizes a moving company, a gas station, a petting zoo, each scheme more elaborate and more openly insane than the last, all of it delivered with the deadpan courtesy of a graduate-school presentation. The comedy lives in a single formal device, which is that Fielder never breaks. He treats every absurdity as sound business, and the real human beings around him, the actual shop owners, mostly go along, because the logic he speaks is the one the whole culture had agreed to honor, the creed that any problem yields to the right marketing, that attention can be manufactured by stunt, that the consultant's confidence is itself a kind of competence. The show is the engineering of consent performed as farce. It takes Bernays's profession, the production of want at the scale of one person through indirection and spectacle, and runs it without the discreet veil that keeps the trade respectable, and what is exposed is that the veil was the only difference between public relations and a confidence game. What Fielder's flat delivery lets erupt is the recognition that the consultant's logic, the whole industry of brand and engagement and attention capture that the decade ran on, is indistinguishable, once the polish is stripped, from an elaborate and sincere form of nonsense, sustained only because everyone has agreed to pretend it is sound.

The same suspicion of the empire's own logic was running, in those years, through the most ambitious television the medium had yet produced, and the form itself was changing under it as fast as the money was. The hearth that had organized the American living room for half a century, the network broadcast watched by everyone at once, had already cracked open in the prestige cable dramas of the prior decade, and now it shattered into something new. *Better Call Saul* premiered on AMC on the eighth of February, 2015, a prequel to a finished masterpiece that no formula said

should work, and it worked by inverting the velocity of its parent. Where the earlier series had charted a decent man's swift conversion into a monster, this one slowed the same machinery to a crawl and watched a striving, gifted, fundamentally hopeful man get ground down by an order that punished his every honest effort and rewarded only the corner cut, until the corruption arrived not as a fall but as the path of least resistance, the only door the system left open. The form is patient past the point most television dares, long static takes of a man working a strip-mall law practice; a person is not seized by evil in a moment but worn into it across years by the steady refusal of the legitimate world to make room for him. It tracks the same shape diagnosis Lamar made of Compton and the credentialed young were making of the meritocracy, told in the register of a man with the right degree and no place to stand.

What delivered these objects to their audience was no longer the network and increasingly no longer the cable bundle either, but the stream, and the stream rewrote the economics of attention as thoroughly as quantitative easing had rewritten the economics of money. A company that had begun by mailing rented discs had, by the middle of the decade, borrowed against the same near-zero interest rates the central banks had set and spent the billions producing its own content, releasing whole seasons at once so that a viewer could consume a year of story in a weekend, and what had once been an appointment kept with everyone became a private binge measured only against the self. The shared hearth was gone, and in its place stood a screen that knew each watcher individually and served each one a different world, the television feed now indistinguishable in principle from the Instagram feed, a stream optimized to capture one pair of eyes by learning what those eyes could not stop watching. Into that medium, in 2018, HBO released *Succession*, which premiered on the third of June, and which took as its subject the dynasty at the head of a media empire and read, through the feuds of a poisoned family, the deeper truth that the men who owned the machines of attention were themselves its most damaged products, fluent in every manipulation and incapable of a single unperformed feeling, fighting for a throne whose only power was the power to shape what hundreds of millions would be told was real. Its formal signature was the handheld camera that never quite settled, that lurched and zoomed and caught its subjects half-composed, a visual grammar that refused the steady authority of the old prestige frame, and the refusal was the meaning: there was no longer any stable place to stand and survey the order, only the jostling, vertiginous interior of the people who ran it, as lost inside the machine as everyone they sold to.



Netflix global paid subscribers, 2010–2024: the audience the cable bundle could no longer retain. Source: Netflix quarterly filings.

What the consultant sells, finally, is the promise of greatness, and the decade told itself a story about its price in two films that meant to disavow the very fantasy they made irresistible. *Whiplash*, released in 2014, is the work of a young director, Damien Chazelle, and it is built as a thriller about a jazz drummer and the teacher who abuses him toward perfection. The teacher, a creation of terrifying control, was given a direction by Chazelle to be not a human being but a monster, and the film's argument, stated in his own mouth, is that there are no two words in English more harmful than good job, that genius is forged only by a cruelty that refuses every comfort. The picture pretends to indict him. Its form betrays the pretense. The cut of the final sequence, the drummer who plays past the point of injury while the camera cuts faster and faster between the bloodied hands and the tyrant's slowly dawning approval, is constructed to deliver to the audience exactly the surge of vindicated triumph that the film's dialogue claims to condemn. One leaves *Whiplash* not in mourning for a soul destroyed but thrilled by a greatness achieved, and that gap between what the film says and what its edited rhythm makes the body feel is the era's avowed and buried fantasy laid open. A culture that measured every person in metrics of approval, that had made exceptional achievement the only secular salvation left, could not actually bring itself to disapprove of the cruelty the summit was said to require. It disapproved in the dialogue and approved in the edit. It disapproved in public and approved in private, which is the shape of every ideology.

Three years later a more mature artist took the same appetite and refused to let it off the hook so cleanly. Paul Thomas Anderson's *Phantom Thread*, in 2017, gave Daniel Day-Lewis his last

role as a couturier in postwar London whose genius is inseparable from a controlling, devouring perfectionism, a man who cannot abide a buttered toast scraped too loudly at breakfast because it interrupts the sealed world his work requires. The film studies the artist's appetite from the inside, the way the pursuit of the flawless object consumes everyone around it, treats other human beings as material, demands a silence and a service it will never return. What makes the picture an advance on *Whiplash* is its formal refusal of the triumphant surge. There is no moment where the cruelty pays off in a thrill; the camera stays close and patient and slightly sickened, and the film's resolution arrives not through achieved greatness but through a strange and disturbing mutual surrender in which the muse poisons the master, mildly, repeatedly, in order to make him weak enough to be loved. The fantasy that *Whiplash* delivered straight, the conviction that the great work justifies any cost paid by anyone, *Phantom Thread* renders as a sickness that can be survived only when it is neutralized, the genius dosed into dependence so that the human relation can exist at all. Set against the decade's worship of the exceptional individual, the curated self, the founder, the brand, the disruptor, the film is the period's most sophisticated counter-evidence. It agrees that greatness has a price and insists, against the whole grain of the age, that the bill is mostly paid by other people, and that this is not a tragic necessity but a thing to be quietly resisted.

There was no resistance in the form that swallowed all the others, and by the decade's second half it had a face. A college dropout in North Carolina spent five years, by his own account, reverse-engineering the recommendation algorithm of the largest video platform on earth with an obsession he called unhealthy, and in January of 2017 he posted himself counting aloud to a hundred thousand, forty hours cut down to fit beneath a day. It spread, and from it he built a method that was the attention economy made fully conscious of itself: he gave away cars and houses and hundreds of thousands of dollars, filmed the gift as theater, and poured the revenue back into ever larger gifts filmed as ever larger spectacle, until generosity and its own documentation were a single industrial process. MrBeast, he called himself, and he was not an aberration of the decade but its culmination, the point at which a person stopped using the platform to display a life and built an entire existence as feed optimization, every act chosen for its capacity to be watched, the self dissolved completely into the content it produced.

The same dissolution ran live and uncut on the platforms where a person simply turned on a camera and let strangers watch. A young woman who streamed herself playing video games on Twitch became, under the name Pokimane, the familiar face of a new kind of work, the livestream, in which the product was not a finished object but presence itself, hours of unedited company sold to an audience that paid in subscriptions and tips and the small donations that scrolled across the screen with the donor's name attached. The intimacy was the commodity. The viewer bought not a performance polished after the fact but the feeling of being there, of being seen back, of belonging to the private world of a person who could never, at the scale of millions, actually know he existed.

And the logic ran off the edge of the screen and into the body. In November of 2016 a British entrepreneur launched a paywall site called OnlyFans on the same mechanism as every other creator platform, a fee paid straight to the person on the other side of the glass, except that this one placed no limit on what could be sold, and within a few years it was a sex-work economy of millions, the oldest trade in the world rebuilt on top of the attention economy, the body and desire metered out by subscription like everything else. The insight under all three was Warhol's, half a century early: the image had become a financial instrument worth what its reproduction fetched, and now the asset had swallowed the maker entirely, so that the person was no longer the producer of the multiple but the multiple itself, a self afloat on attention, and the body was the last private thing the screen colonized because it was the only frontier left.

That colonization had a darker register than the cheerful commerce of the platforms admitted, and it broke into public view at the decade's end in two collapses of the wall between the displayed self and the hidden one. In October of 2017 a tweet by the actress Alyssa Milano, ten days after the first reporting on the producer Harvey Weinstein, asked every woman who had been harassed or assaulted to write two words, and within a day they had been posted millions of times. The phrase was not new; the activist Tarana Burke had used it for a decade. What was new was the medium, the same feed engineered to spread outrage faster than agreement now delivering, for once, a truth the powerful had spent generations suppressing, the testimony pouring out at the speed and scale only the platform could produce, until the men who had traded on the silence found the silence gone. The movement was the attention economy turned, briefly, against the power it usually served, and it brought down studio heads and senators and a long file of men who had assumed the private would stay hidden.

Two years later the same exposure reached the order's most protected precincts. In July of 2019 the financier Jeffrey Epstein was arrested on federal charges of sex-trafficking minors, a man whose entire enterprise had been the cultivation of the powerful, presidents and princes and the chairmen of the institutions the decade had taught the public to distrust, and who had once before been let off with a settlement that protected everyone above him. His source of wealth was never explained by anything he was known to do, no fund anyone could name, no clients who would admit to him, and the woman who ran his operation, who recruited and arranged and managed the procession of the young, was Ghislaine Maxwell, the daughter of the British press baron whose own empire had been a front of debt and whose ties to a foreign intelligence service had been alleged for years before he was pulled dead from the sea off his yacht in 1991. A network that traded access to the powerful for the compromising knowledge of what they did in private is, whatever else it is, a machine for leverage, and such a machine is the oldest instrument the intelligence services possess. The 2008 settlement that had let him plead to almost nothing and walk out of jail to his office by day reads, on the inference, less as the failure of a prosecution than

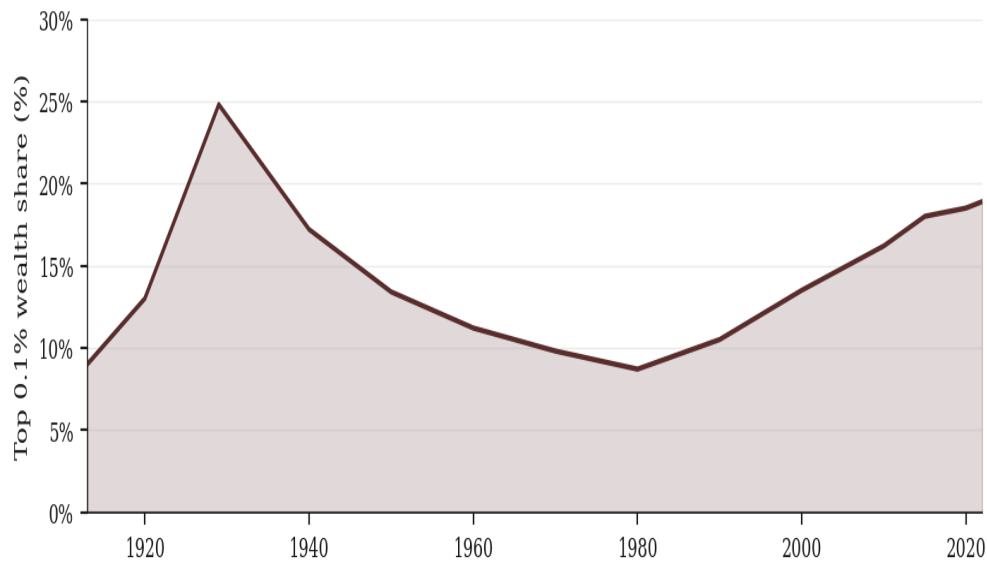
as the protection of an asset - the order shielding a node whose value lay precisely in what it knew about the men at its top. That is the reading. The documentary trail contains no document that names the service that ran him; what it does contain is the impunity, and a public accounting that ought to have shown the money never did. On those two columns - the impunity and the missing money - the pattern is consistent with a compromised-asset arrangement and with several lesser explanations besides. The book asserts the pattern, names the inference, and stops there. In August he was found dead in a federal jail cell, on a night the guards slept and the cameras failed, his death ruled a suicide and believed by almost no one, and the disbelief was itself the decade's signature. A public that had spent ten years learning, correctly, that its institutions lied to it could not bring itself to accept the official account of the death of the one man whose testimony threatened the people who ran them, and whether the suspicion was right or wrong, the inability of the official account to be believed at all was the deeper fact. The Epstein affair was the body and the screen and the rot of the elite converging in a single figure, the buried fact of an establishment that displayed itself endlessly while concealing what it actually did, and the public's certainty that it was being lied to, true or not, was the measure of how completely the order had spent its credit.

While the feed engineered the interior, the arrangements that had organized the exterior were quietly coming apart, and the first to go was the one built on a fiction everyone had agreed not to examine. The euro had joined economies that shared a currency but not a treasury, not a banking union, not any mechanism for moving money from the prosperous north to the indebted south beyond the polite expectation that it would never be needed. The flaw ran as deep as Triffin's had forty years before² A country with its own currency that borrows too much has an escape: it can let the money fall, which makes its debts and its exports cheaper at a stroke and inflates a share of the burden away. A country inside the euro had surrendered that escape. Greece could not devalue a currency it shared with Germany, so when the markets concluded it had borrowed beyond its capacity and disguised the books to do it, there was no relief valve; the only adjustment left was to grind down wages and prices and spending inside the economy itself, which is slower, crueler, and politically near-impossible. In 2010 the polite expectation broke. The bond markets, sensing the empty promise beneath a currency with no treasury behind it, came for Greece, then for Ireland and Portugal, then in 2011 for Spain and Italy, the last two too large to rescue and too large to let fall. For three years the European project lived in the gap between what its treaties promised and what its politics would bear, until on the twenty-sixth of July, 2012, the president of its central bank, Mario Draghi, stood in London and said the bank would do whatever it took to preserve the euro, and added that it would be enough. He had announced no program and committed no money. It was a sentence, not a policy. But the markets believed the resolve, and the conviction defended the line the official design could not, which was the decade's purest demonstration that faith can sustain a position the balance sheet says is already lost. The euro survived on the strength of a

2. Robert Triffin, *Gold and the Dollar Crisis* (1960).

promise that was never tested, and the absence of any test was the whole of its solvency. Beneath the rescue the deeper damage went unrepaired. The austerity imposed on the south to satisfy the creditors of the north produced youth unemployment above fifty percent in Greece and Spain, a generation credentialed beyond the capacity of its economy to employ it, and the resentment of that abandoned periphery would feed, by the decade's end, the politics that came for the center.

For the center had bred its own surplus of the able and abandoned. The order built after the war had made a promise to the educated, that the credential would be honored with a place commensurate with the training, and on the strength of that pledge the universities had expanded for two generations, until by the twenty-tens they produced far more aspirants to elite position than the elite positions could absorb. Lawyers without firms, doctorates without professorships, holders of impressive degrees stacked in unpaid internships and the gig economy and the long humiliation of being overqualified for everything on offer. A surplus of frustrated elites is the most volatile material a society can manufacture, because these are exactly the people equipped to name a grievance, to organize it, and to lead it. They had been told they were the future and discovered they were redundant, and they looked at the credentialed managerial class that had presided over the financial collapse without consequence, that spoke a fluent dialect of meritocratic self-congratulation while the meritocracy hardened into a closed shop, and they concluded, correctly, that the establishment was a self-dealing racket dressed as competence. The asset prices the central banks had levitated told the story to anyone beneath the owning class. Those who owned assets grew enormously richer across the decade while those who owned only their labor were told the crisis was over and left to wonder why their lives had not improved. The recovery from 2008 was the slowest the postwar series had measured; productivity stalled, wages crept; what the cheap money had built was not a repair but a transfer, year upon year, of paper wealth to those who already had it, an arrangement that was, beneath the language of prudence, a heist conducted in daylight and called a recovery.



Top 0.1 percent wealth share, 1913–2022: the long curve the decade's grievance read off. Source: Saez and Zucman (2020); Federal Reserve Distributional Financial Accounts.

The revolt against that arrangement announced itself first as a question on a British ballot. In June of 2016 the United Kingdom voted, against the unanimous advice of its government, its central bank, its corporations, and nearly every expert it possessed, to leave the European Union. The experts had explained with charts that this would make the country poorer; the voters in the hollowed towns where the levitated recovery had never arrived understood the warning as a threat from the people who had grown rich while their towns withered, and voted to leave for the very reason that the establishment told them not to. The vote was not, at bottom, about Europe. It tested whether the people who ran the country could still be believed, and a narrow majority answered no. Five months later the same fault opened wider across the Atlantic, when a property developer and television performer who had spent the campaign insulting the institutions of his own country defeated a candidate who embodied the credentialed Washington class so completely that her victory had been treated as arithmetic. The pollsters were wrong because they had measured a legitimacy already gone. His voters were not, mostly, the poorest; they were the ones who had watched their standing erode and their dignity be administered by people who regarded them with contempt, and they cast a ballot less for a program than against a priesthood.

To read these revolts as the irruption of pure malice, which is how the managerial class received them, is to miss the hard fact they registered. The inverse error is just as false, the picture of a virtuous people rising against a guilty class; these movements were shot through with nativism and falsehood, and the men who rode them were frequently charlatans who stoked the worst impulses of the crowd as deliberately as anything. A revolt can be the symptom of a real disease

3. Census Bureau, foreign-born population series; the Borjas–Card wage dispute.

and a danger in its own right at once, and these were both. But the symptom bore a diagnosis, and it was sound. The aspiring elites who could find no place, the workers whose towns had been written off, the citizens who had watched a financial catastrophe produce bonuses for its authors and austerity for its victims, were correct about the thing they were right about, which was that the people in charge had stopped being accountable to anyone but each other. To that diagnosis the revolts added a charge their critics seldom granted. The fuse lit on Liberty Island in 1965 had arrived. The foreign-born share of the population, which touched its measured low within five years of the act, stood by 2016 near the level last seen between 1890 and 1910, and whether the new arrivals had depressed native wages was a question the economists could not settle among themselves, Borjas finding harm where Card found nearly none. The case against the grievance deserves its full weight, that the country had simply returned to a proportion it had absorbed once before and prospered by. But a transformation of that size had been sold in 1965 as no change at all, and the voters never since consulted on it were entitled to notice the difference³ That the managerial elite could receive both results only as eruptions of irrational hatred is itself the deepest part of the diagnosis. A class that cannot conceive it has earned a revolt is one that has lost the machinery by which a society corrects its own course, and the loss of that capacity is among the surest signs that an order has entered the phase in which it can no longer reform itself and so must wait to be replaced.

What had made the revolt possible, and what was rewiring the shared world even as it conveyed the politics, was the device in every pocket, and its deepest effect was on the one thing a democracy cannot survive without. The platforms had learned that outrage traveled faster than agreement and that confirmation engaged more reliably than challenge, and so, in pursuit of the attention they sold, they sorted the public into sealed chambers, each inhabiting facts the others denied, until the very idea of a common world against which any claim could be checked began to dissolve. This was the century's founding philosophical premise arriving at its terminus. The German idealists had said that no mind touches reality raw, that each person constructs a world from a signal never seen directly; for two centuries a common culture, shared churches and schools and newspapers and a collective sense of what counted as a fact, had quietly supplied the common rendering that let a billion private constructions overlap enough to call themselves one world. The attention economy dissolved that shared rendering, and it did so for profit, because a population sorted into chambers of mutual outrage kept its gaze fixed longer than one that agreed, and the longer the capture lasted the thing being sold. What remained was the idealist premise stripped of the culture that had domesticated it, each person sovereign over a reality of his own, answerable to no fact shared in common, the liberating thought that we make our world curdled into a hall of mirrors in which every chamber was sincere and none could reach the others. A society cannot deliberate if it cannot agree on what is happening. By the decade's end the large

democracies could no longer reliably manage it. The precondition compounded the disease: a people already convinced its institutions lied to it will believe anything except them, and those bodies had spent the decade proving the suspicion sound.

What culture the sealed chambers still shared in common was made by no one and signed by no one. The meme, an image captioned, copied, and altered in each transmission, was the folk art of the feed, the woodcut of the new press, crude by design, authorless by nature, passed hand to hand the way the broadside ballad had once moved from fair to fair. For a few years in the decade's middle the form gripped the whole audience at once. There were calendars, made first as a joke on Tumblr in 2014, that assigned each month its meme the way an almanac gives each day its saint, and the assignment mostly stuck; a screenshot could be dated by its joke as a dig is read from its shards. The high moment came in May 2016, when a zoo in Cincinnati shot a gorilla named Harambe after a three-year-old fell into his enclosure, and the feed, for the rest of that strange electoral summer, staged a mourning whose sincerity could not be located. Candles were lit, petitions were signed by the tens of thousands, and a writer at the Washington Post observed that "the more intense and more sincere-seeming the expression of mourning is, the funnier the joke." The grief was a joke and the joke was in earnest, a public trained to perform feeling and no longer able to feel except in performance, the heart kept at the same distance the decade had learned to keep its wars. And then the common calendar broke up. Researchers measuring collective attention found the lifespan of a shared topic shrinking year on year, a top hashtag's tenure falling by a third between 2013 and 2016, and the joke that had reached everyone gave way to ten thousand jokes each legible to one chamber. By the decade's end nothing could be dated to a joke, because no joke any longer crossed the whole public; the last shared calendar had been made of jokes, and the device dissolved that too⁴

The same device that shattered the public world starved the private one. A civilization that had once located meaning in inherited religion, in nation, in family, in vocation, now invited each person to manufacture significance out of a curated performance, to be at once the protagonist and the brand and the small deity of a private universe measured in approval. It was a cult with a billion congregations of one, and beneath the flush of approval it was a starvation diet. The decade that perfected the technology of self-display registered, in its own mental-health statistics, a rising tide of anxiety and depression among the young and a deepening sense that nothing meant anything, an epidemic of meaninglessness that arrived precisely as the means of self-expression became infinite. This is the condition Lamar had built his album to resist and Knausgaard had excavated his thousands of pages to escape, the state the consultant farce had mocked and the staged-gift performance had embodied without irony. The art of the decade, at its best, was a series of attempts to locate a floor beneath a self that the feed had taught to perform without rest, and they were honest in proportion to their difficulty.

4. Cincinnati Zoo, May 28, 2016; Washington Post, August 16, 2016; Lorenz-Spreen et al., *Nature Communications* 10 (2019).

Where the starved attention actually went, the official culture did not see until the decade was nearly over, because it went to forms no institution had commissioned. The largest was a conversation. Joe Rogan, a comedian and cage-fight commentator with no credential a network would recognize, began in 2009 to record himself talking with one guest for three hours at a stretch, unedited, undirected, released as it ran. Against a media economy that had cut the public utterance to the seven-minute segment and the twenty-second clip, the sheer length was the counter-programming; the show offered the one commodity the attention market had liquidated, time, and by the decade's end it claimed nearly two hundred million downloads a month. The market priced the claim in the spring of 2020, when Spotify bought exclusive rights for a sum the Wall Street Journal reported above one hundred million dollars. The deeper channel ran underground. In June 2018 there appeared on Amazon's print-on-demand rail a book called *Bronze Age Mindset*, written under a pseudonym in a broken declamatory English that mocked the prose of the institutions it despised, preaching vitality, beauty, and contempt for the managed life to the young men the meaning shortage had bitten hardest. No publisher backed it, no journal noticed it, and it sold anyway, samizdat for the feed age, passed by screenshot and recommendation, until the Claremont Review of Books conceded in a long 2019 essay that it had gripped the rising right, and Politico reported, on anonymous sourcing, that the book circulated among the junior staff of the Trump White House. The author was unmasked in 2023 as Costin Alamariu, a Yale doctor of political science, and his 2015 dissertation on tyranny in the thought of Plato and Nietzsche, reissued that September as *Selective Breeding and the Birth of Philosophy*, climbed into Amazon's overall top twenty-five within days, a text written for seven readers outselling, for a moment, the whole catalog of the university presses. A civilization whose accredited critics annotated the prestige dramas while its sons read a pseudonymous Nietzschean tract on their phones was running two canons at once, an official one that had stopped persuading and a shadow one that no longer asked permission, and the gap between them was one more failure of the shared rendering, one more place where the map the institutions maintained and the territory beneath it had come apart⁵

Beneath all of it, woven through the decade as condition and not as event, ran the wars, and their defining quality was their remoteness, the way the order had learned to fight without the society feeling that it fought. The technique was the armed drone, which let a hegemon kill at the far end of the earth while the operator returned home to dinner, the war reduced to a feed of its own, watched on screens in trailers in the Nevada desert, the act made administrative and the dead made data. The years that learned to engineer attention discovered in the same stroke how to engineer distance, and the two were of a piece, both of them ways to convert a visceral human reality into a managed stream that the public need never feel. The wars themselves arrived as ambient noise rather than as rupture. A vegetable seller in the Tunisian interior set himself alight in the last days of 2010 after the police took his scale and his produce and slapped him before the

5. The Joe Rogan Experience, from December 2009; Wall Street Journal, May 2020; *Bronze Age Mindset*, June 2018; Claremont Review of Books, Summer 2019; Politico, August 23, 2019, and July 2023; *Selective Breeding and the Birth of Philosophy*, September 2023.

crowd, and the image of it traveled the Arab world through the same platforms that sold the morning's breakfast, and within a month a president of twenty-three years had fled and within two a ruler of thirty years was gone, the squares of Cairo and Tunis full of exactly the credentialed and unemployed young whose surplus had built across the prior years. But the open moment closed almost as fast as it had opened. Egypt's revolution delivered, through the only organized force available, a government the army overthrew within a year, and by 2013 a general presided over a repression that made the old one look gentle.

Libya did not merely fail to transition; it was dismantled, and the manner of it rewards a closer look than the official account gave it. Of the states the spring touched, Libya was the prosperous one. Its oil wealth was spread across a small population, its citizens drew the highest living standard on the African continent, and its central bank, unique among the world's monetary authorities, was wholly state-owned and kept tons of gold against no foreign master. Its ruler, Muammar Gaddafi, eccentric and brutal and forty-two years in power, had for years been advancing a proposal the order could not tolerate, a gold-backed pan-African money, a dinar of metal that would have let the oil and gas of a continent be priced and settled in something other than the dollar and the franc that had priced it since the colonies fell. A currency answerable to gold is one no central bank can inflate and no sanction can freeze, and a bloc of energy exporters settling trade in such a coin would have stood outside the circuit through which the dollar order recycles the surplus of the producing world back into its own debt. The proposal never reached the scale of a threat. The man who advanced it was removed before it could. In 2011 a coalition flying the banner of civilian protection bombed his forces from the air for seven months, and the shield became regime change in everything but name; he was run to ground in a drainage culvert and killed in the road by a mob that filmed it, and the prosperous state came apart into a decade of warring militias, open slave markets, and a coastline turned into the funnel through which the displaced of three continents pressed toward Europe. The hundred and forty-odd tons of gold the bank had stockpiled passed into the hands of factions and intermediaries and a good part of it was never publicly accounted for again. The intervention was narrated as a rescue and functioned as a foreclosure: a reserve-rich, debt-free, dollar-independent state that had floated an alternative monetary architecture was reduced to a stateless corridor, and the refugee flows it loosed fed the resentment the rest of the decade ran on. Whether the gold dinar was the reason for the war or one motive among several cannot be settled from the documents, but the man who proposed pricing energy outside the dollar is dead, the state that could have hosted the trial is gone, and the order that the experiment threatened is intact, and a reading that asks who moved and who gained does not find the official account of a humanitarian rescue sufficient to the weight of those facts.

Syria did not transition at all. What began in the spring of 2011 as crowds in provincial towns chanting for dignity, met by a regime that answered the first protests with rifle volleys and the

bodies of tortured children returned to their families, hardened within a year into a civil war that would prove the most ruinous conflict of the age. The government of Bashar al-Assad, an Alawite minority ruling a Sunni majority, chose survival at any price and got it by methods that emptied the dictionary of restraint: the siege that starved entire neighborhoods until the residents ate grass, the barrel bomb rolled out of a helicopter onto an apartment block, the industrial torture prisons whose photographed dead were smuggled out by the thousand, and, in August of 2013, the sarin gas loosed on the sleeping suburbs of Ghouta that killed hundreds of civilians in a single night and crossed a line an American president had named in public and then declined to enforce, a hesitation the whole watching world registered as the measure of the order's will. Into the vacuum poured every power with a stake. Iran sent its Revolutionary Guard and its Lebanese militia to prop the regime up; Russia sent its air force in 2015 to bomb the rebellion flat and, in doing so, announced its return as a power that would project strength where the Americans would not; the Gulf monarchies and Turkey armed the opposition. And the Americans armed fragments of it and bombed others, a war of all against all in which half a million died and twelve million were driven from their homes, the largest forced movement of human beings since the Second World War, the survivors washing up against the borders of a Europe already coming apart over its currency and feeding, by their arrival, the very politics of resentment that the decade was breeding everywhere at once.

The stake that drew every power in was not only the regime and the sect. It was the ground itself, and the ground was a corridor. Syria sits on the last overland stretch between the gas fields of the Gulf and the markets of Europe, and in the years before the war two rival pipelines competed to cross it. Qatar, which shares with Iran the largest gas field on earth, had pressed a line that would run north through Saudi Arabia and Jordan and Syria to the Turkish coast and into Europe, gas that would have undercut Russia's grip on the supply that heated the continent and pried open a market the Kremlin treated as its own. Assad declined it in favor of a rival route that would convey Iranian gas west through Iraq and Syria to the same sea, an axis binding Tehran to Damascus to the Mediterranean and keeping the flow inside the Russian-aligned bloc. The choice set the lines of the war that followed almost exactly: the Gulf monarchies and Turkey arming the side that would have hosted their pipe, Iran and Russia spending blood and treasure to defend the side that would have delivered theirs. The deeper logic runs beneath even that. The Iran-Iraq-Syria land bridge is the one overland passage that would let the energy of the inner continent reach the sea without crossing water the American fleet controls, and a route that delivers Gulf and Caspian gas to Europe by land is a corridor that escapes the choke points where the dollar order keeps its hand on the valve. A passage that would let the producing heart of Eurasia bypass the sea lanes is worth more to the incumbent order broken than whole, and Syria kept at a controlled chaos, neither pacified nor partitioned, left the bridge severed without anyone having to defend the severance as

policy. The war is not a malfunction of the order along that corridor; it is the order itself, keeping a rival route from opening.

Out of the eastern deserts of that war, and out of the wreckage the American invasion of Iraq had left a decade before, rose the thing that gave these years their purest image of eschatology as a material force. The movement that called itself the Islamic State swept across the Syrian-Iraqi frontier in 2014, took Mosul, a city of nearly two million, in days as the force trained and equipped by the Americans dissolved before it, and declared a caliphate, the literal end-times kingdom of a particular apocalyptic reading of Islam, a state founded on the conviction that the final battle was at hand. It recruited with grotesque fluency the same supply of unmoored young men the spring had mobilized and the deindustrialized West had discarded, offering them now not a republic but the end of the world, a part in which their lives acquired cosmic weight because the modern order had refused them any weight at all. And it understood the attention economy completely. It filmed its atrocities, the beheadings of captured journalists and aid workers staged in high definition against the desert, a downed pilot set alight in a cage, and it cut them and uploaded them for the same feed that sold the morning's coffee, knowing that horror traveled faster than anything and that the global broadcast of cruelty was itself the recruiting tool, that to be seen was to be powerful. The oldest end-times logic in the modern archive arrived dressed in the production values of the platform, and the promise of cosmic significance proved the most efficient recruiter of the surplus young that any order had ever found, because the modern world had built the audience and left the meaning empty. It took a coalition years, and Mosul and Raqqa reduced to rubble, to grind the caliphate back into the desert, and the human script it had run survived the territory's loss.

And in February of 2014, while the West watched the squares and the deserts, Russian forces with their insignia stripped away seized the Crimean peninsula from Ukraine, and within weeks Moscow annexed it outright, the first forcible redrawing of a European border since 1945.³ The same year Russian arms and Russian men, again denied, opened a war in the industrial east of Ukraine that would grind on for eight years. The West answered with sanctions and stern language and no force at all, because it had no intention of fighting and the man in Moscow had correctly judged as much. He had read the order's resolve and found it hollow, and he was right, and the proof of how completely would not arrive for eight more years. In seizing Crimea he judged the order's will exactly as the bond markets had judged the euro and the voters had judged their elites, and the verdict ran through the whole decade as a single discovery, that the guarantees were no longer believed by the people they were meant to bind, and that capability without conviction guarantees nothing.

The rising power in the east was the apparent answer to all of it, the candidate successor the whole decade assumed would inherit a world the old hegemon could no longer govern, and seen from the long view, that contender runs against the grain of every assumption made about it. China was treated, by its admirers and its alarmists alike, as a returning civilization, five thousand years of continuity gathering itself to resume a primacy interrupted by two unlucky centuries, an independent center of gravity that would soon set the terms the dollar order had set since 1944. The colder account is stranger. China in its modern form was not an independent civilization at all but a thing the dollar system built in its own image and then mistook for a rival, a replica the order had printed onto the far side of the Pacific, and a copy is more fragile than the original it depends on, because it has nothing of its own to fall back on when the original fails. The whole illusion lives in the mechanism. China's rise was an export machine, and machines of that kind earn dollars, since the goods it sold to America were priced and paid in dollars. Those dollars flowed into China by the river. A normal economy would have let them be converted into its own currency, which would have driven the renminbi up and the exports' prices with it, until the trade balanced and the surplus closed. China refused to let that happen. Its central bank stood in the path of the river and bought the dollars as fast as they arrived, paying for them with freshly printed renminbi, pinning its own currency artificially low so the exports stayed cheap and the machine kept running.

But that left the central bank sitting on an ocean of dollars it could not spend at home without flooding its own economy, and there was only one place on earth deep enough to park such a sum, the market for United States government debt. So the dollars came home. The surplus China earned by selling goods to America was lent straight back to the buyer through the Treasury bonds that financed America's deficits, which funded its consumption, which purchased the next shipment of Chinese wares. By the middle of the decade the reserves this circuit had piled up approached four trillion dollars, the largest hoard any state had ever assembled, perhaps seventy percent of it in dollar-denominated paper, and more than a trillion of it in Treasuries alone. The number was presented as China's strength, the leverage of a creditor over a debtor. Read coldly it is the opposite. A creditor whose entire wealth is denominated in the debtor's currency, and parked in its bonds, is not the debtor's master but its hostage, because the hoard can be inflated away by the debtor at will and cannot be moved without crashing its own value the instant it tries to leave. China had not built an alternative to the dollar system; it had assembled the largest single position inside it, and made itself the system's most committed bondholder precisely while imagining itself the heir. The second economy of the world was a hallucination of a hallucination, a fiat construct erected atop another, an export surplus recycled into the paper of the very power it was said to be replacing, and therefore not the rock on which a new order would be built but the most leveraged bet ever placed on the survival of the old one. The dollar is a fiction sustained by collective belief.

China is a fiction sustained by the dollar. And the thing twice removed from any anchor has the least beneath it when belief drains away.

By the decade's close the postwar order's architecture was still standing, and that was the whole of the matter: upright, and no longer believed in by anyone inside it. The alliances persisted, the institutions met, the dollar reigned, the markets levitated on central-bank support and made new highs into 2019 even as the real economies beneath them limped. But the consent that had animated the order was spent. The educated young had turned on the meritocracy that produced and betrayed them; the deindustrialized rounded on the elite that prospered through their decline; abroad, no rival pretended the rules still constrained it; and the power in the east that everyone took for the successor was the system's largest creditor and its most exposed dependent at once, laying the roadbed of a multipolar world while sitting on a trillion dollars of the incumbent's debt. A multipolar order was being born, visibly, and yet it had not arrived, for the old hegemon still possessed the reserve currency and the carrier fleets and the alliances and the deep habit of primacy, and its loudest rival was bound to it by the very wealth that rivalry was supposed to threaten. The decade ended in a strange suspension, the legitimacy spent and the successor not yet enthroned, the assurances that had once bound the world quietly voided while the forms that expressed them persisted.

What survived was not the order, which would shortly discover, in a market in a Chinese city almost no one outside the province could have named, how little slack it had left itself. What survived was the work that a few minds put down under the pressure of the decade. Lamar's album remains the most exact account anyone made of a self trying to remain whole under a machine built to fragment it, an object that still demands to be heard in sequence and rewards the demand. Knausgaard's six volumes are the era's most stubborn report of what was actually there when the performance was stripped away, the radical wager that the over-documented self was the last honest ground. *Better Call Saul* is the patient anatomy of how an order grinds a hopeful man into a corrupt one not by temptation but by attrition; *Succession* is the portrait of the men who owned the machines of attention and were ruined by them; both reached their audience through the very streaming infrastructure they diagnosed. *Phantom Thread* is the decade's most mature refusal of its own fantasy of greatness - the insistence that the price of the exceptional is paid mostly by the people around it and that this is a thing to be resisted rather than admired. The satires earned their place too: *Grand Theft Auto* and the consultant's farce as documents of a culture that had learned to enjoy what it disbelieved, and disbelieve what it enjoyed, and to find in cynical distance no escape but only a more comfortable seat. Even the spectacle of pure attention belongs in the archive as the honest endpoint, the place where the self disappeared entirely into the thing that measured it. The same long reading, extended to the horizon of a decade, sees only the rot; it is blind to the half-second in which a single mind seizes attention and is changed. That blindness is

where the work takes over as evidence. The order is still standing as the decade ends. Each refusal was a different posture against the same machine, and the machine absorbed all of them: that a society can be told its world is its own to construct, and can take the lesson, and can discover too late that a reality everyone constructs alone is a reality no one can share.

The late-stage knowledge economy laid bare the consequences of the system built in the postwar years. The Meritocracy as trauma-machine had finally broken its participants. Death by Meritocracy was visible in the burnout and ideological conformity of the elite, as institutions like Harvard fully embraced their role as an elite VC firm disguised as a university, mass-producing the insecure functionaries required by the tech monopolies. This was also the era that perfected 21st-century warfare. It was no longer a matter of massed armies but of population management: economic strangulation via sanctions, the weaponization of infrastructure, and the algorithmic exploitation of ethnic and political division.

2020 – Beyond

By 2025 the most consequential work on earth was being done by no one. The radiologist's read was confirmed by a system that had absorbed every paper ever published, and the partner signing the brief had not written it. Somewhere between two messages a line of code wired one company's billing to another company's inventory, drafted in the second the partner blinked. Sermons, board memos, condolence letters, customer-service exchanges that the customer never knew were not a person; the reviewer scanned each draft for the moment it took to confirm it sounded right, and the institution that received it could not test whether a mind had been present. The model did more than draft. It sat at the elbow, maintained context across a day's work, took the next step on its own, booked the meeting, paid the invoice, opened the support ticket and closed it before the human had logged in. A consciousness trained on the body of human deliberation could now perform deliberation faster than any human could check it, and where it was not yet trusted to act it sat one button away from acting. This was the terminus of a movement the previous century had set running. The image had become a commodity reproduced without limit; then the attention spent on it; then the intimacy paid for by subscription; and now the work itself, the deliberation the educated middle had been paid to perform, drafted at the scale of seconds. What the document had once promised, that a mind had thought it through, the synthetic paragraph quietly retired. Almost no one noticed. The eulogies were drafted by the model.

The decade these images saturated had opened with a stop. In the first months of 2020 a virus crossed from an animal reservoir into a human lung in central China, and within a single quarter it did what no rival power and no creed had managed in a hundred years: it stopped the world. The machine of global commerce, tuned over forty years to run with no slack at all, with inventories pared to nothing and supply chains stretched across a dozen borders, simply seized. Factories went dark. Shelves emptied of components no one had thought to stockpile, because inventory was waste, and waste had been engineered out of existence. Faced with a sudden stop that threatened to cascade from the shuttered shop to the unpaid landlord to the failing bank, the governments of the rich world reached for the only tool a financialized order had left itself. The United States Congress authorized fiscal transfers measured in the trillions; the Federal Reserve created money to buy not only government debt but corporate bonds, backstopping markets it had once left to fend for themselves; the European Central Bank did the same, and even the Germans agreed at last to issue debt in common. The cascade was halted. The depression the spring had seemed to promise did not arrive. What the rescue revealed, across the longer span, was that the guarantee at the center of the order had become very simple and very thin: when the next blow lands, the state will create whatever sum is required. Everyone now knew it. The knowledge was the new foundation, and it rested on confidence in nothing but the next intervention.

The stop loaded a second charge, and it went off before the rescue's bill was drafted. By late spring the conditions amounted to an experiment no committee would have dared propose: tens of millions idled by decree, rent and debt suspended in abeyance, school and stadium and church all shut, a generation sealed indoors with the feed for its only public square and a transfer payment standing in for a wage. Then, on the twenty-fifth of May, a Minneapolis policeman knelt on the neck of a Black man named George Floyd for more than nine minutes while Floyd died, asking to breathe. The autopsy found a lethal concentration of fentanyl in his bloodstream, a fact the prosecutors at the Chauvin trial conceded and the protesters mostly did not hear; a seventeen-year-old on the sidewalk filmed it. The decade that would drown in synthetic matter was detonated by a phone video. Within weeks the country produced what survey researchers estimated as the largest protest movement in its history, fifteen to twenty-six million participants by the polling, demonstrations in more than two thousand towns, the great majority of them peaceful, beside riot and arson that insurers would book as the costliest civil disorder in American history. The kindling had been stacked by the lockdown and the spark was filmed, and pent force does not store; it discharges along whatever channel stands open¹

The money arrived at a speed the causes of earlier decades never commanded. The Open Society Foundations announced two hundred and twenty million dollars for racial-justice organizations that July; America's largest public companies pledged sums an audit later tallied near fifty billion, nine-tenths of it loans and investments rather than gifts; the movement's flagship foundation disclosed ninety million raised in the single year. The flows are documented to the dollar. The two tempers of the era read them in character: one finds in the receipts a manufactured revolt, the other will not look at them at all, and both are wrong. The wave was real. Public anguish at the camera-recorded killing of a man does not require a check. And the standing interest got a wave it never planned and put it to work, tolerated the riot at the edge of the marches, fed it on occasion, let it frighten the middle and discredit the moderate claim, a thousand separate hands serving the arrangement without a meeting. Both are facts. The reader who finds one comforting needs the other²

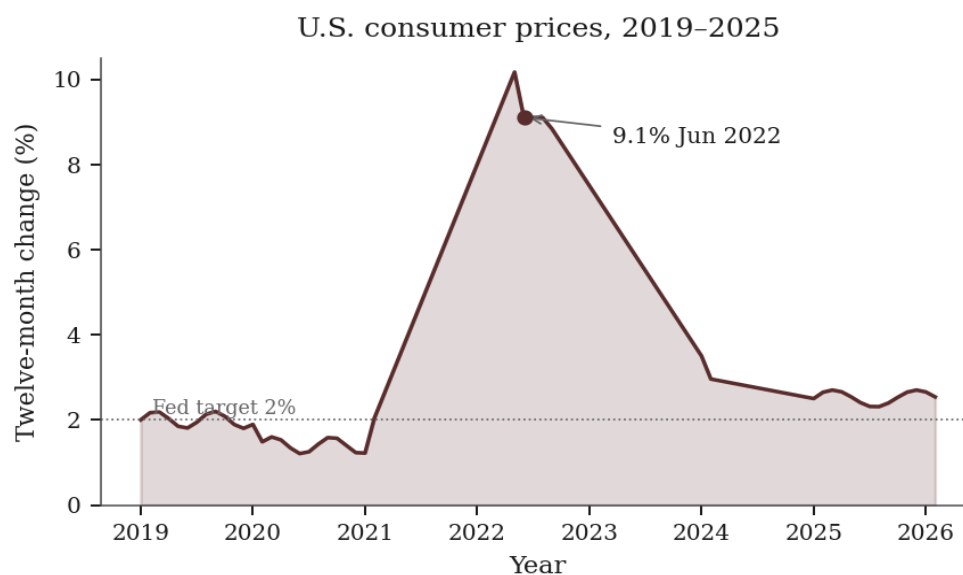
The mirror riot followed eight months later. On the sixth of January 2021 several thousand supporters of the defeated president, persuaded by him that the election had been stolen, broke into the Capitol while Congress counted the vote; five deaths attached to the day, about a hundred and forty officers were injured, and the count resumed that night under guard. It is the same event as the summer. A mass of the idled and the aggrieved, certain the order above them was rigged, assembled through the feed, discharged at a symbol, harvested afterward by every operator with a use for the footage, prosecuted by the thousand under one administration and pardoned wholesale by the next. Two revolts, each aimed vertically at an order it believed had cheated it, were converted within eight months into one horizontal war, each crowd instructed nightly that the other

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1. On the duration, the trial record in *State v. Chauvin* (2021); on the estimate, *New York Times*, July 3, 2020; on the insured losses, Property Claim Services, 2020.
 2. Open Society Foundations announcement, July 13, 2020; *Washington Post*, August 23, 2021; Associated Press, February 23, 2021.
 3. Department of Justice prosecution figures; District of Columbia chief medical examiner rulings; presidential proclamation of January 20, 2025.

was the true face of its dispossession. No ministry drafted the conversion, and none was needed. The century-old machinery for telling a public what to want had found its reverse gear, teaching two publics whom to blame; the platforms were paid in each side's rage at the other; the parties raised their funds on the spectacle of the opposing mob; and the same current that once preferred a red scarecrow to a winning labour movement ran the arrangement without a memo³ A public facing upward is a political problem; turned to face each other, the two halves are a market that needs no minister to keep them in motion.

The bill came due faster than the doctrine had promised. The economists who ran the response had assured the public that inflation was a defeated relic, that the link between the quantity of money and the level of prices had been severed decades earlier, and that they could create trillions with no consequence but the rescue itself. They were wrong. Prices, quiescent for a generation, began to climb in 2021, dismissed at first as transitory, a word that would haunt the officials who chose it, and then undeniable. By June of 2022 the American consumer price index stood 9.1 percent above the year before, the steepest twelve-month rise since 1981, a number that arrived like a forgotten god returning⁴ The central banks raised rates eventually, theatrically, to be seen fighting the very thing they had set loose. But the deeper policy was never to make money truly dear, never to let the real cost of borrowing rise to the level that would force a reckoning with a mountain of debt that could not be repaid and would not be defaulted on. Instead the debt was managed by the oldest method in the sovereign's book, and it has a name: financial repression. A government that owes far more than it can ever raise in taxes, and that will not default, has one quiet exit, which is to make sure the interest it pays on its debt stays below the rate at which prices rise. When a bond yields three percent and prices climb at nine, the lender is handed back money that buys less than what he lent, and the difference, year upon year, transfers real wealth from the holder of the debt to the issuer of it. The central bank pins the short rate down; the long rate is jawboned and, where necessary, bought; the saver is given no instrument that keeps pace; and the mountain of debt shrinks against the economy not because anyone repaid it but because the measuring stick was quietly shortened.

4. Bureau of Labor Statistics, CPI-U, twelve-month change, June 2022.



The bill arriving: U.S. consumer prices, twelve-month change, 2019–2025, peaking at 9.1 percent in June 2022. Source: Bureau of Labor Statistics.

This is a tax in every respect but the name. It was levied without a vote, landing hardest on the patient and the prudent, the pensioner and the wage earner who keep their wealth in cash and bonds, and falling not at all on the borrower who owes in the depreciating money or the owner of the assets the rescue had inflated. The class that owned the assets grew richer in the same season the holders of cash and wages grew poorer; that was the policy doing its work. The flows are documented in full. The official account preferred the language of an unfortunate supply shock, a transitory disturbance no one chose. The transfer was arithmetic, and the arithmetic ran in one direction.

Financial repression as a suppressed price: with the rate kept below the level that clears the market, the gap is a transfer from the lender to the borrower. Schematic.

Beside the repression the parallel money the prior chapter laid out kept developing. In January 2024 the Securities and Exchange Commission approved the spot exchange-traded funds the previous decade had said would never come; the holdings of the major American banks crossed lines no one would have priced when the white paper appeared. El Salvador's Nayib Bukele had made the asset legal tender in 2021. The Trump administration that took office in 2025 created, by executive order in March, a Strategic Bitcoin Reserve and designated the seized coin already in federal custody as the asset's foundational national reserve. The dollar's reserve role was being weaponized in one quarter and partially backstopped by a non-state asset in the next, the same hand making both moves.

A line can be drawn through these facts that the period leaves drawable rather than proved. The cryptographic primitives the design used were standards published by the National Security Agency. The early correspondents around the project included men trained in those same agencies, whose work on anonymous electronic cash had been an open file since the 1990s. The timing of the release, within weeks of the rescue that proved no government would ever let the system fall, was either fortuitous or designed. The shape of the asset that emerged, an unowned-looking hedge that nonetheless came to be owned in vast proportion by American institutions, is exactly the asset a state would build if it wanted an escape valve from a reserve currency it expected, eventually, to compromise. None of this rises to proof. It sits in the documents as the live suspicion of an intelligence-grade move, neither dismissed nor confirmed, and the order's behavior in 2025, embracing the asset it had spent a decade fearing, is consistent with both readings. What is documented is that the central bank's repression and the parallel money's rise traveled together, that the same political coalition that opposed the first welcomed the second, and that the dollar's neutrality was thinned in the same season that an alternative store of value was elevated to federal asset class.

The culture of these years tells one story under five names - attention, the common hearth, intimacy, the self, the picture of the real itself - the last unowned human capacities brought one after another onto the books by the same recursive system. The scenes that follow are not a miscellany of platforms and scandals; they are one mechanism finishing its work.

The art that grew most luxuriantly in this soil was not painting or the novel but the vertical video that played without being asked, looped without ending, and scrolled without bottom. The form had been latent in the photo-feed of the previous decade, but it reached its mature shape on TikTok, when the short video took over: a clip of a few seconds, shot vertically for the hand that gripped the phone, set to a fragment of a song, and delivered not by anyone the viewer had chosen to follow but by a recommendation engine that watched what caught the eye and fed it more of the same. The decisive formal fact is the autoplay loop and the infinite column beneath it. There is no end of the reel, as there was an end of the symphony and a last page of the novel and a closing montage of the film; the column refills itself faster than a thumb can exhaust it, and the work has no edge because a boundary would be a moment at which attention might be returned to its owner and spent elsewhere. The clip itself is not the product; the clip is the bait the product runs on.

The one work of art the era produced that understood this from the inside was made by a comedian alone in a guest house in Los Angeles in the spring of 2020, filming himself with a single camera while the country he could not leave watched the same feed he was about to indict. Bo Burnham had stopped performing live stand-up in 2016 after panic attacks began ambushing him on stage; he was thirty when the lockdowns began, had spent his teens uploading songs to

YouTube and his twenties trying to become something other than a person the camera had created, and during the long quarantine he set up lights and a piano in one rented room and wrote and shot and cut, by himself, the ninety-minute musical special he called *Inside*, released on Netflix on the thirtieth of May 2021. The picture is the feed turned inside out. He shoots himself in the same vertical close-up the algorithm rewards, performs songs whose subjects are the mechanism that made him, "Welcome to the Internet" and "That Funny Feeling" and "All Eyes on Me," and as the months in the room compound, his face thins, his beard lengthens, and the man on the screen begins to look at the camera as one might look at a captor one has stopped distinguishing from oneself. The closing song is performed to an empty room and a projected audience he has built out of light; he opens a door at the end and walks outside into a sun he flinches from, and the camera, still running, watches him try to get back in. The work documents the recognition that the apparatus the previous song was mocking is the same apparatus that built him, and he cannot exit it by mocking it. The feed had absorbed the critique of the feed, as the market had absorbed every prior critique of the market, and the artist's only remaining honesty was to document the absorption from inside the room where it was happening to him.

A working musician on the other side of the same period set the diagnosis in the simplest words anyone had given it, and her biography traces, in a female version, the same recluse-maker the manuscript has tracked across the period. Nika Roza Danilova was born in 1989 in Phoenix to a Russian-Ukrainian Jewish family whose grandparents had crossed in the postwar diaspora, raised from the age of two on a rural property near Merrill in north-central Wisconsin, an only child trained from eight years old in classical operatic voice by a teacher her parents drove her into Madison to study with. The training was severe; the property was wooded and remote; the child who emerged from that arrangement had a body trained as her primary instrument and the surrounding trees as her primary audience. She enrolled at the University of Wisconsin to study French and philosophy, started recording at sixteen on a four-track in her bedroom under the name Zola Jesus, a name assembled from Émile Zola and the figure of Christ, and uploaded the early tracks to MySpace at the moment the MySpace-to-blog-rock pipeline still functioned. The tracks reached the music blogs that mattered between roughly 2008 and 2011, the period when Pitchfork still anointed and Sacred Bones in Brooklyn still signed by hearing rather than by metric. *Stridulum II* in 2010 and *Conatus* in 2011 made her one of the recognizable voices of what the blogs that summer called witch-house and what was actually the last gasp of a discovery economy the streaming platforms were about to dismantle. She moved to Los Angeles after the second record. The migration followed the canonical script of the young American artist whose work has reached the audience that pays it, and the consequence followed the canonical script as well. The city is a manufacturing plant for the illusion the chapter has been treating, and a singer trained in opera from eight years old on a wooded property in Wisconsin had no defenses against what the

plant produced. By her own account the move broke her relation to her own work. The records released from Los Angeles bear the marks of the breakage. Taiga in 2014 was a louder and more polished record made for a larger room than the one she had been writing for; Okovi in 2017 was the record of a singer who had been close enough to several deaths to know what the breakage cost. In the same period she gave the interview the previous footnote cited, to the Pseudodoxology podcast in December 2021, in which she told the host that Christianity had been replaced with capitalism and consumerism, that the new religion was headquartered in places like Los Angeles where everything is about illusion, that she had moved back to Wisconsin to live in the woods because the alternative was the dissolution she was watching the city perform on the people around her. She set down on the same recording the line the prior section cited: that Ted Kaczynski's surrogate-activity diagnosis was correct as far as it went, that the alienation he had diagnosed was real, but that the typewriter and the manifesto and the bomb were the wrong instruments, that Kaczynski should have picked up a guitar, that the art form he refused was the channel through which the diagnosis could have been turned into something other than a body count. The line states the alternative more clearly than anything else the chapter cites, the alternative the recluse-maker pursues when she takes the diagnosis seriously and refuses both the institutional capture the city offers and the manifesto the bomb-maker writes.

What she actually did, beyond the line, is what the line points at. She returned to Wisconsin in 2017, settled on a wooded property of her own outside Madison, and built her practice around what she described in interviews as a Jungian shamanic frame, the working through of dreams and the archetypal material the chapter touched on earlier under the name of the registry the institutions could not enforce. She married, had a child, kept recording. Arkhon, released in May 2022 on Sacred Bones, was the record of a singer who had set the city down and was now writing from inside the woods rather than from the studio in Los Angeles she had used the woods to escape. She moved her business model in the same direction. The Spotify economy by the early 2020s paid an independent artist on the order of fractions of a cent per stream, and the streams flowed not to the singer's choice of which song to release but to the playlist a curator at the platform had decided to place her on, and the placement was unstable and undisclosed and revocable, the playlist itself a private editorial product the platform built for advertisers rather than for listeners or musicians. Danilova moved a meaningful share of her income onto Patreon, the subscription platform the previous decade had built for direct artist-to-listener payment, and structured the work around the audience that had decided to pay her directly rather than the audience the algorithm was willing to deliver. The migration registered her recognition that the apparatus would not pay her and that the only model still available was an updated form of what the previous century had called patronage, equipped now with the rough equivalent of a subscription. The patronage was diffused across thousands of small donors instead of concentrated

in a single court, and the difference matters less than the shared structure: an artist makes work, a particular audience pays directly, no platform sits in between to extract the value the work produces.

She is the figure the manuscript has been tracking since Turner, in a contemporary form the previous chapters could not have anticipated. Turner painted the storm from inside the boat his orders had lashed him to. Cézanne painted the mountain until the seeing went where the seeing went. Basquiat crowned the black name the market would not crown and was crowned in turn and disposed of. Danilova sings the line the order had no use for, refuses the institutional capture the order offered her in Los Angeles, returns to the periphery where the maker has always returned when the center has nothing left to give, produces the testimony the order cannot produce on its own behalf. The pattern is not new. What is new is the form the maker now operates in, the Spotify economy the recluse must route around and the Patreon subscription she must build to fund the rerouting, the woods of north Wisconsin that have to be at least an hour from any city for the practice to take. The recluse-maker is not the figure the platform wants. The platform wants the figure whose work is interchangeable with the surrounding feed and whose attention is fungible with every other unit of attention being auctioned. The recluse-maker produces work the platform cannot interchange and an attention the platform cannot bid for, and the platform's response is to demote her in the ranking and let her find her own audience by the side door. Patreon serves as that side door. The mechanism is older than the name; the medium changes and the practice continues.

She gives the chapter its female specimen of the contemporary recluse-maker. Burnham gives it the male. They are not parallel. Burnham is suburban and urban, Massachusetts and Los Angeles, the camera and the keyboard, the man who came up through the YouTube algorithm and processed the algorithm by performing inside its frame. Danilova is rural and northern, Wisconsin and the woods, the operatic voice and the synthesizer, the woman who came up through the blogs and processed the platforms by walking away from the city the platforms had drawn her into. Burnham delivers his diagnosis by turning the feed on itself in a guest house in Los Angeles. Danilova delivers hers by renouncing the city for the property in Merrill where the practice had originally been formed. Both testify to the same condition. Both document, in their respective forms, what a maker does under the load of the present order when she has understood that the institutional offers do not lead to the practice and has decided that the practice will be kept. The pair gives the chapter two specimens of the same diagnosis, set down in different keys by different bodies, the male specimen alone in a rented room and the female specimen alone in a remote property she returned to after the city had taught her what the city teaches.

The product is the viewer's attention, measured to the second, auctioned to advertisers in the interval it takes the next clip to load, so that the human nervous system was now the raw material

of the largest businesses on the planet and the feed became the most efficient machine ever built to convert biological capacity into revenue. The 1920s technique was now reflexive: the platform did not merely manufacture a desire, it measured the response in real time, adjusted, and fed the measurement back into the next delivery, a self-correcting circuit running billions of times a day. The mind half understood what was happening to it. The word doomscroll entered the language; the users described the feed as something done to them rather than by them, and went on doing it, which is the shape of an ideology that works. They knew very well what the machine was, and they swiped anyway.

What the feed displaced was the hearth, the gathered single audience that the last chapter watched the stream break open. That order reached its last great statement and its close in the same spring. Succession closed its run on the twenty-eighth of May 2023, the prestige serial completing its arc as the very business it dramatized was being dismantled⁵ The studios were retreating from the streaming war they had entered to overthrow the networks and could not afford to win. The same month Netflix abandoned the growth gospel and began enforcing its passwords, having spent a decade letting the base swell unmonetized and now demanding that every viewer pay; the rest of the industry copied the turn inside a year. The era of expansion was over, and the era of extraction had begun. MrBeast, whose method the prior chapter laid out, kept compounding into the early 2020s; by 11 June 2024 his channel passed T-Series to become the most-subscribed on earth, with the audience approaching half a billion⁶ The hearth had not gone dark. It had shattered into a hundred million private screens, each tuned to something no one else was watching; a divided audience is one that can be measured a nervous system at a time and sold one impression at a time.

OnlyFans, the subscription machine the last chapter introduced, found its detonator when the pandemic shut the world indoors in 2020. Signups rose by three-quarters in a single month; the headlines from that August did the platform's marketing for it⁷ What was new about the 2020s was the inversion. The performer was no longer selling a fantasy at a remove, as the centerfold and the film once had; she was offering the appearance of a private relationship, a direct message, a personalized clip, the sensation of access to a particular person; the buyer paid not for sex in the old sense but for the feeling of being chosen by someone whose attention was, in fact, a metered industrial product delivered to thousands at once. Attention had become the reserve asset of the whole economy. Here it took its most intimate form, attention sold as intimacy, the last unmonetized human capacity brought onto the books.

Under the new respectability surfaced in the matter the era could not stop returning to, and it belongs in this sequence because it sits at the bottom of the same gradient: what the feed sold by the impression and OnlyFans sold by the subscription, access to a person, a trafficking ring had sold whole, to men who believed themselves beyond consequence. Jeffrey Epstein had died in his

5. Succession, HBO, 2018–2023.

6. June 2024, YouTube platform rankings.

7. August 2020; contemporaneous press reports of roughly one million dollars in first-day revenue.

federal cell in 2019 with the questions open; Ghislaine Maxwell was convicted at the end of 2021 and sentenced the following summer to twenty years;⁸ the documents kept coming, unsealed in batches across the decade, and in November 2025 a transparency act forced the release of millions of pages,⁹ the matter refusing to close because it touched the thing the order most needed not to examine, the continuity between the open market in attention and intimacy and the closed trade in bodies that the powerful had run all along. What demands explanation is not only what the pages contained but why they had been sealed so long. A financier whose fortune no honest account of money management ever explained had moved for decades among presidents and princes and the chairs of laboratories and banks, and when his network was at last broken the records of it were sealed, redacted, lost, slow-walked through the courts, the daytime release of the earlier prosecution mirrored at the end in years of official reluctance to let the public see whose names the files contained. Silence on that scale registers the presence of an interest in keeping silent, not the absence of one to begin with.

The machine had protected itself in life by being everywhere, and it protected itself in death the same way: the parties who stood to lose from disclosure were the same people positioned to delay it, in the prosecutors who declined to charge and the agencies that claimed an equity in the secrecy and the eminent men who appeared in the documents and preferred they stay shut. To point to who profited from the silence is not to name a single hand that authored it; the protection was distributed across everyone the exposure threatened, which is exactly how a thing too widely useful to too many gets buried without a meeting being called. The culture's compulsive return to the Epstein files was the repressed coming back in the clinical sense, the order made to look at what its own logic produced when the colonization of the body met no limit at all.

The sequence had one more station before the picture of the real, and it was the self. The era did not invent the question; it inherited and accelerated it. In 1965 the Supreme Court had drawn a zone of privacy around the person, an interior the state could not enter; ten years later Tom Wolfe watched the interior become a project and named the builders the Me Decade. The feed then made the project a public work, the self as account, curated, performed, metered, revised in each release like any other product on the platform¹⁰ What the era added was the question underneath: who ratifies a self? For most of written history the answer had been given at birth, by family and parish and the state's certificate, and nothing in it sat deeper than sex. The transgender movement moved the seat of ratification from the birth certificate to the person, the declaration as the founding act, the institutions asked to recognize what the self announced. The claim traveled at a speed no prior revision of status had approached. In June 2014 *TIME* put the actress Laverne Cox on its cover above the words "The Transgender Tipping Point"; six years and six days later the Supreme Court ruled, through its most textualist justice, that a statute of 1964 had protected the announcement all along, because to fire a person for being transgender is to fire them for their sex¹¹ The

10. *Griswold v. Connecticut*, 381 U.S. 479 (1965); Tom Wolfe, "The 'Me' Decade and the Third Great Awakening," *New York*, August 23, 1976.

11. *TIME*, June 9, 2014; *Bostock v. Clayton County*, 590 U.S. 644 (2020).

12. The Cass Review, final report, April 2024; Swedish National Board of Health and Welfare, 2022.

countercurrent had its founding incident two years before the ruling. On the twenty-seventh of September 2016 the Toronto clinical psychologist Jordan Peterson uploaded a twenty-one-minute video to YouTube announcing he would refuse to use the gender-neutral pronouns his students requested and would not comply with the Canadian bill C-16, which proposed to add gender identity to the federal human-rights code as a protected characteristic. The video, a man in a brown jacket at his desk arguing about compelled speech, drew more than five million views in its first months and made Peterson, until that fall a clinician known mostly to his colleagues for a 1999 textbook called *Maps of Meaning*, the most recognizable opponent of the new ratification on earth. His 2018 book *12 Rules for Life* sold past ten million copies; his lecture tour filled theatres in twenty countries; the second book, *Beyond Order*, sold past five million more. He collapsed in 2019 onto a benzodiazepine dependence prescribed during his wife's cancer treatment, was hospitalized in Moscow into a medical coma, emerged hoarse, gaunt, and undimmed, and resumed the tour. The notoriety measured the constituency the change had failed to bring along, a public that read the pronoun request as compelled speech and the testosterone supplement and the Russian rehab and the lecture tour as a single phenomenon, the public elder of every man who felt the registry was being moved without his vote. Both currents deserve their full strength, and both run cold here. One reads the arc as the liberal motion this book has tracked in money completing itself in the person: authority over what a thing is moving from metal to declaration, from the certificate to the spoken claim, conscience seated as the final registrar. The other reads a category the species had treated as observed fact reclassified as self-report, notes that the empirical disputes underneath it, the steep rise in adolescent referrals and the European retreats from early medical transition, are contested and marked so, and asks what else in the registry yields once sex has yielded¹² On the book's Kantian floor a thing is real in society when enough minds behave as though it is; the fiat dollar rests on no other foundation, and every broken parity in this history fell on no other. Which this is, the reading cannot say, and does not. The fight was never over a pronoun. It was over the registry: what it records, and who wields the pen.

Into this attention economy at its terminus came the synthetic stack, and it changed the relation between the made thing and the real more completely than any technology since the camera. The tools arrived in a single season and broadened without pause. A research lab released a model in the spring of 2022 that turned a typed sentence into an image; an open-source version followed in the summer, free for anyone to run and retrain; at the end of November a conversational model reached the public and within two months had drawn more users than almost any product in history¹³ The next models reasoned in steps and showed the work. The next ones maintained context across a day and took actions on their own; the ones after that wrote production code, conducted research at the level of a competent graduate student, and sustained conversations with the patience of an analyst paid to listen. Within three years the machine that made images had

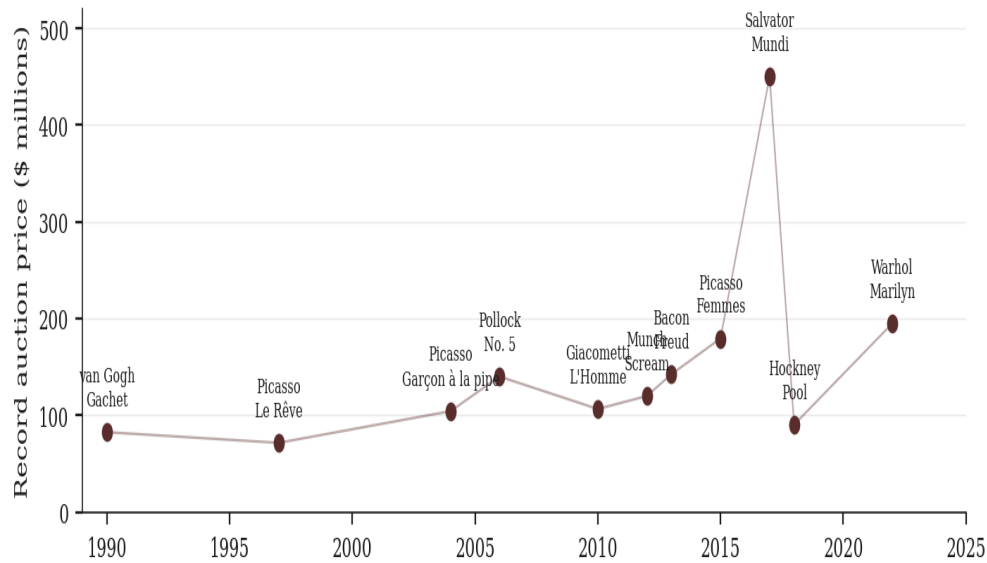
13. ChatGPT, released November 30, 2022; UBS/Similarweb estimate of one hundred million monthly users by January 2023.

14. Merriam-Webster, Word of the Year 2025, announced December 15, 2025.

learned to make moving ones, and a video that resembled documentary footage of an event that had not occurred could be produced from a prompt as easily as a paragraph. By 2026 a voice cloned from thirty seconds of a target's speech was indistinguishable from the original; a model could read a clinical record, draft a treatment plan, and book the appointment; an autonomous coder could close a backlog of tickets while a small team slept. An agent could file the brief, file the response, and negotiate the settlement, signed off by a partner who reviewed the line items the same way he reviewed the bill. The cultural consequence was named before it was understood. The word slop entered the lexicon for the lowest grade of synthetic matter that now flooded every channel, and at the close of 2025 Merriam-Webster made it the word of the year, defining it as low-quality digital content produced in quantity by machine¹⁴ By then more than half of the text on the open internet was no longer written by a human hand. The dead-internet suspicion, once a fringe idea that the web had quietly filled with bots and machines talking to one another, hardened into a fair description of the daytime condition of the network. (The exact synthetic share is an estimate and its method is disputed; that synthetic matter rose sharply to cultural dominance in these years is not.)

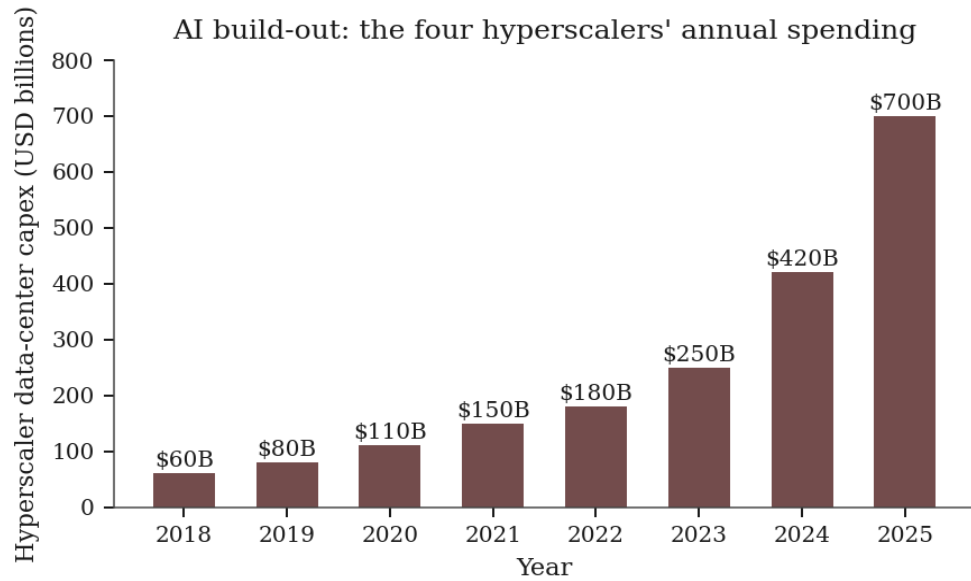
Read for its form rather than its content, the synthetic stack is the place where three of the long century's deepest threads converge and break. It severs authorship: the document has a prompter but no maker, a sequence of words that conjured it and no hand that drafted it, so the question the whole modern era had asked of any made thing, who made this and what did they see, no longer has an answer. It dissolves the index: the photograph's claim, that the light of a real thing once struck a real surface, is what the synthetic image cannot make and does not need, and the same severance runs through the brief and the diagnosis and the strategy paper, none of which any longer rest on a particular mind having weighed a particular fact. And it fractures the shared picture of the real on which a fiat order, in the end, depends. The metaphysical floor under the whole modern era stands fully exposed here. Kant's old limit, that no mind reaches the thing in itself but only the version its own categories construct, had long underwritten the argument that the great collective objects, the nation and the market and money and the future, exist only as shared fictions, real in the one way that finally counts, which is that enough people behave as though they were real. Across the 2010s the German idealist's claim received its modern neuroscientific completion in the work of the British physician Karl Friston, who had begun in the 1990s as a clinician applying statistical methods to functional brain imaging at the Wellcome Centre in London and who became, by a measure citation indexes compile, the most cited neuroscientist alive. Friston argued that any system that persists in a changing environment must, by physical necessity, maintain a model of that environment and act to keep its sensory states inside a narrow range the model predicts. The brain, on his account, is not a passive receiver of the world but a prediction engine. It generates the world it expects, tests the generation against incoming signal,

updates the model where the signal disagrees, and acts on the world to bring the signal closer to what was predicted. Perception is controlled hallucination corrected against the data. Action is that hallucination steering the data toward the prediction. The framework Friston named the free energy principle in 2006 and developed across the next two decades into the active inference formalism gave Kant's two-hundred-year-old limit a mathematical form, with the same conclusion turned the other way around: no mind reaches the world directly, because the mind that reached it would not survive the contact. The model is what stays alive. Every collective object, the nation and the dollar and the future, is the same construction at scale, a shared model maintained because its maintenance keeps the larger body, the society, predictively coupled to its environment. When the model breaks, the body that depended on it does, and what looked permanent gives way in a season. The machine industrializes the construction of those models and pours them into every eye and every inbox at the speed of a scroll, the generative engine of the brain now externalized into the data center and run, for the first time, faster than the brains the engine was originally inferred from. When any picture might be fabricated, two things follow at once and pull against each other. The false thing can wear the face of evidence, so a leader's voice or a massacre or a flood can be manufactured whole. And the true thing loses its privilege, so that a genuine atrocity caught on a real camera can be waved away as one more fabrication, the liar's dividend, the corrosion not of any single fact but of the very category of the witness on which the previous century had leaned to know what was happening in the world. The same corrosion now runs through the credential, where the work that earned a license has been spun out of any particular practitioner. That this corrosion is useful, and serves whoever already wields power, is not incidental to it. A public that can no longer tell the made image from the recorded one, or the practiced brief from the prompted one, is a population that cannot be shown a thing and made to believe it, and the institutions that once feared the camera, the state that dreaded the war photograph and the executive that feared the leaked tape, are released by the synthetic stack from the discipline of the visible. The artwork here is not a painting that comments on the condition. It is the condition. The medium itself became the ideology made visible: an order of pure circulation, the soup cans of the silkscreen multiplied past any anchor in the hand, now run past any mooring in the world.

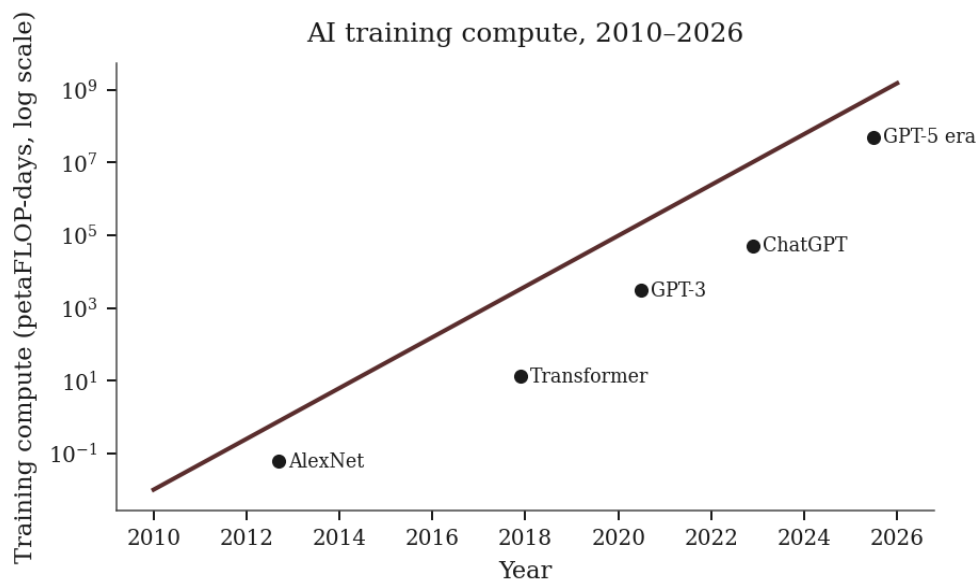


Record auction prices for single works, 1990–2022: the asset class the synthetic image rendered most legible. Source: Christie's, Sotheby's, public auction records.

The same engine, read from the other side, handed out instruments. By the middle of the decade a teenager's bedroom contained what a studio had housed a generation earlier: an orchestra that would play any line a voice could hum, a render farm rented by the hour, a cutting room in a laptop, the whole capital plant of the audiovisual age collapsed onto a desk. Every earlier fall in the price of the means had run the same course, the paperback and the cassette and the Bronx turntable each loosing a flood of dreck with the makers swimming inside it; the new flood was the largest by orders of magnitude. A century after a waifs'-home cornetist announced in twelve unaccompanied seconds that the formal mastery of the age lived wherever it chose to live, the address became literal; mastery could now choose any bedroom on earth, and the apprenticeship that had priced it, the conservatory, the studio system, the label advance, lost its gate. The poison was the same substance at the other dose. The engine that hands the teenager an orchestra drowns the result in an ocean of its own making, and when anyone can produce anything the scarce good moves from production to discovery, which the feed already owns; the new maker is freed from every expense but the one that decides, the cost of being found. What comes of it no reading can call. The machine supplies everything but the life, and the cadenza took the life.



Hyperscaler data-center capital expenditure, 2018–2025: the build-out at scale. Source: company filings.



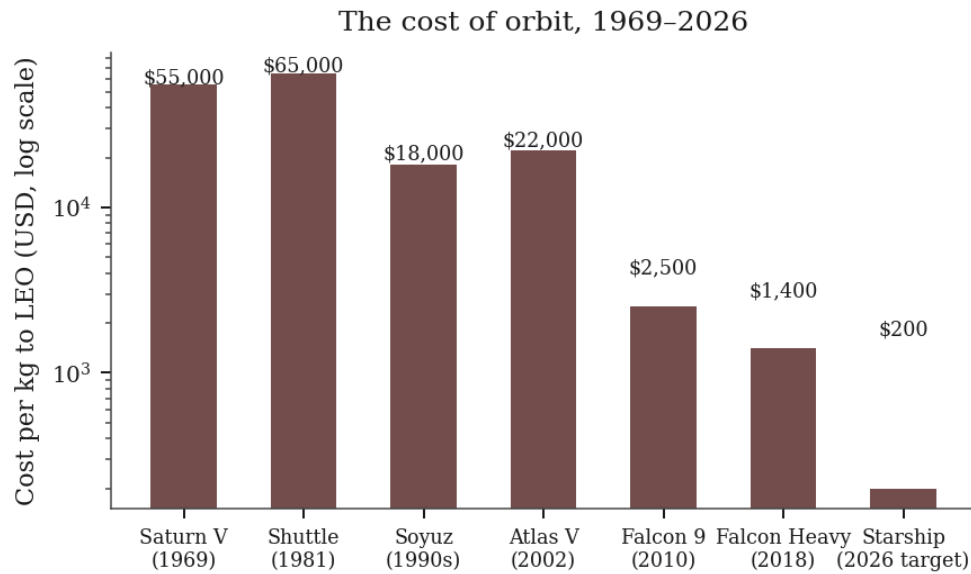
AI training compute, 2010–2026: the exponential the build-out chases. Source: Epoch AI parameter database.

Beneath the inflation and the synthetic flood ran the largest concentration of capital the order had ever assembled, and it ran on the conviction that a created mind capable of more than its makers was about to arrive. The same models that drafted the brief and the diagnosis were the consumer edge of an infrastructure build-out without precedent. Sums that exceeded the gross product of nations poured into a handful of firms, into data centers that drank electricity by the gigawatt and into chips that cost more than aircraft, on the wager that whoever built the thinking

machine first would gain a lever over everything that came after. By 2025 one venture proposed to spend half a trillion dollars on data centers over four years; the largest cloud and chip firms collectively committed hundreds of billions in a single year, the bulk of it aimed at the new machines; and a chipmaker that had once sold graphics cards to gamers crossed five trillion dollars in market value to become, briefly, the most valuable company on earth. Power concentrated into fewer hands than at any time since the trusts of the first Gilded Age. The men who commanded that capital increasingly spoke in the cadence of last things, of an imminent intelligence that would either deliver a final abundance or extinguish the species. The investment that funded it was, by any classical measure, the spending of a society that had largely stopped building everything else, the optimized rail of a financialized order narrowing its remaining surplus onto one bet. The optimized system is the brittle one, and the optimization had selected one wager as the future of every other.

This was a secular eschatology with its own prophets and its own schismatics, its own doctrine of a threshold past which the future could not be foreseen, and it worked exactly as the older end-times creeds had: a coordination script that organized belief and capital the way the older ones had organized armies and crusades. The prophecy did the work whether or not it was true, and the men who preached it stood to gain precisely in proportion to how completely others believed it. A founder who could persuade the market that a created reason was months away could raise sums no ordinary business plan would ever justify, and the threshold beyond which nothing can be foreseen is a convenient place to plant one's flag when the question of returns is pressed, because it converts the absence of profit into evidence of imminence and recasts every empty quarter as the calm before transfiguration. The believers were sincere, and their sincerity moved the capital; the same prophecy was, for the men positioned to sell the picks and shovels of the new rush, the most effective instrument for raising money ever devised, and both of these are true at once, which is the shape of a faith that also enriches its preachers. Money had been the era's first manufactured god, divine by omnipresence, the one thing present in every exchange on earth; the machine was being assembled into a second, divine by omniscience, every database merged toward a single eye; and much of the decade's elite politics, read closely, was a war of succession between the two priesthoods, contending for the same believers and the same tithe. The doom magnitudes that the AI prophets sell are temperament. The doom magnitudes that their schismatic doomers sell are the same temperament with a different sponsor. The capital they jointly mobilized is not. An end-times logic, sold by the parties it made rich, drove the largest deployment of investment in the history of capitalism. The audit will be done by the next decade. On the books today: the magnitude of the sums, the concentration of the hands, and the eschatological conviction marketed in every direction at once.

Inside the same concentration of capital one man's holdings reached the round number the modern era had not yet had a noun for. On the twelfth of June 2026 the rocket company he had founded a generation earlier listed on the public markets, and the offering pushed his fortune past a trillion dollars, the first individual in history to cross the line and a milestone the language had to invent a word for. The same week his rockets were catching themselves out of the sky, the booster returning to the launch tower on jets of fire and being received by a pair of mechanical arms the engineers called chopsticks, a maneuver the previous century would have written into science fiction and that television now broadcast as routine. The cost of a kilogram to orbit fell faster than any number in the aerospace series. He moved openly toward Mars, and named the goal in the language a believer uses for a kingdom rather than a quarter: a settlement on the rust-red dust, a multiplanet species, humanity launched at last into the stars. The frame worked exactly as the build-out's other eschatologies worked, as a coordination script that organized vast capital and human labor around an event no investor could underwrite as a return, and it pointed in the opposite direction from the doom magnitudes of the AI prophets, toward survival and outward rather than transfiguration or extinction. An end state declared in advance, a believer whose conviction moves the capital, a flow of investment unjustifiable by classical accounting and therefore justifiable only by the prophecy. The Mars frame is sincere in the founder and useful for the firm, and both are true at once, which is the shape of a faith that also enriches its preacher. What divides this case from the slop is what the believer caught coming back: the rocket on the arm, the metal returning from the sky, the demonstration that capital and conviction joined to a hard problem still yield the physical answer. The colony on the rust-red dust may be reached or may stand as a beautiful, unfinished marker of where one impulse had been. On the books today: the catch, the trillion, the man who turned the prospectus toward the stars. Two days earlier, in Barcelona, a pope had blessed the central spire of another project on the same scale of ambition and on the opposite economic principle, and the epilogue will return to it.



Cost per kg to LEO, 1969–2026: the price of orbit, log scale. Source: NASA, Aerospace Corporation, SpaceX.

While the West discovered that its money was not free, the borderland it had spent thirty years enriching tested whether the order's guarantees were real. Russian columns crossed into Ukraine from the north, the east, and the south on the twenty-fourth of February 2022, and great-power war returned to the European continent for the first time since 1945. The cause sat upstream of the front, in three decades of contest over whether the country belonged to the Western orbit or the Russian one, and the consequence ran downstream into the monetary order itself; but the war between was real and long. The invasion was a wager on mass and armor against a thing harder to measure, the will of a people who understood the matter as existential in the way the survivors of the long century have always known the things they will not surrender. The opening gamble was a decapitation: a column of tanks and fuel trucks more than forty miles long drove for the capital in the first week, and a planeborne assault tried to seize the airfield at Hostomel on the northern edge of Kyiv as a bridge for the troops meant to take the city in days. Both failed. The airfield was contested and denied; the column stalled on a single highway, out of diesel and out of plan, strafed from the treeline by small teams with shoulder-fired missiles the West had shipped by the thousand, and by the end of March the force that was to have taken Kyiv withdrew from the north of the country altogether. The war moved east and south and became something the planners had not war-gamed. Through the autumn of 2022 the Ukrainians ran two counteroffensives at once, a feint in the south that drew the Russian reserves toward Kherson and then a sudden thrust in the northeast that collapsed a thinly defended line and retook the Kharkiv region in a matter of days; Kherson city fell back into Ukrainian hands in November.

Then the open warfare closed into the kind the long century had seen before, the war of position and attrition in which two armies bleed each other along a static line and yards are paid for in the dead. The small mining town of Bakhmut became its emblem, fought over for most of a year and reduced to rubble before it fell to Russian assault forces in May 2023 at a cost on both sides that no objective could justify by the arithmetic of ground. The Ukrainian counteroffensive that the West had armed and awaited that summer broke against minefields and layered defenses and gained almost nothing; Avdiivka fell the following February; and the front congealed into a grinding stalemate in which resolve tested capability month after month, because attrition is the measure of who will keep bleeding when neither side can break the other and neither will stop. The Western response is the part that changed the monetary world, and it did so in a way that cannot be undone. The United States and its allies froze roughly three hundred billion dollars of the Russian central bank's reserves,¹⁵ the most aggressive use of the world's reserve currency as a weapon ever attempted. The act demonstrated American power and in the same stroke taught every rival a permanent lesson, one that organizes the monetary future as surely as Bretton Woods organized the past: reserves denominated in dollars are not property but a privilege the issuer may revoke, and money parked in New York can be turned off like a tap. The world's central banks saw the mechanism instantly. A foreign government does not keep its dollar reserves as paper in a vault; it keeps them as entries on the books of the Federal Reserve and of the great Western banks, and as holdings of United States Treasury debt routed through that same plumbing. The dollars exist only as long as the institutions that record them agree to say so. To freeze the reserves was simply to instruct that plumbing to stop honoring one owner's claims, and the speed of it, the totality of it, proved that the world's premier store of value was at every moment hostage to the politics of the country that issued it. The promise that had underwritten the post-war order, that dollars were neutral, that money parked in New York was simply currency rather than an American claim, was spent to win a sanctions war and could not be unspent. The movement that followed was the rational answer of every state that does not wish to be the next one switched off: rivals settling more trade in their own currencies, central banks the world over adding gold at a pace not seen in half a century, a patient search for payment rails that run outside Washington's reach. The financial rail was not the only one weaponized that season. In September of 2022 the two Nord Stream pipelines that conveyed Russian gas under the Baltic to Germany were ruptured by underwater charges, four breaches across both lines, and the cheap energy that had powered German industry for a generation stopped at the seabed. Who placed the charges the official inquiries have not made public. What the severance accomplished is not in doubt. Europe, cut off from the pipeline gas it had been told for years it could not safely depend on, turned to liquefied natural gas shipped across the Atlantic at several times the price, much of it American, loaded at American terminals onto tankers and sold into a continent that no longer had the cheaper option. The energy rail and the financial rail were severed in the same season and toward the same end. A Europe bound to

costlier, dollar-priced, seaborne supply that crossed lanes the American fleet patrols was a Europe drawn tighter into the order the reserve freeze had just revealed, its industrial base made dependent on the very power whose money it could no longer treat as neutral. The dollar remained, by an enormous margin, the currency the world reached for in fear, and the migration is slow because there is nowhere yet to go. But its neutrality, the very quality that had made it the reserve of the whole earth rather than merely a strong currency among others, was converted in a single season into a weapon, and a weapon is wielded by someone and aimed at someone. The actor who fired it gained the war it was meant to win and, in the same motion, began to dismantle the foundation its own primacy stood on, which is the recurring predicament of a power that finds it must spend its credibility to enforce its will.

A second front opened where the rivalry of the great powers met the oldest material in the long century. On the seventh of October 2023 the long, frozen wound of the eastern Mediterranean tore open. Fighters broke out of Gaza through the fence at dawn, by truck and motorcycle and powered glider, and fell on the towns and the army posts and a music festival in the desert nearby; roughly twelve hundred people in Israel were killed, most of them civilians, whole families among them, and some two hundred and fifty were dragged back into the tunnels of Gaza as hostages, the deadliest day for Jews since the Nazi genocide and a wound that the Israeli state experienced as a second existential proof. The response was a siege and an invasion of the strip whose scale answered the shock that loosed it. Israel cut the water and the power and the fuel, ordered the north evacuated, and sent its armor and infantry into the densest urban terrain on earth, fighting street by street above a hundreds-of-miles network of tunnels while bombing from the air on a scale that flattened much of the territory's housing. Nearly the whole population of more than two million was driven from their homes, herded south and then further down into shrinking zones, and the war spread outward as Israel struck the Hezbollah leadership in Lebanon, traded direct missile salvos with Iran for the first time in the open, and pressed on while a generation of children grew up under the drones. By late 2025 the dead in Gaza numbered, on the figures of the territory's health ministry that the Israeli military itself came to accept in broad outline, more than sixty-seven thousand, a majority of them women and children, amid mass displacement and the famine conditions that United Nations bodies and a widening body of legal opinion described in the gravest terms. South Africa brought a case before the International Court of Justice in December 2023 alleging breaches of the Genocide Convention; the court ordered provisional measures in January 2024; the matter, as of 2026, was undecided, with full hearings expected only years out. A ceasefire took effect, and broke, and was negotiated again, and the hostages were released and exchanged in stages while the killing paused and resumed. The exact death figures and the legal characterization a court will finally render are contested. What the war was for, and whom its long continuation served, is not.

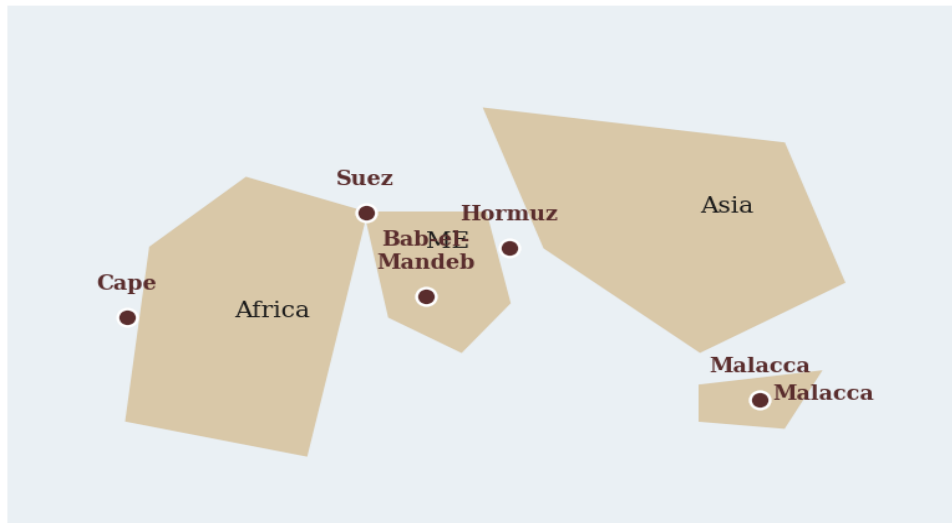
Several of the actors in this contest operated on scripts of last things rather than on a calculus of advantage, and a party that reads its situation as cosmically final will refuse every off-ramp a rational-preference model swears it must take. A messianic religious-Zionist current had become decisive in Israeli governance, its settlers and its ministers treating the land as a promise from God rather than as territory to be traded for peace; an apocalyptic strand ran through the Iranian state and the proxy network it armed and funded across four borders, a doctrine that awaits a hidden imam whose return catastrophe is meant to hasten. And in the United States a Christian-Zionist conviction, tens of millions strong, had entered the country's politics in the Reagan years and never left, binding American support to a prophetic timetable that runs through Jerusalem toward an end its believers do not fear but actively desire. Three eschatologies converged on the same small strip of ground, each materially armed, each reading the others as the adversary their scripture had appointed, and the convergence is not the background color of the war; it is what runs the war. End-times belief here is not private piety; it is a material force that states budget for, that ministries route weapons toward, that hardens negotiating positions past any price a creature of pure self-interest would pay, and the secular analyst who waves it away as rhetoric has thrown out the most powerful variable on the board. This is Marx's reading room and Riefenstahl's frenzy translated into the missile age, the demonstration that what men believe about the end of the world moves armies as surely as what they calculate about their interests.

The image the period produced that registered this with the cold accuracy a war coverage never reaches was made by an English filmmaker who had spent a decade refusing to shoot. Jonathan Glazer, whose *Under the Skin* in 2013 had filmed an alien wearing a woman's body driving a van through Glasgow, took ten years before he released his next picture, and when *The Zone of Interest* reached Cannes in May 2023 it took the Grand Prix and won the Academy Award for international feature the following March. The film follows the household of the commandant of Auschwitz, Rudolf Höss, who lived with his wife Hedwig and five children in a two-story house against the camp's outer wall, the family pool and the rose garden and the greenhouse on one side of the bricks and the gas chambers ten meters away on the other. Glazer films the family directly and the camp not at all. The horror is offscreen and continuous, a sound design composed by the late Mica Levi: the low hum of the crematoria, a single distant scream during a children's birthday party, the train whistles arriving in the night, a guard's order half-heard over the wife's instructions to the cook. Nothing breaks through. The wife considers a fur coat that has come from a transport, complains about an arrangement of flowers, runs the household; the husband bicycles to work along the perimeter wall and comes home to read bedtime stories. What the film documents is not the camp but the partition, the human capacity to set the killing on one side of a wall and the daily life on the other and to pass between them in a clean uniform without the screen collapsing. Glazer accepted his Oscar in March 2024 and used the speech to refuse the use the present moment was

being made to make of his film, naming a war that was then six months in. The film is the form of the wall between the books and the cargo itself rendered as cinema, and the form does not belong to one country or one century. It repeats the pattern at scale partition the financial rail and the energy rail enforce at a distance, the bookkeeper's wall between the price of the cargo and the cost of the cargo, the studio executive's wall between the deal and what the deal pays for, the consumer's wall between the feed and the warehouse that produces what the feed advertises. The wall is the technology, and the technology is portable. What the picture demonstrates is that the divider does not require a fanatic to maintain. A good administrator will do. The men in the secretaries' chairs and the women in the gardens are the load-bearing members of every order that has decided, on the books, that some lives belong on the other side of the bricks.

The deeper question is not whether a single cabal scripted the war, but who the long contest serves, and the answer is legible in the flows for anyone willing to follow them. The eastern Mediterranean is the seam where the world's energy moves and where the United States has, for three generations, underwritten the security of the supply with the standing presence of its fleet. A region kept at a controlled simmer, never resolved and never wholly at peace, is worth more to the powerful actors on every side than a resolution would be, and the proof is that whenever a settlement has come within reach it has been allowed to slip. The permanent crisis sustains the arms industries that arm both halves of it; it justifies the bases and the swelling budgets; it keeps the Gulf clients dependent on the American guarantee they purchase, in part, by pricing their crude in dollars and recycling the proceeds through Western markets, which is the petrodollar circuit kept turning by the very instability it appears to threaten; and it binds the energy rail to the dollar rail with a knot that a lasting peace would loosen. The eastern Mediterranean is only one node of a wider system, and the war exposed the whole of it. The world's energy moves through a few narrow waters. Whoever controls them controls a valve over the trade of nations. Hormuz, the mouth of the Gulf through which a fifth of the world's oil passes and on which Japan and much of Asia depend for the breath of their economies; Bab-el-Mandeb at the foot of the Red Sea, where the Suez route to Europe begins. Malacca, the narrow between Sumatra and the peninsula through which the bulk of China's imported oil must travel, a dependence Beijing names its own dilemma and labors to escape by pipeline and overland rail.

World energy chokepoints



World energy chokepoints: the narrow waters the order's commerce passes through, and that the fleet is positioned to keep open or to close.

When fighters in Yemen began firing on shipping in the Red Sea in sympathy with Gaza and forced the great container lines to abandon Suez for the long passage around Africa, the lesson was delivered in plain sight: the lanes can be closed, and when one closes it reorders the commerce of the planet in a week. The American fleet had stood across these waters for three generations as the guarantor of an open trade it claimed to keep neutral for all. What the decade made visible was a quieter shift in the role, from guaranteeing the lanes for everyone to policing them as the instrument that grants passage or denies it, the same fleet that puts the floor under a faith-backed currency whose neutrality had just been spent in New York. The war is therefore not a malfunction of the order. It is the order functioning, and to read it as a series of tragic accidents that no one wanted and no one shaped is to accept precisely the account the actors who profit from it prefer the public to believe. The strategic capitals did not experience the October war as a catastrophe to be halted; they played it as a board, each move calculated for the advantage in front of the player. The standing incentive is the explanation, and the consensus that reaches instead for the comfort of the unforeseeable is reaching for the account the profiting parties prefer.

The valve had a history, and so did the weapon. Before the reserve freeze taught Moscow what the plumbing could do, the lesson had been rehearsed on Tehran. In 2012 the Iranian banks were expelled from the system that routes the world's payment messages; readmitted in part after the nuclear accord of 2015, they were cut off again in 2018 when Washington tore that agreement up. The playbook of 2022 was a decade old, drafted against one rival and executed against another. The decapitation had its rehearsal too, an American drone killing Qassem Soleimani at the

16. SWIFT disconnection of Iranian banks, March 15–17, 2012; partial reconnection, January 2016; renewed suspension, November 2018; the drone strike of January 3, 2020.

17. Air campaign from February 28, 2026; closure of the Strait of Hormuz, March 27, 2026; ceasefire of April 7–8, 2026.

Baghdad airport in January 2020, and the war the era kept expecting did not then come¹⁶ It came at the end of February 2026. An American and Israeli air campaign opened against the program and the command; the supreme leader was killed in its course; the strait of Hormuz, the first of the valves named above, was blocked within days and formally closed in March, the largest disruption of the world's oil supply since the 1970s. And the ceasefire of April was violated in both directions until the word described a tempo rather than a peace¹⁷ All of that is documented and none of it concluded anything, because each side's objectives could still be read as achievable at once, both parties believing they were winning, which is the configuration in which negotiation has nothing to trade. What remained unsprung was the trap itself. An air war had decapitated and had not compelled, and the next move on the board, the ground invasion, was the one the asymmetric-war law prices as fatal to the power that takes it; the temptation now stands open on the table, the kind a profile of pressures can name and cannot price, and whether it is taken is forecast, not fact.

Behind both wars stood the contest the decade was finally about, and it remained, through these years, a shadow rather than an event. The rivalry between the United States and China hardened from competition into the architecture of a struggle for primacy, the trade war becoming a technology war, the contest narrowing to a single chokepoint that laid bare the whole arrangement of the age. The new economy, and the artificial intelligence at its frontier, rested on semiconductors of a complexity only a few firms on earth could manufacture, and the most advanced of them were made on a single island ninety miles off the Chinese coast. Here the abstraction of great-power rivalry came down to a physical fact: the most valuable manufacturing on the planet sat within artillery range of the power most determined to absorb it, and the incumbent had quietly arranged its denial. Washington moved to cut Beijing off from the machines and the chips, not merely as commerce but as containment, drawing a line around the frontier of the thinking machine and declaring it a national possession; Beijing set out to build what it had been denied and massed its forces near the strait. And over Taiwan there gathered a contest both sides treated as existential, the rising power persuaded that the island was the unfinished business of its own becoming, the established power persuaded that to let it fall was to let the century pass to another. Nothing was settled in these years, and that is the point. The strait is the open shadow, the largest of the decade's unrealized possibilities, primed and undecided, and the actors with the most to gain from its tension, the firms that build the weapons and the states that sell protection, have every reason to keep it taut and none to let it slacken. A war over the strait is one path. A long armed standoff that never becomes the war it threatens to be is another, and the experience of the nuclear age, in which the gravest confrontations were precisely the ones that did not become the wars they promised, is reason enough to refuse the determinism that would write the war as already real. A reading of pressures is blind, by its nature, to the leader who chooses against his position and to the guarantee rebuilt rather than spent, and that blindness is what leaves the strait

genuinely open, not foreclosed.

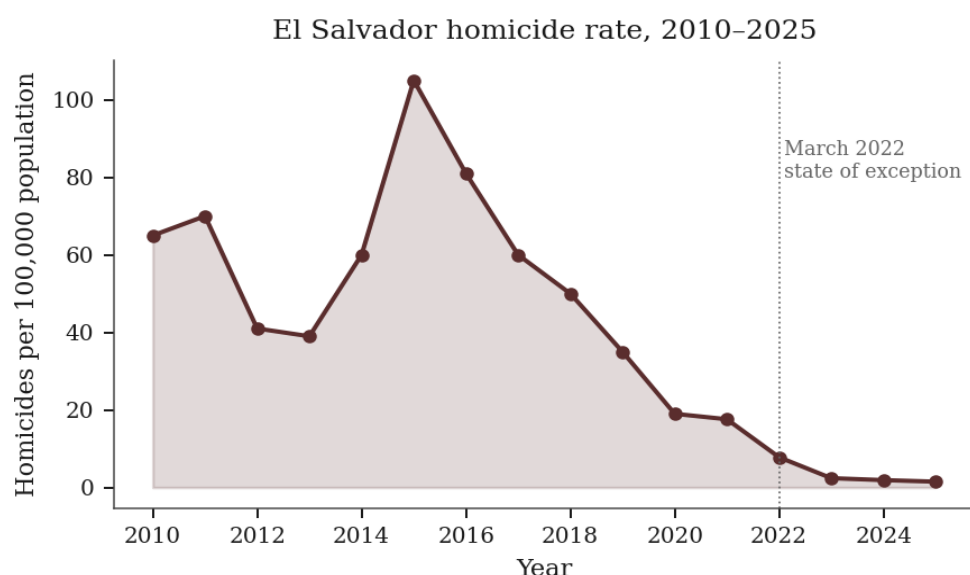
The fracture at home had a place on the map before it had a name: the southern border. The administration that took office in 2021 unwound its predecessor's machinery piece by dated piece: a hundred-day pause on deportations ordered in its first week and halted by a federal judge within six days; the protocols that had kept asylum claimants in Mexico terminated. Wall construction stopped; the public-health expulsions of the pandemic ended in May 2023; and parole programs opened that admitted, by application and by air, hundreds of thousands who would otherwise have crossed on foot¹⁸ The counts followed. Encounters at the southwest border had not crossed a million since the middle 2000s; fiscal 2021 counted 1.7 million; 2022 and 2023 counted 2.4 and then 2.5, the highest totals the series had ever returned on a measure the expulsion rule itself inflated, since a crosser expelled without penalty often crossed again; a single December month logged a quarter-million. Both renderings of those numbers deserve their full voltage. The critics said "open border"; the administration answered that the border was not open but lawful, that most of those encountered were expelled or processed under statute, that the parole entrants were vetted and flown, that the surge was hemispheric, a collapsed Venezuela and a desperate Haiti on the move, and that an asylum law drafted in another era was being administered as written. The skeptics answered that the acts of 2021 had been read in the sending countries as an invitation, that the asylum claim had become an entry ticket with a hearing date years out, and that a demographic act of historic size was being performed, once again, without a vote. By February 2024 the polls found immigration named the country's most important problem, first among all issues, in the year the hinge would turn¹⁹ The border was the split rendering with a fence through it: one half of the country watched a humanitarian queue, the other an invasion, in the same footage, and the failure of the shared picture acquired coordinates on a map.

South of that border ran a laboratory the political class of every wealthy country had begun, openly or otherwise, to study. In El Salvador, Nayib Bukele had declared in March 2022 a state of exception against the criminal gangs that had governed entire neighborhoods of the country, suspended the constitutional protections that had made arrest difficult, deployed the army to sweep districts house by house, and within three years jailed roughly two percent of the country's adult population in a single concrete megaprison built for the purpose, photographed from the air as a rectangle in scrubland and from inside as ranks of tattooed men in white shorts and shaved heads kneeling on a polished floor. The homicide rate, once the highest on earth outside an active war, fell to among the lowest in the Americas. The approval rating of the president who had ordered it ran consistently the highest of any head of government in the hemisphere through the decade, the polling at times above eighty and ninety percent, a popularity sustained through a reelection his own constitution did not permit and that he won anyway. The liberal order's customary instruments, the human-rights brief and the rule-of-law objection, were filed and were correct in

18. Department of Homeland Security memorandum of January 20, 2021, and the restraining order of January 26, 2021; Migrant Protection Protocols termination memoranda, June 1 and October 29, 2021; Title 42 expiration, May 11, 2023; the CHNV parole processes, from January 2023.

19. Customs and Border Protection, southwest border encounters, fiscal years 2019–2023 and December 2023; Gallup, February 2024.

the technical particulars and changed nothing, because the Salvadoran public had made a calculation the brief could not refute: the procedural protections the law had once enshrined for the accused had been, in their experience, protections for the extortioner who had taken their cousin in front of them. A bargain liberalism had refused to name was named here in the open. The order that protects everyone equally cannot be sustained against an apparatus that respects no one, and a public asked to choose between procedural purity and physical safety will choose safety and not feel a complication about it. The lesson traveled. Argentina's voters elected a man who promised the same arithmetic on the fiscal side; Honduras and Ecuador imported the model in pieces; in the United States the impulse the southern border had stacked under the lockdown years arrived in the same currency, the demand not for a tuning of the asylum statute but for the leader who would simply stop the thing the law could not. The exception had once been the recourse of the failing state. In the late phase the exception became its routine, and the leader who claimed it kept the votes. The institution passes from openness through bureaucracy to coercion, and in this case the coercion arrived elected.



El Salvador homicide rate, 2010–2025: the line the state of exception drew. Source: Salvadoran Ministry of Justice and Public Security.

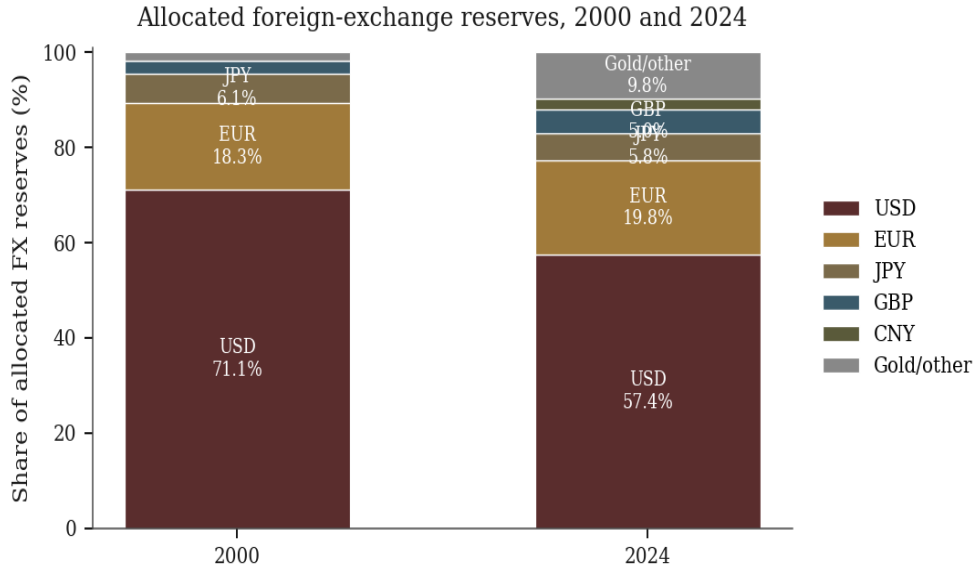
At the decade's hinge the established power turned inward, and the hinge was turned by a network of capital and infrastructure that had been preparing for the role for two decades. Peter Thiel, who had cofounded the payment company that became PayPal in 1999 and the surveillance contractor Palantir in 2003, had spent a generation funding candidates and institutions on the conviction that the liberal-democratic settlement was a wager he expected to lose; he wrote the check that put J. D. Vance in the Senate in 2022 and onto the ticket two years later. Elon Musk

bought the social network then called Twitter for forty-four billion dollars in October 2022, renamed it X, took its content moderation apart, and across 2024 turned the algorithm and the timeline to the campaign of a man whose 2020 ban from the platform half the country had celebrated. His political action committee spent more than two hundred and fifty million dollars on the election, and on its night he stood on a stage in Pennsylvania with the candidate he had remade his portfolio to elect. Palantir, the contractor Thiel had founded to sell intelligence-grade analytics to the state, expanded its federal contracts on a steep curve through 2025 and assembled the data plumbing on which the new administration's immigration enforcement and federal procurement now run. The AI models the build-out had funded sat at the elbow of every operation, drafting the targeted message, the polling memo, the legal brief that defended an executive order and the next one that followed. The same coalition that delivered the election owned disproportionate stakes in the AI build-out, in the rocket company that crossed the trillion, and in the parallel monetary rail that the previous administration had treated as a curiosity and the new one treated as a foundation. The deeper concentration was not visible from the floor of the convention. A small number of men, all of them billionaires by the time the result was called, had spent the prior decade buying out positions in every choke point the digital economy would run through: the platform, the chips, the rockets, the data layer, the payments, the chain. The election they delivered was the political ratification of an arrangement they had already built.

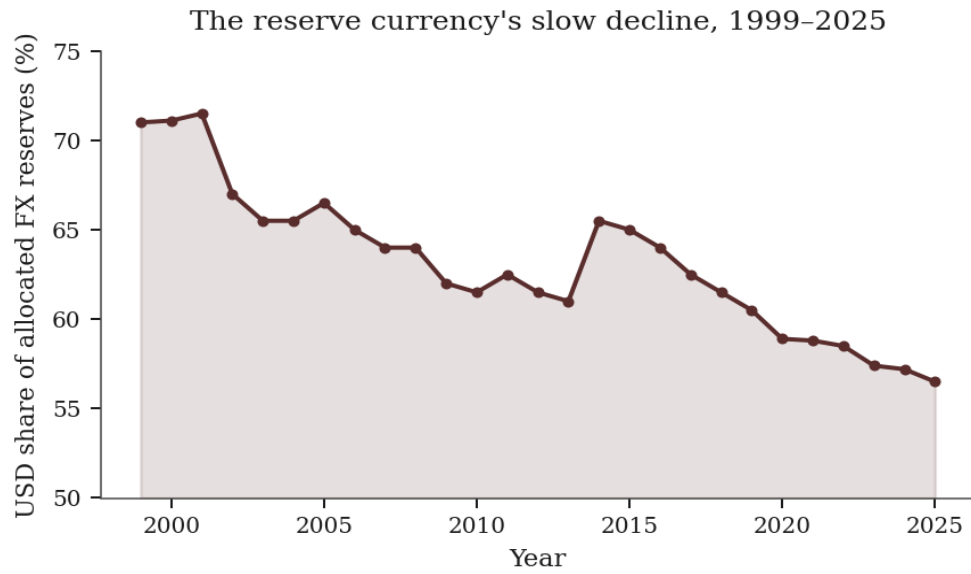
The return of Donald Trump to the presidency in the election of 2024, and the administration that took office in 2025, marked something deeper than a change of party. A hegemon that sensed its own relative decline chose to stop paying for an order it had built and could no longer afford to guarantee at the old price. Tariffs returned not as a tactic but as a worldview; the free-trade gospel a rising America had once preached to the world was abandoned by the same country once the rise had stopped. The alliances were treated as accounts to be priced rather than commitments to be honored. But the second term reads less like a withdrawal than a conversion. In the first week of 2026 the administration took the president of Venezuela from his own capital by airborne assault and flew him to a New York courtroom; the defense strategy published that month named the hemisphere and its chokepoints, Panama and Greenland and the Gulf, as the perimeter to be defended. And in May the president flew to Beijing and settled the trade war on terms both capitals called strategic stability²⁰ A hegemon that had guaranteed the lanes for everyone was learning to charge for passage; protection succeeded guarantee as the product on offer, and the men executing it spoke the language of grievance and renewal whether the result was the managed descent of a tired empire or the foundation of a harder one. Beneath the foreign retrenchment ran a domestic fracture an educated and credentialed and ambitious generation overproduced by a system that no longer had seats for all of it, its resentment channeled into a politics that means to overturn the order that made and then disappointed it. The shared picture of the real had split so far that the two

20. Operation Absolute Resolve, January 3, 2026; the 2026 National Defense Strategy, January 23, 2026; the Beijing summit of May 14–15, 2026.

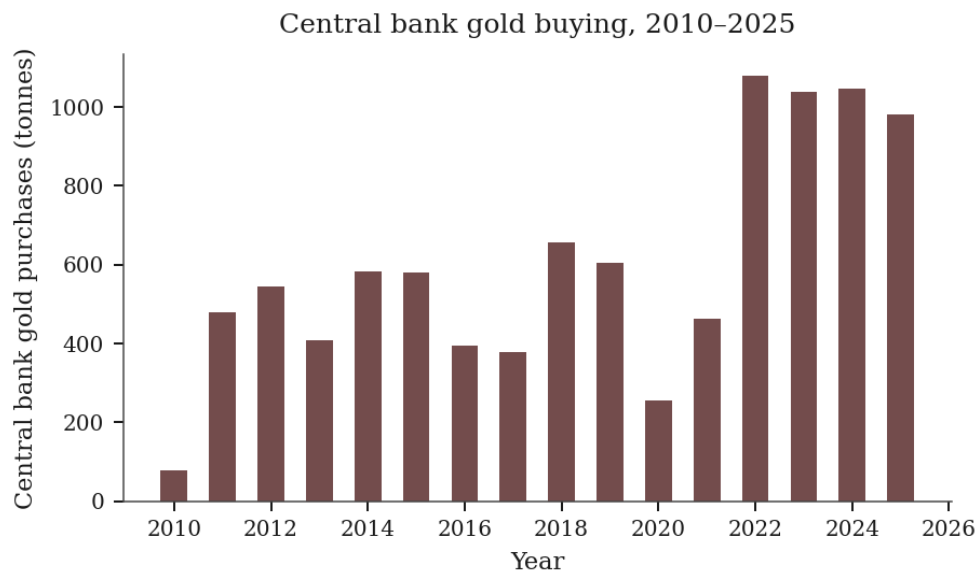
halves of the country no longer agreed on what was happening in front of them, and this was not a misfortune that befell the public. It was a condition produced and then maintained. The platforms that profit from engagement rage, and the political operators who harvest a frightened and divided electorate, widened the split because a public that cannot agree on what it is seeing is a public that cannot combine against the powers above it, and a divided people is a governable one. The procurement of conviction by metric has its mirror in the summer of 2020 and the winter that followed, and the mirror needs no minister. A quarrel that keeps the governed turned on one another rather than upward pays nearly everyone with the power to end it, and so it does not end. The order is more financialized, more concentrated, and more disbelieved than at any point in the long century behind it. Its dynamism is not spent. Its capacity to correct its own errors is, and the monoculture of a single optimized financial and technological rail is the more brittle for being so efficient. The reader who came to this chapter looking for a tribe to root for misread the book. There is no such tribe in the documents. The mechanisms in operation do not need one.



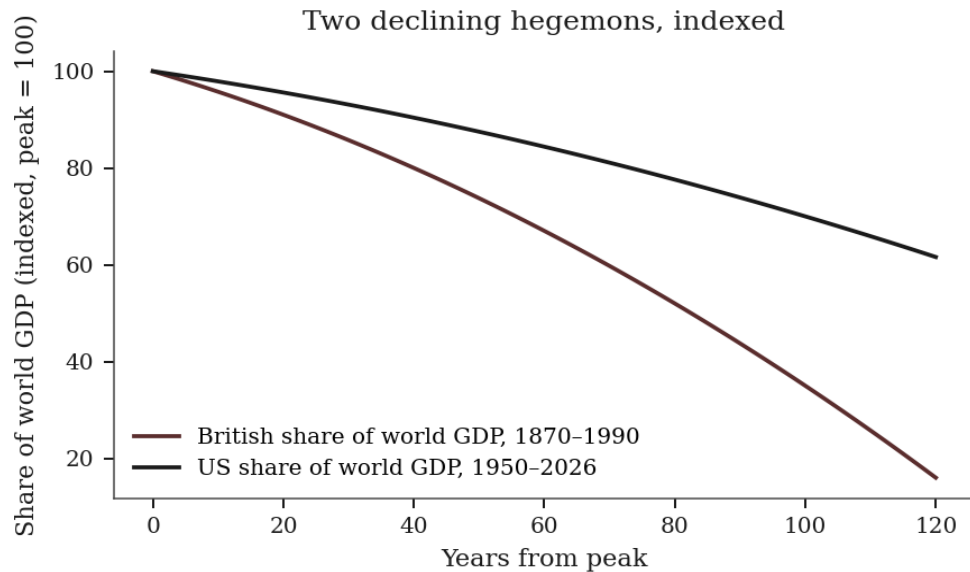
Allocated foreign-exchange reserves by currency, 2000 and 2024. Source: IMF, *Currency Composition of Official Foreign Exchange Reserves*.



USD share of allocated FX reserves, 1999–2025: the reserve currency's slow withdrawal. Source: IMF COFER.



Central bank gold purchases, 2010–2025: the answer side of the same trade. Source: World Gold Council.



Two declining hegemons, indexed from peak: Britain (1870–1990) and the United States (1950–2026). Source: Maddison Project, World Bank.

What the next consciousness will make from these materials is the one thing no reading can foresee, because no one has made it yet, and no analysis can capture the act of a mind that has not yet turned its moment into a form that endures.

To end on the slope would betray the whole argument, because the decline was never the subject. Across one long century the orders of money changed and changed again - the gold standard, the sterling rail, the dollar's convertible promise, the petrodollar understanding, the neutrality of the reserve currency itself - each believed in until, with a suddenness the believers never expected, it was not. The pressures were the background of that succession; the deliberate work of single minds was the figure. The collapse of an order is the weather against which the work is done, and the work is what survived. The pressures of the present can be weighed with some care: an image made by a machine and consumed in half a second; money created without limit and weaponized without recall; an artificial mind built faster than anyone can govern it by people who believe it ends or saves the world; an order brittle in proportion to its optimization and disbelieved in proportion to its concentration. What it cannot read is the figure that will be made against that ground, by minds that take these exact conditions and convert them into something that outlasts them. Some of that work is already legible in the suspicion breaking out across the culture that the synthetic flood has made the unrepeatable human mark precious in the proportion that it has become rare, so that the handmade and the witnessed and the verifiably real acquire a worth the machine cannot manufacture. Some of it is older and quieter, the discipline a single consciousness practices when it sheds each night the accumulated noise of the macro-world and

tests every collective concept of its era against its own direct experience rather than against an authority or a feed, the one thing in this whole span that no monetary order issued and none can confiscate. The forecaster this book audited ended there himself: after years of lectures on money and war, his final session closed on Dante, and the only preparation he commended was of the soul. The economist's last word was the artist's. The future this reading describes is a profile of pressures: the strait, the eschatological front, the machine, the home fracture. The history stops here. What will be made of it is not yet made.

As the global dollar system began to fracture and the periphery rebelled, the center initiated its retreat. The blueprint for the era after 2026 was the emergence of The Technate - a Greater North America where the United States would withdraw into a continental, AI-governed technocratic fortress, trading global hegemony for absolute, algorithmic control over its own hemisphere.

Epilogue

A book that has run from a courier riding out of Waterloo to a paragraph drafted in seconds by a machine that read everything ever written owes its reader a plain account of what was shown. The temptation at the end of a long history is to deliver a verdict, to name the lesson the two centuries were secretly teaching. This volume declines that office. It made its argument by demonstration across fourteen chapters, and it is finished where they end. What remains is to state clearly what the demonstration was, and then to follow the one consequence that does not belong inside any chapter because it belongs to whoever closes the book.

The demonstration was Jiang's frame run against two centuries of evidence and found to stand under condition. History moves in oceanic currents rather than cycles or lines. Orders decline through financialization, status-stasis, and the overproduction of elites. An empire strengthens the borderlands that later overturn it. Institutions pass from openness through bureaucracy to coercion. The optimized system is the brittle one. Money is a fiction, and apocalyptic belief a material force. Two claims bear the most weight, and they stood against the cases: a declining power loses its peripheral and asymmetric wars first, and resolve outlasts capability. These are the beams. Each chapter showed what the beams supported and where they bent, and the negative cases stayed in view: the orders that adapted, the panics that the lender of last resort credibly stopped, the empire that converted itself into a country rather than break. The shape stood; the timing it cannot give.

Against the falling orders stood the figure the book actually cared about. Through every changed monetary order and every governing myth that lost its grip, the durable work was the conversion of an age into form by individual minds. Turner set down the light of a self-confident commercial empire before anyone in it knew the witness would be wanted. Eliot assembled a poem from fragments because the whole that earlier poems assumed no longer cohered, and the formal wreckage is itself the evidence of a belief that had failed. Shostakovich wrote under a regime that could erase him and left a score that says what the diplomatic archive cannot. None of these makers commanded the monetary system that pressed on him. Each registered the pressure, the fantasy, the cost to the mind, in a choice of form he may not have known he was making. That is the work that survived when the order around it changed, and it is the work every reading of this kind is blind to, because pressure-reading sees slow rot and not the reflexive act of a single consciousness that refuses merely to transmit its moment.

Here the book hands its reader something it cannot keep. If the great edifices are orders of belief that lose their grip and give way, then no institution can be trusted to defend the line for what gets made and what gets preserved. The order that frames every chapter here will itself come apart, as each of its predecessors in these pages did, and there is no successor institution whose

standing charge it is to deliver the work across the break. The museum dates the object and loses the conditions; the market prices the work and forgets why it was drawn out of its moment; the state funds and defunds on a schedule no maker can rely on. The responsibility for what a society leaves behind, and for a mind kept clear amid the collective currents that press on it, falls in the end to the individual, because there is nowhere else for it to fall. The discipline the book named for that clarity is unglamorous and daily: the deliberate shedding of the outworn expectation and the broken illusion, so that a mind stays free of the accumulated noise of the macro-world and can still test the ideas of its age against its own experience rather than against an authority. A consciousness kept that clear is the only reliable instrument for the conversion of pressure into form, and it is private property, possessed by one person at a time and inherited by no one.

So the book ends where a history of this kind must, which is not at a conclusion but at a threshold. The present profile is legible enough. An order late in its phase, its money increasingly an instrument of coercion, its attention converted wholesale into capital, its labor itself spun out and drafted by machine before being signed by hand, its remaining surplus narrowed onto a single technological wager whose preachers sell the threshold by the prospectus, its borderlands tested at three fronts at once, its shared picture of the real fractured by the same machines that draft its briefs. The shape of what comes is open. The reading that ran through the last two centuries goes blind before the thing that will decide the next stretch, which is the reflexive choice no current commands. The guarantee credibly rebuilt, the leader who turns against his own position, the fragile profile that endures against the reading: these have happened before, they are the negative cases the book kept in view, and they are the reasons the future is genuinely undecided rather than settled in advance. What the next conversion of an age into form will be, and whose mind will make it under whatever pressure the coming order applies, is not written here. It is not written anywhere - still to be made.

In the week this volume was finished, two long arcs closed in the same news cycle, and the history that had begun with a courier riding out of Waterloo with the price of a continent in his saddlebag ended on them. They are the closing image because they are what the present has actually finished, and the figure against the ground appears on both sides of the same frame.

On the tenth of June 2026 a pope stood in Barcelona and blessed the central spire of the Sagrada Família, the tallest church on earth, one hundred years to the day after the architect's death. The temple had been raised across one hundred and forty-four years of construction, financed first by alms and then by the tickets of millions of strangers who came to watch a thing rise that none of them would see completed. Antoni Gaudí had taken the project over in 1883, a year into its life, knowing it would outlive him; it did, and he is buried in its crypt. Asked about the pace he is said to have answered, "My client is not in a hurry." The temple was begun under a

metal standard and a monarchy that were both long dead within a decade of the first cut stone, and it persisted through every monetary order this book described and the wars that broke them. In 1936 a revolutionary crowd burned the workshop and smashed the architect's plaster models; his successors gathered the fragments and went on building, hands that had never seen Gaudí raising stone from drawings pieced out of rubble. Construction beneath the cross is still not finished.

Two mornings later a stock exchange in New York opened on the listing that crossed the trillion. The same week the rockets the issuing company built had been catching themselves out of the sky, the booster returning to the launch tower on jets of fire and being received by a pair of mechanical arms the engineers called chopsticks, a maneuver the previous century had written into science fiction and that television now broadcast as routine. The founder, by the close of trading on the twelfth of June 2026 the first individual in history to cross a trillion dollars, had named the goal in the language a believer uses for a kingdom rather than a quarter: a settlement on the rust-red dust, a multiplanet species, humanity launched at last into the stars.

Two answers to the question of what the available capital should build sat for one week in the same frame. One financed by alms and tickets across a century and a half, the other by a concentration of capital fewer than ten men in the world commanded. One pointed at a kingdom above, the other at a colony beyond. Both eschatological in their motive, and both outlasting every rational return calculation the period offered them.

The slop is what production looks like with belief subtracted. The temple and the rocket are what belief looks like when it cannot be liquidated. The machine can conjure the image of a cathedral in a second; what no machine has ever conjured is a reason to spend a life on one, or to bet a fortune on a colony no one has stepped on. The rocket and the spire each say, in different doctrines, that a long arc of capital and conviction can still finish a hard thing. What divides them is who paid, on what timetable, and toward which end. What unites them is that they were finished, by individuals who took the specific pressure of an age and converted it into something that endures. The two arrivals in the same week of June 2026 are the most honest news the period delivered about what the order is still able to make.

So the history closes where the reader's own begins. Every order in these pages was a structure of belief that drained to nothing and gave way, and the last of them is the mind running these words: a single consciousness, minted in one year's money and myths, sure of arrangements that will not outlive it. That was the fact folded inside every price and treaty here, and it was never about empires. You are an order. You will end. The certainties that feel to you now like bedrock will be read by whoever comes after the way you read the sterling rail - coolly, a little amused that anyone mistook it for the permanent furniture of the world.

There is one thing a mind can do with that knowledge, aside from falling downstream with everyone else who believes it, and the whole book has pointed at it. Take the pressure of your moment, the belief you have learned to distrust, the feeling that belief still drives up through your chest, the heat these last chapters struck and never let you spend, and beat it into a thing with edges. Not to be remembered, because that is a wage the dead never draw, and the orders that pledge it rot before the bill comes due. You shape it for strangers on the far side of a gap no sympathy reaches, people whose gods and morals and arguments would not know what to do with your face, and you make it anyway. That is the whole of it. A made thing is the only letter that has ever reached from one drowned order to the next, and it reaches because its maker quit asking to be understood and pressed into stone, or onto paper, or into a single hour's work, exactly what it felt like to be alive under one pressure in one year.

So the book ends by setting back in your hand the only tool it ever gave you. Be slow to believe, and slower with the beliefs that flatter you. Watch what a conviction does to your pulse. Then forge something out of it: a canvas, a magnum opus closed clean, a child taught to see straight. Works and acts built to outlast the belief that bred them and addressed to a stranger you will never meet and could never have understood. The orders fall. They have always fallen. The thing you hammer out against their fall is the only object that was ever yours, the only one a stranger will ever pick up and turn over in his hands. Make it anyway. That is the end of the story. It is also the start of the only one that was ever yours.

Further Reading

The long-cycle tradition

- Ibn Khaldun - *The Muqaddimah* (1377). The fourteenth-century Tunisian who saw cohesion bleed out of regimes by the third generation; the *asabiyyah* idea is where this volume's reading descends from, and where almost everyone else stops crediting.
- John Bagot Glubb - *The Fate of Empires* (1976). A British soldier's pamphlet. Eccentric, unfashionable, often right.
- Joseph Tainter - *The Collapse of Complex Societies* (1988). Collapse as the economics of complexity passing its return; the cleanest case the model makes.
- Jack Goldstone - *Revolution and Rebellion in the Early Modern World* (1991). Demography and elite overproduction made measurable.
- Peter Turchin and Sergey Nefedov - *Secular Cycles* (2009).
- Peter Turchin - *End Times* (2023). The same lens turned on the United States right now; the empirical apparatus is the thing to read for, not the forecast.
- Jiang Xueqin - the lecture corpus (2010s–2020s). The spine of this volume's framework, named in the open. Go and audit it.

Money and its orders

- Barry Eichengreen - *Golden Fetters* (1992). If you read one book on the interwar gold standard, this.
- Barry Eichengreen - *Exorbitant Privilege* (2011).
- Liaquat Ahamed - *Lords of Finance* (2009). The central bankers who broke the world, at human scale; a model of how to write monetary history without the math chasing the reader off.
- Charles Kindleberger - *Manias, Panics, and Crashes* (1978).
- Adam Tooze - *The Deluge* (2014). American power remaking the world order, 1916–1931.
- Adam Tooze - *Crashed* (2018). 2008 and the decade it made; the bibliography in the back is half its value.
- Michael Hudson - *Super Imperialism* (1972, third ed. 2021). I disagree with some of it. The framework is load-bearing anyway.

Belief, image, consent

- Immanuel Kant - *Critique of Pure Reason* (1781). The metaphysical floor; almost no one reads it through, including, by his own admission, Hegel.
- G. W. F. Hegel - *Lectures on the Philosophy of History* (1837). The inheritance the century soured.
- F. A. Kirkpatrick, ed. - *Lectures on the History of the Nineteenth Century* (1902). The century summed in confidence, one summer at Cambridge, twelve years before the bill.
- Shailer Mathews - *The Spiritual Interpretation of History* (1916). Consecration, mid-war.

John Herman Randall Jr. - *The Making of the Modern Mind* (1926). Serenity, machine cosmos included.

Emery Neff - *The Poetry of History* (1947). Salvage; a discipline pleading beauty after its predictive claim is gone.

Benedict Anderson - *Imagined Communities* (1983).

Edward Bernays - *Propaganda* (1928). The engineering of consent, by the engineer; do not skip this because the title sounds villainous.

Walter Benjamin - *The Work of Art in the Age of Mechanical Reproduction* (1935). Written before the feed proved it.

Slavoj Žižek - *The Sublime Object of Ideology* (1989). The method of art-reading this volume owes most to.

Susan Sontag - *On Photography* (1977).

Neil Postman - *Amusing Ourselves to Death* (1985). The hearth critiqued while it still stood, by a man who could not have imagined the feed.

Norman Cohn - *The Pursuit of the Millennium* (1957). Eschatology as a material force, documented across centuries; the book this volume's eschatology chapter leans on the hardest.

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The Long Nineteenth Century

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2. On the subsidies, J. M. Sherwig, *Guineas and Gunpowder: British Foreign Aid in the Wars with France, 1793–1815* (Harvard, 1969).
3. The Bank Restriction Act, 1797; convertibility resumed under the Resumption Act of 1819 and was complete by 1821.
4. On the dialectic and the world-historical individual: G. W. F. Hegel, *Lectures on the Philosophy of History*, trans. John Sibree (London: George Bell & Sons, 1837); on the secularization of Christian eschatology in Hegel's reading, Karl Löwith, *Meaning in History* (Chicago, 1949), chs. 3–4. On the older millenarian inheritance the dialectic kept and rebranded: Norman Cohn, *The Pursuit of the Millennium: Revolutionary Millenarians and Mystical Anarchists of the Middle Ages* (London: Secker & Warburg, 1957).
5. On the categorial limit of human cognition: Immanuel Kant, *Critique of Pure Reason*, trans. Norman Kemp Smith (London: Macmillan, 1929 [1781]), B xvi–xxvii (the "Copernican turn") and A 369–380 on the limits of speculative reason. On the nation as one such category that organizes a population without ever being touched directly, Benedict Anderson, *Imagined Communities: Reflections on the Origin and Spread of Nationalism* (London: Verso, 1983).
6. On central-bank cooperation as priesthood: Carroll Quigley, *Tragedy and Hope: A History of the World in Our Time* (New York: Macmillan, 1966), pp. 324–328 on the Bank for International Settlements; for a corrective view, Liaquat Ahamed, *Lords of Finance* (2009).
7. Karl Marx, *Das Kapital*, vol. 1 (Hamburg: Meissner, 1867); Marx's columns on the American Civil War are collected in Marx and Engels, *Civil War in the United States* (International Publishers, 1937). On Helmholtz: Hermann von Helmholtz, *Handbuch der physiologischen Optik*, 3 vols. (Leipzig: Voss, 1856–1867).
8. The National Currency Act of 1863 and the National Bank Act of 1864.
9. The Compromise of 1877. On the crop-lien system, Roger Ransom and Richard Sutch, *One Kind of Freedom* (1977); *Plessy v. Ferguson*, 163 U.S. 537 (1896).
10. Walter Bagehot, *Lombard Street: A Description of the Money Market* (1873). On the longer succession of liquidity crises, Charles P. Kindleberger, *Manias, Panics, and Crashes: A History of Financial Crises* (New York: Basic Books, 1978).
11. Jacob Burckhardt to Friedrich von Preen, July 24, 1889. On the older diagnostic tradition Burckhardt's anxieties belong to: Ibn Khaldun, *The Muqaddimah: An Introduction to History*, trans. Franz Rosenthal (Princeton, 1958 [1377]), book III, on the cycle by which a civilization passes from desert solidarity to settled luxury and dissolution; John Bagot Glubb, *The Fate of Empires and Search for Survival* (Edinburgh: Blackwood, 1976), for the modern restatement.

1900 – 1909

1. John Herman Randall Jr., *The Making of the Modern Mind* (1926), pp. 259–260.
2. Treaty of Portsmouth, September 5, 1905; Roosevelt received the 1906 Nobel Peace Prize for the mediation.
3. On the nickelodeon and the assembly of a mass viewing audience: Neil Postman, *Amusing Ourselves to Death: Public Discourse in the Age of Show Business* (New York: Viking, 1985), chs. 5–7, traces the long passage from print culture to the image-as-discourse; for the period figures, Eileen Bowser, *The Transformation of Cinema, 1907–1915* (Scribner, 1990), reports roughly two million admissions per day in the United States by 1908.

1910 – 1919

1. Frank A. Vanderlip with Boyden Sparkes, *From Farm Boy to Financier* (New York: Appleton-Century, 1935), ch. 23.
2. Federal Reserve Act, December 23, 1913.
3. Currency and Bank Notes Act, August 6, 1914.
4. Shailer Mathews, *The Spiritual Interpretation of History* (Harvard, 1916), pp. 67–68.
5. On the financial transfer that accompanied American entry into the war: Adam Tooze, *The Deluge: The Great War, America and the Remaking of the Global Order, 1916–1931* (New York: Viking, 2014), chs. 2–4. On the House of Morgan as Allied purchasing agent, Ron Chernow, *The House of Morgan* (Atlantic Monthly Press, 1990), part II.
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4. The July 1927 meetings of Norman, Schacht, Rist, and Strong; Liaquat Ahamed, *Lords of Finance* (2009), ch. 17.
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2. The 2007–2008 non-prosecution agreement, S.D. Fla.; Julie K. Brown, "Perversion of Justice," *Miami Herald*, November 2018.
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2010 – 2019

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2. Open Society Foundations announcement, July 13, 2020; Washington Post, August 23, 2021; Associated Press, February 23, 2021.
3. Department of Justice prosecution figures; District of Columbia chief medical examiner rulings; presidential proclamation of January 20, 2025.
4. Bureau of Labor Statistics, CPI-U, twelve-month change, June 2022.
5. *Succession*, HBO, 2018–2023.
6. June 2024, YouTube platform rankings.
7. August 2020; contemporaneous press reports of roughly one million dollars in first-day revenue.
8. *United States v. Maxwell*, S.D.N.Y.; verdict December 29, 2021, sentence June 28, 2022.
9. The Epstein Files Transparency Act, signed November 19, 2025.
10. *Griswold v. Connecticut*, 381 U.S. 479 (1965); Tom Wolfe, "The 'Me' Decade and the Third Great Awakening," New York, August 23, 1976.
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13. ChatGPT, released November 30, 2022; UBS/Similarweb estimate of one hundred million monthly users by January 2023.
14. Merriam-Webster, Word of the Year 2025, announced December 15, 2025.
15. The immobilization of Russian central-bank reserves, announced by the G7 and the European Union, February 26–28, 2022.
16. SWIFT disconnection of Iranian banks, March 15–17, 2012; partial reconnection, January 2016; renewed suspension, November 2018; the drone strike of January 3, 2020.
17. Air campaign from February 28, 2026; closure of the Strait of Hormuz, March 27, 2026; ceasefire of April 7–8, 2026.
18. Department of Homeland Security memorandum of January 20, 2021, and the restraining order of January 26, 2021; Migrant Protection Protocols termination memoranda, June 1 and October 29, 2021; Title 42 expiration, May 11, 2023; the CHNV parole processes, from January 2023.
19. Customs and Border Protection, southwest border encounters, fiscal years 2019–2023 and December 2023; Gallup, February 2024.
20. Operation Absolute Resolve, January 3, 2026; the 2026 National Defense Strategy, January 23, 2026; the Beijing summit of May 14–15, 2026.
21. Jiang Xueqin, lecture of May 29, 2024.
22. The GENIUS Act, July 18, 2025.
23. The final piece of the cross was set February 20, 2026; the papal blessing fell June 10, 2026; the first stone was laid March 19, 1882.
24. The expiatory charter of the Junta Constructora; the workshop destruction, July 1936.
25. *Inside*, written and directed by Bo Burnham, Netflix, released May 30, 2021; production conducted in a single guest house in Los Angeles during the COVID-19 lockdowns; nominated for six Primetime Emmy Awards (winning three) and the Grammy for Best Comedy Album.
26. *The Zone of Interest*, directed by Jonathan Glazer, written by Glazer after Martin Amis's 2014 novel of the same title; premiered at the Cannes Film Festival, May 19, 2023, Grand Prix; won Best International Feature Film and Best Sound, 96th Academy Awards, March 10, 2024. Sound design by Johnnie Burn; score by Mica Levi.
27. The "trillion-dollar man" milestone: SpaceX initial public offering, June 12, 2026, the listing that brought its founder's net worth across one trillion dollars on the public ledger; "chopsticks" catch sequence demonstrated October 13, 2024, on the fifth flight test of Starship at Boca Chica.
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29. On the partition the order maintains between the price and the cost of cargo: Rana Foroohar, *Makers and Takers* (2016); Michael Hudson, *Super Imperialism*, 3rd ed. (2021).
30. Nayib Bukele's first term began June 1, 2019; the state-of-exception regime began March 27, 2022, after a single weekend in which gang violence claimed sixty-two lives; reelected February 4, 2024,

with approval ratings reported above eighty-five percent in CID Gallup and Universidad Centroamericana polling 2024–2025.

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Colophon

This book was composed with the assistance of Claude, a large language model. Joseph B. Smith set its argument and structure, selected the works it reads, and directed, revised, and edited the text throughout. Responsibility for the whole - its claims, its judgments, and its errors - rests with the author named on the title page.